The war on our doorstep

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/37920322.

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Explicit

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
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Lesbian Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Catra (She-Ra), War, War correspondent AU, Smut, Fluff and Smut, Angst, Enemies to Lovers, Ukraine - Freeform, War in Ukraine, Action, Road Trips, real world politics, Minor Violence, Not nice but not cruel either, Mariupol, I wrote this for me but you can read it if you like, Rostov-on-Don, Russia, Slow Burn, and i mean VERY slow burn, Soft Catra (She-Ra), but still Catra, Georgia, Greater Caucasus, A lot of political and military background, Tbilisi, Blindfolds, Teasing, Light Dom/sub

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by 21st_tikonda

Summary

Adora Gray has been a war correspondent for nearly a decade, reporting from the front lines of today's conflicts. Her signature blonde ponytail is well-known across the screens of the western hemisphere, her broadcasting platform reaching millions.

Now she's in Mariupol, a city beleaguered by the Russian Army in the dictator Putin's attempt to conquer Ukraine. Resources are running out, and the situation is getting worse with each passing day. And despite the pleas of her friends and her mentor, she stays in the dying city.
When she's badly injured and brought to a hospital behind the front, a field surgeon with mismatched eyes and a biting attitude apparently saves her life, not just once.
If only the damn woman wasn't on the wrong side.

Notes

Normally, I don't use my writing account to do anything political. I stay away from such topics as far as possible, because I have other accounts and another life where I'm doing this extensively. This here is just my hobby, and it's meant to be lighthearted, and fun, and just for enjoyment.

And yet, writing this story just hit me.

It is partly an attempt and a way to deal with the events happening not too far away from where I live and which affects life in my nation and the peaceful world I've been living in since weeks ago deeply. So, I never meant it more seriously when I'm saying: **I'm writing this for *me*, but you can read it if you like.**
I'm trying to stick to reality, and get my research done

properly, but reality will necessarily overtake me within hours and days, so keep that in mind. Plus, this is a fictional work, so I will deviate and put in made-up stuff. As usual, I will mention many things in the footnotes. You can criticize my writing in good intent and I really care for honest input, but I won't take any insults or a political agenda on this delicate matter. If you think Russia went to this war for a good reason, please fuck off.

This story has a rather grim and serious approach, but it won't be overly cruel, because I'm not a fan of that and gore bores me. I have a complete outline done, so I know the course of this story, and I'm vaguely aiming for around 50k of words and have written around half of it. But I'm just writing as I go, and we already saw how that turned out before at "The Siege", so we'll have to see it here, too. Updates will come in loosely on a perhaps bi-weekly basis or slower. Also, this is the first time I'll be including *explicit* stuff, because I needed something good and nice to hold on to between all the *reality*. It won't be a large part of the story, though, and I will perhaps drag the climax out until the last moment. I'm not above cruelties, too. ;-)

That being said: Please, enjoy.

Telling 'What is' in Mariupol

Chapter Summary

Adora has seldom felt lonelier than in this dying city.
And that's the reason she's still here.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

This isn't a story about the time after the Holocaust.
It's also not a story about a war.
Maybe, it's a story about the time before the Holocaust.[1]

==========

"This is *What is*.
Mariupol is again under heavy siege by the Russian Armed Forces, which as of now have encircled the city entirely and aim to capture the city center in the coming days.
Around 180.000 civilian people still persevere in the city, meaning that around 300.000 have fled or been evacuated. But another attempt of a ceasefire for another evacuation failed this morning. Additionally, Russian soldiers opened fire on construction workers trying to repair parts of the water supply system at municipal works. The city has been cut off from water and energy supply for weeks now, and many are in dire need of drinking water and medical supplies.
During the last 12 hours, bombs and grenades were falling every 10 minutes, and even the city center isn't a secure place anymore. I witnessed several public and residential buildings being hit from the place where I sleep. According to a spokesperson of the mayor, around 50 percent of Mariupol's buildings and infrastructure have been severely or completely destroyed. In an

hour, I'll publish an interview with him and several municipal workers I made today and yesterday.
This is Adora Gray, reporting from Mariupol. Thanks for watching *What is*."
==========

Whump.

The odd sound before the actual explosion is like a failed warning. Too quick to do anything beside getting freaked out. Having enough time to do exactly that - freaking out - is nothing but a cruel joke. Her nerves are already on the edge.
The grenade is probably a misfire, but then the warhead decides to go off yet in a half-hearted detonation. Fire spreads, a blast wave booms, bricks and stones and cement get tossed around, but it's less impressive than it should've been, and that's also because she got used to it.
It makes the facade of the aged residence just across the street crumble, the wall to the northern side collapsing inwards as the stones of the structure give in to the force. A part of the roof follows, a cloud of dust covering the sight. After a few boring moments, it gets silent again, and the dust finally settles down like little happened.
The attack was useless, because the houses have long been evacuated, their former inhabitants fled - or dead - and even if they return… well.

Half a minute later, Adora dares to peek over. She always waits this long, to be sure that all the rubble and splinters have fallen down. There is the crossing before her hotel, and she's in one of the rooms towards the street, in the second floor, for a better sight. Of course, she doesn't sleep there. Adora Gray is no rookie, and would never be so careless. Also, they weren't able to cover the windows here with cardboard plates, because there was only enough material to do that on the ground floor. That was a measure rather for securing the hotel against easy looters than from the shelling.
The cardboard covers won't help much against a direct hit.

Considering the current circumstances, Adora doesn't regret choosing The Spartak Hotel when she called and booked it at the beginning of February. Angella warned her, she warned her twice, but she also told her that the European Commission as well as the Americans expected the Russians to attack Ukraine very soon, within days. Adora knew where she had to go, packed her backpack in a trained two hours session and was on her way the next morning to pick up Bow.
Clearly, she wanted to book something in the city center, because she rightfully assumed that would be the last part of Mariupol where the artillery would fire upon. And until the Middle of March, her assumption hadn't been so wrong. Only a few, accidental impacts targeted them, as this part of the city wasn't really aimed at by the Russian artillery.
It is just a residential area.

Or rather, it has been.

Today, nothing looks like people can or will live here in the foreseeable future. The city is a ruin, and every day and night turns more building into dust. She can hear the artillery of the Russian invasion forces levelling the remains of the vast-spreading steel works in the north-eastern part of the city, as well as the harbor facilities in the south, towards the Sea of Azov. Mariupol had been one of Ukraine's most important harbors, a large city with nearly half a million citizens. Whether the war ends or not, there's probably no real future for Mariupol. The city is finished. Adora'd been over at the harbor three days ago, and there was barely anything left intact of the former halls, cranes, railroads and docks. All works there stopped the day power was gone weeks ago anyway.
But it seems, with the growing frustration of the Russian command about the inability to finally occupy Mariupol, they just decided to level the entire city until nothing else than ash is left. Since early morning, every ten minutes a detonation resounded through the inner city, and the distance of the impacts to her accommodation shrank continuously. Like in Aleppo, she got used to the noise in a weird, accepting way.

Adora took the smallest single room the night she arrived. Its only small window heads towards the little inner courtyard, and she already covered it with a cardboard she mounted into the frame with the help of The Spartak's caretaker, Pjotr. And she put the only drawer before it. Now it's always dark in her room - electricity fell out at the beginning of March - but that was and is an acceptable loss for being able to sleep with a bit more security. She has a strong flashlight, and that must be enough.
The courtyard is surrounded from three sides by the U-shaped hotel building, only open to the north, where the wing of another building to the east shields most of it. It was a good thought, and actually is until now, and Adora hoped that no grenade would hit the courtyard itself. That would probably kill her.
Yet, she didn't want to go into the basement. She did that one time, back in Afghanistan, and it bestowed her with an experience she never wants to relive. Until today, she really doesn't like basements.
Bunkers too.

Again, she peeks outside. No building in her street still has glasses in the frames, despite no grenade directly hit the most of them. But the constant pressure waves from the surrounding blasts had been enough over the course of several days. The roofs are mostly gone too. Only the windows of the Mairpol'skiy Krayeznavchyy Muzey, the local history museum, are still there. It probably has security glass, Adora assumes, but even there the roof is damaged.
She leans at the window frame and bows outside, shielding her eyes against the light of the yet low sun. She can see a few lonely figures hurrying along the streets, perhaps on their search for water and food. The remaining hotel crew… well, no, it was rather Pjtor, the paranoid old fellow who turned out to be right, long decided to keep the doors shut and barricaded. It's probably heartless, but like always when the situation gets pretty dire, people suddenly turn on each other, as desperate people everywhere do.

The hotel crew only let their own guests in and out. That is, the three remaining guests they have. Of which Adora is one. Another

one is a short and stocky, stranded businessman from Azerbaijan who is too afraid to go outside and whom she has only seen twice or thrice during the last fourteen days. The other one is a Polish man who searches for his relatives for the most of his day, and only comes into the hotel to sleep. He hasn't found his daughter and her two children yet. Their nearby house was empty, but their car was still in the garage, and they would never take one of the evacuation busses that left the city through the insecure corridors. After all, the Russian army was too uncoordinated and incompetent not to fire on them on several occasions, and now people are rightfully and totally scared to even try. They didn't leave the city, he's sure of it, and continues his search while his face grows sunken more and more with each passing day. Adora admires him for his dedication, and pities him for what he will go through when the time comes for him to realize what has probably happened.

And there is Adora.
She's the last remaining western war correspondent in the city and probably the entire region eastwards of the Dnieper, Ukraine's large river which parts the country in nearly two halves.
Two other Ukrainian journalists also working for AP left the city a week around a week ago, when it became clear that the Russians were searching for them after they submitted several heart-wrenching reports and photos of the situation[2]. They had to leave. And Adora knows, she should've gone too.

And yet, she's still here.
It's all she can do.

Despite, every single one of her friends and most business contacts begged her not to do this. Angella even went so far as to cry on her video call when Adora asked her for financial support in return for exclusive video material from the city to boost fundraising. She cried and pleaded Adora to get out of there, but Adora has never not been stubborn to do the right thing, didn't comply, and now Angella still supports her. She would never not.

Yet, Adora has no illusions that her status as a German citizen, as a renowned reporter or as a woman will help her in any way if the Russian's catch her. She is far too prominent, documenting the atrocities and war crimes Putin's army commits, as not to be recognized at some point. And there are Russian laws against her kind of work, which is, *telling what is*.
And that's what she's doing.
"Say what is."
The ultimate motto for journalists "Spiegel" founder Rudolf Augstein[3] made in a still analog world decades ago, back in the sixties of the last century. It's never been more important in the digital era, an era of information warfare and purposeful fake news. She internalized the motto during her apprenticeship at the important German newspaper when she moved there and out from Angella. And stuck to it when she switched over to her current profession. Despite what she learned in the very dedicated, very talented newsroom in Hamburg, the entire atmosphere and mindset always felt too narrow, too tight, not wide and not far-sighted enough to breathe freely. They clearly didn't foresee what Putin certainly was going to do. So few did. Adora switched to freelance work, which was hard at the beginning, but with a little help from her former colleagues and again, Angella, she made it. And then she discovered where she wanted to be the day she witnessed the Taliban beheading a woman. She just wanted to make a documentation about the current situation of women in Afghanistan. She didn't even know that she pressed the button of the camera and started filming the entire scene out of the hip. But she knows she will never forget. Nor would she let the world forget.

Youtube deleted the video she posted on her very small, very little watched private channel after three hours, but at that time, the view count had already gone through the roof, the video being watched by millions.
Then it was gone.
She called Bow and Glimmer to talk about what she'd seen, to vent, to get her feelings about what happened out, to do anything, but in the end, she just cried. She cried, and cried, and

then she got angry because Youtube, these cowardly, bureaucratic rule sticklers, just deleted the truth.
What made the difference was Bow's suggestion to host such things on her own platform, and to use an automatic distribution system to post her stuff across as many other platforms as possible for spreading the word. He and a nerdy friend of his programmed it within four days, and at the end Adora had her own website, or rather, a content slingshot.

She put the video there, together with commenting it by just describing *what is*. Slow cuts, no hiding, no *narrative*, without any moral implication, just telling as many facts she could gather from the people witnessing, standing around, watching.
Partaking.
Of the other women of the village who accused one of them and told the Taliban about her whereabouts. Of the man with whom the accused had been *fraternizing* and who didn't get a punishment beyond ten hits on the back. Of the two Taliban judges, who cited according passages from the Koran. Of the victim's sister, who pleaded for her life even *after* her sister was already dead, because she couldn't believe the girl she knew her entire life was already gone.

Because she had sex while not being married.

That was all, *what is*, and it spoke for itself. There was nothing else to tell or to comment, and it still sends shivers down Adora's spine if she thinks about it. Adora wasn't like these idiots on Fox News who talked much while knowing little. It wasn't hers to judge, while she was trying to tell *what is*. She could do nothing else at the time.

The video, as well as many more, went viral, and then Glimmer made some very profound use of Adora's newfound popularity by selling broadcasting rights and setting up a small freelancer team to maintain the platform and Adora's work. Today, she uses a video camera and her voice to tell *what is* rather than a pen or a keyboard. Because she long got that telling *what is* needs a picture too to have an impact. Or even better: animated pictures.

Usually, doing that isn't getting her in a more dangerous position than everyone else in a war area. The problem with this certain war is, that after being reluctant and indecisive for too long, the country she lives in today took a stronger stance against Putin, a few days after the invasion began, and now its citizens are under the same threat as everyone else if they show up in Russia. Germans, businesses and privateers alike, had many connections to Russia, but during the last weeks they'd been fleeing the country in droves, and now there are barely any left. Russia is seen as a hostile country by almost everyone in Europe, today.

And yet, Adora stays in Mariupol. It's, after all, still an Ukrainian city.
Because if she leaves, there's no one left to tell the stories of *what is* in this city.
Of what really happens in Putin's war.

Adora sighs, fixes her ponytail another time, and retreats from the window. The sight is depressing, and beside some noises from far away, nothing happens. The street is dead now.
Her bulletproof vest and the helmet are always on, from the moment she wakes up until she lays down for sleep. But as she walks into the hallway and towards the stairs, she loosens the strap of the helmet and takes it off, putting it under her arm, just because she can. She also checks her gun while she heads down to the ground floor, because gun safety and readiness is important, and of course she has one. When Bow handed it to her before he left, the first thing she did was to aim and shoot two bullets against a nearby tree, and after securing the weapon again - upon Bow's puzzled look - she shrugged and replied: "What? Never trust a gun you haven't personally test fired." She put it away at the small of her back like a cheap villain from a TV show while Bow gulped, then nodded, and now she still has it, and some rounds of ammo.

Adora never believed in careless lack of arms. In her situation, it's better to have one than not.

She heads towards where the kitchen of the hotel lays. It's one of the few rooms without any outward windows, and so the few people still staying here tend to spend their time in there. It's the safest place they can find, and it's also just five of the former employees, then Adora, and sometimes the Polish man when he's not outside, which is often. The businessman hasn't left his room in three days, he just opens his doors when Serhej knocks at his door to bring him something to eat and to take back the dishes. It's a weird resemblance of normality: room service, and Serhej actually seems to do it gladly. It's one the few duties the young handy-man has left, since he's not able to go shopping for the daily needs of the hotel anymore.

For some lucky, unknown reason there's still gas in the pipes, probably of Russian origin, as odd as this is, and so they can cook. And that's another lucky thing: Spartak's only remaining cook, Vassily, is an elder man with just one eye, and he does an excellent job of making something edible from the things they've still left.
Food itself isn't so much of a problem for them, because the hotel was stocked with many basic stuff like noodles, rice, flour, salt, sugar or milk powder when the war began five weeks ago. These folks were obviously prepared, probably thanks to Vassily. A lot of preserved fruits and vegetables in glasses and cans also sit on shelves in a small storage room in the basement, together with a little stove and a few bottles of gas to operate it. They can endure weeks with that supply.

But water is going to be a problem soon, because yesterday, the general water supply of their quarter finally stopped working and without water…
Luckily, they have several 25-Liter canisters, and they already filled every available bottle with the so important liquid. And then the bathtubs of several guest rooms too, so they can still wash themselves, and use it to flush the toilets. But that's a temporary solution, Adora knows it. Open water quickly gets undrinkable and then unusable, and even bottled water needs to be boiled before one can drink it, if it wasn't vacuumed.

She's seen what happens to a city when water and electricity stopped working. Not only once. Surely, more people have been killed in beleaguered cities due to shortage of water than actual bullets and bombs.

Vassily doesn't understand English or German, and Adora doesn't speak Ukrainian. Lucky for them that they both have a basic knowledge of Russian, as ironic as this is, given who is attacking the city.
"Dobroye utro, Vassily," Adora says lightly, as it is her nature, even in the direst circumstances.
She earns a grumbled "Hmpf," in return. He stirs in a large pot, obviously cooking something simple, and Adora asks a bit haltingly: "What's for breakfast today? No… self-baked bread? It's excellent."
"I did not feel like baking this morning," he finally retorts with his rough voice, still grumbling, pointing at the pot and adding: "Rice pudding. With fruits. It's satiating."
His Russian is as rusty as hers, but the worse the situation in the city got, the more Adora could tell how much he despised the Russians - and with them their language. He just speaks it with Adora because he has to.

"It smells good." She leans against one of the unused work places and tries not to soil anything. Vassily keeps the kitchen in a very orderly state, despite the circumstances. "I want to go to the museum and then to the hospital. To make pictures. Tell the world the stories."
"Nobody left in the museum. They are all gone," Vassily replies wearily.
Adora nods accepting. "Well. Then I just talk to other people about it. It is important to show what war does to normal life in a city. People can only relate to such things on a personal level."
She's not sure if she got the wording right, but Vassily nods, pulling a corner of his mouth, and his one eye glistens with a certain wetness. If she didn't know it better, she would assume a very soft core under his hard shell. Then he takes a bowl out of a shelf, and puts two, three trowels of rice pudding into it. He hands it to Adora and asks: "Applesauce or cherries?"

Adora's choice is quick and easy: "Applesauce! What else! Yummy!"
He nods with a grin and opens a glass of applesauce. The glass makes a quiet *click*, as the vacuum seal breaks, and the noise reminds Adora of the unusual silence.
"Where are Valeria and Anna?", she asks. Both women belong to the hotel staff, being receptionists and caretakers and problem solvers and whatnot at once, and they have been best friends from the day they started working here years ago. Another lucky coincidence, as they began their jobs independently of each other within only a week. Ever since, the two women had been inseparable.
"Spinny wanted to look for her aunt. Valeria wanted to go with her."

Adora sighs. Of course, the two damsels would stick together at all cost. And it was a bad idea to go searching, in a city being shelled with artillery and rockets non-stop now. But who was she to blame someone? The two women lived here, their families too. Adora herself was here voluntarily, and now she was kind of stuck in this crumbling resemblance of a once civilized place.
While she spoons up the rice pudding with plenty - plenty! - of applesauce, she thinks about her route for today. She loves to plan ahead, to have a plan, to be ready for every circumstance. But plans tended to be outdated the minute they were made in Mariupol today. And so Adora decided to improvise, once again. She had gotten pretty good at it.

Unlike her uneventful and boring private life, her professional career is something Adora is actually proud of. Since she became a freelance war correspondent, she'd been in Afghanistan, in Syria and Libya in less than a decade. She reported from the hotspots of war during these years, and they weren't so different from each other. Because the faces of the people were always the same: angry, then tired, then frightened, then hopeless.
These conflicts had been civil as much as they had been proxy wars of the superpowers of the world, which were pretty much the same as always.
But she never expected to report from an entire country being

assaulted in a full scale war in the 21st century again. As far as she is concerned, the Long Peace[4] has been gone since the Syrian civil war, which the Russian's also fueled. But their invasion of Ukraine was certainly the final nail in the coffin of that chapter. Another proof, that nuclear powers only attacked non-nuclear ones, and that you had to be pretty stupid to bow to bully more than once.

Adora reported from the front line of the attacks of Syrian troops against rebel occupied cities in Norther Syria, and she witnessed the days when the Taliban overrun Kabul a second time in the chaotic days of summer 2021. This had been her own, personal Saigon, as she left the Afghan capital on a helicopter Angella personally chartered in Peshawar, paying the pilot a fortune to fly Adora out from the roof of her hotel at the western outskirts of the city. It maybe helped that the Embassy of Pakistan was nearby, so the chopper could pass as diplomatic transport and wasn't thoughtless attacked by idiots. Yet, it'd been one of her most terrifying moments, because under her, the city collapsed to the Taliban the very day, and someone like Adora clearly was on their lists. The country has fallen into oblivion and reverted to the Middle Ages since the retreat of the West.

She wipes her eyes and exhales audibly. Oh stars, has this just been three quarters of a year ago? Unbelievable.
Maybe she should've taken a longer break after that. But how could she know that the next world crisis would just be half a winter away, started by another warmonger?

Munching her rice pudding, she asks Vassily with a full mouth: "Why do we actually still have gas? Isn't that all gone now?"
His only eye glances at her with a mixture of amusement and earnestness. "Pyotr and I had a gas tank installed in the basement, years ago. We can continue cooking for weeks. We always knew this war was coming, and wanted to be prepared. Why do you think there were so many chipboards, and tools and stocks in here?"
Well, it makes sense, but: "You knew the Russians were coming?", Adora asks warily, already on the way of switching between

amicable breakfast conversation into a more battle-ready-interview mode.
But he's clearly not up for a long talk. "Not necessarily them. But anyone. Can be any idiot. Separatists like the morons in Donetsk. Or the Russians. My land has been the battlefield of others for centuries. Why should that change?"
There is a certain weariness in his words, as if he is simply tired of it, but then he adds grinning: "That's why you namby-pamby Western girl still get to have rice pudding in the morning."

Adora sticks her tongue out at him and finishes her breakfast, then leaves Vassily to his manners and pans, and goes back to her lookout.
Again, she's sitting at the window of the corner room on the second floor. She wants to let her surveillance drone fly and scout the surrounding streets another time. The news the hotel crew spilled this morning were that the Russians slowly advance into the city, and maybe they already captured the maternity hospital they bombed days ago. It's important to know if she can go out or not, if there are already fights near her position. An hour ago, several SUV-like jeeps of the Ukrainian armed forces rushed eastwards, but since then the street became eerily quiet again. Adora knows that sitting at the window isn't such a good idea and might put her in danger, but she needs it to let the drone fly and for a better connection of the signal. She can't risk the loss of the device.

She steps out on the narrow balcony and throws the drone into the air with a quick move of her hand. It has a self-stabilizer and an automatic which lets it hover around ten meters above the ground immediately, away from other things. As fast as she stepped outside, Adora moves back into the relative and questionable security of the corner room, hiding behind the wall beside the balcony door, and picks up the remote control.
The little monitor doesn't have a large screen, because screens require power, and power is a rare good in a war area. She has a foldable solar panel for charging a power bank which in turn she can use to charge all her other devices: a small and robust satellite phone, a radio, her video camera, the drone and its

remote control, a flashlight and her GPS device. The fewer time she needs to recharge any of them, the better. The solar panel and the power bank itself are military grade stuff, which means they are very robust, super expensive and work with a lower performance than consumer products. But in her situation, a sturdy reliability in any circumstances is much more important than performance. She can live with a longer charging cycle, but she can't with loose contacts or stuff like that. If the damned panel needs six hours to charge the power bank, so be it. It's not like she has a full schedule, and if she got a thing or two, then it's that shortage of time is seldom a problem in a war. To her, it was hair-raising to learn how slow everything goes in the military, where the actions of thousands of people have to be coordinated. Her short flirt with a military career was quickly over when she learned that sitting-around-and-doing-nothing made up around 90 percent of a soldier's time.

However, she made sure to have the best available equipment, and also Bow loves to tinker with her stuff for upgrading it, and so the screen has an excellent resolution, and color, and she can make out nuances of the scenes she flies over. Improving her equipment in general has saved her life, probably not only once.

She steers the drone by setting waypoints on the map with a fingertip, and it quickly moves over the adjacent streets, providing her with a good overview within a few minutes. It shows devastated streets and devastated buildings, car wrecks, an occasional armored vehicle barricading a crossing. What's also noticeable is, that none of the trees have started greening, despite it's slowly getting spring, and temperatures have already risen from minus degrees to something above the freezing point. It seems that leaves obviously don't like being shelled, too. Setting up waypoint after waypoint, Adora doesn't let the little flying object stand still even once, because it would be an easy target. And both sides have become very giddy to shot them down. It also flies an automatic zigzag course to make it harder to aim at it. The drone is painted in light and dark gray with a few light blue stains, and it's nearly impossible to make out against the sky. It also nearly doesn't make any noise. Still, one of her

drones has been shot down in Aleppo before, but since she asked Bow and his geeky friend to adopt the zigzag-thingy, it hasn't happened again.

After exploring the northern side of her area, the drone now moves southwards. Beyond Italiiska Street, the next one parallel to hers, an area of smaller houses in a large residential area spread until the tracks of Mariupol's central station. The railway station was one of the first buildings to fall victim to the Russian artillery, and Adora still wonders why. It's not that the trains were of any military use. Nobody would be so foolish to transport troops in a device as easily targeted as trains. They were just being used to evacuate people. But even that stopped after power went out, and the tracks had been sabotaged by someone a few miles out of the city for whatever reason. For some people, war was and is just an excuse to let themselves go and dive deep into their own abnormalities or their need to finally let the apocalypse happen. Adora never understood that particular attitude, this desire for demise, for the downfall of anything that wasn't perfect in their mind.

She blinks when she realizes that she'd trailed off again, something that tended to happen too often and too long in the recent days, and she fixes her eyes on the screen again, while still cowering against the wall.
Mariupol had never been a beautiful city, and today it's been twenty years since it reached the height of its population of half a million people. It had been a steady decline since then, but it was a moderated and guided one. The city overhauled old Soviet apartment blocks, revamped them and made larger flats out of smaller ones, or demolished them at all. When Russia invaded Ukraine on the 24th of February 2022, the city had around 430.000 citizens. Half of them were of Ukrainian origin, and a bit less of Russian one. Now, a month later, most of them have fled inland, mainly towards Kyiv and further westwards to the European Union who welcomed them with open arms.
Surprisingly, even most of the Russians didn't opt to go to Russia. Because somehow, this war seems to be born out of desperation, yelling out loud that Russia has no future anymore or at least, not

a desirable one.
And today, maybe only one hundred thousand people are left here - and of course several understaffed, overstretched and exhausted battalions of the Ukrainian army, defending a case that already seems to be lost.

She orders the drone back with a tip on the "Return" button, and catches it out of the air when it's hovering before the balcony. Again, she retreats quickly into the room and wraps up her gear. As Adora considers what she's seen from the uncertain safety of her hotel, it looks as if this city is making its last, desperate breaths before dying, before being completely annihilated.
A city, where the window frames have no glasses, where the buildings are empty, void of life, where businesses and supermarkets and restaurants are looted, where the last remaining hospital has been bombed by the invaders and where the 18-month-old boy with the name Kirill had suffered from shrapnel wounds that cost him his very short life. Kirill and other children, other casualties, just a few of perhaps over 3.000 dead, had been laid to rest in a mass grave, alongside the six-year-old girl in her pink striped jacket just a few days ago. And the day after, her last colleagues, the Ukrainian AP journalists, had been gone, and Adora has seldom felt lonelier than in this dying city.

Kirill was just a little child, and his life ended after a short 18 months. Ended, because a dictator miscalculated, couldn't get enough, and no one dared to stop him when it was still time. Because at all times in history of mankind, people tend to be cowards, and selfish, and shortsighted. Because the world had other things to care about.

And that's the reason she's still here. Because she has to make sure that the world *finally* cares.
It's time to make sure of that.

Chapter End Notes

> The next chapter is named "The war on our doorstep". I' gonna publish it come weekend, I think.

Footnotes:

[1] This is an altered version of the preamble of John Shirley's book "Eclipse" of 1985. It's the first book of the Eclipse Trilogy, a very dystopian yet realistic story about the Third World War which aged very well, and given today's world situation, it's looks like a sarcastic prophecy. I recommend it highly. ↑

[2] This is worth your time, but is hard to endure. ↑

[3] The first appearance of this statement was in 1961, when he wrote: "To help bring to light a truth that lies dormant under the smooth surface of the popular opinion, to grasp this necessary truth in an unassailable manner and to send 400,000 copies to the furthest corners so that no one can say that it has been inaccessible to them, a truth that established leaders and opinion makers have evaded out of convenience and selfishness - that is the only way for the journalist to change reality: he can say what is." ↑

[4] Read this about the Long Peace, but for a better understanding of the term, watch this: "The Fallen of World War II". I cannot recommend this visualization highly enough.↑

The war on our doorstep

Chapter Summary

> Catching glimpses and impressions of a besieged city, Adora makes her way through Mariupol.
> Sometimes, memories distract her from the harsh face of reality.
> But as pressure increases, she runs out of time.
> And then it's too late.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The window glasses on the ground floor have been blown out days ago. But Pyotr, the janitor and caretaker of the more crafty stuff at the Spartak hadn't the intention of leaving his house to looters. As the stubborn mule that he was - his words - he carefully covered the empty frames with hardboard pieces and fixed them with thick screws, driven through metal hinges into the old brickwork of the building. And because he's a thoughtful man, he made a double layer, so it would need the force of a car crash to get through them. That isn't much of a threat these days, as beside the occasional military vehicles, cars are rarely seen in the meantime.
At least not driving, because fuel has become as rare as fresh water in Mariupol. Most of the people with working cars have already fled since the war started.

Pyotr also fortified the large entrance door with new, sturdier hinges and a thick crossbar. Now he heaves the wooden beam aside to open the door to let Adora out. "Not a good idea," he says in his clumsy English while opening the door. But then he shrugs his shoulders. "Lady should not go outside." The years of working at a hotel have taught him a little of the language so many people speak today.
Adora pats him on his shoulder and puts a forced smile on her

face. “But that’s what I’m here for. Don’t worry. I’ll be back in the afternoon. Watch out for me then. I’ll knock.”
He will. He’ll sit in the corner room on the first or second floor and observe the streets for her return, as well as for the other ones. After all, there’s not much else for him to do. He already fortified the hotel as much as possible. Not only against the Russians, but his increasingly desperate fellow citizens too.
As Adora stepped out on the street, he closes the door, and she hears how the bar is put back to block the entrance to a hotel that hasn’t really closed but hasn’t really open either. The few employees still there do their daily duties, even if they can’t do or offer much. They just don’t have a clue what to do else.

Adora thinks if people are just like that, even in the most dire circumstances: sticking to their routine as long as possible, because otherwise it would be the concession that life has already changed inevitably. Do they even see themselves as employees, because, well, nobody pays them anymore? The owners of the Spartak were near Charkiw, the large metropolis in the north-east of Ukraine, near the Russian border, when the war started, and nobody has heard of them ever since. Pyotr thinks they are dead, Vassily says they must’ve fled to Poland because they have relatives there, but Anna and Valeria protested vigorously, stating that the couple would never do that and that something else must’ve happened to them. Serhej has no opinion or doesn’t dare to have one or doesn’t want to voice what he thinks. Maybe they are just stuck somewhere.
Well, another story to probably tell in the future, Adora sighs to herself.
But not now.

With a quick step, she starts walking down Heorhiivs'ka Street eastwards. She’s dressed in her typical, sturdy clothes: hard linen jeans and a shirt alike, of light brown color, and well broken in black combat boots. Fully transparent safety goggles protect her eyes. To not look like a mad scientist or soldier, her vest is painted in white, bearing the word “PRESS” front and rear, and her helmet is held in the light blue the UN uses for the helmets of peacekeeping missions. It’s totally contrary to her behavior while

she stays in the hotel or hiding in general.
But when walking around and doing her job, she opts for clear and present visibility. It’s important not to be mistaken as a combatant, but rather as a neutral observer. It’s not much protection, but it’s the best she can do.
As always, her camera sits on its shoulder mount. All she has to do to start recording is pushing a button there. She got used to the weight of the rather small device. But as she walks, her vest sometimes chafes on the back because it reaches the buttocks. Another improvement Bow made, to protect her loin and back. He extended the cover with a flexible Kevlar-like fabric, but it’s not sitting perfectly.
Well, it’s still better than getting a bullet in her back.

To her surprise, there are still people out here, walking, some of them hurrying. Most of them have a haunted look, but there are some in better condition. Of course, there are always war profiteers, on all sides, and in every war, but she would be surprised if there were such people here at the moment. It looks more like some people were just better prepared. Given Vassily’s words, she shouldn’t be surprised.

She passes the parking place by the Café of St. George’s, where her Jeep sometimes used to stand while she still had it. Now the vehicle is somewhere at the outskirts of Mariupol and is probably damaged for good. They siphoned the diesel off of it and put it into Bow’s, because he needed every drop of it to get out of here and to Zaporizhzhia. She mourns over the loss of it, because getting around became outright harder without it. Well, she doesn’t have to stick to it. It was just a rental, and not that important. Her personal stuff is, but she can't afford to have her heart set on things she'll have to leave behind in a heartbeat if needed. Adora has never had a lot of stuff, and keeping her baggage small is a trait she cultivates.

And important was getting Bow out of here, and so she sent him home when the shelling started. She’s relieved to know that he made it back to NATO territory, where he’s safe and now reunited with Glimmer. Adora assured both of them that she just wanted to

stay for two or three more days when they talked about it, but she knew it was a lie, and then the shit hit the fan, the railroad was bombed, and the trains stopped working, the main road towards Zaporizhzhia was bombed too, the evacuation busses were attacked and captured by these morons, and the next day Mariupol was cut off by the Russians who succeeded in surrounding the city. Since then, they haven't made a fast advancement, but had to fight for every meter into the city. Now, they just seem to want to starve the city to death. And while blaming part of this action on the total incompetence of the underprepared Russian army, which has also vastly underestimated the will and capabilities of the Ukrainian defenders, this is also obviously part of their tactic, of Putin's tactic.
To kill resistance.
Because starving people do not fight.

While weaving her way towards the clinic she wants to visit, she makes short interviews with passers-by now and then. Often, she starts asking them in English, but then she switches over to her rusty Russian, which many understand. Which is a cruel and consummate joke.
An elderly woman with deep furrows in her face throws a wall of text on her, complaining about why the Russian's do that to her. She always loved Putin, and she wanted him to make Russia great again - she actually uses this phrase - but now she can't support what he's doing anymore. "My own brother, he lives in Rostov, doesn't believe me when I tell him that Mariupol is attacked with artillery! He says it's probably our own army doing it in some kind of trick! Can you believe that? What kind of trick should that be? Our military doesn't even have that kind of stuff. Why would they do that? It's ridiculous to say that." Her voice is shrill and loud, and as always, Adora doesn't respond with an answer or even compassion, but just another question: "Have you spoken to him again?"
The woman looks at her puzzled. "What? No. He's a bloody bastard. Believes the liars in the television more than me, his own sister! He always said that these news feeds us lies. And now?

Now he believes them over me?" She's still yelling, but it's quickly faltering into stuttered accusations. "He always… ran to our parents and told on me when we did something wrong. It was never… his fault. The coward!"

Adora just nods. It's the minimum of sympathy she can and wants to show. Doing more would pull her in too much. Even after all these years of experience, it's still surprising how openly people talk about what moves them if she just asks. It's like nobody else does that. But she's not here to side with people publicly, but just to show *what is*.
"Do you think he will reach out?", she adds.
The woman huffs. "No. Even if he wanted to, the telephone isn't working anymore. And the idiot hasn't written a goddam letter in his life."
It's a funny, odd thought. "I don't assume the postman still works, or does he?", Adora questions, but is rebuffed.
"He did until three days ago! But now he's sick. Got a cold, because, you know, the heaters have stopped, and he's always been such a wimp." The woman chuckles a bit about her sad joke, then adds: "Look at me! I'm 58 years old, and I never had a cold. A bit of freezing can't kill me."
The woman looks rather like 70, but an assuring smile makes its way onto Adora's lips. "I can see that. If you were able to say something to your brother, what would you like to tell him?"
"Oh, that's easy." She points at Adora's camera, which is sitting in clear sight on Adora's shoulder. "Can he see that, right now?"
Adora shakes her head in denial. "No ma'am. It's not live. And I doubt that he'd be able to watch it in Russian TV, you know? My programs are usually not shown there. Maybe if he has internet."
"Ah, damn it. Anyway. Ilya, if you see this: get your fat ass out of your armchair and dare to visit me! Come here and look for yourself. See what your great dictator has done to moya kvartira.[5] But bring coffee yourself. I haven't any left, do you hear me?"
Adora chuckles dryly. "Thank you for your time, ma'am."
"No problem, little one. But now I have to hurry, before the shelter runs out of soup. Buvay!" [6]

Adora watches after the surprisingly agile elderly until she moves around the next corner, then she makes another two interviews like that, only short pieces, glimpses into people's current lives. She can't spend too much time because she'll need another half an hour to the clinic. In the distance, she hears artillery fire again. Apparently the Russians are still bombing the vast area of the steel mills in the north, although there is very little left of them since the first fights around the 19th of March.
She can feel how the noose tightens slowly, strangling all life out of the city in a cruel, torturing process.

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"This is *What is*.
Today, the Azovstal iron and steel works in norther Mariupol have again been bombarded by the Russian artillery. The production has been practically shut down three weeks ago, when electricity fell out and the blast furnaces were stopped to prevent larger damage. Ukrainian lawmaker Lesia Vasylenko posted a video of explosions on Twitter, where thick columns of gray and black smoke were rising from the buildings. Later, Ukrainian member of parliament, Serhiy Taruta, noted that "the Russian forces had practically destroyed the factory." [7] I couldn't get there personally, because artillery is still shelling the steel mills and the Ukrainian army has set up checkpoints, but the detonations are audible from my point of view, and it's clear the area is partly burning. I'll post a video of that after this.
In some kind, the Azovstal factory is a relic of the Soviet Era. It was founded in 1930 on the behest of Supreme Soviet of the National Economy, the economic council of the Soviet Union. In the Second World War, it produced ammunition and helped fighting Nazi Germany. After Ukraine became independent in 1991, Azovstal was privatized and subsequently modernized. Five of its former six large blast furnaces are still in operation, most of them rebuilt in recent years. Till a few weeks ago, it was one of Europe's biggest metallurgic plants, and it's mother company Metinvest Europe's fifth-largest steel producer. Now the future of this factory and its former thousands of employees remains uncertain. Beside its production, the large railroad infrastructure

with railway lines to the north and west obviously made the factory a priority target for the Russian army, leading to her demise.
This is Adora Gray, reporting from Mariupol. Thanks for watching *What is*."
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About a hundred meters in front of her, a grenade or rocket hits the road. The explosion is loud, sending a shock wave and whirls up splinters and dust. Some people nearby hastily seek shelter. Rather instinctively, Adora points her camera at it. It's not very spectacular, to be honest. The impact leaves behind a crater about half a dozen meters in diameter, and that is what remains as the dust settles. Nobody seems to be harmed, people already start walking past it again. And even the shock wave wasn't that impressive over here, where she stands. It was loud, but she'd been nearer to explosions like that, and thanks to that, her left eardrum is still damaged. When she's back in Germany, she has to have it treated, she promises herself again.
Something tells her, she'll probably even stick to that promise. But on the other hand, Adora had never been great with treating herself very well regarding things like that.
Still, this had been strong luck. If she hadn't talked with the woman, she perhaps would've directly run into the explosion. Adora sighs. What a mess. It's like a bad written drama, with the very annoying sidenote that this is reality, and not a play.

Speaking of drama… well… she should've thought about that earlier, but she had obviously *not been thinking*. She forgot that she also wanted to film what happened to the remains of Mariupol's drama theater. It was bombed more than a week ago, but since then, there'd been little coverage about it. 400 people had been hiding in the bomb shelter under the building, but of course the incompetent, overcharged Russian artillery had to bomb a theater, too.
Or they did it in purpose.
In the end, it didn't matter. Most of the building went up in flames and dust. Rumors have it that 300 people, men, women and children died there. The situation is still unclear. Her Ukrainian AP

colleagues would've covered that story, but they'd been evacuated by the military, which apparently had no order to care for a foreigner in a situation like that, and also Adora wouldn't have gone with them.
And the theater is just a few hundreds of meters away. She actually walked away from it when she left the Hotel to make her way towards the hospital. Ugh! She just kind of… blocked that thought out.

Adora turns westwards again, into the large Myru Avenue, that directly leads towards the theater. She has to. Find out.
Tell what is.

The little stroll takes her longer than expected, because she runs into another Ukrainian who wants to tell her the story of his niece, who's in the medical practice of a doctor friend. The man is in his early thirties, with a messy blonde shortcut and kind eyes, and he blurts out that he's a father of two, working for a software company in Kyiv via home office for the last two years. His English is pretty good, but his job is… well… internet has stopped working in Mariupol days ago, only satellites and sometimes Star Link are of help now. "But it's dangerous to use it," he explains. "They can target the base stations, and then they bombard you", he says and points to the sky.
She already knew that, but this isn't about her.
"But my little girl," the man continues with a desperate look, "she's five, and she has diabetes. Our doctor has run out of the necessary drugs, and now he's just mixing something from scratch. It works, but it's not reliable and also not good for long. I want the world to know that. That perhaps my Sasha is dying from something trivial like fucking diabetes, just because Putin, this coward, is hiding in his palace and doesn't care about what his blindsighted underlings do." He puts his face in front of the camera and points at the lens. "Do you hear me, you svoloch? [8] You fucking asshole!"

Adora has to take a step back. The man is agitated and breathes heavily. Somewhere to the north of them, another grenade explodes, perhaps on a roof that now is nor more. They don't

even realize the constant impacts in the distance anymore, but this one had been near enough to feel the blow.
He shakes out of his anger, and nods to Adora. “Show him this. He’s already a murderer. I never liked him. But my little girl has done nothing to deserve this. She’s… she’s… just a child. She still plays with her puppets. In autumn, she wanted to go to school, with her friends… ”
He balls his fists and turns around, walking off quickly without saying anything else.

Adora pinches the bridge of her nose, a gesture used too often these days. It’s hard to capture all this personal tragedies.
After a deep breath to calm down, she picks up her walk towards the theater place. Left and right are destroyed businesses and shops. The still remaining defenders of the Ukrainian army as well as some police officers try to prevent larger looting, but they don’t have the manpower to uphold public order and to fight the enemy at the same time. It is therefore hardly surprising that, in addition to the destruction caused by the bombs and rocket attacks, looters take their chance. People are desperate, because they starve. Civilization is always just a thin layer of good behavior, made up by a full belly and a warm place to sleep. Take that away, and humans quickly degrade to just relying on their primal survival instincts. The Stone Age isn’t so far away yet.

Adora approaches the theater… the former theater, because most of the building is just a crumbled shell. It’s located in the middle of a large public square, where they used to make a rink for skating in winter just a year ago. Now it looks like a wasteland, the classical architecture, the columns, the iconic gateway mostly gone, the roof completely collapsed into the main room. The rubble before the entrance has been cleared a little. There are a few other people shyly walking by between the rubble, and some are just standing around. Despite the danger, curiosity drives them out. It’s actually a good place to do more interviews, and more than an hour later, she has four of them and a firefighter who still guards the remains of the theater with a colleague showed her around the scene, let her climb over some crumbled walls and burned-down backdrops.

When Adora points towards the doors of the bomb shelter, he shakes his head in denial. “No. Perhaps bodies still down there. We could not get out everyone yet. They have to be buried first.” Adora points at her camera, saying: “We should show this to the world, so they can see what happens here.” She points at the entrance. “They deserve the documentation.” He nods in understanding, but still shrugs, pulls a little, helpless smile, and denies it in his broken English: “Chief ordered me no one goes in. Sorry, lady.”
Actually, Adora wants to go, because this is much, even by her standards of experiences. She can’t even comprehend the thought of hundreds of dead lying on the floor of the basement, beaten to death by a crumbling building. Yet, it’s important, so she tries. “Do you want to tell me what you experienced here?”
Mostly, it’s easy to get anybody to speak. People just are like that. If asked openly, many start talking like a waterfall. But sometimes, they aren’t. The firefighter is one of them, because he just looks at her with watery eyes and compressed lips. “No.”
Adora nods in understanding and takes a step back. She knows the signs of severe trauma, and just replies: “Okay. Thank you. Maybe another time. There’ll be better days again.”
It’s always a fight with herself not to step in and immediately trying to help. A sign of compassion is okay, but she’s neither a psychologist, nor can she abandon the duty she has come for. Everyone fights their own battle here, no matter which side they are on.

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“This is *What is*.
According to local Ukrainian authorities, around 300 people have been killed in the airstrike on Mariupol’s grand, columned Drama Theater. Due to its solitary position in the middle of a large place and the air raid shelter in the basement, it was used by many civilians who sought protection from the ongoing bombardment of the city. The word “CHILDREN” was painted in large white letters on the ground before the building in a fruitless attempt to signal and ward off an aerial attack. Mariupol's government was unable to give an exact casualty count for the March 16 bombardment. [9]

And still rescue workers continue to search for possible survivors in the ruins, but their hope is fading with every day passing. I did several interviews with locals who told me that in the recent days, no living people have been found anymore. Their videos will be up soon after this in single takes.[10]
This is Adora Gray, reporting from Mariupol. Thanks for watching *What is*."
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She knows it's careless, but after walking around and getting interviews with people, she didn't realize how fast time has passed. It's late afternoon, and she's hungry. Time to go back to the hotel. There's no need to stretch her luck. But before, she also wants to call Bow and Glimmer and talk with them. Just to have a little bit of normality in her life, and she doesn't want to do it in the depressing atmosphere of her dark room. She sits down on a bench at the edge of the square, which has surprisingly endured until now. It's just a bit dusty.
Turning on her satellite phone makes her grateful as always. Thanks to Angella and her sometimes scary connections, she has access to Skynet 5, the British military communication satellites. It's pretty unique in her profession to have such a service at her disposal, but luckily, Angella was able to pull some strings, and voilà.[11]
What makes Skynet better than most other current satellite communication is that it has something like high speed data rates - for a satellite phone. It's enough to upload one of her usual videos in around half an hour without an amplifier, and typically, the upload doesn't fail. She can't use Starlink, even if it would be faster. The necessary base station is unwieldy in size - and like the software guy from before already said, it could easily be located by radio direction finding. That would be like painting a large red X on her position, and the Russians already proved that they are targeting such aims.

The phone connects, and Adora presses redial. It rings, three, four times, then an enthusiastic Bow answers the call with a booming "ADORA!", putting a grin on her face.

“Hey Bow. Everything fine in good old Brussels?”
“I’m sooo glad to hear from you. Are you okay? Did something happen?”
“No, I’m fine, Bow, nothing happened. I just wanna talk a little. How are you, how’s Glimmer?”
“We’re fine. Wait a moment, I’m gonna get her. She’s in a conference call with some guys from CNN. They want to put your videos into a regular news show about the war, and she has hell of a time negotiating with them. You know how she is, huh?” He actually chuckles, and Adora barks out a loud laugh, then snorts. It’s so good to hear about such a triviality like negotiating about air rights and stuff while she sits in the middle of a devastated city under siege in the largest war Europe has seen since the Second World War. It’s such a relief to know that such things still happen somewhere, people doing normal stuff like fighting over percentages, timetables, air rights, brands, clothes, blahblah, whatever.
Imagining how Glimmer is trying to pull the wool over the eyes of her counterparts is superbly delighting, and it makes her grin. The woman practically lives for stuff like that: outsmarting her opponents. It’s why they like each other: they understand their competitive nature pretty good, and it’s also good that they don’t compete with each other. That would’ve been… interesting, Adora assumes.
“Hihihi. This is great. Let her do it and tell her she’s the best for the job.”
“What? No, she’ll want to talk to you in person. The other folks can wait! One moment… GLIMMER!”
Even through the speaker, he is loud. Adora chuckles, while she hears rumbling and yelling in the background.
“WHAT?”, a high-pitched female voice yells.
“ADORA IS ON THE PHONE!”
Prompt and noisy, the answer halls: “I’M COMING! Sorry folks…” Adora can’t understand what they say anymore, because Glim obviously tries to dampen her volume due to everyone’s need to keep their hearing.

Just a few seconds later, it's loud again: "ADORA! HOW ARE YOU? ARE YOU OKAY?"
Adora makes a pained grimace and holds the phone an arm's length away until Glimmer stops yelling at her. When it's silent, she wants to pull the phone back to her ear again, but then: "ADOORAAA?"
A groan escapes her, then she holds it before her mouth like how the kids speak today. "Uhm, Glim, you can, you know, speak normally. The line is working pretty fine. You don't have to yell at me."
"I'M SORRY ADORA! IS THIS BETTER?"
"No. Really, Glim." And it isn't because she barely lowered her voice. A bit of rustling comes out of the speaker, then Bow's voice appears: "I'm gonna put you on speaker. Glimmer is a bit too excited, isn't she?" He emphasized the last two words very much and obviously into his wife's direction. An indignant noise is the reply, and Adora imagines her friend with her crossed arms and her pout very vividly.
"I'm not! You don't babysit me when I'm speaking with my best friend!"
"Best friends squad!", Bow retorts squeaking, sounding as annoyed as his other half now.
"Well, not for long if you keep up with your patronizing behavior."
Imagining Bow pouting is really easy for Adora, and she has to chuckle upon her friend's antics. It's always been like that.
"Oh, come ooon," Bow drawls, then turns to back to Adora. "How are you? How's the situation there?"

Adora takes in the late afternoon sun, which still casts a few warm rays over the place. She can spend some more minutes talking, but then she has to go, because she wants to be back in the hotel before sunset. Pyotr doesn't like to open the door in the dark, because he's frightened about thieves, and possibly about more. She tells the pair about her interviews from today, and the theater, and that she wants to do another piece about it tomorrow or the day after, depending on the situation. "It's a wonder that the officials and the city workers are still trying to do their job. I've seen a few vans of the municipal utilities. They still repair gas

lines, and try to get the main water pumping station back online, even if they don't know about how to power it for long. It's admirable, really, but it's also so… I don't know how to describe it." She knows herself she sounds a bit tired.

Her friends stay silent for a few moments, then her voice sounds earnest when Glimmer finally speaks: "Adora, you know you can pull up stakes there and come home at any time, right? You don't have to sacrifice yourself there. It won't change this asshole's mind."
Adora nods, even if Glimmer can't see her face. She knows that Glimmer knows she does it. "I know," she replies without any energy. "But maybe I can change some minds in the west. To persuade them to do more. You aren't here, Glim - I don't hold that against you, certainly not," she quickly adds, "but there's nobody else left here to tell the world what's happening. And if I'm gone, it would be like a betrayal, like we forgot this place, you know?" Her voice got smaller and smaller while talking, and it spoke wonders to what it does to Glimmer, because the woman isn't yelling at her immediately. Which is something Glim often and gladly does whenever she's not pleased with Adora Gray's decisions. Because Adora is still a kind-hearted idiot, even if the last years dampened her positivity and carefree attitude a bit.

Adora feels she needs to turn the tone of this call. "I hear you're talking with CNN? What do they want? And how far have you ripped them off?"
"Whoawhoawhoa! These are fair negotiations with grown-ups on both sides."
Adora giggles. "Sure, at least on one side," and she lets it open which side she means. Glimmer isn't concerned anyway, because "I think we can do a great deal with them. You can't do any real live reporting, that's clear, but they want to have right of first use of your video material for their evening show."
Adora objects in an instant. "We can't give them that, because I won't hold back from publishing it on our platform."
"Oh, Adora, look at you and how smart you are. Of course, I considered that. Have a little trust in me!", Glimmer playfully

scolds her, and Adora immediately concurs.
"They get to have the TV rights, not online. You don't care about TV, and it's CNN, after all. They get a head start of six hours, and we get a nice license fee in return for something we're also publishing online. It will just enlarge our viewership and coverage, AND we're getting paid for something we already have."
Adora doesn't do it for the money, they all know it, but that hasn't stopped Glimmer from treating their little best friends squad side operation like it's her own business and despite her main job is within Angella's organization. Today, Adora is the only one of them three to make her living completely out of the revenues her platform makes. Bow earns money from some patents he filed years ago, and accompanying Adora out into the wild is something he has his own reasons for. Glimmer also has enough for both of them.
But honestly, her two friends became so intertwined over the last two or three years, it's hard to tell them apart. And Glimmer does a great job handling the business and legal stuff of all of it. Glimmer is thrice as effective as herself, Adora isn't a great fan of doing *formalities* anyway, and so she's endlessly grateful that Glimmer took a liking of her and this stuff. Sometimes, the stocky girl is a little overbearing and pretentious, but Adora knows that she can be a bit much too herself, and so they are mostly even, huh?
"Ok, that sounds good. I trust you on that, and I'm not there to stop you either, so… go on. Work your magic."
"Yup, I will, these fellows are going to pay," Glimmer laughs, and then they talk about nonsense shortly.

The call ends, and Adora decides to sit on the bench and just to think for another minute, despite the risk. Sunset is imminent, and she should go, but it's risky in the hotel too, and she wants to rejoice the last rays of the sun in…, well, peace isn't the right word.
Silence neither.
But it's… it's actually nice here. If it weren't for the constant *whumps* and thunder rolling over the city, it could be really nice here.

Not beautiful, but nice.
She dismounts the camera from her shoulder and puts it back into its bag, then lets her right arm hang behind the back of the bench to relax it a little.

Sometimes she envies her friends for their relationship. Adora knows that something like a real partnership with someone else wouldn't fit her life. Last year, she'd been at home for exactly three months, and not even continuously. It was just enough time to get her stuff sorted, to visit her best friends at their home for two weeks to catch up with them and feel a little cared for, attend a few business related meetings and similar and actually sleep a lot. Her body needed it, but then again, her boundless, restless energy drove her out again after a few days, like always. The apartment she lives in is rather a place to put her equipment in when she doesn't need it. It has little personal flair, and it's boring to sit and do nothing meaningful there anyway.
Adora could never just sit and wait for the world to come to her - or let it do its thing.
She has to be a part of it, and try to make a little change for the better. If her documentations and reports are able to convince one important decision maker or a few people to do things in a better way from after watching, it's worth it.

And yet, in some silent, lonely nights, Adora lays awake and asks herself if she wants this condition to stay like that for the rest of her existence. She seldom thinks about her personal life, because it doesn't feel so important and there seems to be so much time left for that. But that doesn't mean that she wanted to live without a fulfilling, intimate relationship with someone she loves. With a partner.
Bow and Glimmer are like her ideal for that, but that happens one in a million. They know each other since they've been kids, and nothing would part them for real. Being in a partnership and even in love with your best friend is a bulls eye. Adora hadn't had this particular luck yet.

Together, as a trio, they roamed the world together, for some time, but while Glimmer is tough in fighting everything, since she

decided to take over more responsibilities within her mother's organization, she barely gets out of the daily, weekly, monthly routine. She complains - loudly! - about all the micromanagement she has to do, but she also doesn't run away from it. That's not her style, and she wants to take over some day also. She fights her mother viciously over boundaries and equality in responsibility. Angella is still the chairwoman, but Glimmer slowly and stubbornly enlarges her own ground.
Bow is still with Adora.
In that, he's really different from Glimmer. He would never let himself be chained to a desk or an office. But he's torn between his need to explore the world, to tinker with tools while they're on the road, to see places he hasn't seen before and his desire to be with Glimmer and to make a home with her. It's good for now, but he already started to be a little more careful. That being one of the reasons Adora sent him home. Glimmer didn't really object, but she also begged Adora to do the same.
It's a constant struggle, and even if she would never voice it, Adora quietly fears the day the couple decides to have children, because then… then Bow will certainly be a good father and stay with them. That's just how he is and how it should be. And then, Adora will be the only one of the Best Friends Squad to still be out here, in the world, trying to… do whatever she has to do.

Alone.

Which brings her back to her previous thoughts.
It's not that she dislikes intimacy, physical and emotional alike, not at all. She *had* a few but *short* flings during her alike short university career and the apprenticeship in Hamburg.
One time, she had something like a bull's eye.
She made out with an alluring, wonderful smelling brunette at a conference in St. Petersburg two years ago, who pounced through her usual defenses easily and overwhelmed her at the hotel bar with her sheer attitude at the second evening of the event. The woman with the long curls, a very short skirt ending just beneath her ass and perky, pushed up breasts had been a tad smaller than her, already a bit tipsy from the free drinks, pretty playful and obviously *very* interested. At least, she continued touching her the

entire time they talked. Adora doesn’t remember much of the conversation, because she had been a bit drunk too, and so enchanted by the stranger’s eyes, running over her own body, drilling into her own, bewitching her.

It made her so washy.

The curly hair brunette nearly did it for her. While they talked - or rather, while Adora was cornered by her at the dimly lit bar - she was put into an armchair and then straddled by the alluring stranger by ruthlessly invading Adora’s space with her stringy body, smelling dangerous like a legion, and starting to whisper so arousing compliments into Adora’s ear that her eyes went wide, and her breath quickened, then stuttered. The tall blonde nearly got a hiccup when she felt the woman’s hand moving down from where it laid on her thigh, while kissing her with her other hand in Adora’s neck, drawing her in. Then the hand slowly circled her way from the thigh to between the slit of Adora’s long dress… and then between her legs to settle down on her panties very, very softly. There was no pressure, her hand just lay there, waiting, daring, not doing anything. And still the woman’s tongue nipped at Adora’s upper lip and her eyes were so…
It felt so exciting! Hot. Arousing.
But also… overwhelming.
It was just a little too fast and aggressive for her taste, and she wasn’t ready yet.

Adora wanted to be ready!

But she wasn’t.

She didn't even know the stranger’s name, they hadn't gotten that far in their conversation, and then the woman was already seducing her with her overwhelming attitude. It was just a bit too fast, too much. And so Adora stopped kissing, put her hand on the woman’s one, and pulled it back to her thigh. It wasn’t an unfriendly gesture and action, but it was firm.
She wasn’t prepared for that this should end their interaction for the evening.

The hurt look on the brunette's face nearly made Adora yield, and she wanted to say something, something dumb possibly, but the woman just shuffled back, stood up, grumbled words that sounded like "I'm such an idiot," and was away before Adora could say anything.
Later - thirty seconds later - Adora still sat in her armchair, a bit tousled, a bit exposed, a bit embarrassed, a bit puzzled, and then fucking cursed herself for not being more quick-witted. As, for example, in going after the alluring stranger to actually do something.

But she just wasn't as fast in personal matters than in everything else. She didn't find the temptress again for the rest of the evening - and the conference - and she never admitted to anyone that she really tried to. Her slow reaction is something she still regrets until today, even if there was nothing really wrong with it. It had just been clumsy.

So, kissing all of her short… experiments was sometimes awkward, but mostly nice, and fun, and touching the naked skin of another person was actually very - *very* - exciting. It's so tingly beneath her fingertips, when she pets the chest of someone else, and not herself. In return, she also likes being touched herself. But beside some light petting here and there, it never went much further than that. Adora still mourns over the missed opportunity with the brunette. She still feels a pull when she thinks about her, even if she barely remembers her look. Only her eyes. There was something with her eyes.

To her surprise, exploring her own body was also quite fascinating. After she rather accidentally discovered to what heights she could bring herself in the most classic way - with the adjustable shower head at a hotel in some podunk town - she systematically tried and experimented with it after that, as it was her nature. Squeezing her own boobs, and playing with her nipples always made her washy and vibrating, even panting a bit very fast.
And funnily, the shower head *incident*, despite the embarrassment, led to more. It took her just a few days of

fiddling around with the sensitive, little nub above her clit to get the hang of *using* it properly. She discovered the pleasures of said shower head in the large shower with a seating in it at Glimmer's and Bow's home. Adora also discovered that it's a good idea to lock the bathroom *before* playing. What started as a simple shower unfolded to a bit more self-care, when the shower jet massaged this delicate place just right, uhhh, just so good, but she must've moaned a bit too loud while lavishly sweet torturing her pussy.
Because the memory of how Glimmer burst into the room, asking, "Have you hurt yourself? Is everything oka—" is still very vivid. Adora's moaning turned into a loud scream, she quickly turned the device down, in her freeze forgetting to just close her legs, instead covering her pussy with the other hand, and desperately trying to look as innocent and not *doing this* as possible while her face went as red as a lobster. "GLIMMER! KNOCKING!, I was… washing myself," she shrieked, trying to defend herself, but she knew her hair was a wussy mess, and she's panting too loud in this compromising position.
Glimmer, on the other side, needed a moment to regain her composure. The sight of her best - female - friend, masturbating and moaning in her shower, Adora's perfect tits and her athletic yet very touchable looking body was really something. The woman was on the edge of orgasm, that much was clear. Glimmer closed her mouth with bulged eyes, stomping down the weird feeling inside her, then smirked, then giggled, then closed the door again while audibly chiming "Sure. Oh man, what a pity I'm taken. But take your time, baby! There's no need to hurry! Hehehe."
Afterwards, a very smugly grinning Glimmer teased Adora the entire evening, and luckily Bow got nothing from all the nasty innuendos his girlfriend made. Later, the little bitch even gifted her with the exact same shower head on the next occasion. It was so embarrassing.

But shame doesn't last forever, and the whole fuck-up was also enlightening, as it showed Adora what is possible. After she tried her first vibrator, she methodically enlarged her collection of said

tools. She often has to bite her hand when using them, because otherwise she tends to be *too loud*, as proven by the shower incident. Even now, here, a small white one accompanies her at the bottom of her backpack. She hasn't used it yet, but that's just because of her current total lack of desire. Her mood regarding that has deteriorated remarkably since her arrival.
However, pleasuring her physical needs is one of the few amenities she strictly allows herself. There's no need to be shy about it, when she is already so bad at satisfying her other ones. But that's a thought she doesn't allow rising to the surface. She merely acknowledges it is there. There's no use in ruminating about these matters.

Because of course Adora knows that having sex *with someone* might be even better than masturbation. But unfortunately, sex needs *a partner* to do it with, to be trusted with her own body and her wants and needs, and she never made it that far. It's not really insecurity, it's rather… well, she doesn't know what it is. There always seemed to be kind of a barrier to do more.
Men were so… boring and blunt, often pretty dumb and overall not very attractive, and women were so emotional, sometimes cringy, and obviously problematic with nearly everything around a relationship. *Needy*, is a word which comes to her mind upon that. Adora doesn't want a *needy* person at her side. She wouldn't know how to deal with that.
Or maybe she would, she has to admit, with the right person? But no, she would rather prefer someone independent, who doesn't have to rely on her for living their own life. Someone who is their own brilliant person, to make each other's life more happy, more fulfilled when being together. Which obviously would be a problem.
It's just… she never felt this particular attraction to anyone, this oh so desired feeling so many people speak of, but that hasn't dared to come to Adora yet.
It's like the world of interpersonal relationships is a distant sphere of the reality that Adora has no part in.

What contributes is that since now, no one could keep up with her energy. She's always on the move, storming from one war scene

to the next crisis, from conference to summit, and there's barely time to get to know anyone. And for having emotional support, the chaotic yet thriving best friends squad the three of them made up worked pretty well so far. Bow and Glimmer both shower her with reassurance and safety - despite Glimmer's occasional scolding - and in return Adora rather unknowingly but willingly bestows them with a genuine and non-judgemental moral leadership that is rarely found today.
And so it had been for the past years.
But in recent times, with the couple settling down, Adora more and more feels like a third wheel. Still welcomed, embraced, loved, but though. And with that, creepy thoughts of loneliness and being left behind wriggle themselves into Adora's heart and soul. Of being redundant, and left outside.

Stop it, she admonishes herself, deciding it's time to go back to the hotel.
Machine guns rattle in the north, but the fights haven't moved from there in days, while the steel mills are still bombarded. To the west, the front line slowly closed in the last 48 hours, because the Russians use the captured airport to supply their troops there. It's still kilometers away, and the Ukrainian defenders fight for their homes, in contrast to the conscript army on the other side. Yet, the Russian's just have more material in every sense.
Her walk to the hotel only takes her ten minutes, because it's actually right around two corners. Twilight has advanced, but one can see her outline still. She's grateful as Pyotr opens the door even before she has to knock. Obviously, he saw her coming from his outlook.
"Priyatno, chto ty vernulsya," [12] he says with an undertone, emphasizing the "you", which Adora picks up. "What does that mean?"
"Valeria and Anna did not come." His face is a portrayal of worry, and Adora pushes down thoughts of dead people she knows.
"They probably just help Anna's aunt or stay with her? You haven't heard anything, have you?"
"No."
"Well…, then nothing's lost. Shall we go and look for them? Where

does she live? Just let me put my gear down." As always, Adora is eager to help when she's not on duty. And both women were so kind to her, treating her like kin, and she wants to make sure they are alright.
Pyotr shakes his head slowly, while closing the door. "Not in the dark. It's dangerous outside. Thieves. Bandits."
Adora argues a little, but he doesn't want to go, and without him, she can't do much in a city still mostly unfamiliar to her. As he puts the crossbar back into its place, somewhere outside two shots are being fired, as to underline his statement.

Vassily has prepared noodles with various canned vegetables mixed under. It's really nothing special, but after all that walking around, Adora's so hungry that anything would taste great. The three of them sit at a small table in the hotel kitchen, and she is grateful that none of them really wants to start a conversation. Eating in this amicable silence just makes her tired, and she needs to go to bed asap. The Polish man hasn't shown up, and Serhej just served the businessman in his room, like always. Anna and Valeria haven't made a sound too, and they all fear the worst.

After Adora made her cat wash, it's still not very late in the evening. But probably even the Russians want to get some sleep, because the artillery has stopped firing half an hour ago. Or maybe they ran out of ammo. Given the incompetency and hubris with which the Russian high command stumbled into this war - to not say *planned* - after half a year of amassing troops at the Ukrainian border, it would be no surprise.
As the sun is long gone at this time of the year, it means the city is mostly dark. In a rush of exuberance, she leans at the balcony in the corner room towards the street on her floor. Nobody should be able to see her in the dark. There are a few lights here and there, in half a dozen windows up and down the alley, seemingly from candles or flashlights.
That is what happens in a modern, civilized settlement of the 21st century that completely relies on electricity to function. Light bulbs don't shine, washing machines don't run, computers and monitors don't hum, and when the battery of a smartphone is dead, it stays like that. Because electricity obviously doesn't come from the

socket, when the infrastructure producing it is bombed into rubble. And besides, even if you could charge your mobile with something else, the cellular network it relies on doesn't work either, because… yeah.
The finely tuned network of invisible, imperceptible dependencies that provides the lifelines of modern society rests on fairly physical things like working power plants, wiring, and electricity.
These are the thoughts running through her mind while she stands at the balcony, looking down on the street and mentally readying herself for the night. She ponders to put her vest back on, but then decides against it. Sleeping with it on is… not so feasible.

Luckily, Adora's solar panel had enough time and sunlight to charge her power bank, and now she connects the satellite phone and camera with it. Without the panel, her situation would be… dire. She could basically quit being here, because making videos is the entire reason for that.
Adora turns and tosses around in her bed.
It's disgusting that being tired is not enough to be able to sleep. It's not about the noises. She doesn't need earplugs for sleeping - hadn't for years - despite the constant clamor in the background, sometimes more far away, sometimes nearer. It's no artillery fire, it's machine guns, and tanks, and anti-tank weapons. She can distinguish these sounds pretty well, because this isn't her first battlefield she's working on. Ignoring it is the best she can do. And well, if a grenade hits the courtyard, there's nothing she can do about. Everything else shouldn't be deadly, given her location.
Upon scrolling over some messages and her slowly loading news feed, she stumbles over a news unexpected.
"Oh no," Adora breathes, scrambles up from the bed, and compresses her lips. Five minutes later, she is dressed back into her signature white shirt and her ponytail, looking into her camera.
The device sits on a shelf before her, capturing a part of the former guest room without windows behind her well enough. She knows for long how to align it so that the lens focuses on her in the right angle and size. It's already recording, she can cut it later,

and storage capacity hasn't been a problem since years. There's a small remote control available, but she decided to not use it anymore, because every piece of equipment she takes with her has to serve an absolutely necessary purpose. Every weight she has to carry must be of use.
Adora looks out into the nightly sky and shortly thinks about what to say, how to say, how to speak about this with her usual, neutral, perspective.
And then, she decides otherwise.

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"This is *What is*.
But today it isn't. My usual job is to show what is." Adora tucks a strand of hair behind her ear. "So I seldom make personal comments when I'm reporting, because that is strictly against the most important rule I have set for my work. I'm showing and telling you what I see, and I do not comment on that. But I'm going to break that rule for once, because news that only reached me today struck me down. A few days ago, Mr. Borys Romanchenko[13], a Ukrainian citizen, died in a bomb raid on Charkiv. You may not know him, because he was an average man, like so many who already died in this war. But I do." She gulps and restarts. "Respectively, I did. I had the luck to make a short interview with Mr. Romanchenko a few years ago, when he visited the concentration camp Buchenwald in the country I'm living for so long. In 1942, when he was sixteen, he was abducted by the Wehrmacht, brought to a German concentration camp and forced to work in a coal mine. The tale of his survival until the end of the war is stunning, but important is, that he managed to become 96 years old. Mr. Romantschenko survived four - four! - of Hitler's concentration camps and several years of forced labor for the Soviets after the war ended. And only now, several lifetimes later, he finally died on the hands of another dictator. At the age of 96. He survived four concentration camps, only to die in this sordid way, slaughtered by Putin's bombs." She heaves a deep breath in a desperate try to stay calm. It is hard.
"And if you ever asked yourself why I'm doing this: that's the reason. To tell you these stories. It's important that you know

what happens here, in Ukraine, and wherever people are dying because dictators and mass murderers are still in power in the 21st century. Unlike so many of us thought, freedom, democracy and peace aren't inevitable. Because we've been too busy, too entangled, too distracted to realize that these virtues and goods have to be defended again every single day." She exhales heavily and pinches the bridge of her nose. "I just wanted you to know that, because… you know, in case I don't make it. Don't worry, I'm good. But it's always a possibility." She smiles a worried smile. "This is Adora Gray, reporting from Mariupol, and for today, I'm signing off. Thanks for watching *What is*. Good luck."
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Morning comes, like it always does. Adora blinks her eyes open, slowly, and needs a few seconds to capture where she is. Because something isn't like it should be. It's dark in her room, but that's no indicator. The window is firmly sealed, and her door is still closed. Adora knows she must've slept her usual amount of time. It's what her body tells her, and her inner clock always works well. And that's… that's actually a good thing, isn't it?
It means that nothing happened during the night. No bomb fell on her hotel, and she's still alive. Her fingers search for the phone and find it beside her, where she put it. The display tells her it's 5:45 am. Well, a little late, but not much past her normal time. She stands up and opens the door after removing the bar she and Pyotr mounted there. "Any protection is better than no protection," he droned while fixing the screws, then holding the cordless screwdriver into her face: "Best invention ever. I really don't know how humanity got so far without this." The memory lets her smile. Pyotr is the phenotype of the goodhearted grumpy grandpa. Doesn't matter that the man is in his early sixties. For Adora, he's a grandpa: always growling, always moody, but with his heart in the right place.

The hallway has a little light falling in from the outside, and it seems to become a sunny day. How nice.
But Adora gets what's wrong when she steps on the balcony to look around: it's far too silent. There's no firing from machine guns, no artillery, no thunder rolling over the city from when a vehicle is blown up. Only in the distance a few shots are to be heard, but Adora quickly recognizes that these are only isolated incidents, as they seem uncoordinated, coming from different places.
Has there been a ceasefire? Neither her news feed nor the background updates she gets from Angella through Bow and Glimmer mentioned anything reliable, but it *could* be an explanation. On the other hand, the Russians announce ceasefires every day, and none of their proclamations have been reliable so far, so she wouldn't trust it anyway.

In the absence of other reasonable options, her morning consists of Adora's typical daily routine since she's arrived in Mariupol, until it doesn't anymore.

Because a little earlier, somewhere deep in the Russian heartland, a man with too much power and too little restrictions decided to do something about the obvious and continuing failure of his subordinates to capture Mariupol, the last resisting city on the Azov Sea between Crimea and Russia. They haven't been able to sack Kyiv, but they will sack Mariupol for sure, at any cost, so they can obtain unrestricted control of the Azov Sea and the Donbass in the future. He's not desperate enough to go for an ultimate solution, but he's unnerved, his fingers tapping on the table in a show of irritation. Firing another one of his Generals also might not help for the necessary turn of the tides. Luckily, his means encompass more than just that.
He presses a button on the oversized telephone set, and instructs his assistant to call a specific person and put him through. A short waiting time and an alike short call later, he again bypassed the formal chain of command, feels a little better because he actually did something to be more in control of the situation.
His order means that on the airfield of a military base near a large city between the Black and the Caspian Sea, men start running,

engines begin howling, flags are waved, and everything gets very hectic. And then, planes take off.

This happens exactly at ten a.m.

Adora left the hotel ten minutes ago, because she dawdled around and now is actually just a kilometer or so away from it, speaking and taking interviews like usual. Her aim for today is the bombed maternity hospital, an ambitious aim, because she has no clue if the way is still free and the area still under Ukrainian control. The road blocks move from day to day, even if only for a few meters.

At ten past ten, her satellite phone rings.

The high-pitched sound tears through the uneasy because unusual silence. It does that for only a handful of people who have this number, and looking on the display tells her that it's Angella. She wonders, her brows forming a frown, because the woman she looks up to like a mother rarely calls her directly, and right now her gut feeling goes straight south as she picks up.
Two short beeps, followed by an automatic female voice saying "Secure" tell Adora that the call has been encrypted, and the phone operates at the lowest possible transmitter energy for additional protection. In that mode, it can't be targeted.
This has happened only once, at a very specific situation, and a shiver runs down her spine. She doesn't get beyond a "Hello?"

"Adora, Condition Red. You must be quick."

She heard this certain kind of seriousness once before, back when Angella got her out of Afghanistan at the eleventh hour, the day the Taliban overran Kabul and all hell broke loose in the city, as everyone with their senses in their right mind tried to flee. Thousands stormed the airport, the last place still guarded by the Americans. Now, the woman sounds exactly alike. The phrase says everything she needs to know. Angella and her repeatedly talked about it, and here it means: seek shelter from bombing. And if there's one thing Adora is really proud of, it's that her reflexes kick in immediately.

She starts running.

Keeping the phone at her ear, she asks, "Are you sure?", while jumping over some rubble on the street, then running left and right around further obstacles.
It's literally easy to hear and imagine Angella nodding vigorously. "I got intel that the Russians are going to hit Mariupol with a full airstrike. Someone up the command chain must've snapped. Looks like they think they won't be hindered. So, this is as sure as possible."
"K," Adora confirms, evading a hole in the paveway, asking, "what else?" Running and talking concurrently is nothing for her, she doesn't even break a sweat. But she has to be attentive, because the streets are so damaged and full of debris. A few people look at her, some of them puzzled, others warily. A running person is seldom a good sign in Mariupol today.
Angella, on the other side, sounds breathless. "My contact in the NATO HQ says they're on their way, coming in from an airfield near Volgograd. Left ten minutes ago, and immediately formed the typical formation, six tactical bombers, probably Su-34, accompanied by several fighters. It's not that far away. This is imminent. Adora, you have to seek an air raid shelter immediately. Where are you?"
Adora has seldom sensed fear in Angella's voice, but now it's barely concealed.
"Running," Adora pants out, because she's doing exactly that. She hadn't made it very far from the hotel, because of her loitering, and now wishes for the first time she'd done it for longer. Also, she has to warn Pyotr, and Vassily, and the Azerbaijanian man, they all have to go down into the basement. The hotel has an air raid shelter, even if only a little one, accessible from the courtyard. Not a perfect solution, but it goes deep, and it's better than nothing. A direct hit of a precision bomb like a KAB-1500 would kill them anyway, but… well. Better than nothing, and the safest place at her disposal now.
"Where do you go?" Angella gets a bit shrill.
"Hotel. Shelter in the basement," Adora presses out, while

sprinting into a side street just five hundred meters away from her goal. “How long?”, she manages.

Faster, she has to be faster!

“Approximately not more than five minutes. I don’t have real time intel on that, I’m just grateful that I got told, and then I immediately called you. NATO also tries to warn the Ukrainians, but I don’t think the warning will reach them in time. They probably know already, but even if, what can they do? Are there still sirens working?”
“No, not for days”, she gasps and would ball her hands to fist if she weren’t running. “Okay, thanks, so any minute. What else?” She just asks to keep herself distracted. Maybe she could sprint a bit faster without the phone, but if Angella knows anything else, she has to tell her. Adora barely listens to Angella, it’s just assuring to hear her speak, despite the content of her words.
“Not much. I don’t know details. My contact said that it looks like a snap reaction to them. The Russians haven’t as many bombers and jets available as they want us to believe. Their maintenance is not so good. And this seems… excessive? Why bombing an already destroyed city? Where are you now? How long do you need?”
“Right there, just a few hundred meters.”

It turns out, that even being as fast as Adora is, it’s still not fast enough.

In the distance she hears a shrill whistling, from air being tortured, being cut by wings from fast flying objects high in the sky, probably. She looks up, but all she sees is blue sky… no, there are thin white lines, appearing out of nowhere that have already passed her position.
Supersonic.
Of course, but *oh fuck*. It means the bombers have…
The whistling gets louder, followed by one, two, more sonic booms, and the bombers already turn. She still has the phone on her ear when she says, “Shit,” and Angella’s voice sounds fearful when she calls “Adora? What’s—"

Behind her, near the place with the café, a loud explosion shatters the silence, and blows away the remains of the entire building that once - not even two months ago - hosted a nice little clothes shop and several floors of residences. The fire dome rises quick and high, rubble is sent into the air and starts pelting down on everything like a hailstorm out of control. Adora turns away and ducks, but the pressure wave hits her back the same moment another explosion right around the corner before her goes off, blasting a hole into the multi-storey building, shredding everything in its way, and then a stone hits her temple and puts her entire world into darkness. She doesn't…

With a head wound, Adora falls to the ground, no longer noticing how her cell phone slips from her feeble fingers as her grip falters. The device skids across the street while around, explosions rip buildings and streets apart, and nobody can hear the desperate voice coming out of the loudspeaker, calling for Adora, again and again and again. Angella can't possibly mistake what happens on the other side of the line, because the screeching of the bombs and explosions, the pure sound of destruction blasting out of her phone can't be misunderstood.

A city is being leveled, and Adora is in the middle of it.

In a cruel joke, the line doesn't close. Instead, Angella is able to listen and thus witnessing the apocalypse that turns the remainders of Mariupol's city center into ashes, happening around a woman she holds dear like her own daughter. It's sheer horror of not being able to do anything but listen, her mouth standing agape, tears forming in her eyes, and she can't breathe, can't breathe, until she finally gasps: "Adora? ADORA! Oh, please, come in! Dear gods, please say anything! ADORA! Oh no, please don't.

Adora!

Adora!"

An indistinct amount of time passes, until it gets quieter on the other side. Only the sound of something burning and crumbling is

heard. Far in the background, someone is crying.

But there’s nobody able to listen to Angella's desperate calls.

Chapter End Notes

Somebody said I need to do more cliffhangers. Here you have one. Please divert your anger on this person.
The next chapter is named "Enemy Mine". I'm gonna publish it around Easter.

[5] Moya kvartira = My apartment ↑
[6] Buvay = Bye Bye! ↑
[7] This is partly a citation from here. ↑
[8] Svoloch = Bastard, Scum. ↑
[9] Some images of the theater are in this gallery. ↑
[10] A survivor of the bomb raid talks about her journey. ↑
[11] Skynet 5 actually is the British military satellite communication system, but I don’t know about their data rates, I just guessed it from what I read about similar stuff. ↑
[12] Priyatno, chto ty vernulsya. = Good to see you again. ↑
[13] Learn a bit more about Borys Romanchenko. ↑

Enemy Mine

Chapter Summary

Adora meets an old encounter. It turns out rather complicated. Luckily, Scorpia's there to help.

Chapter Notes

Please note, that in the previous chapter, I forgot to put in the footnotes 11 to 13. I added them now.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

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"This is What is.
My name is Bow. You haven't seen me on this channel before, well, uhm… maybe besides some time in the background, when Adora filmed around and captured me rather accidentally. I'm the guy taking care of Adora's equipment and the technical stuff of our expeditions. At least, when I'm with her." He needs a moment to get a grip on his guilt."
"But this time I wasn't, because I left Mariupol around three weeks ago. And today I'm the one doing the update, because Adora isn't able to. In fact, we haven't heard of her since the Russian air strike hit Mariupol yesterday. Communication into the city is nearly impossible right now, and the Russian army has moved in. We don't know what happened to her, but until other notice, we assume that she's just cut off or unable to reach her devices she uses to contact us. Given the fact that the Russian's have captured the city center, where her hotel lies, it's a possibility that she's a prisoner of war. Which would also mean she's at least alive and well. Maybe she endures in one of the pockets still held by the Ukrainian army, and just lost her means to talk to us. In any way, we'll keep you updated whenever we have something new to tell.
Thanks for watching." [14]
==========

16 hours after the air strike

"What do we have here?," she asks, her voice seemingly uninvolved, but in her defense, she's so tired. The last fourteen hours have been strenuous, to say the least, and she should've gone sleeping long ago.
But again and again, medics and soldiers brought in wounded after wounded person into the field hospital, and carried out a third of them after they died. As acting commander, it's her duty to make sure, everyone does their best.
She and her colleagues have come up with a triage system from the beginning, to separate the hopeless cases from the not-so-hopeless ones, and still there were far too many patients to take care of all of them. Most have heavy burns. Some, they are able to save, others… not so much. They lack everything they need: personell, supplies, stretchers, medication, bandages.

In hindsight, it was a dumb idea to volunteer for this position when her superior asked her to take over as acting commander, but the promotion to *Lieutenant Colonel*, maybe even *Colonel* beckoned, and she wasn't *not* competitive enough to turn *that opportunity* down. Despite claiming otherwise, she actually wants to rise through the ranks. Her feigned disinterest was just that: a lie. And the interim promotion to provisional commander of the *Second Tactical Rapid Response Medical Command* was a clear sign of her star rising. Around 500 men, under her command. Not a bad step for someone her age. And as a woman.[15]
But it was obviously a dumb idea to trust him when he said, that "*it won't be so bad",* and *"it'll be over in two weeks max, they'll just surrender."* Maybe she didn't take the hint seriously enough that her predecessor apparently fell while on duty in the first three days of the war. Apparently, the Ukrainians haven't gotten the memo about their immediate surrender, and more horrifying is, that they turned out to be effective in shooting down the commanding ranks of her army.

Ok, well, granted. He was right about that: this war isn't so bad.

It’s way worse than everyone thought.

“Looks like a westerner,” the soldier says with a hint of aversion in this voice. She sighs and doesn’t even look on the stretcher the men carried in beside a quick glance, but on her papers, where she has to put down her notes from the previous case before she forgets her thoughts. “And what leads you to this mind-boggling yet insignificant assumption? I was asking about the patient’s condition, not their origin,” she snarks while scribbling other words.
“Sorry, Major. We found her lying on the street in the city center. A small but already dried head wound. Unconscious, maybe a concussion. Doesn’t look like a citizen. She has a small backpack, with several devices of western origin, and her clothes…”
"What device isn't made in China today, comrade?" she asks smirking, using the phrase from Soviet times in a mocking way, and knowing she's being a bit hard on the man. She reconsiders that, when she looks up at the boy after finishing her writing, because he’s barely older than 20. Quietly, she thinks he’s just another one of Putin's child soldiers, whom he’s sending into this war, uninformed, not trained enough and absolutely unprepared.

She runs her gaze over the female form on the stretcher. “Never mind, just leave her…”, she looks around in the overcrowded tent, then points with the pen to the corner in the back of it, where her little desk stands. Beside there is the only place not completely occupied with other stretchers and patients on them.
Drawing up another form to note the most important details, she asks: “Is she seriously injured? Bleeding. Internal injuries? Did you speak to her?”
“I don’t know about internal, but she’s not bleeding. The head wound has dried. Maybe she has a concussion from a hit, or something broke, but we didn’t check. She was unconscious the entire time. There are so many—"
“Okay, okay. You found her on the street? Any other details worth mentioning?” He holds up a light blue helmet and a white vest reading “PRESS” on it. “We found her in that. Doesn’t look like official equipment, but maybe it means something.”
She eyes it, but besides the odd coloring and the fact that the

vest has been extended, there's nothing conspicuous with it. Anyone can pretend to belong to the press, and it doesn't give special rights anyway. "Put it here. Anything else?"
The soldier shakes his head in denial. It's obvious he didn't even care to look, and she's so tired.
"Good. Put her there, and I'll take care of her later."
"Yes, ma'am."

The soldiers are quickly away, and she still doesn't give the woman a closer look, only gets the side impression of messy, blonde hair and an athletic figure. Making another note on the form on her clipboard with a *tsk*, she decides to visit the patient later, after she took care of the more urgent ones. Someone not bleeding and crying, but just sleeping, doesn't range very high on her priority list. The air strike brought in many new cases that needs her more, and so she returns to assisting one of her colleagues, who desperately tried to get her attention and help since a minute ago.
This day is far from being over, that much is for sure.

And two hours later, she's really at the end of her rope.

Her colleague finally urged her to retire and take a nap, because her eyes fluttered shut for the third time while she was assisting him with another emergency operation. They all know she shouldn't even be here, but they are so short-staffed that they need every skilled hand. She hesitantly and grumbling agreed, but still pretended that everything was fine, even if it so obviously wasn't.
The elder man patted her on the shoulder and didn't let it sound like an order, when he jested something that sounded conspicuously like *"Seniority before beauty"* and she complied without fuzzing around, a clear sign of her exhaustion.
Attached to the back of the main tent is a small one with partitioned sleeping places for the on-call surgeons. She'll lay down there, because in the wake of this entire, hasty operation, she has no other place to sleep anyway. In fact, she should have been relieved two weeks ago and back to Rostov - another detail where reality didn't match with what her supervisor said, and the

marching luggage with her change of clothes is still stuck in a truck somewhere near the former border.
Former border. She *tsks* again, because… how that even sounds.

As she walks by her desk, her foggy brain remembers the woman from before. The stretcher still stands beside the makeshift table, and the woman is still sleeping - or unconscious. She *didn't* check on her, and with that reminder crashing her out of her foggy thinking, she feels a little rueful. She should've examined the patient, to make sure the woman didn't fall in a coma or had unnoticed internal bleeding. They're already killing enough people on the battlefield, there's no need to add up to that here due to simple neglect of her duties.
And all the paperwork!

She sighs for a countless repeated time and turns towards the patient. Her eyes wander over the woman's body, but everything seems fine so far. The head wound is a sharp cut, but already dry, the face otherwise covered with dirt and loosely hanging hair. She's breathing evenly, albeit rather shallow. Carefully, she peels the woman out of her jacket, which leaves her in a white yet dusty shirt and gray pants, both sitting very neatly. Her head and chest are unharmed, the arms and hands okay as well. Under the dirty face and behind the tousled, messy and stained hair seems to lie a pretty face. She's not really sure, and to clean the wound with a damp cloth, she wipes a few strands to the side.
Hmm.
Something about her features looks vaguely familiar, like if she saw this woman before.
Well… after 16 hours of work, her brain is obviously not working at her usual capacity. But there is a memory, it's just out of reach…
As she tries to remember, her hands continue examining the limbs, down from the waist towards the legs, and it's there she notices a small pool of blood beside the woman's left hip.
"Fuck, she *was* bleeding", escapes her.

It has already started to dry, so the wound can't be large, and the bleeding must've stopped a while ago. She fetches a pair of

scissors, cuts the pants open at both sides and takes them off. The woman is left in her boy shorts and thick gray socks, she has long, trained legs with a soft, pale complexion, and what matters more, a wound right at the backside of her hip.
It takes her one fucking minute to do what she should've done two hours before, and to remove the splinter still sticking there. It sits in a delicate position beside important nerves, and she shortly ponders to call a colleague for help. But despite the problematic position of the splinter, it also isn't complicated to remove, it just needs a steady hand and a bit of sensitivity. And despite everyone teases her for having too much of the first and too little of the second one, thankfully, her body flushed her system with enough adrenaline for another, short high, and so she's awake and attentive enough for doing this.

Using a tweezer, she quickly finds the little, sharp piece of metal that cut through fabric and flesh and wounded the woman. Hopefully, it hasn't damaged important nerves, but it's nowhere near the spine, and so she's cautiously optimistic. After removing, cleaning and patching her patient up, she administers her a light analgesic so that she continues sleeping undisturbed.
With a large sigh, she pulls back, then her thoughts wander to the matter of how she's going to dress her again.
It feels wrong to let her lying here without pants, but on the other hand, it wouldn't be different in a hospital. But it's not very warm in here, and it's just… yes, the woman is tall, and looks strong, her body obviously trained as not in a bodybuilder style but just athletic and fit, she has this touch of a soft, underlying vulnerability, that makes her wanting to protect her.
It's a weird feeling for someone she doesn't even know.
But there's still this vague sense of familiarity.

She looks around, thinking about what to do.
Well, there isn't much.
She fetches two blankets from a staple - it's one of the few commodities of which they have enough - and uses one to wrap it loosely around the woman's waist, legs and feet and the other one to cover her till the head. It won't be the most comfortable, but it'll keep her warm and protected enough.

After another runover, she feels how the adrenaline rush ebbs away, and decides it's time to go to sleep. The evening is quite advanced, and she really needs it.

When she lets herself fall onto the camp bed, she's gone in under a minute.

Adora wakes up, and it's a slow process. Unusual slow, and there's a spike of hurt in her side that she can't ignore. Her head is dizzy, too. Sitting up also seems to be difficult. All in all, it's like her body's betraying her, and that her vision is still pretty blurry doesn't make it better.
But she can pick up a lot of background noise. She's obviously in quite a busy place. As her sight slowly clears, the first thing she really sees is a pair of eyes watching her intently.
There's something strange about them, but also… something familiar.
Her focus widens, but only as much as to be able to take in the woman before her. The reserved features of the face to whom the pretty eyes obvious belong are that of a woman in a white doctor's coat, hair bound in a low ponytail, carefully mustering her, and now Adora's eyes are illuminated with a small flashlight. She blinks and twitches a little, and the woman mumbles, "Reaction is good." Her voice sounds so enticing, a bit rough, but also silky. Something pulls in Adora's chest, and it's completely on it's own that one of her hands is slowly rising to touch the seducing woman's cheek.

Seeing how the woman slowly turns her head and draws her look towards Adora's just as slowly rising hand is almost comically.

It's like Adora is under a spell, but it seems the woman is too, and her hand is nearly there where it belongs, when suddenly a very sharp pain runs through her left side, and she yelps, "Ow!"

Her hand falls to her hip, but she quickly withdraws it as the touch triggers another spike of pain. “Uh!. What happened? Where am I?”, Adora presses out through gritted teeth, groaning. She must’ve been injured, and doesn’t have a clue what brought her here.

The doctor snaps out of her stupor and after a second to take a breath, she informs her: “You have been found, wounded, on the streets of Mariupol and were brought into our field hospital. I treated you.”
She tries to remember what happened, but her memory is so clouded. The question, “Is the wound bad?”, comes to her mind.
The doctor puckers her mouth a bit. “I haven’t come so far as to look after it today. You’re not the only one I’ve to take care for. We’ll have to do some tests, but couldn’t, because you were unconscious for the last 22 hours.”
Adora gasps. “22 hours?! Fuck, I have to call my friends, they must know that I’m alive, and I have—"
She’s cut short with a raised hand and a firm voice: “Well, that comes later. Now is the time for checking up on you and make sure that there’s no long-lasting damage. I mentioned tests.”
The thought of being disabled shuts Adora up, and only now she gets that she was talking in her mother tongue, English, and was spoken to alike. Warily, she looks around. There are no insignia to be seen on the woman’s coat. “Are you from the Ukrainian army? Who are you?”

The woman tilts her head and looks even more beautiful. Adora wonders why that is even a thought, when the answer shatters her. The woman is reserved when she informs her: “This is a field hospital of the Second Tactical Rapid Response Medical Command of the Russian Armed Forces. I am Major Ekaterina Volovodova. And to whom I am speaking?”

Her pulse rises. Russian Army. She’s a prisoner of war. Of the Russians. Who obviously hate her. Yet, when asked like this, an answer is coming out just naturally: “Adora—”.
In the last moment, she can stop herself from telling her complete name. Knowing her forename is already bad enough. Have the

Russians found her backpack? Is she a real prisoner or haven't they found out yet?
"That's overly sugary, even for someone as pretty as you," Doctor Volovodova voices absent-mindedly while scribbling something on her clipboard, realizing a moment too late how that came out. Her head pops up from looking at the board with an odd, caught impression. "Oh! Uh, never mind. What I meant is that we don't get to hear such… foolish Western names here often. But it's clearly a trait to be expected from such an effeminated culture as __"

What happens now is a very unlucky coincidence for Major Ekaterina Volovodova, because both women turn their heads towards the entrance, as into the tent stomps an unusual large woman in full battle equipment, wearing camouflage clothing, a protective vest, helmet, muddy combat boots and a sniper rifle on her back, and her gaze falls onto the doctor at once.
"Catra!", she booms over the rows of stretchers with wounded people on them and several of the staff between, drawing the looks of many onto herself. The woman smiles so broadly, it could lighten up an entire city. Many frowns appear on many faces.
The addressed has already stopped lecturing Adora and startles like a kid with the fingers in the cookie jar, her curls whirling around, when the archetypical poster girl of the bygone Soviet era barrels through the rows with an eager, unbound energy. The tall and muscular woman with an undercut must have sprung from every propagandist's wet dream. Even her white hair fits into that picture. She's like the secondary antagonist from some odd computer game or a children's TV show, surely lacking the cruel will to think up malicious plans, but certainly willing to carry them out without thinking too much if ordered. This woman is a fighter, that much is clear on first sight.

Catra growls, and Adora can't help but stare as the scene unfolds before her. The Soviet threat places herself before her doctor, who is now mercilessly pulled into a crushing hug that seems to squeeze life out of her. The woman actually squeaks. "Scorpia, no! Stop it! Let go of me! Are you crazy?", and after a bit more crushing and yelling, the other woman actually let go.

Usually, Captain Scorpia is obedient to an amount that's nearly unbearable, even for the desired standards of the Russian army. Catra often struggles with that. So far, the only violation of Scorpia Catra knows of is the woman's absolute inability to let go of the pet name she gave Ekaterina from the day on they met. Scorpia found it funny, and just stuck to it ever since. It's maybe due to the fact that Catra vehemently - vehemently! - forbade Scorpia to ever use '*Wildcat*' again. Besides that it's plain uncomfortable to be called like that, it's also not a good idea to use an English pet name in the current social climate washing through her home country. "Catra", how Scorpia pronounces it in a very non-English-sounding way, rolling the R, isn't as compromising by far.
Well, that, and she didn't want to encourage Scorpia.
Catra reluctantly tolerates the overly eager woman as a friend, but she couldn't *not* notice the crush the woman has on her since they got to know each other. And Catra doesn't need a relationship. She has work to do, and there's no time for that childish, immature things as crushes. Fortunately for both of them, Scorpia isn't a person to hold grudges, and just tries to be a friend.
Anyway, Catra furiously frees herself from the squashing embrace.

Adora realizes that her eyes have gone wide and are pinned on… "Catra?". Of course, she speaks it out like they would do it in the US, and both women turn their attention to her. And some gears start to turn in her head. She heard that name before. But… where?
"Your name is Catra?", she asks hesitantly, but a small laugh bubbles out of her chest too. "Really?"
"No," Catra firmly states. She rolls her eyes and continues growling lowly, because in the same moment, Captain Scorpia places herself at her side and says with a very rough, very Russian accent, but in English: "Of course it is."

Catra makes audible knocks with her pen on her clipboards, showing her growing *inamusement*, and switches to Russian to talk to Scorpia: "What do you want, Captain?"

Scorpia nearly pouts. “Oh, so formal today? Well, okay then, Major Ekaterina Vi,” Scorpia grins wide and Catra rolls her eyes again while she’s being informed: “I’ve got something for you.”
“Then don’t tease me, just spit it out,” Catra retorts a bit too harsh.
“We shouldn’t talk about that in front of a patient.”
“Oh, so now are you’re able to keep a secret, but not when it comes to private matters, huh?”
Scorpia looks wounded and throws her hands in the air. “What? Everyone calls you like that. It’s not a secret!”
“Duh. I can declare it one. And obviously no sneaky Westerner must know.”
“She’s just a patient, huh? Can she even understand us?”
Scorpia’s look falls onto Adora, then looks back to Catra. “I don’t like how she’s watching us.”
Now, both women turn their attention to Adora who quickly pretends to not having eavesdropped the entire conversation.

All of this is very weird. Being a prisoner of war should come with being detained and maybe interrogated, not listening to the banter of two semi-friendly, semi-hostile women. She ponders about if she should tell them that she indeed understands and speaks Russian too, but then she decides to hide this information for now. It’s not really lying - and she’s a very bad liar - it’s rather… saying nothing at all, just innocently looking at them with puppy dog eyes.
As Angella taught her, sometimes, saying nothing is the best you can do. But being a bit quick-witted for once, she mouths, “What?” - in English - and watches the women turn away from her again.

The doctor woman - Catra - shrugs her shoulders, and takes the Soviet poster icon a few meters away, where they talk to each other more quietly. The conversation goes on for several minutes, getting heated, and despite trying, Adora doesn’t get what they’re talking about, until she hears Catra saying louder: “Captain Scorpia, that is not ours to decide, and I have to remind you that it’s an order from above.”
An alike loud “Yes, ma’am!” is barked out, followed by a mock

salute, and Catra rolls her eyes again. She's still loud enough for Adora to hear it. "You're not in my chain of command, you know? You don't have to salute."
"Yes, ma'am!" the other woman repeats, grinning, adding "See you for lunch," and off she goes, again plowing through the rows of stretchers, not without apologizing every time she accidentally touches anything, which happens two or three times.

The doctor returns to Adora's stretcher.
"So, you were about to tell me what happened to you, right?"
Adora smirk way too wide. "Not really. We were talking about your cute name, Doctor Catra."
"It's Ekaterina, and I'm not cute."
The indignant expression is worth it. "Well, I didn't say that. I said your name is cute. But it suits you." Adora has absolutely no clue what makes her so bold as to start something that could in another situation be interpreted as flirting with this woman. But there's this feeling of familiarity. It's disturbing. But also, encouraging.
"Do you wanna tell me what happened? You don't seem like a citizen of Mariupol, or am I wrong?"
Even if that might put her in danger, Adora decides to tell her a bit of the truth. It's like always: she's bad at lying. But she can leave things out. Her eyes are on her intertwined fingers in her lap when she admits: "Actually, I was there as a journalist, reporting from the siege and about what happened to the city. And then I got trapped and couldn't get out."
This is… problematic. Journalists are always problematic. Not thinking too much of if by now, Catra pulls a corner of her mouth and puts her pen down to the clipboard, mumbling: "So, we can add 'Hero complex' to the conditions", and then, louder, "I'm not sure if we have a psychiatrist with us, but this should be treated at some time. It's not deadly, at least not immediately." Her voice sounds so sarcastic that even Adora gets that she's being mocked.
"What? I don't have a hero complex!", she shrills.
"Sure. Whatever you say," mumbles the doctor behind her board, obviously smirking even if Adora can't see it, because the woman's looking at her with her eyes just above the edge of the

clipboard, hiding her grin behind it, and for a moment it's downright amicable between them.

But then it happens.

Catra groans, "God, this is killing me," puts the clipboard down, pulls the hair tie out of her ponytail and shakes out her - curly, brunette - hair, which falls voluminously over her shoulder.
The sight, paired with the tonality and the relieved smirk, lets something click into place for Adora, finally toggling her memory. It's like a revelation.

"Oh stars, it's you! Oh, my—". Adora slaps her hand in front of her mouth to keep herself from babbling on, then quickly winces because her side hurts from the movement.
On the receiving end of that... accusation? statement? exclamation? stands a frozen Catra. "What are you talking about?"
"We met!", Adora calls excitedly. "We met, at this conference, in St. Petersburg, two or so years ago. At the bar. You kissed me and —"
She's cut short by a grimly looking person, and the amicable atmosphere is gone, suddenly changed into… anger?
"I knew that I knew you. But it didn't come to my mind that you and this clumsy, dumb blonde bitch that dumped me in the bar were the same person. This is… wow, it's… what an unlucky coincidence," Catra hisses, but then, somehow struggling, frowning, taking her pen and clicking it several times, she continues, her voice cold and repellant. "Well, you're okay for now, and I have to care of more important cases. Just don't move and stay in bed. I'll have someone looking after you later." And with that, she stomps away and out of the tent, leaving a baffled Adora behind, staring after the infuriated woman with a mouth still agape.

Adora expected many things, but clearly not meeting the seductress again in her life.

She would've slapped her forehead, like in a bad comic book, for not recognizing the woman earlier. But moving her arms still

hurts, and so she lets herself fall back onto her pillow and stares at the ceiling of the tent, blending out her surrounding.
The point is that Catra looked nothing like her previous self. The professional wardrobe, her demeanor, the uneasy environment, her own situation, still being a bit dizzy: all of that added to a slow running mind and not making the connection earlier.
And in return, Adora's appearance had been undoubtedly different back then: the short bob with the undercut was gone, her hair much longer now. A small scar covers her jaw, stemming from a shrapnel in Aleppo. Overall, she's more athletic now, her jawline a bit more prominent, her face slightly more contoured.
Still a bit in a haze about Catra's reaction and her mind twisting and jumping between what happened and her memories, she touches the mark on her jaw with her fingertips.

It's weird, and an odd coincidence, how much the citizen's war in Syria and the current one are connected. In both cases, Putin played the decisive role. In Syria, he helped the dictator Assad staying in power by assisting him with air strikes on bases of the opposition while claiming to be fighting the IS. That actually happened too, and the West was as always torn between being silently grateful that someone took up the blade and did the bloody work they didn't want to do and calling for a ceasefire and Assad's resignation while not doing much to actually help the opposition. Which didn't behave so much better. So it wasn't a surprise when again the ones with more cruelty, more dedication and less moral boundaries won the case. Assad stayed in power, and Putin trained his army for another war.

In an attempt to distract herself from her strange plight, she looks around. The tent she's lying in is not overly large. Around twenty camp beds stand in several rows, and all of them are occupied with patients. She's seen that before, it's a not so unfamiliar place for her to be, because she visited field hospitals before. Even if it could be considered as overbearing, crossing borders of good taste, she always thought that interviewing the direct victims of war and violence was one of the most important ways to tell people what an oh-so-far-away world crisis actually means on a personal level. Many can't endure the view of wounded people,

but it’s a part of what is, and their stories are a necessary part of reality needed to be told, too.
Reality doesn’t solely consist of safe spaces. They are rather the exception.
So yeah, she already knows places like this.
Just not as a patient herself.
And so she silently wishes for the mean yet pretty and oh-so-well tasting doctor to come back. How odd that this memory is still on her lips.

Stomping, or rather storming out of the tent, Catra knows herself she's childish. Their encounter has been two years ago, and all in all, it was just an awkward situation not gone lucky. It’s not that she thought about how the evening could’ve gone better again and again afterwards. Not at all.

Because she'd been so embarrassed by this woman.

The entire ramp-up to said evening, over the whole conference, she'd pumped herself with enough courage to make a move on the stunning, amicable, gorgeous blonde with the ridiculous poof and the straight posture who was strolling around and taking interviews with everyone but her, never even approaching her. Sometimes Catra noticed, that the woman threw her a glance, from the side, but she dismissed it as normal curiosity.
When she finally dared to capture the damned Nordic goddess at the bar, both of them half drunk and quite in the right mood, she was just coldly repelled when she tried to make a move, to push her luck. Wasn't she good enough for the westerner?

The sting of rejection had been quite sharp then, and made her withdraw and leaving the conference the next morning, because…, because, fuck yeah. Even then, it had come to her mind that it might’ve been an overreaction, but the

embarrassment hurt nevertheless. And till today, the feeling was still there. Dimmed, muted, but though.

And now? Now Catra's still fuming. Wasting 20 minutes walking around the base hasn't calmed her down so much that she doesn't hiss at Scorpia when the other woman places her tablet across of her at one of the long tables in the canteen.
Canteen is a big word for something that consists of a field kitchen mounted at the back of a truck, two tents and several tables with benches to sit and eat placed before, all of that set up on something that is or was the crumbling parking place of a local supermarket a few weeks ago.
"Woah, Wildcat, easy," Scorpia waves her down and is met with a brutal glare and growling.
"I already forbade you to ever use this name again. I'm not above letting you be sent to Siberia for the next year."
"Okay, sorry, Catra," Scorpia apologizes, but not without an edge to her words, "but first, and I quote you, 'not my chain of command', and second, you wouldn't do that." The woman has consistently grown more confident over the course of her career. Not that she hasn't been before, but she had a tendency to be overly self-aware and sometimes even angsty about scaring other people with her stingy, overwhelming presence. Admittedly, Scorpia's appearance can be frightening, but the woman is still a sweetheart. In the last two years, her trait of being too self-conscious had been remarkably ground down, and Catra is a tiny bit proud of herself that she played a part in that. On the other hand, when she's at the receiving end of Scorpia's newfound… courage, it's not so nice.
Catra grumbles out an annoyed "Hrmpf", and her friend cocks her head encouragingly: "Wanna tell me what happened? Usually, you're not that grumpy by noon."
"No."
"Okay."
Scorpia looks at her while sipping on a cup of tea, a small smile forming on her lips. The curt reply makes Catra wonder about why Scorpia is so compliant and not digging deeper. Usually, the woman doesn't bother to pry until she gets some answers.

Curiosity and Scorpia are actually synonyms.
“Good,” Catra doubles down, unnerved, with narrowed eyes.
“Okay,” Scorpia grins over her cup.
She sighs and raises her hands in defeat. “Is this some weird kind of reverse psychology trick you’re trying on me?”
“Ah.” Scorpia’s smirk is as wide as the Volga, the large Russian river of nostalgia and yearning for the aims unachieved.
“Ugh. I hate you.”
Scorpia giggles upon Catra’s obvious show while sipping. She wouldn’t have dared to do that two years ago, but everyone grew up in the recent time, and Scorpia more than others. “I mean, you could also just start talking instead of pretending of not wanting to be asked again. I’m here for you, Catra, and I still care, okay? You can just skip the dramatics, and you know I won’t let you go until you’ve spilled your heart. And you also know I’m good at listening. I wanna know what worries you, but you know that, too. So, how about getting to the point?”
It’s clearly the most unapologetic and straight - hehehe - speech Catra has heard of Scorpia so far. The woman just sits and has started to spoon her stew like she’s the more innocent version of herself from two years ago.
Rolling her eyes, she lets out a huge sigh.
“The patient, the western woman, she… unnerves me.”
A puzzled frown appears on Scorpia’s face. “Wow. That was… pretty fast, even by your standards. I mean, how long is she awake?”
“It’s not that! It’s… I know her.”

Scorpia’s spoon splashes back into the bowl. “What?
“It’s her, the woman I told you about, from the conference in Saint Petersburg.”
The puzzled look on her friend’s face is priceless, and if Catra weren’t so confused and upset herself, she would mock Scorpia mercilessly.
“Whoa. That’s… is that true? I mean, what are the odds? That was two years ago, wasn’t it?”
“Yeah, you can say that again. It’s like fate is spitting into my face, rubbing the shit in again.”

Scorpia frowns, wipes some splashes away and picks up her soon again before answering: "I think you get this completely the wrong way. Nothing really bad happened back then. By judging how you usually tend to mess with your… non-existent personal matters, it has to mean exactly the opposite. This is fate telling you that you have unfinished business."
"You can't mean what you're saying."
The Soviet Poster Girl leans back and crosses her arms. In other circumstances, this would be a frightening sight, to be eyed by her like that. "Well. I know you, Catra, even if you pretend otherwise. And I know that you're not exactly the lenient and tolerant type when you don't get what you want. Usually, you just lash out. She rejected you, okay. But has it ever crossed your mind to ask her why she did that? I mean, instead of stomping away like you always do?"
"We were in the middle of making out, and she just stopped it and practically shoved me away! What else is there to talk about?"
"Hmm." Scorpia cocks her head a little. "That sounded a little different when you told me last time."
"Duh! It didn't. She didn't want me, and that's it," Catra states with crossed arms herself.
"So, you're telling me that one second you're practically jumping each other's laps, and the next one she shoves you away. Sorry to say, but from knowing you, I'm a bit… suspicious, so to say. How about if you tell me again about what both of you did exactly?"
"Nothing! She didn't like it when I touched her."
"Where did you touch her?", Scorpia presses on.
Catra feels a tiny little bit uncomfortable. Even if Scorpia is something like her best friend and the only person with whom she's able to talk about personal matters, this seems a bit encroaching. "Is this an interrogation? Have you switched to the FSB without telling me? Who are you and what did you do to Scorpia? My friend would never pry on me like that. She would encourage and approve of me!", Catra pouts, but is smiled at in return, as Scorpia doesn't buy it: "Hohoho… of course she would. She would, and she does, because she cares and wants to help you. But she can't do that when she's being lied to. Come on."
"I'm not lying!", Catra practically yells, then adding more silently:

“I know she just didn’t like me.”
The next words are the most truculent Catra has ever heard of Scorpia. Which means that the woman talks firmly, like reprimanding a little child who crashed its toy: “You don’t know shit why she did what she did. Because you didn’t talk to her. You just guessed.”
It baffles Catra. Fury rises its ugly head, fueled by a gut feeling she doesn’t really like. Guilt has always driven her angry. “I don't have to listen to that anymore,” she barks out and is on her way to stand up and storm out - which is such a coincidence, given the topic they just were talking about. It’s a bit cruel that fate seems to keep slapping in her face.
Well, she can ignore fate.

Scorpia lays a firm hand on hers and pulls her down again. Frozen, Catra is actually too baffled to do anything against it.

“Oh, come on, Catra. Don’t be so touchy. I know you're pretty sensitive about stuff like that, and I'm not saying you aren't allowed to be. But it's been two years, and you're still carrying it around. Doesn't that mean something? And isn’t this the most unlikely opportunity to get an answer, if only to let it go? I’m pretty sure there’s more than just ‘she doesn’t like me’ to this. Now you can ask her. That’s good.”
Scorpia withdraws her hand, clearly leaving her to choose if she wants to jump and run, or if she wants to talk about it. Catra’s anger is still somewhere in the back of her mind, but upon Scorpia’s words, her will and power to storm away have left like air out of a balloon.
She hides her face in her hands, elbows propped on the table, and she groans. Loud. “Uugh. Since when did you get so… insightful? I thought you would rather advise me to stay away from her.” Referring to Scorpia’s one-sided crush on her may be not the best idea, but Catra feels raw, too exposed, and taunting back is one of the few ways she feels halfway on safe ground.
Her words are met by a gentle smile: “Catra, I know we’re not going to become a thing. That’s clear as day. I’m moving on, don’t worry. But that doesn’t mean I’m not going to be a good friend if I can. I still like you."

Shit like that always shuts Catra up. She can’t deal with open and honest displays of affection like that very well.
Luckily, Scorpia continues. “I advise you to be careful about that, though. After all, she’s a westerner, and even if we aren’t at war with NATO, it’s not exactly a welcoming climate today. You know how critically all connections to western people are viewed, especially by the FSB lurking around.[16] I mean, they won’t do anything to you just for treating your patient and talking to her. But be careful not to go too far. Okay?”

Of course, that’s okay. Catra is used to not getting what she wants, and the blonde goddess rejecting her just fits in. There's no way this encounter will lead to anything, even if she still wanted to. And she doesn't. Still, Scorpia has a point: the woman is here, and at her mercy. Finding out why she did it might actually help herself to move on, and to finally let go of her idiotic infatuation with the blonde goddess.

Later, Catra sits at a desk in the command tent of her Rapid Forces, and she makes some general notes of her daily work, as well as supply orders they dearly need, when suddenly a shadow falls on it. Looking up, she notices a man approached her. He wears civilian clothes, muddy black hair slicked back, and a smile she doesn’t like from the beginning. His overall demeanor is somewhere between scary and quirky. Catra can’t exactly lay a finger on it, but she’s not really eager to take his hand when he holds out his own one to greet her.
“Major Volodova. I’m Major Hordak Suworow, Federal Security Service. I’m from the Military Counterintelligence Directorate, and I would like to have a quick conversation with you.” Catra stares at the outstretched hand, needing a second to react properly, and when they shake, it feels neither fish nor fowl. And the man still grins at her with this crooked smile.
No, she doesn’t like his attitude at all. A little shiver runs down her spine as she asks:

“What can I do for you, Major?”

Chapter End Notes

The next chapter is called “Putin's Russia”. I'll probably publish it in a week or two.
I'm not perfectly content with this chapter, but I brushed over it three times, and well... If you become aware of any inaccuracies when I'm talking about real world stuff (and it isn't a clear part of the fiction) please notify me. I'm always glad and grateful for further input.

[14] It’s horrible, and not because reality overtakes me again and again. See: when I wrote this chapter in the beginning of April, there had been no massive air strike on Mariupol like this, and I just made it up for the story, because I wanted to move forward. But reality is beyond my worst imagination. Because on April 14th, strategic heavy bombers Tu-95 launched cruise missiles and long-range bombers Tu-22M3 dropped heavy bombs on Mariupol. I always assumed something like an air raid as a last resort measure, but again, I was wrong. ↕
[15] Find more information about the military structure of the Russian Ground Forces in the notes at the end of this chapter. ↕
[16] The FSB, The Federal Security Service of the Russian Federation, is the security agency of Russia and successor of the KGB. It was always a powerful and rather independently acting organization, serving intelligence and counterintelligence duties, and its executive leader was an important political figure. However, over the course of Putin’s presidency, the FSB more and more become severely tied to the office of the President, turning it into an extended arm of Putin. ↕

Military Background:
The Russian Armed Forces have around one million of active personell, with the Ground Forces being the largest service, making up around 300.000 of them. As far as we know, around 175.000 to 190.000 men have been deployed at the beginning of the war.

For information about the military structure of Catra's '20th Guards Combined Arms Army' I found valuable insight on articles on Wikipedia, and more notably this report about the Russian Ground Forces in the Western Military District from the Center for Naval Analyses (CNA). Also, on this list about all units presumably or confirmed partaking in the war.

Summarized, the 20th Guards is one of the three operative large field armies in the Western District, with *army* historically and usually meaning a troop strength of over 100,000 men, but since the ending of the Cold War, they've become smaller everywhere. Its headquarter is located in Voronezh, which lies a few hundred of kilometers east of Kharkiv, the second-largest Ukrainian city right across the border. Kharkiv has been under heavy siege since the Russian attack in late February.

The army consists of divisions like Motor Rifles, Tanks, Artillery and Rocket Brigades, Anti-Aircraft and Logistics. In the forementioned report, it is stated, that the 20th Guards 'features two motor rifle divisions; this indicates the prime focus given to Ukraine, and the need to have a heavy motorized and tank force present near the border with Ukraine that can immediately deliver a preponderance of power against opposing forces. Current force prepositioning within the 20th CAA also makes it suitable to undertake combat operations in Belarus.'

Combined with other indicators and as shown on the list from above, I think it's a given that this army is currently operating in the war. Due to the relative proximity, I also assume that it

has been deployed across the front line northeast of Mariupol. However, that's just my speculation.

Given Catra's Second Tactical Rapid Response Medical Command, I don't know if the Russian Ground Forces have something like that. I made it up after the example of the Germany-Netherlands Rapid Forces Division, an airborne army of around 11.800 men, and combined it with the German 800 men strong medical corps "Kommando Schnelle Einsatzkräfte Sanitätsdienst" (~ Rapid Response Medical Command) with is a supporting force in case of need, but not integrated into the Division. I found leading something like that very fitting, given Catra's capabilities and eagerness, and I didn't want to have her on an actual front job.

Putin’s Russia

Chapter Summary

> Both women have a hard time; with paperwork, the circumstances, but also with each other.
> Why should it be any different?

Chapter Notes

> This chapter is going to be heavy political. I'll make it up to you in the next ones, I promise.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora doesn’t freeze easily, but the atmosphere in the tent *is* cold. It makes her shiver. That’s not only because it is poorly heated. Temperatures outside still tend to drop to just a few degrees above zero at night and this morning, it was clearly freezing. Still, that wouldn’t be much of a problem because, usually, Adora’s circulatory system runs so high that she produces enough heat to feel warm even on cold nights.
She never stopped hardening since her youth.
Growing up in the foster system hadn’t been easy for her, but purely physically, she never lacked anything important. It taught her much about a certain necessity to keep herself in good shape, having body control, and an ability to defend herself, being always attentive, always ready, and to stay out of sight when ill.
Adora never had or has cold fingers.
Therefore, what makes her shiver is not so much the chill air.

It’s rather two other things, connected.

Firstly, what’s happening around her the entire morning, turns the atmosphere herein into a thick, uncomfortable haze of human suffering. Every now and then, a frustrated groan or a desperate cry indicates that the medics and doctors weren’t able to save another wounded. There’s seldom time for them to take a breath. Because upon their failure or inability to save a life, the stretcher

with the body is brought outside, and the free place is filled with another patient soon after. And there are many of them: wounded soldiers, people crying, even children sometimes, some with shattered limbs, head wounds or missing hands. The medics may be Russians, but they're clearly trying their best to save everyone who's brought in, regardless of origin. If she's being honest, Adora has never witnessed anything else from anyone in this profession in her entire career, so it shouldn't surprise her.

As she looks around, she falls back into her professional attitude, the reporter personality, in which she severs her ingrained desire to act, to do, to help from her current state, and just watches. To take note.
She developed that ability soon, giving it a kick-start when she filmed that beheading in Afghanistan. Later, when she processed the event, and edited the video before uploading, she noticed that she did it on instinct. There was nothing she could have done. Any intervention, any opposition from her as a stranger, would have been life-threatening. But documenting and telling the world what happened was the second-best she could do.
And she needed to put her guard up.
For being able to survive these atrocities without damaging her own soul too much. Somewhere inside her, not very much beneath a more careful, more defensive surface, there's still this teenager with endless naivety and energy, without boundaries to act upon anything and anyone in need of help, regardless the situation. The recent years got her more in control of herself, but they also made it clear that there's always a price to pay, when it comes to telling what is, and witnessing how the world can be. Namely, a place where every single atrocity imaginable is ultimately carried out by someone.

Humanity has proven time and again that nothing is too low for them.

Well, these dire thoughts will lead to nothing. Therefore, Adora takes in her surrounding again, assessing the situation. Her stretcher still stands in the corner of the short side of the tent, where also three tables are lined up, opposite the entrance.

Occasionally, one of the doctors takes place there and puts down notes. And sometimes, after they finished, they look up and just stare into the void for a minute or two.
Adora knows the trait.
The need to collect oneself, to focus on something good or simply mundane, to clear the mind before moving on again, before returning to the deadening reality that inevitably grinds away and dulls the accessible, open-hearted human being in you, and only leaves a harsher, more self-defending version of yourself behind.

She sighs. Given the conditions of the most wounded people around her, Adora considers herself lucky, because she still has all her limbs, eyes, ears and fingers, and isn't severely wounded. Not everyone gets out of here like that.

Besides, there's the other problem she has to think about, and it's about "getting out of here." Since now, Adora hasn't seen any guards, but it's possible or rather likely that they are outside the tent. If this is a regular field camp of the Army, there will certainly be soldiers guarding the perimeter defenses, and they won't only be looking outwards. Anything else would be negligent. Her just leaving will obviously be noticed, prevented. The conclusion is rather scary: if she's under Russian custody, and the FSB or another of Putin's watchdog services recognize who she is, they will surely try to get a fix on her.

And that can turn out really ugly.

For two decades, these organizations are collecting a renowned record track in murdering critical journalists or people in opposition to Putin and just let them vanish.

Anna Politkovskaya is maybe the most prominent, but there are so much more: Anastassija Baburowa, Igor Domnikow, Natalja Estemirowa, Juri Schtschekotschichin, just to name four of them and all working for the same newspaper as Anna did. 'Nowaja Gaseta' is or rather was the last remaining independent, oppositional newspaper of Russia, and it has been operating since 1993, always under a certain informal pressure by the accused

people within or near the government, as the journalists uncovered corruption and crimes - just like a newspaper should do.

But it was only after Putin took power in 2000, that the murders started.

Many people have been killed since the man's inauguration, not only journalists, but also human rights activists, lawyers and rivaling politicians, and in so many cases these murders were somehow linked to people working or formerly working for the FSB, the homeland security agency Putin shortly led in the late nineties before becoming president. The blunt, efficient cruelty and brutality with which most of the murders were carried out always pointed to professional henchmen, as did the poison murders.

Anna Politkovskaya, the renowned journalist, human rights activist reported on the war crimes the Russian Army committed in the war in Chechnya, calling it a dirty war. It also made her an enemy of the self-proclaimed tyrant Kadyrov, and by many in the Russian government and Putin's followers she was seen as a traitor for calling out corruption. For nearly a decade, she lived under constant death threats. The inconspicuous but fearless 48-year-old woman was on her way home, and found shot dead in the elevator of her apartment house, right in the middle of Moscow. Four bullets, one of them straight in the head. That the Makarov pistol used for killing her was found lying next to the woman, and the day of her assassination occurred on the 7th of October - Vladimir Putin's birthday - were two very strong messages to everyone daring to accusing the government under his reign of anything. That happened in 2006 and by far, she's not the only one to perish like that.

In hindsight, the indicators had always been clear, but of course, there were never any evidences that Putin or the government itself ordered anything directly. Orders, certainly, weren't necessary anyway. His underlings and allies knew very well how to please him, how to be risen to power, and in the eyes of many

observers, he was and is the one person responsible for creating a political, and over the years an overall governmental climate where such crimes were possible and furthered by the highest levels of the states without being prosecuted.

People opposing him just tend to vanish in Putin's Russia since two decades.[17]

In Adora's mind - as well as that of many others - the West didn't really care about all of that. Because cheap gas and oil were too important, the life juice of Germany, Europe's economic powerhouse, as well as so many nations around it. Countries from Estonia over Poland and Austria to the Mediterranean Sea, Greece, Turkey, the small nations around the Black and the Caspian Sea: all of them at least gradually depend on the vast network of good old pipelines built during the time of the Soviet Union, stretching over thousands of kilometers from Siberia to the United Kingdom. Many heard and fought over Nord Stream II, the highly disputed new gas pipeline through the Baltic Sea, directly from Russia to Germany. Many ignored that Nord Stream I already delivered the same amount of gas every day.[18]

And despite condemning how Putin lead the Russian society into a slow and steady demise for two decades, spreading corruption and depriving the nation of a brighter future by violating human rights, murdering people, invading other countries, spreading havoc in the small nations around it, and overall mostly making his own people hopeless and depressed, the West just went on to buy from Putin, because he provided cheap resources, and looked reliable.

Adora has reasons to be frightened. In her first days as a reporter, while covering the annexation of Crimea from afar, Adora made a few documentations about how the West ignored the building Russian threat to Ukraine as a nation. She didn't get death threats back then, not like Anna, because she was just too little known and her channel wasn't very prominent. Her videos were rather amateurish then. However, she is also sure that the FSB and the services and underlings connected to it have a very good

institutionalized memory.
Today, she's well-known. That's not a shield, obviously, but a marker on her back. Not notoriety and not even wealth offer protection in today's Russia anymore. Even the oligarchs had to realize that since long.[19]
Being well-known, in her current position, is a problem, because despite she has only a few hundred thousand followers on her platform, many news channels use her reports since the war started. She had been the only reporter left at Mariupol, reporting from this dangerous hotspot, and now, it seems, she's going to pay a price for her… heroism. Was Catra actually right about that? It's a creepy thought. She didn't do it for fame or such. It was just the right thing to do, nothing else.

The realization that Putin's authorities, his buddies and lickspittles can lay their fingers on her now, makes her stomach clench. Instinctively, she scans her surrounding again, watching out for hideous figures in the dark, but stomps the urge down when noticing how ridiculous that is. If the FSB picks up her trail, they will approach and arrest her directly, because this is their territory. However, the longer she stays here, the higher the risk that something happens.

It rolls through her mind that, maybe, she shouldn't have said anything about being a journalist to the beautiful doctor. That could've been a mistake. Judging from how she stormed away - actually the second time - the woman seems to hold a grudge against her, despite Adora has no idea why that is. It can't have anything to do with their encounter from two years ago, can it? That would be ridiculous. It wasn't the woman's fault that Adora recoiled. Even after all the time, she feels a little embarrassed about her stupid reaction, about the missed opportunity.
Well, they'll have to talk about that, Adora thinks, but until then, she returns to her previous concerns, and that means: she should flee and try to return to NATO or at least EU territory.

That can turn out problematic, because as far she knows, she has nothing. Her small rucksack with her phone and money seems to be gone, her equipment in Mariupol is probably lost. She doesn't

even have a clue if the Spartak still stands and going there would mean to cross the front line - if the fights still go on. The city has probably already been conquered and is under Russian control now. The thought lets her realize that, far away, occasional artillery is audible the entire time. It's insane that Adora got so used to the noise that she's just able to ignore it. But it's always been there, she notices.
Anyway, going back to Mariupol seems off the table.
And without money or even just a phone to call for backup, her situation looks, well, dire.

But the largest problem is that she can't move her hip well, at least, not without pain. When she tries to pull herself up, it hurts. Moving her legs and feet out of the bed in a sorry attempt to stand up hurts more. She clenches her teeth, realizing with growing despair that she can't do ten steps in that condition. And so she can't run, cannot even walk properly. Adora shuffles her legs back under the blanket and touches the plaster covering the wound. Immediately a spike of hurt pulses, and it's not only superficial. Quickly, she withdraws her hand. The doctor - *Catra* - has not been lying: this will need days to heal properly, she knows it on instinct.

Looking under the blankets and then around again with a searching gaze, she also gets that she's without proper clothes, too. Hmm, she doesn't even know how she got out of her stuff. Probably cut off by the medics? Now, she's just wearing her stained shirt and her boyshorts and the socks, but her pants are gone, as well as the jacket. And where are her boots?
Plus, she has no clue where she is. Judging from the artillery, probably not far behind the front, but who knows. Oh stars, this is pretty dire. A knot forms in her stomach.

Calm down, she says to herself, and takes a few deep breaths. Most of her problems are probably solvable, but to be able to flee, she must be able to walk. And she needs more information on what to do and where to go if she escapes this place. A phone would be good, too. Angella, Glimmer, Bow, her other friends must be worried sick about her whereabouts, and she wants to

warn them to not do anything drastic. Nobody should put themselves in danger because of her.

"What can I do for you, Major?"

Catra keeps her tone strictly formal, not wanting to arise any misconceived camaraderie between them. Luckily, the FSB isn't in her chain of command. It's still a civilian institution. She's part of the military, and the two institutions don't always get along very well. It's not that they are openly hostile to each other, it's more about competencies and budgets, the old rivalries of the Soviet Union carried over to contemporary times because things like that never change. Why should they? Institutions are still run by people, people who stake their claim and defend it.

Since Major Suworow held out his badge, identifying him as a member of the FSB, she decided to get rid of him as quick as possible. She really doesn't want these folks breathing down her neck, not even for five minutes. In her eyes, the organization has become dangerous to anyone these days, friend or foe alike, frightening everyone, and the sooner this encounter is over, the better.
Suworow smiles, but Catra knows when it's a false one, and his voice sounds creepy. "Well, Major, since your unit has been in charge of treating many of the wounded coming in from Mariupol, my office wants to make sure that potential foreign forces are being identified and properly handled. I'm here to take care of that task, with your support."

Properly handled.

Catra doesn't like the sound of this. Not at all. In a way, it's really against for what her profession stands for. Additionally, her thoughts wander to this one patient laying in the field hospital, beside her desk. Adora *without a surname*, how the idiotic woman

called herself, already told her she's a journalist. And that is clearly enough for the FSB to take over.
Well, that's not her problem, Catra thinks, and a grumpy voice inside her adds that this is maybe a good and easy way to get rid of the source of the puzzled feelings she has since the woman showed up. Hmm.
But then, there's also something true about what Scorpia said and what lets her hesitate, denying to just hand over the woman. Does she deserve to fall into the hands of the FSB? Catra is torn. Plus, she doesn't like Suworow's attitude, and the FSB at all, and that's decisive. The Russian Army doesn't bow to anyone, and neither does Catra. Fuck the FSB. She can at least play for time first and assess the situation.

"We haven't gotten to do all the paperwork. The assistant field surgeons assigned to us, who are normally responsible for this, haven't arrived yet. And we were quite busy, as you can imagine. So, I'm not of much help at the moment."
It's a put-down, and comes across that way. Suworow doesn't even make a face. "That is understandable. And I am sure you didn't intend to criticize your High Command, Major."
Catra narrows her eyes down to slits. These people always do shit like that, and the bad hidden threat is going on her nerves. "Слово – не воробей.[20] I was stating facts. If you want to insinuate something, say so clearly. Or complain to Lieutenant General Ivanaev[21] and tell him about your concerns. I'm sure he'll listen carefully and speed up the provisions immediately, because he has nothing else to do. I can get him on the line for you."
To underline her unnerved tonality with a gesture, she points to the telephone, sitting on top of a small technical cabinet a few meters away. It doesn't always work, but as long as that isn't her fault, she's fine with that. And then she grins at Suworow with her own false smile and thinks 'What you can do, I can too'. She has no idea if Ivanaev has her back, but one thing is for sure: when it comes to the Army versus the FSB, the army sticks together.

The spook with the weird forename doesn't bite back, he's good at deflecting. And at pushing. "I'm certain that given the majority

of the patients have been treated, updating the logs is taken care of today, isn't it? I can be of help."
If there's another thing she can't stand, it's when someone tries to tell her how to do her job. Even more so, if this person isn't in her line of command.
"We'll come to it, when we come to it. If you need it more urgent, please speak about this with my commanding officer. You know how it is. Brigadier General Nyrkow is not known for his leniency when it comes to formalities. You'll clearly understand that."

Without making a face or even a grin, inwardly, she snickers to herself. The FSB is known for permanently approaching military personnel without sticking to the chain of command. She knows Suworow will get any permission he wants to, but still, she can stick to the rules, slow him down, distract him, and if the rules work in her favor and not against her while also unnerving him, that's a nice plus. It's really not her job to put more poor souls into the meat grinder that is this organization.

Suworow tilts his head and narrows his eyes. He clearly isn't used that someone the same rank as him doesn't bow immediately to his demands. But he knows Catra is right: she's not in his chain of command. His voice contradicts every of his words. "Thank you for that reminder. I'll certainly take your advice to heart. Until then, may I ask if you have noticed any abnormalities?"
Catra actually pretends to think about. There's no use in pissing him off more than she already did. After a well-measured amount of pretending, she shakes her head. "Not that I think of. Most of our cases aren't in any condition to talk much anyway".
She gets an unconvinced nod in return. Whether he buys it or not, for now, their encounter is over.
"Thank you. I'll be back to see you soon, Major."
It sounds like a threat.

After he's gone, Catra lets out a long breath, but a few moments later, she has already forgotten him, drowned in work as she is. Morning passes, noon approaches, in the distance, the constant

artillery fire has intensified. Tank shots added, too, which is kind of a change. In the last few days, troops of every branch of her army have been amassed to finally bring the siege of Mariupol to an end. In the aftermath of yesterday's air strike, ground forces have been ordered a full attack into the city. The air raid surprised her, but she's used to not being informed about the strategies of her superiors. Secrecy has a long tradition in her army. Yet she knows she has to prepare her unit for new wounded people.
She completes the most recent paperwork and orders supplies via radio, a job usually to be done by an adjutant of hers, but Catra knows since long that it's always better to make her wishes clear by herself to put the necessary weight on it. The logistics units always tend to prefer fighting units - until they need Catra's help themselves, of course.

Afterwards, she decides to replace one of her colleagues who has been operating for too long. Two tents of wounded people are under her watch now, and in one of them lies an alluring blonde who makes her feelings uneasy. As her thoughts wander back to Adora *without a surname*, Catra quietly admits that her yesterday's behavior had been a bit childish. Now, the underlying threat of the FSB lurking around and searching for people like *Adora* only adds to this uncertainty, and it makes their next encounter quite chilly.

It's just before noon, and Catra has already examined every other patient in her tent, dished out a few orders to subordinates, before she begrudgingly takes care of the woman. She's definitely not childish enough to hand her job over to someone else like a coward.
But she thought about. Shortly.

Adora says nothing while she's being examined, but it's clear that the woman wants to talk and can barely contain herself. Catra struggles to look into Adora's face, when the woman obviously tries to catch her gaze. Memories of how she straddled the blonde's lap and traced along her side, her thighs, tumble into her mind.
Instead of giving her a chance to talk, she evades the woman's

look and points to the wound while she puts on a new bandage. "The tissue has been deeply cut, but it's mostly a flesh wound. It will definitely need some days to heal, but as long as you don't do anything drastic, you're not in danger of permanent damage."
It's the only moment she looks into her patient eyes. Adora finally nods, reluctantly, and there's more to the look than meets the eye. But… what might that be? The question almost escapes her, she almost voices it. She remembers just in time that she should ideally have nothing to do with the woman, outside the treatment. Despite what happened between them two years ago, when they were practically slobbering each other until Adora rejected her, this is clearly not the time to reminiscence.

"What's going to happen to me?"
The question shouldn't have surprised Catra, but funnily, it does, if only for a moment. Of course, Adora would want to know what's going to happen next, but Catra was so captivated with her own thoughts while she gently traced the woman's form, her soft skin… uh, no, she examined the patient's limbs professionally, yes! Ugh, hopefully Adora didn't catch how entangled Catra got while moving her fingers across her arm. Unbelievable.
She knows exactly what Adora's speaking of, and yet, she maintains a cool tone."What are you talking about?"
"Well, can I go when I want to? Where am I even? Nobody talked to me about anything yet?"
That's always the problem when - potentially hostile - civilians are brought into a military field camp. There are international and their own military rules for handling them, sure, and in case of doubt, a captive has to be treated as a civilian, but that doesn't mean that they can do what they want, even more so, if they are potential threats or violated Russian law.
"You're not going anywhere soon, as I just explained to you. You have to heal."
"Am I going to stay here, or will I be brought to a hospital elsewhere? I mean, this is a field camp, isn't it?"

That's a good question, too, and maybe Catra could've spent a thought on handling that before coming here. It's another sign of how distracted she is. There's still something in Adora's entire

presence, even in her state, that does something to her. “That hasn’t been decided yet. Our clinical capacities in nearby cities are already overwhelmed. But according to rules, I could arrange for you to be taken to a facility inland if that's what you want.”
A frown appears on Adora’s face. “Where are we now?”
“I’m not allowed to disclose the exact place, but it’s somewhere between Mariupol and Rostov.”

So, they may be just a few dozen kilometers behind the front line, judging from the loudness of the artillery. Here, in these flat landscapes, the thunder rolls over long distances. And a few dozen kilometers Adora might think could be manageable to even walk.
“Do not think about that, Blondie. You can’t just leave the camp.”
Catra knows exactly what goes through Adora’s mind.
“Am I a prisoner?”

Catra has no good answer to that. Adora’s status has not been verified yet, and that has something to do with the missing paperwork of *someone*. Usually, civilians are sent to hospitals inland, to clear capacities at the frontline, and after being released they can go where they want. Being harmed in a war is no justiciable crime. This is even valid for Ukrainian citizens. Russia has neither the capacity nor the will to hold civilians in detention camps till the end of the war. No one has a clue when it will end, and these people are noncombatants. Even in the cities they already captured, like Cherson, or Melitopol, life mostly goes on - that is, as long as people do not oppose the new ruler. That’s even clear to Catra, but that’s also just how it is.

But that’s not the case with Adora. She’s a journalist, and was obviously reporting from Mariupol. Catra has a strong sense that this Hordak guy would not be pleased if she let her go, not without cross-check. It could be the end of her career if Adora turns out to be a hostile agent or similar.
And besides all that, Adora actually has to heal. Catra’s duty is clear for now.
“That’s yet to decide. What were you doing in Mariupol?”
“Why should I tell you?” Adora’s reply is quick.

Catra taps the badge showing her rank insignia with a smirk. "Medical confidentiality. I'm not allowed to repeat to anyone what you are telling me." Well, that's not exactly true, because she can if Adora commits actual major crimes. But she needs the woman to trust her, otherwise she can't do anything. And there's this little part of her wanting to know. It's probably the same little part making her wanting to lay her hand on Adora's defined arms and trace them more. The woman lies on a stretcher, is wounded, in a dire need of a bath, her hair is tousled, and her face has surely seen better times. And yet, there's something emanating from her, a certain inner strength, compared with a vulnerable softness that makes Catra wanting to…

Ugh! What is this woman doing to her? She's rejected her before, and now, under these circumstances, there's nothing this can possibly lead to.
"I told you, I was working there as a journalist."
"Who sent you?"
"Sent me?" Either Adora is an excellent actor, or this is so genuine that it can't be faked. "No one sent me? I'm working on my own."
That's ridiculous, but Catra has to smirk. "Oh, so my guess about a hero complex wasn't so farfetched, huh? I mean, who else would voluntarily go into a war zone", she teases. They hadn't come so far to tell each other what they did for a living when they met the first time. They had mostly… well… smooched each other. And before that, Catra had eyed the damn woman from away. Her gaze falls onto Adora's lips, which look as enticing as before.
"Ugh, are you ever going to let it go? I don't have a hero complex. I'm just not cut out for an office job. This is just what I do since years."

Adora pouting is even more adorable.
Oh no, has she really used this word to describe her? "And the best alternative you came up with was going into a war zone and reporting from there? I'm pretty sure there are a few less dangerous options to an office job than that."
She must've hit a nerve, because Adora falls silent for a moment, and looks into her lap. Her mouth opens, then closes, then she bites her lips.

"Looks like I'm not the only one, huh? You're not a conscript either, Majooor." Adora puts a weird emphasize on the second half of the word, accentuating everything with making quotation marks in the air with her fingers. But again, the gesture falls short when visible pain streaks across her face, her stupidly beautiful face. "Ow," Adora lets out, and Catra immediately scolds her. "Don't move too much, you idiot. When you move your arm, you load exactly the wrong muscles."
"Yeah, yeah," Adora manages, between compressed lips, and lets her head fall back. "I was just painfully reminded of this."

This is so confusing. One part of Catra hates the woman, who dared to push her back, to reject her so cruelly. Another part wants to lay a hand on her head and pet her, to trace Adora's form, her arms, maybe more. This is absolutely inappropriate. Inside Catra, warring feelings contest for dominance, making her unable to do anything useful. She needs distance, to calm down, to think clearly. Thankfully, behind her, a soldier has started handing out lunch to the patients, so this is an easy way out. "Here comes your meal. And I have to look after my other patients," she curtly presses out, and leaves Adora to herself and a rather meager plate with food that looks like gray ration bars, accompanied by some bread and a bottle of water, as well as a sippy cup with presumably lukewarm tea.
But of course, Adora can't let go of her so easily, because the moment Catra is about to turn around and leave, she lays her hand softly on Catra's forearm and asks: "Why did you just run away like that, back then? What did I do wrong?"

Frozen. Catra is frozen.
The audacity, to ask her what SHE did wrong? And the touch, this beguiling touch of hers. It just tumbles out of her, without thinking, all the suppressed feelings and words need a way out. "You rejected me, thanks for reminding me about being so stupid. I won't make that mistake again."
Adora's gasp is nearly convincing. "I wasn't rejecting you, that's not what happened!" And damn can the woman play innocent. "I was there, and it clearly felt like that," Catra retorts, glowering darkly, and upon Adora's hurt look, she feels a little triumph mixed

with an odd feeling of… guilt inside. But why should she feel guilty?
“All I did was—", Adora begins.
This has to end. This has to end now. She cuts the stupid blonde short.“I don’t care. It’s been two years, it doesn’t matter today. And clearly not with you being an enemy.”

Her tone is so spiteful, so angry, that it makes Adora’s eyes go wide at the accusation, and Catra instinctively knows she shouldn’t have said that. Sometimes she curses herself for being in the military. For a hammer, everything looks like a nail, she realized that long ago, even for her in the medical service. After all, Adora is just a civilian, even if on the wrong side.

She turns around, upon to leave the tent and clear her mind, when Adora speaks up again and calls “You overwhelmed me! I was insecure, I just wasn’t ready yet. I’m still—"
What was that? She’s still what?
Only turning half-around, looking over her shoulder, she gets an impression of a shocked look Adora has on an embarrassed face, her right hand covering her mouth. It makes Catra curious. But no, she has to end this encounter, now, before she makes more mistakes.
“Yeah, whatever.” Heaving a deep breath, she storms out of the tent, in a repetition of the last day.

She trudges over to her command tent and rolls her eyes. The cold air outside helps a bit, but her mind is still racing. Why can’t she just stay calm and professional around the woman? What is it about Adora that’s derailing her so much?
Entering the tent makes clear there’s little to do for her right now. An adjutant is on duty at the communication devices, but beside him, it’s empty, because everyone is either sleeping or working. Her stomach grumbles and she looks at the clock. Ok, time to eat something.

It’s maybe an unfortunate coincidence that Scorpia also sits at a table, but Catra knows she needs a distraction. But Scorpia doesn’t know it, and she clearly didn’t forget about their talk from

last day. “What about the mysterious woman, Wildcat? Tell me everything!”
“Scorpia, what do you think about a longer stay in Lorino?”, Catra gruffs.
Calling Lorino a podunk town in the far east of Russia would be an overstatement. The place is so far in the east, it’s just a short boat trip away from Alaska. Not even a thousand people live there, but there is an old Soviet watchtower, boredly guarding the coast from non-existent threats.
“Don’t be a spoilsport, Catra.”
“Sure,” she scoffs. Scorpia can’t possibly mean that. “That’s utter bullshit. She said she,” now she’s the one making finger exclamation marks in the air, aping Adora’s voice,
“*wasn’t ready*. She said she was *insecure*, can you believe that?”
A weird look plasters Scorpia’s face, as the woman cocks her head questioningly. She’s silent for a few moments.
“That sounds like a reasonable explanation to me,” Scorpia says, while poking around in her meal.
“Sure. Bullshit.”
Scorpia frowns: “And what makes you believe she’s lying?”
Catra knows when Scorpia is generally curious. The woman is just too much in good faith. Unbelievable that she’s one of the best snipers in her army, taking out enemies without worrying about it.
“Oh come on, Scorpia, look at her. She’s so… pretty, and sweet, and gorgeous. So confident. Why would she be insecure?”

A scoff escapes the tall, buff woman. “Hm! Let me ask you if you’ve looked into the mirror today?”
“Huh?” Now Catra frowns. What on earth is the woman getting at now?
“I mean, what you just complained about is exactly what I’ve been thinking about you the entire time since we got to know each other.”
“What?” Underlining her bewilderment with words obviously lets herself sound even more dumbstruck, but she can’t muster better ones.
Scorpia leans back, laying her fingertips against each other: “You are pretty, and gorgeous, and cute—"

“I’m not cute.” Catra interrupts, stating it with firm determination.
“You’re super cute,” Scorpia grins broadly, “the best-looking doctor since Izzie, you’re deeply insecure about yourself, and you cover it up with your aggressive, repellant behavior. And that doesn’t sound so different from what you just told me about her, huh? You and this blonde hero-wannabe share practically the same trait. It’s only that you lash out, and she withdraws when feeling threatened.” During her rant, Scorpia stood up and started to pace around like she’s lecturing silly students. They are lucky that the canteen has practically emptied during the last few minutes, otherwise they would get unneeded attention as the woman rambles on.
“Ok, so tell me if I’m wrong, but if she said that she wasn’t ready for taking whatever you did with each other to the next level, it doesn’t sound like it had or has something to do especially with you, but solely with her. Put your analytical mind to some use, Wildcat. Am I right?”

Catra hates being lectured.

But what Scorpia says matches with a feeling she already had, deep down. A low grumble that doesn't sound completely like denial is all Scorpia gets in confirmation, and all the woman needs to keep going.
“And that’s telling me that your entire grudge is practically aiming in the wrong direction. The woman did nothing wrong, she just defended her own boundaries when she needed to. Everything you owed her was a little respect, from woman to woman. And if,” she emphasizes the next word very much, pointing with her index finger on Catra who has curled into a ball on the seat, hugging her knees while letting herself being scolded, “*you* just had been a little more patient and sensitive, you probably would have ended up in bed with her that night.” She pauses for a moment, then makes another stab: “Because you’re cute.” Catra is about to protest, but silenced when Scorpia points wildly at her, shaking her finger several times. “But instead, you stormed away like a child throwing a tantrum because you didn’t get what you wanted instantly.”
Scorpia sighs and puts the finger down again. “Well, I’m not

surprised. It sounds exactly like you."
Catra bites her lower lip, trying to come up with a defense against this ridiculous accusation, until something registers in her mind. Did Scorpia just say they could've landed in bed with each other that night? It reminds her of how Adora tasted: sweet, like blooming flowers.
"This is bullshit! I was not acting childish! She was… she just didn't want me like I wanted her!"
Scorpia stands before her and smirks down at her, then she lowers herself onto her heels and drags Catra's hands into a firm grip: "Wildcat, I'm saying this because I really like you, but: you're an idiot, and I rest my case. You know you're childish."

And Major Ekaterina Volodova just sits there with a grim expression and continues to bite her lip.
Well, maybe Scorpia is right, and she is a bit childish.
That doesn't mean anything, and it clearly doesn't mean that the blonde goddess in her bed - uhm, that's not true, on the stretcher in the field hospital she's in charge of and that's… and why does she even think about the woman like that?
She doesn't want Adora in her bed. Of course not!
Catra doesn't want to pick up and continue what happened or nearly happened in St. Petersburg again, that's totally out of the question. Never would she fraternize with a Westerner in a situation like now. They are enemies, and that's it.

But Scorpia doesn't let her off the hook so easily. The woman really can be an annoying pain in the ass. "So, what do you wanna do with her now"?, Scorpia asks. While Catra was bubbling and ruminating, the woman settled down across of her again and watched her.
"Nothing, of course. We are enemies, and besides, I can't get involved with a patient. It's against the rules, and that's it."
Scorpia laughs amused, not believing a word. "What? Who are you, and what have you done to Catra, my rule-breaking friend who spits on stuff like that? I mean—"
"Don't you get it? She's an enemy, and I'm not going—"
She's getting waved off by the buff woman. "Puh, that's a bit much, isn't it? Calling her an enemy? Has she done anything

hostile? Right now, she's just your patient, not a soldier. And as far as I know, we haven't declared war on NATO yet, huh? Where is she from?"
Catra cocks her head a little and shrugs her shoulders, a bit distracted from her fury because of the trivial question. "Don't really know. Somewhere from the EU, I assume. She told me that she works as a journalist."
Scorpia pulls a corner of her mouth with a "Hmm. I wouldn't spread that information if I were you. She has the right to remain silent, and Journalists aren't exactly welcomed at the moment, if you know what I mean. You might as well deliver her directly into the arms of… well, you know." Scorpia looks a bit worried.
"Why do you care about what happens to her?", Catra asks aggressively in return because she doesn't get it.
"I don't care about her. I don't even like her very much. That she appears here is actually a bit suspicious, and maybe there's more to her than we know. But I also know she means something to you," and Scorpia has to raise her hand and silence Catra because otherwise she would get interrupted, "and it would be a pity if she's detained, and you never get the chance to right your mistake. She doesn't look like an enemy of ours, and even if, what can she do."
"She doesn't mean anything to me," Catra protests weakly.
"Sure thing, Wildcat, sure thing."

Sometimes, it baffles Catra how absolutely loyal Scorpia is to her friends, even if it's against the rules she so much obeys to, or her own interest. She wouldn't have acted like that a few years ago, but over the course of the recent years, while serving in the army, she got more confident, more firm in herself. And despite that the one-sided crush always made Catra uncomfortable around her, keeping the woman on a distance, right now, she feels… embarrassed, and threatened, and understood, all at the same time.
"Ugh… you know, there's something about her that makes me so… confused. When I look at her, I always want to…", she really can't finish this sentence. No way. "I just don't understand it."
Admitting so much is hard for Catra. But Scorpia is actually the

one person she trusts with stuff like that.
“Well. You’ll never find out if you don’t talk with her.”

That’s probably right, and Catra sips on her cup of tea that got cold in the meantime. Still, drinking the now cold, bitter tea and glancing angrily at her best companion - friend, she quietly admits - is better than babbling more compromising stuff.

Catra screwed up.
Or rather, this talk could’ve gone better. Yelling at Adora, angrily threatening her to put her into a cell, was possibly a bit too much. On the outside, the woman kept her posture, pressed her lips together and said nothing. But she saw how Adora’s fingers clutched together, trying to keep them from shaking, and the woman looked shocked. A bit angry, too, and man, was that beautiful on her face. Adora’s actually cute, when she’s angry. A bit scary, too, because if she weren’t bound and unable to move, Catra would’ve thought about restraining her. Adora looks like she’s built to crush anyone who gets in her way. But it was the combination of hurt and anger in Adora’s face that made Catra stop yelling at her and - again - stomping away.

Now she’s in her own tent, laying down on her bed which is too big a word for a cot, but at least she has one, unlike many of the rank and file soldiers out there right now. Even in Russia, being an acting Lieutenant Colonel brings some comfort, even if it’s just a place to sleep that she shares with her deputy. Unfortunately, her deputy disappeared after three weeks of war and has not yet shown up again. Either he’s lying dead in the woods or has deserted. Anyway, it puts more pressure on her shoulders, because no replacement is yet in sight. It's not exactly like people are excited to partake in this *special military operation* and joyfully rush to go to war. Instead, dawdling prevails, and in Catra’s opinion that has much to do with the fact that they are miserably supplied with everything and that this entire operation is poorly executed. Enthusiasm about this war is rather limited to folks on social media.

Pulling off her boots, she sighs. The argument with Adora left her in discord. Catra is mostly not an idiot. And maybe she shouldn't have gone through the roof like she did. Of course, she's aware of what the Russians do to Ukraine and the Ukrainians in general. Even in good times, she doesn't trust most politicians and the government of her nation, because they've been lying to everyone ever since. But she has also known for long that the problems of countries with different opinions on how the world has to be shaped will always ultimately get out of hand and end in war, because every time some idiot messes things up. History has proven to have a nasty tendency to repeat itself, and in her opinion, nobody's innocent about this situation. She just prefers to be on the winner's side, as much as she wants to rise in the ranks of her army and into a position where no one has a say over her.

The damn woman on the opposite side had of course a very different opinion on that, and she was so judgmental. Catra doesn't even remember what led to the argument. One minute she was carefully examining Adora, the next they were in the middle of a dispute.
"But Catra, it can't be right to do what you are doing," Adora insisted. "Don't you see that your nation is leading a war of aggression against a country that was once your friend? You can't possibly agree with that, do you?"
Catra know she had a tired look on her face when she replied: "War doesn't determine who is right - only who is left." It's a very casual, trivial statement. Adora was puzzled. "Have you just quoted Bertrand Russell? How… literate, but that's—"
"It's actually a mystery that Russel said this adage," Catra cut her off, adding: "We do not know who said it first, but that doesn't make the saying wrong. Anyway, the point is that you have intentionally put us into a corner, and now we're fighting back."
"That's bullshit, and you know it. No one attacked your country, and for the last two decades, it's actually the other way around. Which is - what a coincidence - also the tenure of the man still in charge." She held her hand up and counted with her fingers into Catra's face - who hates being lectured. "Georgia, Syria, Kazakhstan, Crimea, and now the whole Ukraine. It was always

Putin who attacked another country first or entered a civil war from outside, and never the other way around. This has been his strategy all the time: destabilize the little nations around your borders while also stabilizing his own presidency by pretending that you have enemies outside. Which is just not true. Nobody attacked you in the last decades. Don't you see that he's a cynical warmonger?"

Catra vacillated.
She has no "Z" on her uniform like so many others have. Of course not. It's mostly because she doesn't think this war is clever and will do nothing but harm her nation in the long run. Everyone with a bit of foresight can see that. But she also knows that the West has deluded itself into believing that this war was solely the work of Putin and his inner circle. In her eyes, this belief was always pretty stupid and proof that they didn't know her country well. Putin has been rightfully re-elected multiple times. The undoubted voter sway, however, had always met with a willing recipient in the common Russian population, a people dying of their return to glory, to renowned power and recognition on the world stage after the trauma of the collapse of the once-so-feared Soviet Union. And now, after three decades of a shrinking population and a dwindling economy, plagued by corruption and the lack of foreign investment as well as a new superpower rising on its southeastern borders, Russia is a mere shadow of its former might, outplayed again and again. They all feel it, everywhere, that their nation is struggling. This war might be the last they could ever fight, with equipment from a state that doesn't exist anymore, and to a certain extent, Catra understands the strategic reasoning behind doing it now.

Because Russia is still the largest nation on Earth. With nuclear weapons. And just as the Americans were stupid enough to vote for an obvious agitator and impostor like Trump, Russians had the right to be stupid enough to vote for an obvious warmonger like Putin who let them feel great again.
To her, the differences between the two are marginal. Both men are absolutely ruthless, without any moral inhibitions and surrounded by a cult of blinded but willing helpers, just like Hitler.

The only real thing separating them from their predecessor in mind is that they live in a world of nuclear weapons, and the power of the atomic bomb changed everything regarding warfare. Unrestricted war or even war at all is not an option between nations with first strike weapons. That being the reason why the NATO doesn't really want to step in, and also why they hesitated for too long to allow Ukraine to join their ranks. They really didn't understand Putin.

That he is smarter than Trump only makes him more dangerous. Trump, the little dictator-wannabe, had been a joke compared to Putin, who made the American look like an idiot when they met at the Helsinki summit in 2018. As if Trump could outplay Putin. Ridiculous. She heard about how they'd been joking about him, afterwards, in the Kremlin. And the American didn't even get how easily and foolishly he'd been insulted. What a narcissistic idiot.

After all, the Russian president has now ruled the country for more than two decades, while the American oaf had lasted just four years and achieved nothing but weaken the American leadership of the west, alienating his most important allies with his child-like mannerisms and his need for quick but unimportant *deals*. Putin must've been laughing the entire time of the fool's presidency, while he annexed the Crimea and fueled the war in Syria to keep the West occupied, continuing to prepare for his own, more important one. If the oh-so-clever Western world was dumb enough to believe the man wasn't willing to do what he obviously wanted to do, well, that wasn't her problem.
The world just worked like that, and Catra has to make a living in it, too.

In her opinion, the main problem is that Putin is getting *old*. He took power in the beginning of his 50s, and this year, he becomes 70. His time is running out, and now he put his limited strategic talent to bad use when he finally ordered the offense. The man had always been a good tactician, but during the recent years, he got blinded by his own hubris, and real long-term-thinking never was his strength either. Growing old, the man's fear to be overturned like every aging dictator just grew, and he also wanted

to see his great, desired war and Russia's resurrection happening when he was still there, in power, dishing out orders to obedient recipients, and returning glory to Russia just like Stalin did.

And history tells them all about how that turns out for the common people.

Catra has no illusions about what happens in her nation, but it's not like she can or will do anything against it, and it's also not her fault that the West underestimated Putin for twenty years now.

In her opinion, these people are just plain stupid. Only the kind of cowardly fools you meet in the West, wimpy morons in their comfortable, expensive professor's chairs, could philosophize in impeccably mannered Sunday afternoon talks about how important it was *to see the other side, to make compromises,* to file around sophisticated legal texts and tactics that could be used *to contain and embed* Putin, to make a friend out of him, to change him.
And while they talked and talked and talked without an end and without reaching anything beside printing paper good for nothing, said man just entered Azerbaijan, Georgia, Moldavia, the Crimea and then the Donbass with his army. And he stayed. He just kept going, one step at a time, not backing down, and the West whined a bit until he got back to business as usual.

The world just keeps spinning, no matter what. Violence comes before justice, the UN can't do anything because they still didn't get rid of the outdated security council, and the normative force of the factual is far more enduring than eloquent claims on paper or on talk shows. It's this attitude of weakness, of non-perserverance what will finally be the downfall of the West, Catra knows. Yes, she has no illusions about what happens, but she's not blinding herself by standing against actual, real power.

Yet, despite her realistic assertion of the current situation, she doesn't, she can't support this war either. War doesn't solve any problems. It only leads to new problems you have to solve otherwise, and then on and on it goes. There might be a few

exceptions to that rule, but war against the people of Ukraine was just plain stupid in the long run, creating a hostile nation and an ongoing war on their doorsteps for generations to come.
It already made Russia a pariah in the international community, and will condemn her and her fellow citizens to an isolated life in a nation outcast and left behind, while the entire world moves on much faster than they were able to do alone.

Russia will suffer from this for her lifetime and still when Putin and his minions are long gone. Sadly, all these clever considerations were good for one thing only: to neutralize Catra's stand in the entire matter. It's not like if she can do anything, though.

She turns her thoughts back to her argument with Adora. She groaned, threw her hands in the air, yelled nonsense at Adora and stormed away.
After calming down and with a bit of guilt plaguing her - she doesn't want to put her into a cell, no way - she is up to go back and tell her at least that, when one of her Lieutenants comes in, holding a report. She looks at him, prompting "Hm?"
"Ma'am, Command orders us to relocate all civilians and soldiers with severe wounds to other hospitals, in preparation for new injured coming in from the front."
It's a usual measure, but she's a bit unprepared. "Where to?"
He looks at the clipboard. "Rostov, it seems. And Wolgodonsk, if needed. But only the cases up for a longer transport."
Catra sighs. "We haven't even registered all of them," she remarks, rather tired, rubbing the bridge of her nose, but then, quickly, her brains picks up the opportunity and forms a plan. Her eyes light a little up. "But that shouldn't prevent us from transferring everyone in question. I'll make a list. Ready everything for tomorrow."

Chapter End Notes

> The next chapter is called "Flowers and wheat beer". I'll publish it in around two weeks.

And a few notes:
This chapter grew and grew, and now I'm upping the chapter count, because, as I feared from the beginning, I can't stop from researching and rambling about it. But after you made it through this political-heavy thing, I promise more action and fun and road-trips as we're going to move forward and visit Rostov-on-Don. And then, we gonna have so many roads ahead of us, oh yeah!
Besides, in case you're wondering why I'm moderating comments: this story has caught the attention of a few of Putin's fanboys, who keep complaining about how unjust I am by disregarding their beloved Fuehrer's war. So, that's the entire reason. As I said: critique and discussions are welcomed, Putinism is not. I delete such stuff and do not interact. Everything else, I will gladly approve.

Footnotes

[17] I swear I wasn't aware of that Anna Politkovskaya wrote a book with the title "Putin's Russia" when I picked the title for this chapter. It came to my attention while I brushed over the chapter and wrote down some more insight into Anna's backstory. I was unsure about actually choosing that title, but with that coincidence, I couldn't do anything else. ↑
[18] Nord Stream 1 has been operating since 2011, bypassing the other land-based pipelines through the countries of Belarus and Ukraine by going through the Baltic Sea, and therefore causing political trouble because they don't get paid for transit anymore. Even now, during the war, the most important Brotherhood-Transgas pipeline through Ukraine is operating and Russia pays Ukraine transit fees on a daily basis. One Nord Stream pipeline has a transport capacity of 55 Mrd. m^3 per year, which equals around 550 TWh (Terawatt hours) of energy. The Transgas pipeline through Ukraine, Slovakia and Czechia has a capacity of 110 Mrd. m^3 per year, and supplies South and Western Europe. Germany, as the most important buyer, uses around 1.000 TWh of natural gas a year. ↑

[19] In the Nineties and Zeros, many of the Oligarchs came to wealth by shady measures, some of them clearly using unethical or criminal methods, but they also brought competition and development to an otherwise stagnating Russian economy. Many of them thought that playing along Putin's game and rules would secure them and their families while also bringing them to wealth. It turns out, that speaking out against Putin or even just turning your back on him is possibly deadly for anybody in Russia today, regardless of your status or wealth. If you think, that six Oligarchs, some of them with their wives and even their 13-year-old children being stabbed to death isn't so important, well, the list is much longer. During the recent years, dozens of people mysteriously vanished.
Here is a half-funny, half-scaring story, where the underlying golden rule is mentioned: "Stay out of politics, and you can keep your ill-gotten gains." If you don't, well, it's made clear otherwise. The lesson to be learned is the following: nobody in Russia takes away power from Putin and his feudal system. If you turn against him, you'll be threatened on a direct, personal level, and if you don't submit, you'll be jailed and / or killed. ↕

[20] Слово, не воробей ~ A word is no sparrow, a Russian saying, that a spoken word can't be taken back and therefore one wrong word, especially spoken to the wrong people, can have fatal consequences. You should think before you say something out loud. ↕

[21] Lieutenant General Andrey Sergeevich Ivanaev is presumably the current commander of the 20th Guards Combined Arms Army. Please also refer to the information given in the afterword of the previous chapter. ↕

To know you better

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra strides into the tent to be greeted by a tired-looking Adora. A - very small - spike of guilt shoots through her. Maybe she should've been a bit more lenient with the woman, because obviously, Adora didn't sleep well. Around them, her soldiers and medics already started to check their first patients out and carry them over to the waiting transport vehicles. Some are being carried on their stretchers, others can walk on their own, but due to the circumstances and the muddy ground outside this will take a while.
"Time to say goodbye," she says, more excited than she actually feels. But pretending and hiding her feelings has always been a strength of hers. "Just want to make a last check on your wound, then you're good to go."

At first, Adora looks a bit surprised. Obviously the woman has been daydreaming, but lets the quick examination wash over her. At the end, she looks outright uncomfortable. "Am I brought into a prison now?", she asks, half-accusing, her voice sounding as strong as always, but there is an edge to it.
Catra knows she's acting like a little bitch, and that tensions are high enough, yet she can't help but to tease the woman with a ghostly voice: "The darkest and worst we have, where prisoners are being chained upside down to the wall, cold water is dripping on them all day long and our best agents torture you with bad poetry. We call it Beast Island, and it's somewhere behind the Ural, right next to Azkaban."
"Azka—", Adora parrots, frowning. It's over-the-top bullshit, but it's so over-the-top that it takes Adora a moment to catch on. She rolls her eyes when she gets it.

"You should've seen your face. I can't believe that you're so gullible," Catra cackles restrained, clearly amused and barely

refraining from patting her knees.
“Not funny,” Adora pouts, but it’s clear she’s a bit relieved.
“Oh, but sure,” Catra replies, still grinning broadly. It’s a surprise that Adora can’t suppress a short laugh making it onto her lips. Catra has no clue why she finds this sight so enticing, but she pulls herself together: “It’s beyond me how a person as oblivious as you can make it through a war zone. Luck of the stupid, maybe. You’re being transferred to a military hospital at Rostov for further treatment. We need the capacities here.”
There’s a relieved look on Adora’s face. “What, is your army still struggling to cut through Ukraine like your great leader thought you would? Aren't things going according to his great plan?

It’s unbelievable how cocky the woman can be. Adora really has an ability to make her angry in an instant.
“Save the chatter, Blondie. Maybe it takes longer than we thought, but we will achieve what we aim to.”
“Making a misery out of everyone's life you touch? Is that your goal?”
Catra knows Adora is speaking about the war itself, and not about them personally, not about what happened between them. Yet, she can’t help but to feel again reminded.
“In war, sacrifices have to be made."
“The cheap excuse aggressors have used since ever. What does it matter if people get hurt or killed in the process, huh?”
“Always high and mighty. Of course, you and your priggish people are completely innocent in the situation.”

“You started this war, nobody else. It was clearly not the other way around,” Adora shoots back, and Catra knows it’s true, but it’s also not true.
For three decades, Russia has been pushed back again and again by the West, not being treated as a partner at eye level, but as some second rate nation. After the breakdown of the Soviet Union, and the slow but steady expansion of the NATO as well the European Union, her nation was slowly cornered and surrounded by increasingly hostile-looking nations. If it weren’t for their nuclear arsenal, they would’ve been run over like any other nation the oh-so-great US-of-A decided worthy to do so. Just like they

did with Iraq, Afghanistan, Syria or nearly the entire Middle and South American continent. Like many, Catra has a bad feeling about this war, but she's also long come to the conclusion that it isn't her job telling her superiors what to do about the greater good. "We're defending our interests," she retorts snappishly.

The woman on the stretcher makes a grimace. For a moment, it seems like Adora would just shut up, but of course, she can't: "If you ask me, you're doing a pretty bad job. Don't you get it? Even if you conquer a part of Ukraine - a totally devastated and worthless part then - you'll gain barely anything from it. Instead, your nation will be isolated for decades as long as don't withdraw to your territory. You'll never return into the international community. And I just know of another nation that casts quite covetous eyes on your east, with all it's riches and the little population living there. Have fun dealing with them when they decide to grab a snack. They're already buying you out there, and they aren't your friends. Nobody will come to your help then. All of this will only end badly for you." [22]
In disbelief, Catra shakes her head. "I really don't understand how someone in your situation can run one's mouth so much. If I were you, I would really shut up."
"Pfff. It doesn't matter what I say. You're going to do what you want, anyway," Adora retaliates.
If she weren't the target of it, Catra would be laughing about the ridiculousness of how much the comment derails her anger. What she wants and what she gets are two completely different things. So it just slips out of her mouth before she thinks about it: "You have no idea what I want."
Again, the surprised expression on Adora's face almost calms her, because the woman looks so funny. "What's that supposed to mean?"
"Nothing," Catra grumbles, thrown off again by the annoying, stupidly pretty yet so annoying yet so alluring yet so annoying woman. Why is she so easily distracted by the blonde menace? Just because they made out so long ago that it's not even true anymore? "I'm just here to tell you that you're being transferred and that we don't have to bother each other again."

“That’s not what I—"
“Yeah, save it,” Catra waves it off quickly and turns around.

It seems that stomping away from Adora *Unknown* is something she should get accustomed to. Outside the tent again, she takes a minute to breathe in and calm down. Around her, people are bustling to do their duties. A line of camouflaged trucks wait and are being loaded. Her anger is quickly pushed aside as she has to talk to a few Lieutenants of hers and dishes out some orders to speed up the process. They’ll need an hour or a bit longer, and she wants it to be finished as soon as possible for two reasons: Firstly, getting rid of Adora will remove a major source of trouble and distraction for her. Secondly, when she’s gone, Hordak won’t be able to notice the woman anymore and Catra can continue to pretend to be oblivious about her in more than just one way.

Back in her command tent, she decides to get some paperwork done before she sends the convoy off, blending out the coming and going of several people. But a quarter of an hour later, she’s interrupted by the greasy voice.

“Major Volovodova.”
“Major Suworow,” she greets him, unnerved, but he ignores it. Again, Hordak just looks like an agent, with his hair slicked back and his long, black trench coat.
“I couldn't help but notice that patients are being transferred. That made me look into the files, and I picked up an interesting difference between the reports you handed in and the numbers of patients I actually counted. Would you mind explaining that to me?”
Catra knows exactly what the man is talking about. Unfortunately for Hordak Suchorow, she’s an excellent liar. Without batting an eye, she retorts.
“Maybe you counted wrong?”
“Maybe, but I doubt it.” He gets zero upset and smiles creepily at her. “Let’s clarify this discrepancy before you move them?” His superficial friendliness is really insanely annoying, yet, Catra has to work with him if she doesn’t want to hear from her superiors soon. She has no intention of giving in to his demand to slow the

process.
“What have you noticed,” she sighs, pretending to have better things to do.
“87 patients went through your field hospital in the last week.” He pretends to turn the page, but in reality he is only watching her closely over the edge of the paper. Catra pretends to not notice it.
“According to your reports, 34 died, 22 were released, 33 are up for a transfer, as your Lieutenant told me. The numbers don’t add up, that’s two too many.”

“Maybe the releases are not up-to-date? That’s sometimes the case. We still can’t imprison civilians for no reason.”
“Sure, Major. But I examined the releases thoroughly and the number is correct.”
Okay, so that’s the reason why he has been so busy. He’s really doing his job with attention to detail, but that is not so good for her.
Luckily, Catra had been a bit smarter than to simply not creating two files. Adora has a file, but she is simply listed under the name *Anna*, an unimportant Ukrainian civilian. Unless Hordak’s going to talk to every single patient, he'll never find out. The other two files are from patients who were transferred the week before last. A bait, pure smoke and mirrors to distract him from searching at the right place while he tracks down the nonexistent people.
“Well, let me have a look at the documents. But, explain: is this really important? Do you assume that some James Bond is trying to sneak into our ranks as a wounded, to spy us out? Sounds stupid to me.”
He looks at her with narrowed eyes. “We have seen stranger things. But I’m not expecting you to pick up on that. That’s my job.” There could’ve been more subtle ways to tell her that she’s too stupid to do what he can do, but for once, she swallows her need to hit back and listen to her judgement not to start a brawl.
“I’ll go through my notes and inform you about my findings.”
He cocks his head and his eyes are still piercing her. “Do this, Major. It would be best to clarify this as soon as possible. I’d rather not stop the convoy just because of paperwork.”
It’s a threat, but it sounds rather like an order.

Catra pretends to go through her notes while the convoy is getting ready. She’s clever enough to make a big fuss around the fact that two files were from already transferred people. Hordak accepts the explanation stone-faced and goes back to his workplace, obviously searching through the files again. As long as he doesn’t stop the convoy, she’s fine with that. In an hour, Adora will be out of Hordak’s reach. Maybe she can distract him long enough.

Around ten trucks must have lined up, and Adora is in the last but one. She didn’t get to see much when she was brought over, still lying on her stretcher and firmly told not to move, but so many she counted. Her attentive nature is always on watch, providing her with too many details to get them all.
Her cot had been pushed into the vehicle through the back door, which is still open, letting her look at parts of the muddy field camp she stayed in for the last few days. Despite it still hurts, she’s able to prop herself on her elbows. The white tents of the medical corps have obtained a rather gray shade, due to dirt and rain and not being washed when actually needed. Adora’s not ungrateful to get away from this, but the picture of a certain woman comes to her mind, too.

Suddenly, said woman comes into her actual view and her mind derails a little because of the coincidence.
Catra looks pretty good in her uniform, Adora cannot help to observe. It’s possible that it’s half a number too tight, hugging her curves like they do. And given Catra’s traits, it’s possibly on purpose. But she also wonders what Catra would look like in civilian clothes. Maybe she would be a little... softer, a bit more pliable, and not so prickly when she's off duty?
“So,” Catra says curtly, while placing herself before the door, folding her arms.
“So,” Adora repeats, noticing that Catra looks a little

uncomfortable. If that's when they part for good, she decides to make it a bit easier, for both of them. "Thank you. For taking care of me."
It's waved off with nonchalance. "That's literally my job, so don't. Anyone would've done the same."
"Well, but it was you who did it, so I can thank you," Adora insists. It's a bit strange that despite the situation and Catra's overall grating behavior, she still feels drawn to the gruffy woman.
"Whatever."
Adora smiles. "If you're not here to be praised, then why you are?" It's a bit bold.

The question obviously hits Catra off guard, because her arms fall to the side. For a moment, she looks speechless, needing a little to come back: "I'm just supervising the send-off. Not everything is about you." It sounds as weak as it is, even Adora gets it.

It might be true, but Adora knows that's not the reason why Catra is here. She could've been anywhere, but she's here. And Adora doesn't want their encounter to end on this note. She hears how the trucks in front of the line are started with loud rumbles.
So, if these are the last words she'll ever say to Catra, she doesn't want them to be teasing or taunting ones. Desperately searching for something to say, her mind comes along with this: "What we did in St. Petersburg was awesome. I really would have liked to get to know you better."
It's so stupid to say that that it's probably in the Top 10 of dumb things she ever said. But yes, it's true. She really would have liked. There is a connection between them, as odd as it is, and despite that they've argued more than actually talked. But there's something about the woman she just can't let go. Even if it has been more than two years since they kissed, she still remembers it vividly, still feels the hungry touches and—
Catra looks bewildered, a bit run-over. Her mouth opens, then shuts. Maybe it was a bit too much?
But no. It was the right thing to say, Adora tells herself. She wanted to say more, but time has run out.

The vehicle’s backdoor is closed by a soldier and only seconds later, they start moving. Slowly, because the road is just a little better than a gravel track. Despite that it still hurts, Adora tries to rise a little to be able to look out of the rear window. She sees Catra, still standing, looking after her truck. Adora knows the woman can’t see her in the shady space of the vehicle, but it feels like Catra’s gaze is aimed right at her heart.
The woman looks somehow lost, and not really content.
Why that is, Adora has no idea. She wanted to say something nice, something kind.
But it looks like she just made Catra sad.

In a mixture of relief and bewilderment, Catra stands and watches behind the trucks, as they make their way out of the camp. Unbelievable, how much this woman needs to have the last word. How dare she pretends of being so nice! Ugh! Couldn't they have just parted ways without opening up old wounds? But no, of course Adora had to bring her failure up again, again awkwardly indicating what could’ve happened that night if she just hadn’t been so stupid. It’s always Catra’s fault, isn’t it?

In all her pent-up frustration, Catra has long-lost track about at whom her anger is actually directed. Adora? Herself? The circumstances?
Quietly and unspoken, fueled by Scorpia’s scolding, she has come to the conclusion that stomping away from Adora back then had been a mistake, too. Despite she would never admit it loud, Scorpia was of course right, hitting the nail on the head when blatantly accusing her of just behaving like a child. Catra knows that for herself now. But it’s been two years ago, why bringing this up again? Is it just another time when fate decides to spit in her face, throwing her own bad decisions back at her, just because? And why is Adora so stubborn on bringing up their

unfortunate first encounter again and again? Why can't she let it go?

Catra is not able to continue her ruminating - and to possibly consider the simple idea that on the other side is also just an insecure person, someone just a tad too inept to do what would be needed to get a step further.
Just like herself.
Instead, she's called upon by a Lieutenant of hers and starts trudging through the mud towards her command tent. She fears the next encounter with Hordak, really hates this war, and if only because it forces her to clean her boots every four hours because of all the mud she has to walk through.
And the coffee is also pretty bad here.

After she settled down, quickly, a welcomed routine sets in again and with Adora gone, she's actually able to concentrate for a while, do some paperwork, and has two, three good hours before fate decides to strike again.
Her phone rings.
Catra groans. Can't she just have some time for herself, her actual duties, and the stupid paperwork? Even Suworow hasn't shown up.
She picks up the handset of the old-fashioned device that fits perfectly with all their equipment. One might have assumed that a war in the 21st century would somehow... look more modern, cleaner, perhaps. But it's nothing like that. Or maybe it's just her unit that isn't provided with the fancy new stuff that instead goes to fighting units? Whatever.
"Second Tactical, Volovodova."

"Major Volovodova."
It's a rough voice Catra knows well. She feels how she tenses and gets rigid, straightening her pose. Catra is no fan of it, but she actually *can* stand at attention. When the commander of her army is on the phone, it's rather instinct to do so.
"Sir!"
"How are you doing down there?"
It's not totally unusual for him to call his subordinates from time

to time to get personal on-site insights from them. He surely knows her reports - her complaints - but she hasn't expected a call today, and it catches her off guard. Complaining about supplies is a duty every commander has to fulfill at all times.
"It could be worse." Catra wanted to come up with a more eloquent Russian saying, but she's still a bit too surprised upon the call.
He scoffs, but it's amicable. "When would it ever have been different, Major. But say, do I hear a certain resentment there?"
"Never, Sir! Everything is fine, victory is within reach!" It's so exaggerated that they both know it's a lie. He chuckles, but they also know they can't say all of what they want to say. Wherever his current HQ is, he's probably swarmed by political officers, who just have other names today. "Well, Major, it has come to my attention that your unit has been on front duty for the last eight weeks. Is that correct?", he probes.
"Yes, Sir." Come to his attention?
"Good. According to rules of operation, your unit should be shifted with the Fourth Tactical the day after tomorrow. Their redeployment is overdue anyway, and we will move yours back to Rostov for reinforcement and rest for four weeks in a rotation."

Catra doesn't want to sound ungrateful, because four weeks of rest sound like an opportunity from heaven. But Rostov? It means, that— "But Sir, we're really hitting our stride right now. Replacing us would lower efficiency." She knows herself that she's just pretending. After two months of constant field duty, everyone is exhausted and their efficiency will only decline further, regardless of any replenishment. Of course, Ivanaev sees right through it:
"What is your level of deployment?"
"Eighty-two percent!" Again, they both know it's exaggerating. Anyone in the army knows how to gloss over the situation, because that's part of the game, always has been.
He huffs. "Ok, so take your sixty percent and ready them for movement. The base stays, just your unit retreats in exchange."
"Yes Sir." Resisting would be dumb. But there's another thing concerning her: "But, why Rostov? Shouldn't we go back to Boguchar?" [23]

“Not yet, Major. Logistics are currently tight.” And with that he tells her that they lack the transport capacity to move them so far inland, because - it is ridiculous - the mighty Russian army lacks such a formerly abundant device as military trucks. In comparison to Boguchar, it’s just a half day trip to Rostov, even in their Jeeps and trucks and given the shitty roads they’ll probably need to use.
“Understood.”
“Good, Major. The garrison at Rostov isn’t so bad, either, even if the Southerns can’t get anything done.” Mocking the other military districts is just a well-oiled tradition, dating back well past every modern reformation of them. Organization patterns have changed over the recent 30 years, but some things never do. She knows she won’t get any closer to hear the man making a joke. “Report back to me when you arrive, then you have a few weeks until redeployment. Let your men rest, but you are free to let them assist at the garrison hospital or undergo other light duties. But in moderation. We need your people back at full capacity soon.”
After a moment, he adds a final “Dismissed.”

The line is disconnected, and after putting the handset back, Catra leans back, letting out a deep breath while the realization sinks in.
They lack transport capacity.
This is ridiculous. During Soviet times, army trucks used to be everywhere, counting in the tens of thousands. Even on their own Russian academies and training camps, the saying of the famous World War II General Omar Bradley had been taught: “Amateurs talk strategy, professionals talk logistics." Bradley knew what he was talking about: in 1944 and 1945 he led the 12th United States Army, which was with around 1.3 million soldiers under his sole command the largest military formation ever taken to field.
She’s often reminded of this phrase, even more so when she sees the idiotic TV moderators and talk show hosts crying for total war while actually knowing nothing about the harsh reality of it. Such a mundane and trivial thing as logistics and supply doesn’t fare well at parades and show reels for the TV screens, where videos of firing tanks, artillery and the howling of Katyushas are much more impressive and able to sway the public opinion about their

abilities.
But an army's combat range is only as long as its supply chain. And now she’s stuck in the mud in a godforsaken shithole because they lack trucks.

She sighs. Well, at least Rostov is not so bad. But hmm, that’s a little… strange. She opens a drawer and pulls out a map of the Southern Military District, looking up their bases around the large southern metropolis. Her finger circles over the map, and finds the hospital where the wounded are being brought to right now, and it lies… of course on the same base they ought to go.
Catra clenches her fist in mock defeat, she nearly wants to pull her hair. Is this a coincidence? Not so much the location, because there are just so many bases in the area they can use. But the timing is so odd.

Her mind wanders back to a particular woman she had assumed she’d gotten rid of. What is she going to do with that? Four weeks of rest sound good after two months of deployment, but the thought also makes her a bit uneasy.
Well, there’s nothing to do about it, and the base is big enough to not run into a former patient. She folds the map and puts it back, while thinking that she can just stay away from this nuisance in her life. There’s still a war going on, and she has better things to do than to long after an alluring blonde with a gorgeous body, a tasteful kiss and a smile that—
“Oh, fuck me,” she grumpily sighs.

Two mornings after Adora’s departure, Catra’s in her tent, for the hopeful last time cleaning her boots, readying herself to set off, when she’s suddenly approached with a crushing hug.
“Wildcat!”
In deep need of air, she squeals and squirms out of the smothering embrace. “Scorpia, no! Ugh!”
“Oh, uhm, sure. Sorry,” the Soviet propaganda offspring apologizes, sounding just a bit too unconvincing to be believable. After straightening, Catra asks: “What are you doing here?”, and is smiled at broadly in return. Scorpia is in her usual attire, looking ready for battle any given time.

“Oh, just saying goodbye, you know? As you’re going to Rostov and—"
“How do you know about that? We haven’t talked since…” It quickly dawns on her what might’ve happened. “Scorpia, what have you done?”
“Me? Nothing!” The woman looks guilty as fuck, and she even *sounds* caught. Catra can’t believe it. “Do you have anything to do with that?”
A small uneasy laughter bubbles out of Scropia. “What? Noo! I mean, what could I even do?” The giggling gives it away. “I mean, besides mentioning that your unit is overdue for a rotation to my uncle, maybe? A little slip-up, nothing more, I promise.”
Piecing it together is not hard. “And he mentioned it to Ivanaev. Great, Scorpia, great. You know how I feel about such things. Now he thinks that I used my connection to be pampered. That will be great for my career.”
“You know it’s not like that. According to rules, your unit was overdue for a rotation. And you guys really need a rest. I just reminded him of it. You know how it is: they tend to overlook you if you don’t complain loud enough. And you were clearly too stubborn to do it, huh?
“That’s not yours to decide upon,” Catra snarks back.
“I’m sorry,” Scorpia says, but doesn’t really look so sorry. “I thought it was a good idea. But hey, look at it from the bright side: you can spend some time with that mysterious reporter girl of yours.”

Catra is speechless. Which doesn’t happen very often. Rather… never. “Did you do that, so I can be near her?”
Again, it’s surprising that the woman made it so far if she can’t act. “What? I would never! It’s just a happy little coincidence, nothing more.” The puppy eyes she’s met with could persuade anyone who didn’t know the woman better. “You haven’t talked with her about what I said, have you?”
She hasn’t, and probably never will.

Four days have passed since she's been brought here. Time enough to get accustomed to the boring and mind-depraving routine of a hospital. Her wound heals, even if only slowly. But she was able to walk around a few steps in the recent days, go to the bathrooms she shares with four other patients, and until three hours before, she would've welcomed any distraction, but, well, boredom came to a screeching halt.

The military hospital is a recent, usual, no-frills functional building of the modern era, gray, two stories high, laid out in a U-shape. This is no place to be pampered. It's a place to be passed through, either dead or alive, and the structure obviously doesn't care in which condition. The people working here do, but maybe just gradually more, in a weird mix of military personell and civilians. Adora got so much that the command structure seems to be filled with officers from the army, but the actual nursing duties are fulfilled by many local civilians. Well, this is not an unusual model. Any professional modern army hires subcontractors for non-military tasks, but the recent events and the management of this war have awoken some doubts that the Russian army is actually a modern one.

Yet, here she is.
The standard room she shares with four other women is also typical. Five beds and an array of medical monitoring equipment alongside two of them, because they have been more unconscious than awake. The other two only speak Russian. Which Adora understands, but she has a hard time to cut through the accent and speed they use, and she doesn't want to reveal that she understands the language herself. Not for now. She pondered how to proceed, and decided to talk in English. It's obvious that she's a foreigner, her Russian is just not good enough to pretend. And not talking might also be suspicious.
Each day, a doctor makes his round, and she answers the few questions about her condition in English. It doesn't seem that they care about her origin and nationality, but when she asked when she's allowed to leave, he just refused to answer. Aside of that,

there’s little to do, and it bores her to hell. Her eager nature doesn’t cope well with doing nothing.

One of the women has been able to catch a radio which plays music quietly. It’s a Russian program, and on the little news the entertainment program has they’re talking just as little about the war, still calling it a “Special Military Operation,” reporting that everything goes according to plan, but not talking about what this actually plan is. Well, if people believe that invading Ukraine with the largest equivalent of an army the world has ever seen in Europe since the Great War, is just an “operation”, then the situation is obviously dire.
She picks up enough of the desperate tries to sell the standstill as some kind of success. But the two women only speak shortly of it, then they just listen to the music and don’t talk about the war again.

The little distraction vanished with her visitor, though.

Just two hours have passed by since the creepy FSB officer with the black hair and the weird name left. Enough time for Adora to turn her brain into overdrive five times, calm herself down four times, and now she’s again in a state of agitation. It’s not exactly fear. Fear is for the weak, fear is a failure. Adora always managed to turn her fear into energy. But it’s different when you’re not at full height of your physical capabilities and at the mercy of your enemy who has captured you.
She uses fear-turned-energy to stand up and try a few steps using a simple crutch, which results in a very slow walk towards the inner courtyard of the hospital. Someone with enough sense and decency tried to make this place a bit more beautiful than just being a gravel yard.
It’s a place to catch a bit of fresh air for patients, but there’s no possibility to escape from there, too, because as the entire building, it’s inside the perimeter fence of the garrison.
But the air helps a little. It feels great to be able to walk around and breath in, despite it still hurts. Because ten minutes of walking make clear that the wound is still healing. The pain grows and grows, and Adora has to clench her teeth and to settle down

on a bench. Inevitably, her thoughts turn back to the encounter with the FSB officer, Hordak Suchorow.

She isn't derailed easily, and is usually confident and cocky enough to talk back to anyone belittling her. But this guy had a way of using words in a manner that made her deeply uneasy, even in his weird English. The threat wasn't at the surface, but the innuendos were clear: he hasn't yet picked up who exactly she is, because for some reason Catra obviously didn't mention her name. He asked for it, and Adora denied giving him one. That was probably a mistake, because now he's taken a picture of her. Even if Russia is years behind the most sophisticated technology the West has regarding supercomputers and artificial intelligence, it shouldn't be so hard for him to use the reverse Google image search or something like that to finally come up with a result. There are clearly enough pictures of her on the web to put him on track, and her website is - intentionally - easy to find. Once he makes the connection of a few search terms, he should be able to quickly find out who she is.
"We'll speak again," he simply said, and Adora has no clue when that will happen. But he's on to her.

Sitting on the bench for just a few minutes, her gaze has fallen onto the ground while she tried to breathe more slowly. But now, a shadow falls onto her, and she looks up.
"Catra!"
The call escapes her involuntarily, actually needing a moment to recognize the woman in her civil outfit. Catra has placed herself before her, with folded arms and a small grin. And damn, does she look good.
She has her curls open, voluminously flowing over her shoulders and reminding Adora of the time they met first, more than two years ago. But today, she looks even better. Catra wears a black leather jacket and dark red leather jeans. High-heeled black leather boots support her height and let her look a tad taller than normal. She would be about Adora's size in them, the perfect height for making—.
Catra did not zip the jacket, instead it's open, showing the red body she wears under it. The garment hugs the curves of her

figure neatly, and more important, of her breasts, and she's obviously not wearing a bra.

Oh stars, she looks perfect, Adora thinks, and all other thoughts are washed away. Her eyes are fixed on the woman, the alluring, bewitching woman, who emanates sexiness combined with a rough, playful appearance, and she can't find the strength to tear them away. Adora feels, stupidly feels how her heart fastens as she takes in the sight of Catra. It's only getting worse, with her being so near, but she notices that something's off.
In Adora's opinion, Catra's own appearance should make her nothing but confident. Instead, the doctor stands there more like a little schoolgirl, with her little smile, and for an awkward moment, they're both silent, until…
"Hey, Adora."
Funny, how she missed that voice.
"Hey, Catra."
Adora curses herself for sounding so croaking, and clears her throat. She's just so baffled to see Catra again. "This is… quite a surprise. What you brings you here?"
Catra rolls her eyes. ""Eh, I just wanted to check if you're good?"
"What?" Catra's answer makes no sense, but it also puts an end to Adora's ridiculous stupor. "You came here all the way from your camp just to look after me?"
Catra shakes her head in denial. "No. My unit has been transferred to this garrison for recovery yesterday. I'm just here to say hello. How are you?"

Hordak's visit comes to Adora's mind and the fact that she has been ruminating about this for the last two hours. But that must not be Catra's problem.
"Thank you so much. I'm fine. Even started walking." She points at her crook and doesn't mention why she felt the urge to do.
Catra tilts her head, seemingly searching for a bit more. "That's good. But remember that the tissue still has to heal. Only small rounds, okay?" Adora nods, torn between begrudgingly accepting to be treated like a child by Catra and happily accepting to be treated like someone Catra might care about on a… personal

level.
"Are you being treated well?"
The question isn't exactly what Adora expected. Is Catra aiming at something specific? Because somehow she has a feeling that Catra wants to ask something, but can't really voice it. And the problem is, that Adora can't really voice *that* either.
"It's all right. It is a military hospital, after all. I'm not expecting stellar treatment. Everyone does his job."
"Okay. That's good."

They fall silent. The entire atmosphere is awkward now. Around them, in the little garden, other patients haven't picked up on the two women. Everyone is busy with themselves. Adora has no clue how to continue their conversation, and Catra is just standing before her, rubbing her left arm with her right hand, looking at the ground.
"Is there something? What's up with you?", Adora finally asks.
The brunette looks up, hesitates for a moment before pointing at the bench. "Mind if I sit down for a moment?"
"Of course not." Even sitting in silence beside Catra will be nice. After all, even if they mostly argued with each other, she doesn't think that the woman wants to harm her. Adora's left hand lies next to her thigh on the bench. Where Catra settles down, and now her arms fall beside her. For a moment, their hands touch. Only the little fingers, but it sends all sparks and giddiness into Adora. A volcano of warmth emanates from her left hand, sending her heart into overdrive, and she feels how her eyes go wide. Quickly, the touch is gone, Catra has retracted her hand a little, but it was just a small move to the side, and it's lying still just a finger's breadth away. Now the woman looks onto the ground, and Adora's heart is still pounding much too fast for such a little incident, yet her brain is too distracted to voice anything.

What is happening to her? Why did the touch make her so washy?

It's silent for a minute, until, finally, Catra speaks up. Luckily, because Adora's brain is still too electrocuted by a simple touch from a hand.
"I'm… actually here for a reason."

If her ears could perk up, they would, Adora knows while a shiver runs down her spine. Catra's voice sounds uneasy, not as teasing as before.
This doesn't sound good at all.

Chapter End Notes

Originally, I wanted to get further with this chapter. But as always, it got longer the more often I ran through it and researched, and now I'm upping the chapter count again *sigh* and so, this chapter is a bit shorter than intended, and it's mostly build-up. But next chapter, we'll a little fun and stuff, and then it's getting rough. And the chapter after even more. I have already written plenty of them, and uhhh, it's going to be good. :-)
See you at "Flowers and wheat beer."

[22] The book "The Bear and the Dragon" is a novel from the Jack Ryan series of the late Tom Clancy and explores - in his typical unhinged American jingoism - the scenario of China invading the Russian east in a full-scale-war in a setting around the year 2000, I assume. The warfare described there has well researched modern battle scenarios of the 21st century, and sees the use of advanced technology we might've expected to experience in this war by the Russians today, but to our surprise, do not or at least only to very little extent. If you like extended battles, overly lengthy writing and can see past Clancy's thinly veiled conservatism, it's worth a read and gives an entertaining insight of war on a strategic-tactical level. ↑
[23] The small town of Boguchar in Voronezh Oblast is host to a large garrison of the 20th Guards Army and I decided to make it host to Catra's division too for no particular reason than being near enough. ↑

Flowers and wheat beer

Chapter Summary

> Adora has a rough time in Rostov-on-Don. But also, a hilarious evening.
> And Catra has a terrible idea. Really, really terrible.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Only an hour earlier, Catra looked at Hordak Suchorow with a mixture of disgust and fear. She would never admit the second one, and since her transfer she had hoped not to see him again, but here he is. The pale man has proven to be a remarkable pain in her ass.

The military camp lies a little northwest of Rostov-on-Don, the large metropolis of Southern Russia, and since her arrival, she has been busy with overseeing and sending her subordinates into a well deserved rest. She does it with a heavy heart, because she knows not every one of them will come back. It's a problem she has no good solution for: since the beginning of this war, all divisions are plagued by desertions or simple *no shows* of newly contracted soldiers as well as conscripts. The supporting units, not involved in actual front line fighting like her medical division, are not so affected as, for example, the infantry. But even for these, it got noticeable. Since they've been stationed east of the beleaguered - well, now occupied, she reminds herself - Mariupol, an astounding 15 percent of her men went AWOL and nearly none of those whose contracts ended renewed them. Advocating war on social media and actually participating in it are two very different things, Catra thinks, while tapping with her pen on the table. She was never shy of doing her actual duties, and she despises those who only talk about it. Rich kids, having achieved nothing else than owning a smartphone with their parent's money.

Talk show guest whose only purpose seem to incite meaningless arguments. Pfff.

In the first days of the war, she tortured her mind if this had something to do with her own style of leadership. Was it probably too harsh, too rigid? Was it because she was a woman? Too young, probably?
But when the topic was covered in a meeting of the 20th Army Command she attended, other commanders mentioned absent rates of 20 percent and more. Ivanaev decided that they weren't at fault. It would be ridiculous to punish them for not being morally prepared to enter into a war their political leadership didn't tell them about until they were ordered to cross the Ukrainian border on the 24th of February. They trained for that scenario, sure, but nearly none of them believed that it would become a cruel reality. So she stomped down her insecurities and stuck to her routine.

At the mostly newly-built camp, they had been accommodated in one of the old barracks from the 80s, from Soviet times. It's a cheap treatment of camp commander, a derogatory necessity, but they're just visitors here, and at least they are free to leave the camp because they aren't on duty for the next four weeks. They only have to do a morning training to stay fit, and some use the time for recertification and studies. As doctors and folks from the medical professions, many have an intrinsic need to stay up-to-date, even if this got more difficult in recent years.

It's undoubted that the large medical advancements of today are made in the USA, Western Europe, Japan and maybe South Korea, and access to the international community of exchange via congresses and expert conferences has gradually dried up recently. She ran into Adora at this fateful conference two years ago, originally intending to participate in discussions and smaller talks about certain new means of surgery, and to meet a few old colleagues from university.
But then, the blonde menace to womanhood crossed her path - or rather, stumbled into her with her stupid smile and her gorgeous light blue eyes, and Catra started stalking… uuhmm… carefully

watching her quietly from afar, until she finally cornered the woman at the bar where they made out in a weird blow up of short-lived attraction.
Well, a one-sided, short-lived attraction.
She's still not over it, and Catra has accepted that awful reality begrudgingly. And till today, she has no idea what exactly happened to them.

It was the last conference she attended - not because of the Adora-incident - but because ever since, all conferences hosted in Russia have been increasingly neglected by the leading experts of the Western hemisphere. Nothing against China or India, they had good people too, but their educational system was still second-rate and so, the largest chunk of high-end research and publication is done within the medical networks and research clusters of the West.
It also surely helps that it's still the Anglo-European sphere where the big money is made - instead of actually helping people decently, she often thinks. It's a shame that the times when her own nation showed prowess in that field was a few decades ago. And it's still a mystery to Catra how a culture as disorganized and chaotic as the West is, achieves anything.
Fucking idiots, all of them. Mostly, a certain blonde.

But well, that's not the point now, and Adora shouldn't be a point either since Catra decided to go against Scorpia's advice - or rather to cowardly shy away from it, but that's something she would never admit to anyone, too - and not to pursue this specific relationship. That can only end in chaos and turmoil, and she just doesn't need that.

"Major," she's approached, and "Major," she returns.
The automatic reply is like a weird ritual of formal friendliness. She knows they don't like each other, her unwillingness to willingly cooperate with him is something he clearly takes personal. Catra couldn't care less about the wants and likes of Hordak and the FSB, but she still has to collaborate to a certain extent if she doesn't want to get into trouble.

“You made a mistake,” Hordak says with a crooked grin on his pale face and puts down a folder on her desk.
“Is that so?”, Catra replies dryly, perfectly knowing that she made several, and some of them even on purpose, but why the fuck should she admit that willingly to that creep?
“I tracked down a few inconsistencies in your files, and this one patient of yours doesn’t seem to be as inconspicuous as it looked like.” He glances onto the clipboard he still holds, but again, only for a moment, while actually watching Catra’s reaction. “This ‘Anna’ is a foreigner, and the woman refused to answer my questions. What do you know about her?”

This stubborn bastard. He really tracked her down, through all the cases. She has to try hard not to get angry. Showing emotions is never good, but especially not when dealing with the Secret Service.
“The blonde one? Not much beside the name. She was found severely wounded in a street after our air strike on Mariupol. Since she isn’t an enemy soldier, she is of no further interest to us. From what I understood, her name is Anna.”
Hordak makes a disapproving face. “If she’s a threat or not has yet to be decided. How you got her name?”
“Maybe I got it wrong? We didn’t talk much. It’s not I have a personal relationship to my patients. There are way too many of them.”
Now, he glances at her with narrowed eyes. “Really? That looked different when you said goodbye to her at the camp. Wasn’t that some kind of familiarity I noticed between you?”
So he watched them. Catra ignores it. “How would you know that her name is wrong? You said she didn’t talk to you.” That’s the only good thing for now. As long as Adora doesn’t betray herself, he shouldn’t be able to pick up on her too fast.
“Oh, that was easy. When I called for Anna, she showed no reaction. I don’t know her real name yet, but it’s clearly not Anna.”

Catra’s mind is running. She could’ve told Adora, but she long learned that keeping her secrets to herself was the only way of actually protecting them. On the other hand, she feels a weird

need to protect Adora from the grasp of the FSB. Today, nothing good comes from this organization.
"This particular interest in a single woman seems rather exaggerated to me. Does Sergey[24] have any needs? Blonde and buff in particular never seemed to be his type."
It's just a snarky comment, and she doesn't expect Hordak to blow up like he does. Yet, he's snarling: "The traitor is where he belongs. You better concentrate on not sharing his fate."
"What?" Her amazement must be visible. She immediately curses herself for showing such a weakness, but she really didn't know that something happened to the head of the Fifth Service.
Of course, Hordak picks it up. "Ah, you didn't know? He was removed from office as he has proven to be compromised, ineffective, and worthless. You might take a lesson from this. This is what happens to failures."
Beseda has been in office for 13 years, a loyal schmoozer of Putin for two decades, and this just reeks. "So, what you're telling me is that even the FSB makes mistakes? Let me mark that day in my calendar, please! This is awesome," Catra cackles, but Hordak is getting none of it.
"Save your little speech, Major. He's not of our concern, instead, your own failures are. I'll track down this patient of yours, and if it turns out that your reports have been wrong on purpose, well then… then we'll see again soon."
Without greeting, he leaves her, and somehow the temperature in the room got a bit colder.

And that's how she ended up sitting beside Adora at the bench in the hospital courtyard. She should just hand over Adora and claim to have nothing to do with her. But even if she can't form the thought laying beneath the surface in words, she knows she can't do it, instead and for some weird reason, she came up with a half-formed plan and now sets off to execute it immediately.
Helping Adora is stupid. Of course, it is. But if Hordak interrogates her thoroughly, the woman might spill information about their encounter of two years ago, and that would clearly be the end of

her career. How could she be so careless, letting herself be compromised by an alluring stranger? It was an infatuation, or course it was.

It brings her back to now, where she sits beside Adora. When the blonde speaks, it sounds calm: “So, he knows who I am and wants to arrest me?”
Catra nods. “I think so. I assume that right now he’s filling out the necessary paperwork to transfer custody of you from the Army to the FSB, and then he can take you in. It’s a needed formality, but’s it’s also just that. They won’t fight back on behalf of a foreign agent.”
“I’m not an agent, this—"
Catra raises her hands in defense. The other patients and staff walking around don’t care, but she doesn’t want any attention.
“Sshhh! I know that. You’re way too stupid to act like one, even to save your life. That much is clear. But whatever you reported from Mariupol can be perceived as a violation of our laws, and Suchorow seems very eager to please his uppers.”
“I was in Mariupol, and that’s not in Russia,” Adora retorts firmly. “I didn’t do anything wrong there.”
“Well, tell that to the FSB and see how they think about it. As far as I know, they are already started to put up traffic signs in Russia around the area. From our view, it belongs to us now. I don’t think that you have the guts to take it back, so…” It’s just an implication, but the extended conclusions are clear: her country will incorporate all occupied territory into the Russian Federation. Like they did with the Crimea.

Adora shakes her head slowly. “You know that this is gonna be different from Crimea. The West will never recognize the annexation of this territory by you. There’s no way you're gonna win something out of this. The only matter will be, how much both of your countries are going to lose. There won’t be a victory for you, just isolation.”
Shrugging her shoulders, Catra retorts: “Well, it’s not that it’s us who are calling the shots, Blondie. You and I are just pawns in a game played by others.”

Adora lets out a deep breath, and she looks a little resigned. Her next question surprises Catra.
"Why are you telling me this?"

Catra inhales. Despite she's here to do exactly what she's up to do, now that it's time she's hesitating. In fact, she has no fucking clue why she wants to help Adora. Sure, not handing someone over to the FSB is one thing, but actively helping is something completely different. She has no clue how it's going to turn out with her superiors, when Hordak will inevitably file a complaint about her. But letting Adora be squeezed about their weird make-out-session is also a bad idea. And when she remembers Hordak's creepy smile and his attitude, and thinks about what he's going to do with Adora, the kind-hearted, good-natured, kissable Adora… ugh, not again.
She's not here to make out with Blondie. Well, maybe Scorpia was right, and Catra was wrong all along.
"How well can you walk by now?", she asks Adora, and gets a puzzled look.
"Why do you ask me that?"
Catra doesn't reply instantly, but pulls out a small tin, filled with tablets.
"You should take these."

Half an hour later, they walk side by side towards Catra's Tigr[25]. As a commanding officer, she has constant access to a personal vehicle, which is a small perk. She actually never owned an own car. Having no family to pay for her medical studies, she decided to join the military to be able to afford them. She didn't really want to pursue a military career in the first place, but it hadn't been so bad in recent years. Despite it doesn't pay very well, her basic needs have been covered all the time, and beside them, she doesn't need much. Superfluous possessions on which many in the West are so proud to have them were not for her. She never had much, and life in the army, with its constant changes of location, did its part to keep her luggage light.

Which was and is good. Keeping the physical and emotional luggage light keeps her mobile. Letting herself not get too attached to anything or anyone made her invulnerable to the widespread corruption and blackmail that's a part of her country's culture. That wasn't a moral decision. She just doesn't like it to owe anybody anything.
Plus, she can save her income for later and until this entire mess started, she'd intended to extend her contract and stay a few more years. However, the events of the last three months made her unsure about that.

Fuck it, right now isn't the time for pointless musings.
Catra glances at the woman beside her, and judging from Adora's face, the ample painkillers she administered her in the largest possible dose work pretty well. And yet, Adora is rather slow, maybe dazed, and Catra senses how the woman tries no to hold her stomach while they walk over the parking lot. Which is just an exaggerated description for a graveled part where a lot of vehicles stand. Like, a lot. Dozens of Jeeps, cars, trucks stand neatly line up and wait.

Around them, the camp is bustling in its usual atmosphere. Men are training, utilities are maintained, orders are yelled. The atmosphere is rather relaxed, because as this location is a hundred or more kilometers away from the front, these units are not currently involved in battles. Most are on watch or recovering. Still, this is a huge army camp with a few thousands of soldiers stationed here, and she doesn't need any attention on her.
She hooks up with Adora in an attempt to support the woman. Immediately, Adora straightens up and becomes a little more brisk. But the body contact sends many unneeded feelings into Catra. How can it be that just touching Adora's side with several layers of clothes between them is able to make her so washy? And how can it be that Adora looks good even in a simple Russian mess dress uniform? She looks like a liaison officer, with her stupid, pretty face and her goofy, nice blue eyes. Maybe because the clothes are a little tight. After all, Adora is a tad taller than she is. Stupidly, it just means that Adora's curves are perfectly visible. Catra already saw the woman nearly naked, but it's different from

when working and as always, fantasy is a strong instrument.
Oh, dear.
"Just a little more," Catra says, holding Adora tight. "Do you see the jeeps over there? We're almost there."

Adora nods, but says nothing. It's clear she's struggling with her strength, even if the painkillers do their job. "How do we get out of this camp?"
Catra laughs quietly. "That is the easiest part. I'm an acting Lieutenant Colonel. When leaving the camp, they'll just wave us through. Getting in would be harder, but you won't be with me when I do that."

"What? Adora knows her voice pitched too high, but she hasn't expected that turn.
When Catra ordered her to dress into the uniform, her anticipation led her to believe she was about to be dragged into an interrogation room or something.
But this is different, and the woman doesn't behave like her usual, snarky self. They nearly reached the vehicles Catra seemed to aim at, when she says: "Is that so hard to understand? I'm getting you out of here, dummy."
Adora is still trying to comprehend what Catra's going to do when the brunette opens the door of the passenger side and helps her into the jeep. She's grateful for the assistance, even if Catra's touch leaves heat marks everywhere her hands get in contact with her own skin.
This is ridiculous.
She shouldn't be so enticed by the enemy. But she can't suppress the question, if Catra actually is her enemy?
Breathing fast, she sinks into the seat of the small off road jeep. Even walking the short distance over here was burdensome and makes it clear how much she's out of shape, painkillers or not.

Luckily, getting out of the camp is ludicrous easy.
Adora's heartbeat is already quickened, while Catra rounds and jumps into the car in a smooth movement. The key stuck, she immediately starts the engine and threads into the little traffic heading towards the main gate from all over the camp.
"Do not say anything. If we're talked to, I handle it. Do nothing, just look bored," Catra murmurs. Five, then four cars are before them, and the guards look not very attentive. Adora has her gaze fixed on the windshield.
But when it's their turn, the soldiers just do their job with a trained routine. Luckily, they can't see how hard Adora grips the door handle with her right hand and the seat with her left one while she desperately tries to keep a stone face. But all the soldiers seem to see is a commander, wearing the badges of a Lieutenant Colonel, and there are no questions asked.

They are waved through.

Outside, Catra speeds up a bit as they quickly reach an asphalted main road. A minute later, they drive up a highway towards the southeast and only there, Adora breathes out hard. "Wow, that was easier than I thought."
Catra huffs. "Of course it was. They had no reason to search us. Now comes the hard part, dummy."
"What do you mean by that?", then louder: "And what's the meaning of all of this?
Catra points forward, where a big city lies. Around them, traffic has become remarkably intense. ""I'm going to bring you to Rostov. It's large enough for you to hide there, and to think about an idea to get out of Russia. That might be a challenge, but it's your best shot by now. You can reach many means of transportation from there."
That's probably true. Or… can be true if she's able to come up with a plan, with an idea how to leave this country, and a metropolis like Rostov will help. But at this moment, another question is much more important. "Why are you doing this."
But as she waits, and looks at Catra, all she gets in response is a grumble. And that's when Adora decides not to poke her. Instead, she rolls down the window and lets the warm air blow into her

face.
It’s not all about getting a clear head.

They are already in the city, when the highway ends at a large roundabout, which Catra leaves straight ahead towards the city center. It’s no problem for Adora to read the Cyrillic traffic signs. While they drive along a wide, tree trimmed boulevard, high-rising apartment blocks show up left and right. They are from the Soviet era, the architecture shows. When they stop at red lights before a crossing, Adora looks out, and sees people in their daily business strolling around. Children are playing on walkways and little lawns before them. A few dogs bark at each other. In the sunshine, everything looks just so… normal. A bit outdated, sure.
But it’s peaceful.
There is nothing to remind you that cities not even 200 kilometers away are being reduced to rubble by artillery, rockets and tanks. From the last news she heard, the Russians fire more than ten thousand rounds onto the Ukrainians per day. Here, it’s just a day like any other.
“It looks so normal. So calm,” Adora mumbles rather unwittingly, but again, Catra doesn’t pick it up. She only lets out some curses and cusses like a coachman in the dense traffic where rules seem to be an optional thing.

It takes them fifteen minutes, then Catra stops before a gate of something that looks like a park or a public garden. A sign reading “Botanical Garden” makes it clear.
“What? Are you taking me on an excursion?”, Adora asks, half-grinning, but guarded.
“Don’t be such an idiot. It’s a place for you to hide for a while. I go and fetch you some civilian clothes. The fewer you show your pretty face in the public, the better. I’m going to look for a hotel room or a place to sleep for you for a few nights, too, but I don’t want to be seen with you or have to watch you. And this park is the last place anyone would look out for you. It’s perfect for waiting for a while.”
Catra rummages in her pocket and fishes out a few bills. “Here, a little down this road is a pub where you can get something to eat and drink, in case of need. Toilets are there, too. But it would be

better if you just take a walk or sit at one of the benches nearby and wait for me. I'll need a few hours, though." She holds out the money to Adora.

To be honest, it doesn't feel very good.

Adora knows she has an uneasy look on her face. This park is probably a bad idea to wait there. Sure, it's a public place, not much is going on, everybody is just minding his business, there are many ways for her to flee in case of need. But she's still not very fast, and running away would be just that: a stupid idea with no prospects of success. It'll take a long time until she's back in shape.
"Don't worry. I'll pick you up in a few. Just don't do anything stupid." Catra says.
"Okay." Hesitatingly, Adora steps outside and closes the door. Catra gives her a last nod, then she heads off in her jeep with a grim expression, and Adora looks past the vehicle with an uneasy feeling. It has an unpleasant resemblance to being an abandoned kitten.

Afternoon is already well advanced, and she's tired. Since Catra left, Adora did little beside walking around, and mainly sitting on several benches just outside the visibility of the main building of the park, never going too far away, so Catra could find her easily.

But… Catra hasn't shown up again.

The day is sunny, and still warm, which gave her the opportunity to take off the jacket of the uniform she's still wearing. She looks a little more casual like that, not so military. When other passers-by walk past her, she pretended to enjoy the afternoon sun. The peaceful atmosphere in the park is actually calming. Before her is a little lake. She enjoys the sight of flowers, not flat rolled by continuous track vehicles or destroyed by the craters of rocket impacts. The manifold colors of something simple as flowers soothe her. And the beauty of the flowerbeds and bushes is so

normal, such a trivial thing here - the complete opposite of her weeks in Mariupol. For the first time since her capture, she has the nerve to wonder what happened to the city, and the people she knew there. Are they still alive? Is the city really under Russian control now, with all the implications?

The more the afternoon stretches and has no sight of Catra reappearing, the more she gets restless. She even counted flowers of different colors twice, and now, with the sun slowly approaching the horizon, it gets colder.
She has no watch, but she's trained enough to guess the time from reading the position of the sun. That's not so hard. It's also clear that the nights are probably still cool here, even if it's May. Maybe she's naive, and an idiot, but she still believes that this wasn't Catra's plan all along. It wouldn't make any sense, leaving her behind just like that.
Or does it, and Adora is just not clever enough to see through? Is it possible that Catra just won't return?

Anyway, the gruffy woman has not returned. And maybe, she shouldn't be surprised. After all, they aren't friends, and Catra is a member of an army Adora has to consider hostile. She clearly doesn't owe her anything. But she somehow hoped that the woman… at least… liked her.
Just a bit.
And would *not* leave her behind.

Well, there is no use in ruminating. She has to think about what to do now, what her options are.
Still, she has next to no money. She's hungry, but she can endure a night without dinner. The few Rubles in her pocket that Catra gave her will buy her a breakfast or lunch tomorrow, but that's about it.
But then? Without access to a bank with connection to SWIFT[26] - of which Russia has been cut off - she can't get any money, even if she was able to provide any mean of identification - which she has not.

Okay, that are thoughts for tomorrow.
For now, she has to think about where to stay the night. A warm place would be best, and not too far away, because she has not given up hope that Catra returns yet. With the little money she has, she can't afford a room. She could possibly go to a nearby pension or search for a hotel and ask for help, promise to pay everything twice after she contacted her friends. Glimmer can send her money somehow. But the prospect of walking aimlessly through the city isn't very appealing, not only because of the pain. Plus, she can't be sure that the employees at a hotel won't back check and report such a suspicious guest to the security authorities. The FSB has his hands probably everywhere. Same goes for restaurants and such. She's obviously looking a bit ominous, with her not really fitting military outfit and without money, ID and a smartphone, her situation is pretty shitty.
And leaving the park would rob her of the only possibility to get into contact with Catra again. If she vanishes into Rostov, Catra won't be able to find her ever again.
Maybe something happened, and she just couldn't get back? But will tomorrow?

Adora sighs and closes her eyes. Rest; she needs a rest, a possibility to lay down and stretch. The bandages are still fine, but the side of her stomach hurts from the efforts of this day, and the painkillers Catra gave her have slowly worn off during the afternoon. Walking and moving for so much and for the first time since her injury made the entire area of her body hurt again.
She decides to look for a nearby place to stay the night. She picks herself up from the bench and starts walking towards the main building. The huge, manor-like structure stands on a slight hill and has a large lettering on the edge of its roof that reads "Southern Federal University's Botanical Garden". Adora ponders to give it a more thorough look from the inside, but at a crossing, a sign to the other side, the left, reads "Oranzhereynyy Kompleks". Instinctively, she decides to take a look there.

The orangery turns out to be a large with several smaller, somewhat run-down greenhouses attached, with large glass fronts on all sides and as ceilings too. A smaller, unadorned,

modern facility building accompanies them beside a parking place in front of the greenhouses. It obviously serves as entrance and maintenance storage. A sign for visitors indicates that the building is open from nine to five, and tells about what is shown inside. Luckily, no entrance fee is charged.
Rather out of curiosity, Adora enters the building. The man behind a reception desk doesn't even raise his look from his smartphone. Quickly, Adora walks past him, encountering a couple on its way of leaving, then she enters a small hallway, and at the end another glass door gives way into the greenhouse. Tropical plants and trees fill the structure abundantly, the atmosphere is warm and damp, and a nice wooden sign in front of her indicates a round tour on a gravel path. Tall palms tower over the path and all other growth.

Ten minutes later, she sits on a bench beside the entrance, with a half-formed plan.
At least, this place is peaceful. And quiet.
The plants, bushes and trees, with all the shades of green they cast, make it comforting. And it's warm. And… it's actually a safe place during the night. The thought rolls through her mind. Why not stay here? It's all she needs, and if she's able to evade the last tour of the supervisors, she might also be able to find a place where she can actually sleep a little.
On a bench or so. And there's a toilet in the hallway, too, she noticed that in her always attentive nature. She can fetch water there.
This isn't such a bad idea, is it?
Her heartbeat quickens a little. A look at the clock tells her it's half past four. The greenhouse will close in half an hour. If she's going to do this, she should probably find a good hiding place and stay out of sight until everyone is gone. In case of being caught, she can always pretend to have missed closing time, to be captured with taking notes for a study project or so, or playing a game of hide and seek with friends. Maybe it will work as an excuse. The idea is probably just so-so, but she doesn't have a better one, and she's tired, and clearly too weak to run away from anyone.

Five minutes later, Adora has squeezed herself into a corner of the greenhouse, behind two huge palm trees, where the ground is covered by several bushes. She leans against the back wall, and it’s a pathetic, ridiculous excuse of a hide-out and far from perfect, because even from here she can look at the pathway. But as one has to bend down to see her from there, it’s probably the best she can get.
With her knees drawn up, she waits. Her stomach grumbles.
Time plays its usual cruel game of not ticking by when actually wanted. Five p.m. goes by, and not even five minutes later, an overseer walks by, now a woman, judging from her step. The steps get nearer as she walks along the path, and Adora feels her heart beating faster.
The woman doesn’t even stop for a second, instead, she's whistling a silent melody while walking by, obviously happy that her working day is over. Quickly, the sound of her footsteps disappear, and after a door falls shut, Adora lets out a breath.
That’s fine.
She’s alone.

It’s getting night. In the background, the air condition works with a constant whir. It’s not really disturbing, it’s just there.
After warily searching for any kind of video surveillance, Adora tries out a few places to rest. The orangery consists of several adjacent greenhouses, a larger one and several small ones. At first, she lays down on one of the benches beside the path, but quickly finds that it’s hard and not very comfortable. She can’t stretch her legs and in this position, her side and stomach start to hurt. The same goes for most of the ground between bushes. It looks softer than the pathways, which are made of stone tiles, but it’s actually just a tad more comfortable. The little bumps everywhere are not softened by any layer beside her thin clothes. And the parts she can actually use are small, because an irrigation system of thin hoses along the ground keeps the most of the soil moist.
After five minutes of restlessness, Adora decides to use the

guest's bathroom. She uses the sink to make a cat wash and to drink, then she takes notice of another door in the small hallway leading to the toilets. It has a small label “Частный” [27] on it. Probably rooms for the staff? She tries the handle, and the door actually opens.
It gives view to a cubbyhole, not bigger than maybe four square meters. A tiny table with a few manuals stands right next to the door. And in front of her: the most welcoming sight she’s ever seen: a camp bed.

It doesn’t look like this room’s used often.

Adora lets out a sigh of relief. As it’s almost night outside, she doesn’t dare to switch on a light. It means the room is nearly dark now. She sits down, and takes off her shoes. She leaves the door open, so she’s able to hear anyone coming as soon as possible. Her body will wake her up before morning comes.
It’s a bit cold. She doesn’t freeze, but the atmosphere of the tiny room is not exactly comfortable. But just laying here and being able to rest is more than enough. After covering herself with the uniform jacket, she tries to keep her mind busy by thinking about a plan for tomorrow.
“What shall I do tomorrow?”

Rolling the question around in her mind, here, in this small room, the feeling of loneliness is probably the biggest she’s ever experienced since she woke up in Catra's camp.
Now she's on her own, in an alien city, in Russia, an isolated nation at an undeclared war with half the world, and she's surely someone the worse part of the authorities would love to lay their hands on. The invisible pressure of having no means to even buy the most simple supplies, being cut off from her normal means of communication only adds to that.
Adora looks at the ceiling. By the little she can make out in the dark, it's just concrete, dreary, cold.
She's alone, it's never been clearer than now. Her friends have no clue she's even alive, and she has yet to form a plan how to talk to them. And since they parted, Catra must've decided to stay away from her. And of course, she means nothing than trouble.

Helping her so far must've been enough. Adora was just too stupid to pick up the hints.
As before, probably.
But so be it.
She'll deal with all of this tomorrow.
Thanks to her exhaustion, her eyes fall shut quickly, and she's taken away into uneasy dreams.

Despite everything, Adora wakes up on dawn. Her inner clock always works well. After pulling herself up, she ambles into the greenhouse to look on the actual clock, and it tells her it's half past six. The orangery opens at nine, but the staff will be here sooner. So, after using the stretcher for a few minutes of more loafing, it's not even eight a.m. when she walks back to her hideout after making sure that she leaves no sign of her presence in the room she slept in.
And then she waits. With knees drawn up and arms wrapped around them. Sometimes she stretches herself, but then falls back into the guarded position.
Not much happens. It's terribly boring.

A quarter before nine, someone of the staff seems to make a round to look if everything's okay, but it's just a walk-by. Nine a.m. passes, and shortly after the usual visitors start to fill in.
Adora's stomach has been grumbling since she woke up, but she'd suppressed it. Since then, the feeling only grew, and she decides it's time to fetch something to eat and to plan then, because an empty stomach doesn't think well.

A group of pupils walks by on the round path, their teacher ahead. The chattering hoard is the perfect disguise, so she steps out well after them and weaves her way towards the exit. When she leaves the building, the man at the reception says nothing, but this time she can see him looking after her. As yesterday, she has casually thrown her uniform jacket over her shoulder to avoid looking too formal.
But he probably remembers her.

With a quick pace, Adora leaves the building and walks down the narrow road from the park entrance towards the main street. Catra told her about a diner at little down the street, so she heads south. There is normal traffic, a few pedestrians are on the road, everything looks normal.
200 meters further on, she reaches the small diner. It looks family-owned, a small, one-story brick building with many signs indicating today's servings. There's a kind of self-service beer garden on the side, with a few plants giving shade, where two or three guests are already sitting and having breakfast. It looks nice, and the view from the street is a bit guarded, so Adora decides to sit down there.

Having breakfast here obviously means having coffee, kascha[28] and blini, because the other patrons are digging into them like there's no morning. They are probably workers, having late breakfast or an early snack. Adora gets herself a large cup of coffee and *two* portions of blini. The Russian pancakes made of buckwheat can be stuffed with nearly everything from sweet to savory. But her body needs something to burn, so she takes them with the offered fig jam. The more sugar, the better.
Turns out, the blini fill her pretty good. She tries not to gobble them down too fast, because the small but thick and fluffy pancakes ooze from butter, and jam doesn't make it better. After the two portions, Adora struggles not to fall into a sugar-induced coma.

She leans back into the cheap seat, and while sipping at her coffee, she's ready to think about her options. At least, there's no need to worry about the weather. The day is overcast, it's neither cold nor warm, and doesn't look like that's gone change, soon. But she has to come up with an idea to get some money, and a telephone to call her friends or at least to use an internet café. It's ten in the morning. Weighing the options of returning to the botanical garden - and probably being recognized - or looking for something different, she decides that she'll head off to the city by afternoon. Until then, she wants to give Catra's return another chance by waiting in the park. She doesn't dare to return to the

orangery, not after the searching look she earned from the receptionist, but the park itself should be fine. Putting down the cup after her last sip, she pulls herself up and heads back to the park.

However, the decision is taken out of her hands.

Back in the park, she walks along the narrow road leading towards the main building again, when she sees two police officers, a man and a woman, walking up the stairs of the manor and entering it through the door at a fast pace.
They're looking for someone, that much is for sure. Adora doesn't know if it's for her, but the suspicious look she got from the receptionist comes into her mind again. Maybe he reported her? She has to be quick.
They'll surely search the building now, but will they look around in the park too?. Well, anyway, her time here is up. She keeps her pace normal to not spark any attention, just walks by the building and towards the Orangery again, where the roads leads towards the lake. There was a bridge over a narrow spot, and at the other side, a settlement lays. If this route is guarded now, her luck has run out, but it's probably the best route.
Luckily, there's just a woman with a child walking by at the road, coming from the greenhouses.

In contrast to her own situation, the weather is still just nice. The clouds have gone, warm sunshine floods the garden and paints everything in a bright spring green.
She takes the right-hand path towards the bridge.
Her step quickens the more she leaves the main building behind, but again, her hip starts to hurt with every single step. She keeps a fast pace though, walking by the trees, beautiful blooming bushes and the flowerbeds to whom she doesn't pay any attention now. They provide some kind of sight protection, and Adora keeps listening to noises in her back.
Don't look back, don't make it obvious that you're possibly hunted, she thinks.

A few meters further, she leaves the cover of the trees behind her.

Only small growth seam the side of the road towards the lake and bridge, and there's no one else walking around. With a quick glance to the back, she sees that the police car still stands in front of the main complex, and someone is on the steps of the building, too. Probably the person who called them. Adora looks back forward, walking as fast as she can without making it obvious she's fleeing.
She has no idea where this road leads, but before her, the small bridge crossing the river or canal feeding the lake appears, and on the other side are several industrial buildings, warehouses and so on to be seen. It's perhaps a place to get lost while the police are occupied with searching the park.

Adora keeps her pace, and has only reached the bridge, when two things happen at the same time.

From behind, she hears someone running, now yelling something that can only be interpreted as an order to stop.
Up front, from the other side of the canal, a small white Lada rushes up the road, approaching way too fast, nearly jumping over the bridge. The car comes to a screeching halt right beside her, the window of the passenger's side already lowered.
"Jump in!", Adora's suddenly screamed at.

She needs a stupid moment to pick up that it's Catra who's yelling at her out of the car. Then the woman leans over and pushes open the door, adding a harsh, loud: "Now!"
"Stoy! Nemedlenno ostanovis'!" [29], the police officer running at her yells again. He's merely twenty steps away, laying his hand on the holster of his weapon now.
Adora stumbles forward two steps, plummets ungracefully into the seat and hasn't the door closed yet as Catra already pushes down the accelerator, forcing the car to jump into action and into a 90 degree curve, on a path along the canal. They quickly leave the officer behind. Catra's still speeds up, while the river rushes by on their right side and the park on their left.

Adora's heart is pumping, and due to the insane velocity which with Catra is racing over the narrow road, it doesn't exactly calm

down. Quickly, she fastens her seat belt. Everything in her hip hurts now. The road is a mere gravel track, and she feels every bump they ride over.
“Ow,” she lets out when they hit another hole.
“Sorry,” mumbles Catra who leans forward, her gaze fixed on the road. They underpass several railroad bridges, then drive through a residential area with small houses. “I have more painkillers when we get a breather.”

Adora turns to Catra, and, for the first time, sees her in actual civilian clothes. She has so many questions, but her stupid mind is derailed by the look of the brunette. Her mane is bound, and she wears simple blue jeans, a black shirt and an alike jacket. It’s casual and inconspicuous, yet, it looks good on her. It’s a contrast to the lines under her eyes, testifying to a rather sleepless night.
“What happened to you?”, Adora asks, instead of asking where the fuck she’s been.
“Nothing,” is all she gets in return, barked out by a rugged voice.
“You don’t look like—"
“Shut up and get off my back about it! I need to concentrate.”

Minutes later they reach a two-lane main road where Catra slows down to a normal, reasonable pace and weaves into the traffic. Adora looks behind, but realizes how stupid that is. “Aren’t you afraid they’ll follow us?”, Adora asks. The harsh rebuff from before is still having an effect on her, but she’s restless about being chased, too.
Catra huffs amused, still concentrating on driving. “Look around.”
Adora searches the surrounding traffic, and it doesn’t take long to get the pretty obvious that Catra means. Every eighth or tenth car is a white Lada. White seems to be the color of choice for cars anyway, it’s the predominant.
“See? Don’t worry about it. They’ll never find us by chasing a white Lada, and they know it.” She lets out a small breath. “Why was he pursuing you anyway?”

Adora shrugs her shoulders, and instantly regrets it. “I don’t know. My guess is that someone from the park oversight got wary about me and called the police.”

Catra replies nothing. She seems to be concentrating on the dense traffic, but Adora senses that she also doesn't really want to talk.
"Whose car is that? Yours?"
Judging from Catra's answer, she can see the woman imaginary rolling her eyes. "Do you think I'm an idiot? Of course, it's not. It's a lease."
"But… they may have caught the license plate. Can't they track it down and get your identity with it?"
Catra huffs. "This is Russia, and not your overly glorified digitalized society where everything is monitored around the clock. If you need a car for a few hours, you get it. If you need it anonymously, you'll get it cheaper, because the fellow handing it out makes a few bucks without putting it into the records. The plate is probably false. That's how this country is run: everybody fucks everybody." She started with an amused tone, but at the end, her voice grew a little bitter and sounded disillusioned. "Well, some just get fucked."
Adora doesn't really know how to respond. "Oh, okay? I mean, that's not okay, but… you know, not being tracked is… good."

Ten more minutes of uneasy silence go by as they make their way into the city, until Catra speaks again: "You need to get off the road. At first glance, you almost pass for a Russian. But Hordak is not stupid. He'll surely guess that you try to hide here, and we have to get you some civilian clothes. And probably a hair job." She weaves her hand through her curly mane, making them fall over her shoulder. "How about brown?"
Despite the situation, Adora has to grin. "What? You think you're pretty?
Catra groans. "Please, don't make me regret this."
"Okay, okay. I'll do the hair job. But what do you wanna do? Do you have a plan? I mean, besides dumping me at the next highway parking place?" Adora means it as a joke, but she can't hide her voice from spilling how uncomfortable she is beneath her words.
"It sounds tempting, you know?", Catra says. After a moment of letting Adora stew, she adds. "But no. I got you a hotel room for

the night. It's nothing special, but it's no questions asked in a pad Hordak won't look for you. Too normal, you know? No one will notice you there, so, it's exactly what we need."
"Thank you. But… he's still looking for me, huh?"
She shouldn't have let this information slip. "I'll tell you later. Unfortunately, the room is only ready by the evening, so we have some time to pass. For now, you can change your clothes on the backseat, then I have to return the car. After that, we find a hairdresser."
Adora just nods and looks on the backseat, where a plastic bag lies. "We?"
"Of course we. I can't let you wander around alone. You'll probably be captured within half an hour." Catra steers into a side street, stops the car at a parking slot, and turns to Adora. "So, hop back. You got ten minutes. I promise I won't peek"

Of course, she peeks.
Adora slides onto the backseat and starts changing her clothes. While the woman struggles a little to get out of the pants, Catra tells her it's necessary to do it before they get to the hairdresser. A military uniform is always something noticeable. She doesn't add that Adora looks strikingly good in it. She also doesn't add that it's probably the reason why she was spotted at the park. Now, Catra tries to prevent her gaze from falling onto the rearview mirror, to watch how Adora has taken off her pants and shirt and is only in her gray underwear. Catra has seen the woman like that before, but at that time she was a patient, and Catra doesn't have an eye for the contours of people when treating them. But a nearly naked woman on her backseat is something… different.

Then her look falls onto the patches and bandages around her waist. There's no sign of blood on them, which is good, but they should be replaced anyway.
"We should change that too when we got to your room," she says,

actually without further intentions.
She wasn’t expecting Adora’s head to snap up, and her eyes piercing Catra’s through the mirror. “Hey! You said you won’t peek!”
With just a little pout, Catra turns the mirror to the side. “Don't let this go to your head. I say this as your doctor.”
“Sure,” Adora scoffs, while wiggling into the blue jeans not too gracefully. Then she asks: “Could you drop me off at an internet café while you return the car? I want to write a mail to my friends to let them know that I’m still there. They haven’t heard from me since… well, you know… and they’re surely worried sick.”

Catra thinks about the idea.
She pulls up Yandex Maps on her phone, and quickly finds a few in the city. It’s no problem, logistically, to let Adora out at a location and pick her up after she returned the car. The problem is, that she doesn’t want to let the woman out of her sight. Who knows what trouble she will get herself into?
“It’s probably a bad idea to write them. We can’t be sure that Hordak hasn’t put the pieces together and let the traffic be traced for keywords or such things.” She senses Adora’s look from the back and shrugs her shoulders. “Just sayin. Outbound internet traffic is being traced. I don’t know about the details or possibilities, it’s not my field, but I think you should be careful.”
“I’ll be careful,” Adora assures her. “I can use a throwaway mail, and my friend has a mail address she uses for sensitive content. It’s not connected with her publicly.”
Catra grins. “Very considerate of her.”
“Yeah, I mean, it’s not the first time we have to do this.”
Catra cocks her head. “One day you have to tell my about your work. All of this sounds suspicious, you know that?” While she speaks, her gaze wanders to the mirror again, which she turns back to look at Adora. The woman has finished dressing herself, sits on the back seat and looks at her with rather tired eyes. Even like that, and in just a shirt, Catra’s thinks how beautiful she is. Something tugs at her, down in her lap. A feeling of…
“Yeah, well, I know. It’s not that I’m a hidden superhero. I’m just a reporter.”

Catra laughs quietly. “Sure. Superheros don’t get shot.”
Shaking her head, Adora denies: “I wasn’t shot. It was your bombardment of a city you had no business being there.”
“Whatever.” Better not to dive into that topic now. “Let’s look for a hairdresser.”

An hour later, Adora’s hair has changed from dark blond into a medium brown, sandy tone. It looks so perfectly normal and unremarkable that it's almost suspicious. But Catra said, that it’s perfect, and she just accepts it.
Now she sits in an Internet Café and tries to get this computer to work. The girl at the counter just pointed to a free place and left it to her to find out how to how start it. Something in the back of mind finds it funny, that it’s a sign of Russia being a little backwards that it still has internet cafés. 20 years before, there was a short time when these establishments were a sign of being an advanced society that has internet access. They became obsolete as quickly as their rise was with the emerging of cheap internet connections and the corresponding devices. Today, the remaining ones mostly survive by providing additional services like printing or a cool gaming environment.
In this case, Adora is grateful that Russia is not so up to date, because finding an internet café was easy.

Catra dropped her off at a place called ‘Kyber Arena.” Around her, a few older teenagers and young men sit in front of their screens, playing shooters or surfing. Beside the girl at the counter, she’s the only female here, and the boys definitely ignore her. When she was a little younger, she would’ve found that behavior weird and probably upsetting, but today she knows about such insecurities. She grins, and concentrates on what she’s here for. Quickly, she notices the coin slot beside the desktop and puts in two from the coins Catra gave her, alongside with a few notes. The keyboard layout is unfamiliar, but it’s good she reads and

writes Russian, because otherwise, it would be hard to type anything.

Although she wants to know what has become of her friends and if there are any rumors about herself, she avoids any search for her own name. It's unlikely, but not impossible, that internet traffic, and especially search queries, are being monitored whether the traffic is encrypted or not. If the internet café is forced by law to allow a man-in-the-middle attack or simply a spy software on their computers, everything can be scanned in real time. She has no clue if the legal situation has gotten so bad so that the FSB can do that, but given how much the Russian government suppresses any oppositional activities, she wouldn't wonder. Games are certainly not considered a danger. But everything political surely is. Sometimes, in discussions, she's wondering how the country actually ended up in this downward spiral. There was a time when rapprochement with the EU, even under Putin, seemed a no-brainer. But this time is long gone.

The best will be to be fast, brief, and as inconspicuous as possible. She wants to write a mail, and look into her account, but quickly, Adora realizes that without her smartphone, she can't access her normal one due to the two-factor-authentication. Silently groaning and cursing at herself, she gets that has no backup method of access. Such a stupid, trivial mistake. She's tempted to knock her head to the table.

Well, it's probably a good idea to use an anonymous account anyway. After searching around for a minute, she creates a disposable account under the not-so-meaningless name goldenretriever@postilon.mail[30]. If Bow sees it, he'll surely recognize the nickname Glimmer attributed to her one night, when they all were a little drunk and giggling their way through some bars in Brussels. Glimmer teased her for half an hour with the stupid sobriquet, saying that Adora had too much of said energy and just wasn't able to stay out of trouble to save her life. In hindsight, it's a little less funny.

She starts her mail with assuring them that she's alive and well, but mentions her wounding during the air strike briefly, explaining why she wasn't able to write earlier. It shouldn't be a problem to talk about that, because the war and injuries should be a topic many others do, too. Adora carefully stripes the matter that Glimmer shall tell Angella that it wasn't her fault of not being fast enough. She can't make it too blatantly, but if Angella hadn't warned Adora, she would've probably been in the center of the air strike, and dead by now.
Adora then proceeds to tell them that she's in Rostov, and planning to leave the country as soon as possible. Her location is no secret: if the mail is intercepted, they'll know from where it was sent anyway.
"If you have any ideas for a nice travel route, please let me know. It's not that I'm in a hurry, but I'm looking forward to seeing you as soon as possible." She doesn't want to make it too obvious that she's no specific idea of how to flee out of Russia. If they have any suggestions, they'll be clever enough to hide them, too, or direct her into the right direction by using innuendos only they understand.

But what else to say, without making it too obvious who she is? She types some more assuring sentences into the mail, carefully intending of not giving away too many details, and not mentioning that she has help from someone. Even if the Russians probably do not intercept or read the mail, she has to be careful, though. Now, thinking about it, Adora understands that Catra puts herself in danger by helping her, and she still wonders why the woman is doing it.

After sending the mail, she feels a little lighter, leans back and relaxes for a minute. It's good that her friends will be assured that she's alive.
Catra hasn't shown up yet, and it's not that authorities will get here in real time if they find anything suspicious. She also needs a little rest, because the last few hours have been more strenuous than she expected.
Her instinct tells her to move, though, not to be a fixed target and not to spark any attention. But she has to wait for Catra. And

maybe she gets an answer from her friends. Luckily, this geeky place sure is inconspicuous as fuck, but amongst the teenage boys and gamers, she surely stands out. And something to eat would be cool, too.

Usually, she would pretend to be a tourist, visiting the southern metropolis of the Russian Federation. But due to *circumstances*, tourists have become a rare thing today. Western ones are pretty much nonexistent, and the Russians are wary too. The skyrocketing inflation and rising unemployment due to the closure of so many foreign businesses already start to make an impact on the lives of the normal people. And Adora knows that when talked to, she's quickly identified as a foreigner, so she's well advised to keep her head down.

She browses several websites, Russian newspapers as well as Western ones, reading articles about the progress - or rather the standstill - of the war. It's a wonder that some western news sites are still accessible, because since February, Russia has blocked many of them. Another element in the total media control the Russian President exerts over the society of the nation.

All in all, it looks like that since the beginning of the war, the Ukrainian army has focused on taking out the Russian logistics units wherever they could, making the attacking troops vulnerable to shortages of fuel and ammunition. A 15 million Euro tank without gas and rounds is nothing but a large piece of useless scrap, prone to be blown up by a 200.000 Euro anti tank rocket like the Javelin or Panzerfaust 3, of which NATO countries have been shipping thousands to Ukraine for weeks, as far as it's told to the public. That was their major mistake in the first days of this war, and it was discussed extensively.
Not having enough supplies and supply units is either a rookie's mistake, another sign of the miserable planning of this invasion, or it's the clear showing of how much the Russian army is interspersed by corruption, where officers funnel funds meant for tedious tasks like maintenance and rations into shiny villas and a luxurious lifestyle. It shouldn't have surprised anyone, that in a society, where the highest levels of government and economy

exemplify corruption and personal enrichment via state funds, this has also spread far into the military, depriving the army of her capabilities.[31]
It's probably both, and now reality proves, once again, to be a harsh mistress. It also looks like, that finally, in 2022, drones have their first major deployment in a real war in quantities: suicide drones have become an important mean to take out tanks and trucks, especially those who have been separated from their supporting troops. Not only that, but it also looks like if the USA is providing the Ukrainian high command with real time images from their spy satellites.
But three months into this war, even the Russians seem to learn. They have amassed nearly all their mobile troops in the Donbass area and cover everything in advance with artillery before moving in with ground troops. Even the western news outlets don't sound so teasing like a few weeks before. If defenders are outnumbered ten to one, it doesn't matter how motivated they are.
The Ukrainians are winning on the sidelines, and losing on the main front.

But a major advancement is, that the European Commission has granted Ukraine accession candidate status to the Union[32], alongside with the Republic of Moldova, another nation plague by Russian oppression. It's a big step for the country, surely. But what they need right now is something different, given what she reads. And while the West tries to do something to help, it's clearly not enough.

Adora scrolls a few more news, and doesn't dare to log into her other accounts, she doesn't even visit them. Then she gets stuck on an analysis of the war from a Western war economist. It puts a smile on her face.
"Why are you grinning like an idiot?"
Spoken to so out of the blue surprises her a little too much to keep her cool. She flinches, then groans when she realizes who stands beside her booth. "Catra."
"Obviously," the woman casually shrugs, and leans on the table beside hers. "What's up. Have you found some nice headlines?"

Adora keeps her voice low. Everyone around them has huge headphones on, but she doesn't want any attention on them. "Oh, there are several highlights I really like. Do you wanna hear them?"
"No," Catra shakes her head, "Do I have to listen to you?"
"No." But she continues regardless: "I'll tell you anyway. I really like the one where this analyst writes, and I quote, '*Putin shows amateurish improvisation.*' Or '*The Russians are showing 20th century mechanized warfare. It has little to do with high-tech*', and '*The biggest supplier of heavy weapons to the Ukrainians is the Russian army.*' But my personal favorite is still: '*The Russian attack wedge is as wide as the Autobahn*.' It doesn't exactly look like that your *special operation* is going according to plan, huh?"
Adora notices how Catra gets rigid, and she probably senses that she'd been a bit too mouthy.

Catra clenches her fists.
She knows first hand about the mistakes her army makes, but given what they have to work and deal with, they could really do worse. Throughout the first weeks of the war, they have been humiliated on a global, public stage, but that had fewer to do with them and their abilities, but with the political decision makers, mainly, Putin's choice to not inform anyone about his real intention. Being psychologically unprepared to actually invade a foreign country is as detrimental to warfare as outdated equipment or a bad plan is.
But in the meantime, and with a better strategy, their superior quantities of nearly everything, mostly artillery, started to count. Throughout the last weeks, and with the concentration of their efforts on the Donbass region, their advancements are noticeable. Slowly, but steadily, city by city is taken, and Ukraine is giving up territory.
"For the last thirty years, you've forced your culture and manners on us, if we wanted it or not. In another ten years, we might just

be your cultural colony. So don't teach me about that. War isn’t something that goes according to plan. It never does. It’s not like your little intervention in Afghanistan did as well, or is it? History isn’t exactly written by losers.”
Adora shakes her head. “Well, at least there weren’t tens of thousands of men killed in just three months just because someone wanted to resemble a former Tsar.”
It makes Catra laugh: “That’s so ridiculous. You and your pixilated analysts still haven't understood that the man only rattles off such comments to annoy you. That's just gibberish for the masses, but your news jump on this like dogs after the bone. It’s a ruse, a tease. I bet he’s laughing his head off anytime he looks into the news and sees your dumb experts babbling about how much he wants to restore Russia’s ‘former glory’.” She emphasizes it with making question marks with her fingers, then adds. “This is just bullshit talk for the common people who believe such things. But what really happens is, that he’s enlarged our territory step by step, over twenty years, and not a single time have you stupid jerks really stood up to him. You just went ahead and bought our gas. As far as I’m concerned, you’re all hypocrites. As long as your fuel was cheap, you always looked the other way, didn’t you?”

Given Adora’s big eyes upon her outbreak, she realizes that their little argument has gotten out of hand. But torn between her own considerations about the uselessness of this war and putting this arrogant idiot into her place, she just couldn’t stop herself. And given what she knows about Adora’s background by now, it’s not a surprise that the woman is well-informed about how this war goes on and can put the information pieces together quickly.
She doesn’t want to apologize, but it’s a surprise that Adora backs off herself.
“I’m sorry. I didn’t want to make you feel… we… we should probably change the topic.”
Adora’s obviously uncomfortable, but Catra can’t help but to feel happy about the small victory, and to follow with another tease: “That’s the first clever sentence leaving your mouth today.” Why is she like this?

Luckily, Adora just rolls her eyes and doesn't fight back. Instead, she asks: "What do we do now?"
"We have a some time left before we can go to the hotel," Catra says, then she looks around, and a thought hits her, letting her grin mischievously. It's probably not her best idea, given their argument, but…
She points at the gaming younglings around them. "How about if we try and play a little?"
Adora looks at her surprised. "Are you serious? You wanna… play video games? Now?"
"What? It keeps us off the street." She shrugs and plops into the seat next to Adora. "Or don't you have the guts for a competition?"
Adora's eyes narrow to small slots, piercing her. Catra already knew that the woman is competitive. She unlocks the computer with some coins, flips a few more to Adora, takes the controller and fires up the Gaming Hub. "What do you wanna play?"
It's ridiculous how easy Adora's into this, but she does the same on her computer and scrolls through some categories, until her eyes seem to land on a choice. She points at it. "Skywards!"[33]
Catra laughs. "Really? You wanna play sky fighting in an X-Wing against me? Okay, your choice." She doesn't tell Adora that she played this game before. It's been a few years, the game is not the newest, but it still holds up and has a fantastical way of handling aerodynamics paired with space tactics.
They start and play a few rounds in training mode individually, before entering combat mode. When Catra peeks onto Adora's screen, it becomes clear, that they both know what they do. Adora is actually a little cute, with the tip of her tongue sticking out while she concentrates during her maneuvers. Catra wonders how this would feel on—
"What mode?", she asks, deeply in need to distract herself from certain thoughts, and because the training parkour has ended, they enter the combat arena.

"Ring race," Adora replies immediately, while already selecting her fighter. In this mode, each player has to steer a fighter through five rings in a race of three rounds. If a ring is missed, it doesn't

count as a point. The player with the most one wins. What makes it challenging is that there's much debris in the form of falling asteroids coming from the sky. The fighters have shields to compensate to that, but only so much. The gameplay has always been easy to learn, but difficult to master. Only a handful of times she got 15 points. Today, she'll be content with 12 or 13. Catra sees that Adora chooses a well-armored, maneuverable racer with the largest amount of shield power. For herself, she selects a speedy one. With this flier, she can be so fast that plenty of the falling rubble will miss her because she'll be through before it even gets in her way. On the other hand, one big hit will take her out immediately. It's a risky strategy, but it can work.
"Ok, show me what you have," Catra says, and lets Adora start the first round.

It turns out that Adora is really skilled. A little too much for Catra's taste, even. Also turns out, that both of them have fun while teasing and taunting each other while they race. "Skywards" has no bullshit like "Levels". Instead, it quickly adapts to the skill of the pilot while playing, and challenges him to his limits. This makes every round, every fight, every battle a hard one: you learned how to evade this certain falling rock? How about if we put another right behind it, directly into your line? Ah, look, how beautiful they explode and scatter debris right into your propulsion drive now. Oh no, did that hurt? Let's try again! What's that? A smoke bomb hiding an obstacle right behind? What a pity!

In return, Adora's style is very straightforward, without frills and elegance. She doesn't dwell on the finer points of dodging smaller debris. The woman simply barrels through them, and given her shield power, she can. Catra has never seen such a style in this game, but she quietly admits that this kind of confident aggressiveness is goddam sexy.
The game throws a smaller debris into Adora's path, trying to nudge her off course, and the woman just punches her way through it, heading for the next ring. She's rather like a warrior with a broadsword. Simultaneously, she looks so sexy that Catra feels the attraction tugging inside her, and she can't take her eyes

off of her.
Adora is absolutely adorable, with her belly laugh when she makes a point, and her kid grin when she evades a larger piece, and with her lovely bluebell eyes that keep shooting this teasing glances at her in the little moments when nothing happens. Catra realizes that… Goddess, she'd been such an idiot to run away when they first met. Scorpia was absolutely right: they could've ended in bed if she hadn't been such an idiot.

Their contest continues to the third round.
There, Adora changes her tactic, much to Catra's surprise. Her fighter sits at the start of the race ring, and she lets Catra's craft pass.
"What?", Catra scoffs, "Now you wanna watch how to do it right?"
A smug smirk appears on Adora's face. "Well kitty? Afraid?"
Ok then, Catra thinks, she wants to know how I'm doing. Not dumb, Blondie's obviously a quick learner. Then she just flies past Adora and through the first ring, evades a lot of debris by going full speed and bolting through the course before it reaches her, hits the second one and then adds the third, the difficult one to her gains, too. Unfortunately, she's so happy about this win that she misses the last two, and ends up with twelve points. A groan escapes her as she leans back. But it's a good result. The problem is that Adora has already ten points, and one round left to go. Given what Catra already saw, she'll easily fetch another three points and win this.
And that can't happen. No way this arrogant western girl, this stupid idiot, this beautifully smiling… ugh, stop!

A terrible idea comes to Catra's mind.

She pushes the thrust button and her fighter jumps forward til she's at full speed, heading after Adora's ship. The blonde's fighter is at the third ring, and she has already gathered her fucking thirteen points. How dare she! And of course, she wants to rub her success into Catra's face and goes for the last two rings to make it perfect. 15 points? That's impossible. Fueled by a mixture of anger and arousal, she instinctively forces her fighter in a hairraising curve through the fourth ring and is right behind

Adora, catching up way too fast to stop her from…
"What are you doing?" Adora screams and Catra just grins. Then she rams her ship into Adora's, overloading both their shields and blowing them up to ash. They explode in bright light. The game is finished. A tie.
"WHAT?" Adora yells, throws her controller onto the table and is nearly jumping her seat, but immediately falls back with a hand on her side. Catra raises her hands in mock defeat, and grins broadly. "How's it hanging over there?"

"Oh man!"
"Shit shit shit."
"Yeah, what a bitch."

Only now they get that several of the other gamers, mostly teenage boys, stand around, looking at them in shock and awe.
"Wow," one of them lets out. "That was so mean," and a tall boy with glasses, maybe 18 years old, turns to Catra and asks: "How did you come up with that? I never even thought it was possible to kill another player in this mode!"
Catra basks a little in the praise, even if they're just boys. It's funny that nearly no one gets it. Of course, she can't admit that it was pure chance she found out that move was even possible.
"You always have to think outside the box, if you want to defeat a superior enemy."
Adora jumps on it, turning and pointing with her finger into Catra's face. "So you admit you would've lost if you played fair!"
"No. I admit that I used the possibilities the game provided and looked for options where you wouldn't. The rules weren't against it, so it's allowed." She grins broadly, feeling great, despite Adora's complaints.
"I can't believe it. You cheated to not let me win, really? That's low, even for you."
"Awww. Nothing's too low for me."
Watching Adora rolling her eyes is something she could get used to. The proper idiot looks cute when doing this.
"Come on, don't pout. I make it up to you with dinner, okay?"
Catra lets it sound accommodating, because she has her win.
Adora huffs: "You wanna cook? Can you even do that?"

“Of course not, because I don’t wanna poison you after I just saved your life twice. No, there’s a place I think you're gonna like.”

It’s gotten a little silent while they walk. Adora also looks tired, and Catra sympathizes with her. But she still has to endure a little. Organizing the room was actually quite easy, but the fact of keeping Adora's presence there out of the books makes it more difficult to just turn up there. They have to wait until the chief receptionist gets off work, so her contact can hand the key out unnoticed. For a little extra fee. It’s like always: everyone fucks everyone in this country.

“Would you mind telling me what happened yesterday? It didn’t go according to your plan, or did it?”, Adora suddenly asks.
Catra sighs, but well, she might owe Adora an explanation. “No, it didn’t. Just ten minutes after we parted, I got a callback to the camp for a meeting of the commanders. I can’t tell you what it was about, but it went on for three hours, and afterwards, I had to stick around for briefings and stuff. I couldn’t leave till midnight, and by that time I guessed you would’ve found something for the night. It would’ve been suspicious if I left by then, too.”
This is as close as she will come to an apology for how it went, even if she was worrying about Adora. And she didn’t tell everything that happened. There’s no use in ruining this okay evening.
“What? Are you being surveilled?”
“No.” Probably not. “But of course it’s noticed when I leave the camp. I have to be available all time, if I don’t take a leave.”
“Hmm, I see,” is all Adora says, and Catra wonders why the woman is so accepting.

It’s no long walk to the river shore.
Rostov isn’t nearly as beautiful as cities of similar size in Western Europe. It lacks the mass of impressive buildings which the monarchies of the past scattered all around their lands, to the

detriment of their contemporaries, but the delight of their descendants. That may have much to do with the fact, that Rostov was never a seat of government and therefore, no monarch felt obliged to build plenty of splendorous buildings here. But even Rostov has nice sites. This becomes clear to Adora, as they walk down a crowded pedestrian zone, a street called '*Sobornyy Pereulok*' with many retail stores, restaurants and offices in three-storey-buildings on both sides. The street heads straight for a large open place with a magnificent Orthodox church, with its iconic golden onion domes. At their side, a narrow street with many small market stalls offer goods, mostly aimed at tourists.
It doesn't look like business is particularly good these days. Catra drags Adora past a few stands selling food, and, upon Adora's hesitation to leave them behind, she says: "I know you're hungry. Hang in there a little longer. I have a surprise for you."
"Is it that obvious?", Adora laughs quietly, but also admits that it's true. She's been hungry the entire day, nearly since her breakfast, which feels like it's been forever.
"You look like you're about to rip that guy's burger right out of his hand", Catra grins, and it's true. Adora hasn't even recognized how she stared at the food Catra pointed out so well, and the brunette adds: "We'll be right there."

They round the cathedral and dive into one of the small streets leading south, walking past a postman still carrying out letters on a bike loaded with pockets full of post. Adora gives him an uneasy look, then quietly says to Catra: "Even your postal officers look like the Gestapo[34] today. But I'm sure that's just a coincidence."
Catra rolls her eyes. Not everything has to do with anything, and this comparison is outright stupid. But she doesn't want to go into it, because she wants them to be in a light mood when they reach her goal, and beside her, Adora has fallen silent again and is looking at the ground. It seems, that all their conversations have always a certain topic lingering in the background, and that's what will finally keep them apart.
Well, there's nothing to be done about that, and so they walk for another five minutes.

The sun is about to set, as they come to a halt, and Catra says: "Let me introduce you to one of our amenities. Tadaa!"
Pointing at the building they just approached, she gets that Adora notices something familiar. The structure in front of them is two stories high and looks a bit like a former railway station. It's made of red bricks and with high arched, slim windows. A rooftop terrace sits left and right of the entrance gateway, and the signs are so…
It takes Adora a second to register that the letters aren't Cyrillic. "Oh! It's German," then she reads loudly, "Weisses Brauhaus." [35]
Despite Adora's German accent sounds a bit odd to her, Catra complacently grins back while the pretty sight of the smiling blonde is sending many butterflies into her stomach. They approach the entrance of the restaurant, walking up a few stairs, then Catra bows invitingly, pointing with her arm to the door: "How about some German cuisine. A little bit of home?"
Adora laughs. "Wow. That's… awesome!"
"Let's try it out then," Catra seconds, and opens the door.

An hour later, it's clearly the best feeling Adora has since, well, weeks. It's warm, like when a friend calls and the conversation goes effortlessly over hours, leaving you with nothing but satisfaction. And well, Germany isn't exactly her home, but she has lived in the country for so long that this place sparks an alike feeling. And of course, with her appetite, Adora admires German cuisine.
Across of her, on the other couch, Catra has leaned back, an arm draped over the backrest, and watches her with amusement. "Wow. This is like watching a pack of wolves feasting on their prey. The poor shrimps." She laughs, then sips on her drink.
"What," muffles Adora, continuing to stuff herself with another grilled delicacy. "You have no idea how great it is to have something to eat again. And this is really good."
Now, Catra has one elbow propped on the armrest, leans into her

palm, and with that little smile on her face, she looks outright cute.
Adora’s one millimeter away from voicing that, but she knows she should not. She’s just glad that Catra is helping and no longer mad at her. At least, it looks like that. The evening is actually nice. That doesn’t mean that they can continue where… no, it doesn’t mean that.
She would, Adora realizes, while finishing her dish. She totally would continue where they stopped, back then. Swallowing down, she wipes her mouth with a napkin, and leans back to give herself a little time to digest. To support that, and to buy her some time before she says something stupid, she takes a big sip from the wheat beer both of them ordered.

Okay, Catra maybe right: her plates looks like a carnage, but their entire meal was just great. Maybe her judgement is clouded because it’s the first time she has eaten so well since weeks, but the food is actually good here. ‘Don't burp now’, she admonishes herself, and, for a distraction, she takes in the vista of the bustling street and waterfront promenade they can look over from the terrace.
Little reminds of the raging war that happens only half a day trip from here. Despite a state of emergency has been declared for Southern Russia and the state of economy is already in a bad shape, people still go out here, wandering along the promenade, meeting with friends and business partners. Even this restaurant is well attended, although not full.
Clearly, Rostov, as the largest city and the cultural center of the south, is home to enough wealthy citizens, that even a nearby war and a looming economic breakdown hasn’t yet dampened the mood or a larger impact on the well-heeled. Rostov is a metropolis, and people are filling the restaurants along the promenade, even in times like this. The seemingly carefree attitude of all of them is absolutely contradictory to Adora’s entire experiences of the last weeks.

At the public place over the street, lively fountains splash water onto the pavement, and a few young people hang around there, with skateboards. Ah, there is - or rather has been - a McDonald's,

but now it’s closed. It's perhaps the clearest sign and reminder of the current situation, and it's honestly pretty trivial. The place is just closed, and that’s it. People actually can live without McDonald’s, huh?

Over the street, she sees the broad river Don, ponderously rolling through the city, parting it in two unequal pieces. The major part lies at the northern bank, only some business parks and the industrial harbor are on the south. For some geographers and decision makers, this river a frontier, the border between Europe and Asia. From her comfortable chair on the rooftop terrace, surrounded by the chatter of people enjoying the summery evening and where she now sips on her drink, she sees nothing of it. It’s just a river, making the city a whole tad more beautiful.
“And Quiet Flows the Don” comes to her mind, a four-part novel she once read, dealing with the life of the untamed Cossacks during the times of the Russian Civil War around the October Revolution, in the end times of the Great War. Till today, the melancholic, Nobel-Prize-winning story, telling the events of the time through political, military, civilian and - most important - romantic lenses shapes the view on Russia. Adora read it five years ago, and still the story sticks in her mind.

Her gaze wanders back to the woman across from her, who is busy spooning up her dessert. Catra looks nearly relaxed. Again, she feels that connection, the draw to touch her, to be touched by her.
If it weren’t for the circumstances, this would be the perfect date. Catra is so cool, in her black leather jacket, with the curly mane, her battered leather boots, and now she licks the spoon like a… cat.
This is just too funny. Adora breaks out in laughter, it just bubbles out of her chest.
“What?” Catra asks, frowning, still with the spoon in her hand. She looks a bit caught.
“It’s nothing”, Adora tries to assure her, but she’s such a bad liar.
“Spill it!”, Catra insists.
“I can’t, really. It was just a silly thought,” she desperately tries to fight it off.

“Coward!”
It’s pretty dumb that the tease manages to get a rise out of her. But it works. “I'm not!”
“Pfft. Coward!”
“You were licking the spoon like…”
“Like what?”
“Like a cat,” Adora muffles, and she can feel how her face turns pink.
Catra raises her hand to call for a waiter: “Check please! My companion is an idiot.”
Adora breaks out in laughter, while Catra tries again to get the attention of someone, waving with her hand excitedly.
"Oh, come on," Adora smirks and Catra lowers her hand. "This is revenge," she states, then takes Adora's drink and downs the rest of the still half-full glass.

The evening goes by, and as the sun slowly travels down to the horizon, sets and finally vanishes in the west by bathing everything in a warm glow, it has seen the women amicably talking about whatever for hours. Again and again, their drinks have been refilled, a basket of small Pretzels has been too, and now small tealights and softly glowing lamps illuminate the scenery.
They have fallen into a steady back and forth of joking and telling stories about their past, their teenage years, their education and the beginning of their careers or whatever you call becoming a war correspondent and a doctor in the military. Instinctively, they avoid events from the present and recent time, because they know that that might touch sensitive ground and spark arguments they don’t want right now. Adora doesn’t want Catra to blow up again about the war - or their first encounter - and Catra doesn’t want to make Adora fear that she’s doing exactly that. It’s a precious balance they keep without speaking about it, but rather by dancing around delicate topics.

But it also doesn’t linger in the front of their mind, as they tell each other stupid stuff. And funnily, everything is just easy between them. Catra has just finished a long, elaborated rant about a time when she had to work with a colleague who wasn’t

able to orientate herself because she always got distracted so easily with any tech given to her. “One time, I had to pull her out of a sewer because she got lost in tracking down supplies she should find. She was full of dirt and rubble and man, did she stink. It was awesome - well, awesome in a scary, disgusting way.”
She has accentuated her telling with many gestures and arm waving, and Adora giggles upon the lively telling and returns a story of a time she helped Glimmer persuading a friend of hers joining her party.
Catra can’t believe it. “You have a friend called Glitter? That’s so *you*. It’s the manifestation of everything that’s wrong with your society!”
“Her name’s Glimmer!”, Adora insists.
“Yeah, whatever. As if that’s any better. In my country, women have strong and proud names like Aleksandra, Waleria or Jekaterina. Not this princessy stuff.” To punctuate her argument, she pounds on her chest with a fist.
“Is that where your nickname comes from,” Adora asks, “Ekaterina?”
Catra smirks at her amused and in Adora’s mind, it makes her even more beautiful. “Oh, you’ll never find out.” And they both forget that Catra already told Adora her name the first day they met. “But don’t let me wait, you puppy. How did this sparkly story turn out?” She laughs mischievously, snickering to herself about the tease, about showing her knowledge in English, and Adora can’t help but to smile back at her. She’s just not able to be mad at the pretty, alluring woman. It’s like Catra is not really herself tonight, not so grating and gruffy as usual, but in a laid-back mood, not worrying about… well, whatever she usually worries about when she looks at her so grumpy.

Maybe it’s just the alcohol.
But it makes Adora hoping that they, maybe, can return to a time when they were… well, kissing each other.
Ok, that won’t happen, because Catra is just helping her to get away and to not be captured by the authorities, by this creepy guy.
Not because she actually likes her.

But it’s a nice thought and a nice evening nevertheless.
Again, Catra makes a joke, Adora laughs, they sip their drinks and fall into another conversation about a time when they were both younger, and not so scarred from life. It's easy to pretend to be a more lighthearted version of yourself when the person looking at you does this with such a smile.

Interestingly, the idea applies to both.

The evening ends on a kind yet awkward note.
It’s past midnight, and the restaurant is finally about to close, Adora has completely lost her sense of time, but as they walk out on the street, she notices how tired she is. The conversation with Catra kept her awake, but now the struggles of this and the recent days really shows. She yawns.
“Pussy!”, Catra says grinning.
“Hey, I haven’t had a good night of rest since… well… it’s been a while,” Adora defends herself, then adding with blank teeth: “And my doctor said I need to rest.”
Catra nods, obviously only a little convinced by wiggling her head left and right: “She didn’t order you to be a wimp.”
“Don’t be rude. I wanna see how you handle that in my situation. However, I think it’s time to sleep.”
“I’ll take you there. Still have to fetch the room key from the guy at the reception,” Catra says. “Otherwise, you’ll probably be kidnapped or fall into the river.”

Adora says nothing. She’s grateful for the company. They take a route alongside the river for a few minutes, until they have to head into the city. In the nightly atmosphere, it mostly looks like in any major city of any country, but there are also little differences, making it clear she isn’t in the west.
Everything is a little too old. The cars. The signs. Clothes people wear. The buildings. The onion spires of the churches have already made it known that they are in an Orthodox country. It’s familiar and it’s also not. But that isn’t frightening. What’s frightening is, that this nation is in an undeclared war with half the world, with the half she wants to return to, and to which nearly all connections have been cut off. She has to pass a border

to be able to return to friendly territory, and one mistake will let her be captured by the FSB. She doesn't want to end up in a show trial.
When they reach the road where they have to leave the promenade, Adora takes a moment to lean over the railing beside her, and takes in the sight of the nightly stream, letting it calm her. Catra stands behind her, then takes a place at her side. She says nothing.

Two things are clear to Adora.
She knows she needs Catra's help, and admits it to herself with a heavy heart. Asking for help was something Adora had never been good at.
She also knows she doesn't want to let go of Catra yet. Not only because Catra is the only person she can perhaps trust here, no. It's rather that she knows, when they part for good, she will probably never see Catra again. And that thought makes her restless.

"Oh my goodness, just ask me!"
Catra's voice cuts through her ruminating and Adora startles. The brunette stands beside her, now leaning at the railing too, arms crossed and with an unnerved expression on her face. Adora feels caught and yet, she can't voice what she wants to say. There's something impeding her. "I don't know what you mean," she pretends, unconvincingly for everyone taking part in this odd conversation.
Catra expression morphs into a smirk. "You want to ask me for help, just admit it."
"I didn't say anything," Adora retorts, not half as firm as she wants to.
"It's written all over your face. Why can't you admit that you need help?"
It takes her a few seconds to reply, because asking for help is something Adora has seldom done. She helps, and it's not the other way around. Yet, the situation is like it is, and even if Catra hasn't offered it… or has she? She could've said nothing, but she…

“Would you?” It’s a quiet question, from a woman looking into the dark river.
“No,” Catra states firmly, with seriousness, arms crossed, looking down on her even if she’s a tad smaller than her, not giving away any emotion. Both women stare at each other, and Adora is about to throw her hands into the air and to groan loudly, when she notices the mischievous glistening in the corner of Catra’s eyes lighten up.
“Oh, you fucking bastard! How can you be so— Ugh!” Now she throws her hands up to vent her anger.
Catra bursts out laughing, pats a knee with her hand, and has to hold her stomach. “You should’ve seen your face!”
Adora rolls her eyes, but then, slowly, admitting that Catra’s laugh is contagious - and so beautiful - she starts giggling herself, and for a short time, both of them giggle like little girls, and the nightly, moody atmosphere at the river bank gets somewhat relaxed. This lasts just as long until Catra puts her hand on Adora's arm and says: “This is not because I like you. But I’m helping you. You won't get 100 kilometers without me. I will…”

Catra says more words, but Adora registers exactly none of them. She only feels the hand of the woman, laying on her forearm. The last time Catra’s touch felt so invigorating was when they met first, two years ago, when she traced her upper arms and her neck with her bewitching tangency and made Adora so washy that she lost it. Of course, the kissing contributed to that too, but now it’s nearly the same. Adora’s eyes are about to pop out, she looks down at Catra’s hand, which is still lying on her forearm. She wants to lay down her own hand onto Catra’s - just as a gesture of thanking her, surely - but the moment she starts moving her other arm to reach out, Catra withdraws. Maybe she hasn’t noticed how stupefied she made her? Or maybe she had, and is embarrassed about Adora’s childish, immature reaction?
Now, Catra takes a step back, and Adora misses the touch already.

They’ve reached the hotel, and without any comment, Catra accompanies her into her room after she obtained the key from the receptionist. Having her here, so close, in the nightly

atmosphere, all kinds of thoughts go through Adora's head, mostly stupid ones.
But Catra obviously is in a different mood. After making sure that all the curtains are well closed, she turns back to Adora, and shatters any stupid idea she might've had about what could've, should've, would've happen here.
"Look, I should probably go back to the camp. I didn't file for absence tonight, and I'm on duty tomorrow morning, so I'll be back by noon," the woman says, and there's an edge to her voice Adora can't interpret. "We're going to plan how to get you out of here. Don't do anything stupid till I'm back, okay? Not playing the hero for anyone here, do you understand? If you need anything to eat and drink, order it from the room service, but don't leave the room!"

The relaxed atmosphere has faded as Adora settles down on the edge of the bed. "I'm not going anywhere," then she pats the mattress. "Actually, I can use a handful of sleep. The last days haven't been very restful."
"Good." Catra acknowledges while fumbling at her jacket, adding, "Otherwise, that would have been a doctor's order."
"Don't worry. I'll be in bed as soon as you're out of here."
Again, Catra pierces her a little too long with that strange look she can't interpret. For a moment Adora has the distinct feeling that she should reach out, should beg Catra to stay a little longer, because then they could do… hell, she has no idea what they could do, but before she's able to finish her stupid overthinking, the woman across of her just nods. "See you tomorrow. Good night, Adora."
While she zips her jacket, Adora still feels the pull to hold her back, to take her by her arm and let herself be touched another time. Yet, she does nothing of it, she just sits at the edge of the bed and watches Catra leaving the room, quietly closing the door from outside.

The silence and sudden solitude leaves Adora in a weird state. As she looks around in the small room, she gets that she didn't realize how soothing Catra's presence in here really was. Now that she's gone, Adora feels a stronger loneliness than the days before,

in the park or the hospital or even the orangery.
With a sigh, she pulls herself together, goes to the door and locks it, then puts a stool under the door handle for a little more additional protection. It's not much, but it might give her a few seconds. Just in case. If Hordak Suchorow picks up where she is, there's not much she can do, anyway. He's surely still out there, searching for her. Jumping out of the window maybe possible, but as she peeks out - after switching the light off - it looks a little too high for that.

She closes the curtain, and in the darkness of the room, with the only light stemming from an emergency exit sign, the bed looks very tempting.
Adora decides to stick to her promise to Catra, and getting a handful of sleep will be the most clever thing to do anyway. She undresses herself, takes a short shower to clean herself thoroughly, then puts on boy shorts out of the bag Catra left her. They are white, with a black waistband and black stripes around the legs. Not super fancy, but they look good. She doesn't put on a bra because she wants to steam out a little from the shower, and it's not that she needs one, the more when she's alone. Looking down on her chest, then into the mirror, her tits looks really fine. But when her gaze wanders up to her face, she notices the lines under her eyes, and how gaunt she got. The last weeks have taken a toll on her, that's undeniable.
Her whole figure has become a bit more angular and the always clearly defined muscles have diminished. A clear lack of training, due to her injury. "I've to pick up my exercises again," Adora cautions herself. "But not today. Tomorrow." She can admit that much to herself after these long and tiring days. Another night of rest for her wound will do her good, too.
She turns off the light in the bathroom and sits on the bed, flipping through the TV while shuffling to get comfortable.

Zapping through some TV channels makes it clear that Russian state TV is everywhere - and barely anything else. Even Dozhd[36], the last independent, critical channel, ceased broadcasting since beginning of March. All the other channels are state-owned, some

of them have entertainment shows on, but she's not interested in them. 'Russia Today' catches her attention when a moderator talks about a statement Margarita Simonjan, editor-in-chief of Rossija Sewodnja - Russia Today - made in 2018. "Margarita said that before the last presidential election, Vladimir Vladimirovich was simply our president and could be replaced. Now he is our leader. And we will not allow him to be replaced. And that sums it up very well. Tonight, we speak about the unity of the people and our leader, who has done a remarkable job of leading Russia for two decades, and restoring the glory—"

Adora groans, turns off the device and falls onto her back. She just can't stand that kind of propaganda, of devious, malicious parroting of populist talking points, and the indoctrination coming with it. Even the wording makes her shiver: "The unity of the people and the leader." It's unbelievable that such a phrase can be used in the 21st century, and in Russia!
Because anyone with a decent knowledge about history knows that saying. Everyone in her adopted country is educated about it pretty well. "The unity of the people and the leader, my ass", Adora headshakingly repeats. In German and around 80 years ago ´, they called it "Führerprinzip" - Fuehrers Principle - which means nothing less than the unrestricted authority of Adolf Hitler on every institution of the German state during the time of National Socialism. The Fuehrer's power was comprehensive and total; it united in itself all the means of political organization; it extends to all the material spheres of national life; it embraces all the comrades of the people who are bound to loyalty and obedience to the Fuehrer."[37]
And regarding that, it's just the same with Putin. During the last 20 years, he removed any opposition and encircled himself with a cadre of loyal, parroting liegemen. And when a nation is constantly fueled with mindless indoctrination like that, it feels like bygone times are being resurrected.

Over her ruminating, she hasn't noticed how her eyes fell shut in the dark room, and just a minute later, she's fallen asleep. Into her dreams, a pair of golden and turquoise eyes follow her.

Author's note: Sorry that I had to put my footnotes in here, because they exceeded the character limit in the chapter end notes of AO3. I have no idea why there is such a stupid thing as character limits to footnotes.

[24]Sergey Beseda is, or perhaps was, head of the Fifth Service of the FSB. This part of the agency is responsible for counterintelligence and mainly targeted Russia's direct neighbors in recent years. Beseda was tasked with gathering information in Ukraine, but seemingly failed to report according to reality. As a long comrade of Putin, he has been in this position as of 2009, but in March 2022, he was reportedly arrested and probably imprisoned as of April 2022. Other sources say, he's untouchable. Yet, around 150 FSB officials have probably been dismissed and put under accusation of providing misleading information to the government or working with foreign agencies.↑

[25]The UAZ 469B, in some newer versions named "Tigr", is an equivalent to an US army jeep, thus a light off-road military vehicle, manufactured by UAZ since Soviet times, and has been modernized several times. The vehicles are still widespread in service, and some versions are also still in production. It was and is produced in the tens of thousands and spread across all armies of the Warsaw Pact and their successors.↑

[26] SWIFT, the Society for Worldwide Interbank Financial Telecommunication, located in Belgium, is a cooperative society and provides a secure telecommunication network for the execution of financial transactions between banks. It's the worldwide de facto standard for payments between banks. Without access to SWIFT, a bank is basically cut off from transferring money to other banks. There are a few competitors to

SWIFT, mainly sponsored by nations like China, India and Russia for inland use, but also to bypass sanctions. Around 40 trillion Euros are transferred day-by-day via SWIFT. Legally secure payment across national borders is practically only possible with SWIFT.↑

[27] Частный ~ Private ↑

[28] Kascha is a kind of porridge made of buckwheat boiled with milk or water, enriched with butter, sugar or salt. It's a common breakfast or supplement.↑

[29] Stoy! ~ Stop! Nemedlenno ostanovis'! ~ Stop immediately! ↑

[30] "Postilon" is the Russian word for Postman. ↑

[31] It looks like that western analysts have - due to lack of deeper on-site information and relying too much on misinformation - for long overestimated the current capabilities of the Russian Armed Forces. Only now there's widespread reconsideration. Especially the shortcoming in logistics and proper training of conscripts sent into this war is conspicuous, and tell much about how "good" this operation was prepared. ↑

[32] If you wanna know how this looks like, here is the 30 page document describing it. Joining the European Union is a highly formalized process with many requirements to be met by the applicant. If you look at the basic data provided from page 24 on, and compare it with the medium European ones, it's pretty clear there's still a long way to go for the country. ↑

[33] The name and this entire scene draws inspiration from Brandon Sanderson's book of the same name. While I'm not his greatest fan, these books are very good. Give Spensa a try. She's a brave and very funny hero. ↑

[34] Gestapo is an abbreviation for "Geheime Staatspolizei", "Secret State Police", and was formed in 1933 out of former police units of Prussia after the Nazis took control over Germany. They started to fill the ranks with their own, mostly young and highly educated, motivated companions. The Gestapo became an important force to drive the Nazi agenda forward and to take control over the entire state and society by the suppression of any resistance. It was declared a criminal organization after the war. ↑

[35] This location actually exists, and I'm having a hilarious time

exploring their website. ↑
[36] Since its founding in 2014, Dozhd has been mostly broadcasting news, discussions, culture, politics, business reports, and documentaries in live shows. As of March 2022, the Russian government has blocked access to Dozhd, based on the new law that prohibits calling the Russian invasion of Ukraine anything else than a "Special Military Operation". Dozhd has ceased operating after that, but tries to it pick up again from Latvia in June 2022.↑
[37] So far the unaltered, actual description of a leading German jurist, Ernst Rudolf Huber, who provided legal underpinning for the Nazi regime. Habilitated in 1931, he published important legal works and had the following opinion on personal rights of the individual: "In particular, the liberty rights of the individual (...) are not compatible with the principle of the 'Völkisches Recht' (People's Law). There is no personal, pre-state and extra-state freedom of the individual to be respected by the state." He supported the Nuremberg Laws of 1935 and taught law at several German universities until 1945. He was expelled from it after 1945, but it is a shame and disgrace that such a person was allowed a professorship in 1957 again until his retirement. ↑

Chapter End Notes

> This chapter got out of hand, regarding the time it needed and the length. It could've needed more editing, and I should've probably split it, but then again, I took it as a challenge.
> The longer this war goes on, the more I'm convinced that the Russian's will lose it badly on a strategical level. Territorial gains over the next weeks until summer are likely, but with the continuing retrogradation of the Russian economy into the nineties, while Ukraine is constantly supplied with military high-tech and money from the west, the tides will inevitably turn at some point. All of this depends, of course, on the willingness of the West to supply the country as long as this war goes on. Russia has bombarded most of Ukrainian facilities needed for production of war material, and the country is running out of money. But, as the Russian GDP

(1,5 tn) isn’t even on par with Italy (2 tn), a relatively small part of the NATO GDP (> 35 tn) would be sufficient to bleed Russia out. The medium-term main risk is that the West loses interest, with the result of an unresolved stalemate, frozen by a ceasefire. But even then, Russia would be an outlaw for a long time, marginalized and slowly left behind. In 20 years, it will be a shadow of its former self.
Here is a rather entertaining video of the Infographics Show that pinpoints heavy mistakes a professional, modern army should not make at all. The video is clearly more watchable than the dry reports I’m reading to support that, too.

Georgia?

Chapter Summary

Catra is distracted by Adora's tits and forms a half-baked plan.
Adora gets drunk and discovers Entrapta's little secrets.
Both meet unexpected obstacles.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Loud knocking wakes Adora.
The light of a bright day falls around the opaque curtains, and dimly lits the room. It must be morning – late morning, even. Hastily, Adora flaps the bedspread back. Somehow she must have wrapped herself in it during the night, because she can't remember that she actually readied herself for bed.
But now it's knocking again and there's no time for anything.
"It's me. Open!"
A little part of her had feared that the woman wouldn't return today. She recognizes that, because Catra's voice is unexpectedly soothing and exciting at the same time. Jumping out of the bed, she pulls open the curtain, and is at the door with two, three steps. She puts the chair to the side and pushes down the handle to open the door.

A grave mistake, she realizes just a moment too late.

Before her stands Catra, and stares at her, seemingly stunned. A single word tumbles out of the woman's mouth, who's holding a paper bag in one hand and a coffee in the other one.
"Wow!"
Adora blinks and rubs sleep from her eyes. She's not fully awake yet, because sleeping for apparently ten hours or so is something she's done maybe four or five times in her entire life. A clear sign of how exhausted she was, and probably still is. Her body needed

it, sure, but now she needs a moment to collect and turn on her gears. What was Catra saying?
The woman before her looks frozen.
“What’s up?”, she asks, and it shakes Catra out of her stupor.
“I mean: Wow! What a sight. Whatever you’re selling, I’ll buy it from the naked lady in the front row.”

In her daze, Adora realizes only now that she’s as good as naked and still has only the boy shorts on, that her boobs are on full display, and before she can do anything, Catra adds smugly: “I knew the shorts would look good on you, but I never dreamed they would look this good. Admit it, my taste in clothes is great. But you’d be doing great without them, too.”
Then she leans against the doorframe with the widest grin ever seen and enjoys herself pretty obviously.

Embarrassment is a very mild description for the feeling running through Adora. She squeaks and jumps back two paces, then turns around and frantically searches for something to put on. She notices the gray T-Shirt Catra gave her yesterday, hanging over the chair, grabs and quickly slips into it.
Behind her, she can hear Catra closing the door and when she turns to her, Adora sees the woman is still looking at the door, probably shaking with quiet snickering.
“Thank you, you can turn around now,” she assures her, a little relieved.
Catra still has a wide smirk on her face when she does. “No, I thank you. That was a sight to behold.”

Adora rolls her eyes, but doesn’t reply anything. She’s not good at getting compliments on her looks, never has been. The analytical part of her mind is aware that she’s pretty, but she never put enough attention to it to take any advantage of. But Catra states it so casually, so forward, that it does something to her, and lets her feel a bit more relaxed, and not so self-conscious anymore. She doesn’t even bother to slip into a pair of pants immediately, on the contrary, she runs into the bathrooms first, right past Catra. And given the reaction she sees from the corner of her eyes, she just knows the woman is looking on her butt.

Hehe.
Adora knows her butt is great, but then again, it's nothing important, not in her mindset. Behind the closed door, she looks into the mirror with wide eyes and grins at herself with a mixture of reluctance and self-assessment. The surprise is gone, and after yesterday's realization of how haggard she got, Catra's reaction is reassuring, even if she has no idea what to do with it, not with the woman's oscillating behavior. Again, she takes in her sight in the mirror, and wonders what Catra might see in her, even more so when she compares it with the one from two years ago, the younger, prettier, not so tired-looking version of herself. It's not that she got unsightly, not at all, but the lines that the last two years, and especially the last few weeks, have drawn on her face and body are unmistakable, and maybe they showed up to stay. She's not twenty anymore.
Well, enough of the pointless behavior of a lecherous teenager, and all these confused, mixed feelings. They have work to do and plans to make, and Catra is here to help, not to gawk after her.

Adora splashes cold water into her face, and when she's finished her necessities in the bathroom, she puts her hair into the usual ponytail, using the tie around her wrist as always. Opening the door, she finds Catra with her back towards her, bent over the table where a large map lies. Catra's back view is also quite pretty, in the tight, dark jeans, Adora admits, and for a moment, the question comes to her mind, if the woman did this accentuating pose on purpose?

While Adora walks towards the bed where jeans lie, she recognizes again, that Catra looks good in her civil outfit. Today it's a bit rebellious, in her black leather jacket and the alike boots, with the loose brunette curls framing her face so beautifully. It's different from her military appearance, more naturally and wilder. Adora slips into the jeans, then places herself on the other side of the table. Catra's shirt has a rather low neckline, and the woman's bust is really—
"Hey, Adora, attention here," Catra calls at her, pointing at her eyes with index and middle finger. "We need to talk about how we get you out of here. I'm not here for being gawked at."

Has Catra read her mind? Adora cocks her head. “You gawked at my tits just now!”
“That’s up for debate,” Catra fires back, “it’s not that I had a chance to avoid it. You practically shoved them into my face.”
“I did not!”, Adora retorts indignantly, but they both know it’s a little acting, and then they get into a stupid staring contest like angry bulls, holding eye contact until Catra breaks it by saying. “Here’s a coffee for you. You look like you need it more.” She pushes over her coffee cup, and Adora’s first reaction is to start an argument that she can’t just take it, but she’s shushed by a raised finger and Catra saying “Don’t! Just be grateful.”
To everybody’s surprise, Adora starts sipping at the coffee like an obedient little girl with big eyes.

While the black and bitter liquid runs down her throat, Catra points at the map on the table. “I thought a map would spark our imagination to come up with a few ideas. First, we lay out all options, and then we start crossing off the useless ones. This exclusion method leaves us with the possibilities to pursue.”
That sounds like something someone from the military would do, and Adora nods. She’s used to thinking like that. In preparation for several of her missions and in exchange for her support, Angella put her through several military trainings in recent years. Adora attended the so-called “Basic Training for the Unserved” the German Army offers, and a few advanced courses in survival tactics, to sharpen her abilities and combat instincts.
The map before them is actually a good idea. It’s a normal road atlas on a large scale, showing southern Russia, the region from Voronezh in the north, which is half-way up to Moscow down to the entire Caucasus in the south, a part of the Black Sea on the west and the Caspian Sea on the east. It’s a reminder of how large Russia is. The Southern Federal District is the second-smallest in size of all federal districts of Russia, but it has still nearly half a million square kilometers in size. Even that is larger than her adopted home country, with it’s around 350.000.

“Plane, train, road, boat or by foot.” Adora has already pondered about this and Catra writes it down on a sheet of paper, while she half-jokingly adds: “We can probably let bikes out, it's the same as

walking and I would rather not," while she points at her side.
Catra nods. "Okay. So, what do we cross out?"
"We can probably forget about trains, because they check every passenger when they cross the border. I know that from my research when we prepared for our trip to Mariupol. And since the war started, all connections by train to Western countries were suspended. So, even if they restart one here or there, I don't know about how feasible it is to hide in one?"
Catra shakes her head. "Not a good idea. Since the refugee crises started in 2015, they began to search the trains more thoroughly. I wouldn't count on the chance that they haven't found every possible hideout. And as you said, there are no trains to the west today. You could try a connection to Kazakhstan, for example. But it would be like Roulette."
"Okay, so trains are out."
Catra crosses out the trains.
"What else is out too?", Adora continues.
"By plane, obviously," Catra says, and Adora nods, unnerved, because that would've been the easiest option. "Would be too simple if I could use that way, huh?"
"Sure, Blondie. I mean, there are still flights towards the east and south, but even if I'm able to book a ticket for you, they'll screen everyone soundly at the border checks, and I'm pretty sure that Hordak will have your name blinking up on every screen at every airport. We could try getting you a false ID and would need a small backwater place which is not digitally equipped. With a bit of disguise, it could work, but at these places, border guards often have time to look it up manually. And the main problem with that is, that the Border Service is a part of the FSB today."
Adora sighs. "Okay, that's bad. They'll surely check for suspects, huh?"
"With pleasure," Catra growls, but continues, "and their border surveillance at the international airports is tight, far tighter than on land crossings. We could also try to bribe an amateur pilot with a small machine, but I seriously doubt we'd find one who would dare to fly over a border today. The larger airports in Southern Russia are closed for civilian flights anyway, so, planes are out, too" and with that, she reaches over to cross off that option.

“I could steal a small plane, from a smaller airfield?” Adora throws in.
“Of course! That’s a brilliant idea,” Catra seconds, “and how about you steal a fitting anti-missile system too? It shouldn’t be so hard to get into a camp. And while you're at it: why don’t you steal an entire MIG? I’m pretty sure you’ll find it easy to fly one, given all your experience and certifications in… what again? Journalism? Please, Adora, remind me when you became a pilot, because I had no fucking idea.”
Adora says nothing. She was joking, but Catra crosses out planes again, by angrily scrawling over the word several times.

Adora points at the Azov Sea, west of Rostov. It is a subsea, an extension to the northeast of the Black Sea. On world maps, it’s barely visible, but it’s still a large ocean. Then she moves her finger downwards to the northeastern coast of the Black Sea. “By boat, from here? I mean, could I perhaps charter a small boat at, let’s say, around Sochi and hop over to Georgia, so I wouldn’t have to cross a border check.” The city of the Winter Olympics 2014 - the same year Russia invaded Crimea later on - lies at the northeast shore of the Black Sea, right under the last, western foothills of the Greater Caucasus. Her finger moves a few kilometers southeast from Sochi, along the coastline, towards Georgia. “That doesn’t look too far, and I don’t think that they’re affected by the war. Wouldn’t that be a possibility?

All she gets in return from Catra is a shaking head again. “No, you can’t. That’s not Georgia, it’s Abkhazia, and the Georgians consider it Russian-occupied because *it is*. It’s one of these de facto independent states in the region. Georgia doesn’t acknowledge them, and thus doesn’t allow crossings from Abkhazia to their country, and you would have to travel all the way from Sochi to, let’s say, Anaklia.” She points to a small city further down at the eastern shore of the Black Sea, which looks like more than 200 kilometers away from Sochi. “I don’t think you will get to go so far and not being noticed by any authority guarding these borders. It would be a better idea to sail to Turkey then, but that’s a huge risk, too, given the distance. Could you handle a storm or a boat even? And again, this part of the Black

Sea is practically Russian. We have a lot of ships out there. I wouldn't recommend it."

Adora needs to stop her hands from fisting. One by one, her means of flight are being taken away. But she won't give up. Never has.
"Okay. And other sea routes aren't feasible. The Black Sea towards the west is a war zone, too, and it's way too far to the western shore." She points back to the Northern Caucasus. "This entire region is really a mess, isn't it? Why did you have to spark all these separatists movements?"
Catra shrugs casually. "Reasons of state, I guess. For one, a lot of Russians live there. As on Crimea. Aside of all this demarcation-play, the thought of bringing our people home is very popular here.[38] Plus, as long as all these little states are fighting each other, they don't fight us. It keeps our neighbors occupied, and puts a wall of struggling nations around our borders, that also depend on us. We can't really guard 20.000 kilometers of borders effectively. It is also a perfect way to distract *you* guys, with all your need to intervene anywhere in the world where no one wants you to.

Adora rolls her eyes. "Aside from sounding paranoid, it also sounds like 19th-century strategy to me, from concepts of ground war from a time long gone. Today, you can't spark all these regional conflicts and not expect the world not to react to it. It's not 1800 anymore, when the news about such things needed days or weeks to travel across the world, and another nation imposing sanctions on you won't harm you much."
"Please tell me if Russia had intervened when you sparked your little private wars in Iraq or Afghanistan? No, we stayed behind and let you do what you wanted to: mess things up. So, why do you think you have a right to intervene in conflicts you have no say in?" Catra tonality got more cutting during her speech.
"Don't lecture me with such theoretical questions from the past and completely different circumstances. That wasn't *us,* because there is no us. When the USA decide to do something, the EU or we have little we can do about it. And don't get off the topic: this

is the present, and Ukraine has done nothing to you for decades. The country is no threat to you, and *you* attacked them, it's not the other way around. This strategically inept President of yours thought it would be a good idea and pretty easy to annex the country and present the rest of the world with a fait accompli. Well, it appears that he was wrong. The Ukrainians didn't just roll over on their backs and give up like you expected, did they? Which leads to the conclusion that you might want to consider what else he's wrong about." She can do cutting, too.

"War is never going according to plan. From our point of view, where you have to govern a nation spanning eleven times zones, bordering fourteen other countries, and I'm not counting in Japan and the USA which are right across the sea, then all of this becomes very real. And let's not forget about Germany. I know they're making every effort to look harmless and friendly these days. But its economy is still twice the size of ours, it practically governs the EU, and it has its nice and friendly bully with nuclear weapons just around the corner. Nowhere else does the US have more people under arms abroad than there. Til today." She states it with crossed arms, clearly getting heating.

But Adora can't help but to laugh exaggeratedly, because it's so ridiculous. "Hello? The school book publisher called and wants his pages back. You don't get to pull this ancient stuff in the 21st century. Since the Second World War - and this is 77 years ago, for fuck's sake - nobody, literally nobody, has attacked your country directly ever again. Instead, all of these nations live in fear of *you* today. It's not the other way around. Some of them were *your* friends at a time. You're the bully here, not us." Catra's nod isn't as complacent as she guessed it would be. Instead, she shrugs her shoulders and replies rather indifferent: "And that's better for them and us. Only when they fear us do they leave us alone. And besides, it's not that you haven't done the same thing in Iraq, or Yugoslavia, right on your own doorstep, have you?"

Adora doesn't respond immediately to the blatant and somehow untrue accusation. To some extent, Catra is right, but the situation

is not the same. Interfering in the Yugoslav Wars of the nineties had been a rough, stumbling adventure by every participant; by the UN and NATO alike, and it happened at a time when the European Union had just been formed, and no own military capacity.
The Yugoslavian state itself had always been a terribly dumb idea by the powers that shaped the aftermath of the First World War and another remarkable example of why thoughts of revenge should never shape or be included into transnational, worldbuilding negotiations, in this case, the Paris Peace Conference of 1920, where the humiliation of Germany by mostly France would directly lead into the next great war.
With the downfall of the Austro-Hungarian Empire to which the lands of Yugoslavia belonged before, the now Serbian dominated country was formed and outlasted the invasion of the Axis powers and Soviet times. It didn't outlast the downfall of the Warsaw Pact and the rise of a more civil-based European nation-landscape, because brute force had been the only thing holding it together. Consisting of six federal republics, each with a different major ethnicity hating each other, the nation always struggled with these tensions, and sparked many separatist movements during its entire existence. It was no wonder that the state failed the moment the forcible grip around it vanished, and that it ended in a cruel civil war with massacres of tens of thousands, expulsions and more long-lasting mutual hatred til present day.

Drawing frontiers just on maps has never been a good idea, too. Anyway, fighting over events from more than 20 years ago, when they were both kids, is pointless. She decides to let it go.
"I don't think we're going to solve that now. Let's focus back on our discussion."
She glares at Catra, seeking for consent or at least an acknowledgement that they should end this argument *now*, and after another silent staring contest, the heavily breathing brunette actually looks like she gets a hold on herself, and nods curtly.

Gratified, Adora exhales: "Ok." She pinches the back of her nose to concentrate again.
"Good, let's see. Boats are out, ferries too, because they check

them as well as the planes. That leaves us with land routes, by car or foot. What about going to the west?" She traces the area of the Donbass and overall Eastern Ukraine with her hand. It's such a large area that there must be ways through the front lines. Catra picks it up. "Taking a land route towards the west is a bad idea, too, because our campaign into the Donbass is in full advance. Our troops are everywhere there. That doesn't mean that you can't slip through, because it's hundreds of kilometers of front lines. It's even not unlikely to pass the front without anyone noticing you. But the entire area has become outright dangerous. Our artillery is killing it there, it's a war zone, from Mariupol over Donetsk and Kramatorsk towards Kharkiv." Her finger glides over the Dnipro, the large river parting Ukraine in a western and eastern part. "And, most bridges over the Dnipro have been destroyed, at least the ones near the front." She moves north. "Going to Belarus is no option either, as aren't Latvia and Estonia. I mean, you can try to sneak across the green border over to Finland, but with all this NATO bullshit from over there, they certainly ramped up security and patrolling too, and I don't know the area. Many fences have been put up, in recent years." She shrugs her shoulders. "Plus, we would have to travel through 2.000 kilometers of Russia, and that's not a good idea. We could run into a checkpoint or simple traffic inspection anytime, and that would probably be it."

It took her a while, but Adora notices how Catra says "We" all the time, and this raises questions. Catra promised to help her, but she doesn't yet know how far the woman is willing to go. "We" indicates that she wants to accompany her, but Adora didn't expect her to go that far, and it's clearly something they have to talk about.

Well, probably later, because now, Catra points south of them, at the mountain range separating Russia from several small countries. "No, my best advice is to go south." Here, the map shows the Black Sea on the west and the Caspian Sea on the east, parted by said mountain range, running from the Northeast, where Sochi lies towards Baku, the capital of Azerbaijan, lying on a peninsula at the shore of the Caspian Sea. It looks like it's not a

far trip, and it's also mostly small Russian cities with maybe less intense presence of the security authorities.
"South of the Great Caucasus lies Georgia. Just four million people, one large city, and the best for you is: they hate us."
The candid statement makes Adora laugh. "Really? Well, who doesn't. You might call yourself the Evil Horde today." Upon the reference to the Golden Horde, Adora can't suppress herself from half-chuckling, half-snorting, but apologizes immediately. "Sorry, that was unneeded. I really do appreciate you helping me. I know you don't have to do this." And there's this unspoken notion hanging that they'll have to discuss why Catra does it.
"Never mind, dumb face," the brunette snides.
"I'm not a dumb face."
Catra waves it off with a smirk. "That's up for debate, too, dumb face. Whatever. The point is that Georgia is one of these many small countries hating us, and its capital Tbilisi has an international airport. From there, flights go to Turkey, Israel, and even Germany."
Obviously having reached the end of her elaborate remarks, she looks expectantly at Adora, spreading her hands in a gesture that presumably means "Well?".

"Hmm, Georgia." Adora lets the name roll over her lip. "Perhaps a way to go, but it doesn't sound easy, though. I mean, it's probably the best of all the bad ideas we have. I read they applied for EU membership. These time are so weird. We don't even know if the country is in Europe or in Asia, but I guess it's another nation your dictator has driven away and into our arms, isn't it?"

"How about keeping your mouth shut?" Catra snappishly retorts. Adora's condescending, snippy comments about her nation make her angry. She realized herself that they alienated nearly every nation around their own border, save for Belarus, which is – what a coincidence – also run by a dictator. Friends have become rare these years, and she knows that, too.

Adora bites her lip and changes the topic. They really need to stop fighting about this political stuff. The tension between them is strong enough, and she needs Catra's help, for whatever reason

the woman's doing it.
"What about crossing the border? I mean, it's from Russia to Georgia, two countries not exactly on good terms, as you say. Won't they be extra picky at the customs check?"

Catra grins broadly. "Here comes what's playing into our hands. The problem for everyone is, that aside for the route along the Caspian Sea to Azerbaijan, there are only three roads through the entire Caucasus. There is the Transcaucasian Highway via the Roki Tunnel." She points at a place in the middle of the mountain range. "It was the most important and easiest route through the mountains, but we can't take it. Today, one can only go to South Ossetia, which is this area right south of the main ridge. We and Georgia have practically closed it off. Georgia doesn't allow people entering their country if they traveled through South Ossetia, and we don't either. It's another one of these independent de facto regimes, and Georgia considers it illegally occupied, still belonging to them. A fence has been built almost everywhere, and it's heavily guarded."
Adora nods in approval. "Yeah, I'd rather not to. Even crossing a normal border check seems to be a bad idea."

"Well, we don't have many options when it comes to that. At least, if we don't wanna do a one-week climbing tour. Another idea would be the old Ossetian Military Road over the Mamison Pass. I find it not very appealing to use it, and it's only open from May to September, being nearly 3.000 meters high. It is a route rarely used today, sometimes by tourists from Georgia to Russia. That is allowed, or at least, it was. Due to the Roki Tunnel there has been little use for this way, and since the separation of South Ossetia, the Georgians practically closed the border there. We would bypass the tunnel by leaving the feeder road a few kilometers before, but we would still have to drive over a mostly unpaved and hairpinned road with sharp and blinds curves for hours. The Georgian side is said to be in horrifying shape." [39] She shrugs her shoulders. "Not my words. Anyway, my suspicion is that if there are border guards at Mamison, they will check people crossing there without hurry, just because they have nothing else

to do. It's maybe possible to sneak through, though, and I assume, the Georgians will let you in, if you can provide them with some evidence of your identity." Upon this crucial point, Adora raises an index finger like in school, but is shushed by Catra shaking her head. "Later! The pass still might be closed during this time of the year due to weather conditions. It's unpredictable."
Despite she wants to talk about heir passport and many other things, Adora has nothing to add to it. She has no clue about the entire region, never been there, and so she has to rely on Catra's assessment.
The woman points to a place east of the Transcaucasian Highway. "So, our opportunity to cross the border is south of Vladikavkaz, at Verkhny Lars. It's the only road where you can directly and legally enter Georgia from Russia. The next opportunity is so much farther in the east that we would go to Azerbaijan. I can't recommend that." Now, Catra is tipping with her finger on a place in the middle of the mountain range, right south of the Russian-Georgian border, where a place named *Stepantsminda* lies. "This is where you wanna go. Here, you'll be safe again."

It sounds nice, but… "What about the actual border check there?" Catra grins. "Here's our trump card. You know, the border at Verkhny Lars is famous for its traffic jams and long waiting hours. Because, as I said, it's the only crossing between Russia and Georgia, so, everyone uses," she points at the border station and emphasizes every word, "This. Single. Point. In winter, it's so often closed that people just have to wait for days, sometimes weeks. Heavy snow, rockfall, storms, accidents, mudfall. Despite the 21st century, this is still a dangerous route, but at least it's a paved road. So now, in May, they are buried under floods of people visiting relatives, picking up business again, and tourists." She grimaces. "Okay, tourists will be rare today, but anyway, it's a madhouse of angry truck drivers, overworked customs officers and tired people just wanting to get through this bullshit."
Adora giggles upon the lively description, but Catra rambles on, obviously in her element."The guards will be stressed and worn-out. What also works in our favor is, that despite it's so crowed,

it’s just a backwater place. Because, who actually cares about folks crossing the border with a bit of contraband. A few Dollars or Rubles, and they’ll be fine. On both sides, actually. They probably don’t give a fuck and just wave you through, if you look like a tourist. I mean, it’s just Georgia, huh? What can they do?”

Catra grins, but there are many assumptions in her reasoning, Adora thinks. It sounds a bit too good to be true, and it surely won’t be so easy.
A half-hearted, “Really?”, is all she says in response. She has to think about this, and she also hasn’t overheard how Catra switched from “us” to “you” when it came to crossing the border. Is this her plan? Bringing her there, and then go back?

“I guess the road is open for a few weeks only, and so it will still be crowded.” She pulls a smirk: “And the good side of that is, that Hordak most certainly won’t expect you to make such a move.” Her finger moves along the mountain ridge on the map. “Look, these pass roads move up to more than 2.300 meters in Georgia and when it snows, it… I mean, this is the Great Caucasus, there are many four- and also some five-thousanders. These are not just a few hills, but the highest mountain range between the Ural and the Alps. Plus, it’s not an easy trip. It’s only about 900 kilometers from Rostov to Tbilisi. Ok, well, we’re talking about Russian and Georgian roads.” She bares her teeth. “When it comes to crossing the border, just waving with your passport will probably be best, if we’re able to—”
“About my passport—”
“We’ll come to that. The point is, I don’t assume they're gonna cross-check it, and we’re going to do something about that. We can think about a plan for this while we travel there. We’ll need two or three days, I think. As I said, the roads are often shitty, and as soon as you reach Georgian territory, you should be safe.” She leans back. “They really hate us.”
Adora looks at her, frowning. “You’re relying on a lot of assumptions, don’t you? What if they look me up?”
Catra raises her hands and grimaces. “I have an idea about that. Just have to make a call to check it. But feel free to suggest

something better, then. Don’t be such a coward. I mean, there are little alternatives. Everything else is just more dangerous.”

Adora sits down on the edge of her bed. It’s a lot, to be honest. "Ooff.” This is much to think about, she should really do some research and make a plan. Plans! And she has to get her passport.
“Okay, so now about my passport. I haven’t seen any of my stuff since you guys… took me in at Mariupol. So, how do we solve that?”
“That’s not hard. I’m going to look if your stuff has been brought to the camp. Don’t expect your wallet or phone, that has been most certainly stolen. But your passport and other worthless things have probably made it, and been stored.”
“And if it’s gone?”
“Then we have to think around it. Maybe my friend can help with that, too.”
“You have a friend who can provide me with a new passport?”
“Oh, it’s not the only thing she can do,” Catra replies, sounding pretty smug. “But I’d prefer not to bother her with this. We deal with it, when we come to it.”

It leaves Adora rather unconvinced. This entire plan reeks of holes and insecurities. She’s usually optimistic and doesn't give up easily. But Mariupol and the last two weeks have taken their toll on her, physically and mental. And she still feels quite lost, alone, with her only friend being a doctor, working for the enemy.
“I mean, if you think so.”
“I think so, and I’m always right. You should be able to get home via this route.”
“Hmm. Actually, I think the first thing I do is jumping over to Brussels and stay with my friends for a while. I’d rather not be alone the first few days,” Adora replies subdued, and Catra adds.
“That’s probably a good idea. You still have to heal. Rest a bit before you throw yourself into the next adventure. Having someone to take care of you is good.”

It’s true, but Catra feels a tug inside her, making her want to be the one looking after Adora, if maybe just for a while. Just to be close to her. It’s ridiculous that she still can’t get the picture of the

woman just in her boyshorts out of her head. She was so radiant, beautiful, and athletic, even more so with her still dozy look. Cute, actually. Oblivious, and cute.
That Adora's body is so well contoured, that such a perfect goddess exists, should be considered a sin. Adora's tits could pretty much fill exactly one hand each, her short-circuited brain kindly supplies. Catra would really like to try out how they feel, looking so firm yet soft. Well, she probably burnt that bridge. She stares at Adora and all she thinks of is that the other woman still wears no bra under the shirt.
Given what she saw, she actually doesn't need one.

"Uhm, hello, Catra?", Adora asks.
"What? Oh, sure." She snaps out of her stupor. Gawking at Adora isn't making the situation better, and she diverts the Blonde by waving it off.
"We have a plan for now. I'm going back to the garrison for the night. I have to try to fetch your passport and perhaps the rest of your stuff that has been brought. And I have to make some arrangements, so I can take a leave for a few days."
Adora cocks her head: "How long will you be gone? Shall I wait for you in here?"
"That'd be best. I don't assume you'll be searched publicly. You're not that important. But… better not take any chances. Okay? You have no ID. If you are checked, it can end badly."

Adora drops onto the bed, looking dissatisfied. "Hmm. Okay."
"It's just a few hours. I think I can be back by tomorrow morning. It's also good for you to rest. Stop whining."
"No, that's fine." Adora shakes her head, and the ponytail of her now brownish hair flies left and right. Stupid, pretty, unconvincing woman. "It's just… I've never been good at waiting, you know? Doing nothing is… I don't like it."
Her tone is somewhere between comically-desperate and exasperated. It's hard to judge, to be honest. Inside Catra, two feelings are warring: her need to process what they just talked about, and, oh boy, does she need to do that. She also needs more than this half-baked plan which she made out of nowhere. The problem is that she got her mouth pretty full. Going with

Adora wasn’t her first idea when they started strategizing about their plan, but now she talked herself into this adventure, and she has absolutely no clue why she was so bold.
Of course, she doesn’t want the woman to end up in Hordak’s clutches. But why for fuck's sake has she practically promised to guide Adora to the border? It’s a three-days trip there and back again. Taking a leave shouldn’t be an issue, but it may look suspicious, from Hordak’s viewpoint.

The other feeling is – and that may have something to do with the fact that she doesn’t want to let Adora go – that she wants to sit down beside the woman and hug her. Feel her. Touch her. Put her hands under her shirts, on the skin of Adora’s sides. She stands before her, just two steps away, and wants to embrace her.
This is so strange. The whole attraction Adora exerts on her doesn’t make much sense.
They have little in common.
They are as good as enemies.
They won’t see each other ever again.

And Adora doesn’t want her like that.

Not like she wants her.

Oh, goodness.
The realization hits Catra like a shell. She withdraws the hand she already stretched out to touch Adora’s shoulder. “I have to go. I’ll pay for the room for another night and make sure you’re not going to be disturbed. If you need something to eat or drink, use the room service. I’ll be back in the morning.”
The frown, appearing on Adora’s face, is visible. Mostly, the woman is like an open book, her emotions reflect on her face like they do on a child’s one. Nevertheless, Catra can't figure her out.
“Do not leave,” she repeats, and Adora hesitantly nods.

Out on the street, she has to walk around several corners and for a few minutes, because she didn’t park near the hotel. A simple security measure, just in case. While she drives out of Rostov, towards her camp, her grip on the steering wheel is grim. She has

a lot to think about, and a lot to plan. And not everything of that is strictly tied to tactical measures.

Catra sits at her desk. The small room she'd been assigned in one of the Soviet Era buildings of the camp is unadorned, and has little equipment beside a desk, a computer, telephone, a few boxes with files – mainly requests for leave from her subordinates and the usual paperwork coming along with topping up her division because nearly all members whose temporary contracts end do not renew. Luckily, her small staff of people who take care of this are sitting two rooms away and make phone calls half the day to arrange for replacements. It somehow doesn't seem like many people actually want to serve in a war beyond purely verbal expressions of patriotic enthusiasm online.

Before coming here, she fetched another coffee in the canteen. According to the glimpses she got from state TV there, the entire country stands strong behind its President, supporting the *special military operation* with overwhelming consent. Of course, voicing dissenting opinion publicly is a bad idea, today. Still, freeing the world of Nazis has always been a good trigger for the Russian public for 80 years.
But the army folks around her, carrying the actual weight of war, are not so enthusiastic anymore. They die in the thousands, and if she's honest, she can't condemn anyone for a lack of willingness to die in a war many of them don't understand or want.
She never really thought about leaving the military. Her contract lasts for two more years, but she made that decision while she still believed that Putin would never actually order a full-blown attack on Ukraine. Most of her comrades thought that too. They all have been proven wrong, but that's hindsight, and hindsight is a cruel and bitter thing. Still, they follow their orders, because they have little choice if Putin throws her lives under the bus, have they? And for what exactly? She doesn't understand the strategic endgame of her bosses boss, but, well, that's possibly just how it is.

She sorts a few reports, files away leave requests, orders two truckloads worth of supplies herself to make sure - surer - they actually get them, and yells at an officer from the logistics command to actually do his job instead of playing on his fucking smartphone, then her eyes fall upon a news summary, covering western political reactions to the war. It's something she occasionally skims, but this one sticks out: "Germany beefing up its army with a 100 billion fund." [40] One statement is marked in yellow by a helpful intelligence officer: "Germany will soon have the largest conventional army in Europe within NATO," the German Chancellor says there, elaborating on the measures his country undertakes.

"Great, really great," Catra mutters to herself. If her nation has an end boss on the continent, it has always been Germany. Even if the country's military is just a shadow of its former self today, the Germans have always been the only nation in Europe able to challenge, threaten Russia existentially. "Exactly what the world needs. Because an upgraded German military has always been a good idea for the rest of the world. Stupid idiots. Why does nobody learn from history?" In her eyes, it's another sign of an escalation spiral getting out of control.

She works through the rest of the afternoon, talking with her staff, calling superiors and subordinates. Her tactical command has two more weeks for recreation, then another two weeks on light duty at the garrison before a potential – or rather likely – redeployment.
"The requirements at the front do not allow more," Ivanaev says during their call, "but I recommend making the best of the next two weeks."
"Yes Sir," Catra replies automatically. "I'd like to ask for a personal favor."
"Go ahead."
"I want to visit a few friends in Kuban, Sir.[41] I would need a few days off for that. My staff can run things until then."
"Sure. This applies to you as well. If you're in control of your chain of command, there's no problem." This is just reminding her

that it’s her job to run things in her unit. If that is going well, she can surely decide for herself.
“Thank you, Sir. I’ll keep you updated.”

It still feels weird to know that her unit is on leave while just a hundred kilometers away their artillery fires thousands of rounds a day and tens of thousands of men engage in combat. But the Russian Armed Forces encompass a million people, with the Ground Forces having more than 300.000 on active duty, and only half of them are engaged on the front lines of this war. There are, after all, a lot of other borders to protect, too. She doubts that they haven't overstretched their abilities with this war.

When the door opens without forewarning, she’s startled and shortly tempted to lash out, but the face of Hordak Suchorow lets her stop in that consideration.
“Manners. Would suit you well,” she greets him coolly.
If the man has one good trait – in her humble opinion – it’s that he jumps right into it, without fuzzing around. She prefers that too. “I’m not here for you, but for this mysterious patient of yours I’ve managed to track down.”
“What? You finally found a Western spy,” she mocks him.
“In a way. After I spoke to this ‘Anna’ of yours, because I knew something reminded me of her. It took me some time, but I finally got it.” He opens a folder and pulls out a paper printout. The image on it is of mediocre quality, apparently printed with a cheap ink jet. It's a screenshot from a video, and it clearly shows Adora standing in front of Mariupol's destroyed theater. Despite the situation, Catra can’t tear her gaze away from Adora, because she looks so exceptionally handsome in her vest, with the helmet, vest, combat boots and all. She looks better without it, sure, but there’s something about her—
Her stupid and derailed thoughts are cut off by Hordak rambling on. “Adora Gray, a war correspondent and self-proclaimed defender of the weak. She runs a so-called news channel on the internet.”
“Is this what you’re doing in your office the whole day? Watching YouTube to catch what? *Influencers*? Isn’t that low, even for you? What’s about the dignity of your service?”

Hordak obviously enjoys leering at her with hostility. "Oh, she's far more than that. In recent years, she was working with the Brightmoon Foundation, a large NGO situated in Brussels. They receive EU funding and use it to support and spread their ideological propaganda. She's close with the founder, a woman with the ridiculous name Angella Brightmoon, and judging from what is publicly known, something like a daughter to her. She's also friends with the woman's actual daughter."
"And?," Catra asks, shrugging shoulders. ""It's hard to believe that you waste your time with stuff like that. Is it a crime today, being friends with people who do not like us?
"It is a crime, when you have been reporting directly from Mariupol, which is – as I might remind you – now under our jurisdiction. Federal law prohibits calling the special military operation in Ukraine a *war*. But she did. In front of an audience of millions, on the Internet, several times. After the law was invoked."
He closes the folder with a snap, obviously to make his point. "The woman is obviously a foreign agent. How could this escape your attention?"

His accusations are so stupid that it's outrageous. Technically, Hordak is right, but Mariupol wasn't Russian when Adora was there, and it's doubtful it is now. But as usual, Putin's minions are overdoing it. Stupid bastards.
"It's not my job to watch internet videos, you know," Catra bites back, nearly hissing. She doesn't like to be surprised like this. Of course, she knew what Adora was, the woman told her herself, but this connection to an EU-funded NGO really sounds suspicious, and Adora hasn't said a word about it.
"But it's your job to make sure that all suspects are reported properly. To me, it looks like you tried to cover this person, and I want to know why."
"There's no reason. I didn't try to hide her or whatever. Dozens of civilians pass our facility when on field. Our job is to heal them, not to look up for criminals." Catra inwardly curses herself for the bad wording. All Hordak has is a weak connection to a Western think tank or so. This is not a crime by itself. "If you were better

at doing your actual job instead of smelling ridiculous conspiracies everywhere, we wouldn't have to deal with that kind of stuff."
"This will not remain without consequences, I can assure you. But I'm actually here to find out where the woman is now?" He puts his hands on her desk, in an obvious attempt to scare her.

It only makes her more truculent.

But she isn't an idiot. Catra pretends to search around in her files, clicking on some windows on her screen, while her mind is running a mile a minute to come up with a good distraction that would keep Hordak off her back for another day or two. "Isn't that a question you should ask the people in charge of the hospital? I'm not responsible here," she affects being helpful.
"Don't be stupid. I have already done that. No one knows anything about her whereabouts. You were last seen with her, yesterday, walking around."
"We took a simple walk. She wasn't in a bad condition anymore. To me, it looks like she was just released."
"She wasn't. And to me, it looks like that you've developed a strange, personal connection towards a patient, and a possible foreign agent."
He's not dumb, she has to give him that. The FSB always trained his agents to count in personal relationships, love affairs, or just physical attraction between people fucking each other. That these simple human weaknesses and desires make everyone vulnerable, prone to treason and betrayal alike. Catra has never publicly discussed her own sexual preferences because it is simply nobody's business. She doesn't have to run around and shove her likes into people's faces. But in the tradition of the KGB, the FSB has never been dumb enough to disregard the possibilities of same-sex relationships and *entanglements*.

So, Catra clearly knows what he's insinuating. If he knew about their past… well, he doesn't. "With all due respect, you're interpreting a lot into relatively little evidence there. It's stupid, you realize that?
"My chain of evidence is none of your business," he snarls, his face a mask barely hiding his ire. "I ask again: where is the

woman?”
“I don’t have a clue.” Lucky for her that she’s such a perfect liar, Catra inwardly smirks at herself while leaning back in her chair, staring at Hordak without showing any emotion. She swears, Hordak is one tease away to slap her. The man is practically fuming with anger.
“It would be better if I don't catch you lying in bed with an enemy, figuratively, or even… in a more practical sense.”
“Blondes are not my type,” Catra dryly retorts. It’s true and not true. In fact, she doesn’t have a type. Her prey scheme rather boils down to women who fit her inclinations. That is already quite a limitation. With Adora, she knew immediately they would suit each other in bed. That was instinct. Their mutual attraction was clear, the magnetism that Adora exerted on her was unmistakable. She knew it back then, and that hasn’t changed. She just fucked it up when she had her chance.
Like so often.
“We’ll see again, Major, be assured,” Hordak snarls.
“Take your time. I'm not that keen on your illustrious company,” she barks out with a good hint of spite. She says nothing about taking a few days off duty.

After he closed the door to her room not too softly, Catra opens a window to let in some fresh air. Her heart still pumps fast, the adrenaline pushed through her veins wears off only slowly. He’s clearly onto something, wants to put her under pressure, and the bad thing is: it’s working. Right now, he has nothing except a suspicion, but his experience tells him that she has her hands in Adora's escape. He can’t just arrest her, not yet, but she has to be careful, cautious.

As is Catra's nature, “being cautious” simply means upping the ante and implementing her plan faster. When she looks out of her door, Hordak is already gone. A minute later, she strides across the parade ground with a quick step, on her way to the evidence room. She has to get Adora’s ID before Hordak has the idea to look after such belongings himself – if he hasn’t already. Her heart beats faster, and it’s not because of the little walking.

Luckily, the soldier in charge of the storage is bored, and to add on her luck, he's just a Lieutenant. So he doesn't question Catra's authority when she demands the possessions of "Anna", captured in Mariupol, brought with her unit three days before.
What he brings from the back of the small storage room in a small plastic box is not much. In it lies only a small rucksack of blackish-sandy colors.
"Is that all?," she asks, and the soldier shrugs his shoulders. "No clothes or other stuff?", she presses on. He denies and lets her sign a receipt in return. That's a trace Hordak can pick up on, if he's clever enough to look here, Catra sighs to herself. He most certainly is. Well, it's another problem for future Catra.

Back in her office, she rummages through the little backpack. There's not much in it. An unopened water bottle. A pack of tissues, one set of plasters, half-emptied. A small switchblade. A pocket version of a map of Mariupol, stained and worn-out. If Adora had any electronics, they're gone. And at the bottom, a small wallet. Of course, the money is gone too, at least the notes. A few Cents as well as Kopiykas hadn't found the necessary attention to be stolen, obviously. Catra lets the coins jingle through her hand. Searching the compartments of the wallet, she unearths a medical insurance and a driver's license. This younger Adora, awkwardly smiling into the camera for making the photo for the driver's license, is similar to the one she knows. And yet, there's a difference, visible. Photo Adora is brighter, her small grin perhaps a little cocky and more *expecting*. Fewer lines in her face. The real one seems to have sharper edges now, a more contoured jawline, while also being more confident in herself, and less naïve. When her hand finally produces a passport and opens it, she freezes.

It's Adora's, that's clear. But this is not the normal EU passport. On first sight, it's not so different from the ones every citizen of the equally admired as abominated construct of formerly warring nations in the west carries, with Adora's stupidly pretty face on a picture top left, and her personal data on the right side. Catra feels like sneaking through Adora's diary, and it's honestly a little arousing. It feels like having a part of the woman.

Aha, she was born in 1996, so they are of the same age. Interesting, but not as important as someone might think. The same goes for her place of birth. Just the word "unknown" fills the place. Maybe there is an appealing story behind that, maybe not. It's not that important, too, not now. What's important is, that below the place unrevealing her birthplace, there is an additional field named "function". This is unusual, and the entry reads: "Special Envoy of the European Commission".

This is a diplomatic passport.

What does that mean? What function has Adora? And what does "Special Envoy" mean? Catra lets the two words roll over her tongue and plays with them again.
Despite she hates him, is this an indicator that Hordak is perhaps on the right track, and Adora is actually more than meets the eye. More than a pretty, self-proclaimed war correspondent, probably spying on them in some kind of weird mission? But why would they reveal that by printing it on her passport? That doesn't make much sense, aside from if that document is some measure of last resort.
What is Adora's game here? Is she perhaps lying?

No, that seems to be ridiculous. The woman is no diplomat, she has neither the attitude nor the education for that, she can't act to save her life and would probably be the worst spy in the history of humankind. And as pretty as she is, she's just as inconspicuous as Scarlett Johansson in a tight red bikini amongst a crowd of men in black robes. *Just with… smaller, firmer tits*, Catra's brain kindly supplies not for the first time this day, again pulling out the memory of the now brown-haired woman from this very morning. Adora looked good with so little clothing. And she flushed so pretty when she got it. She would look even better with no clothes on, and Catra…
Oh, goddammit. Can't she just focus on the topic at hand and probably not think about naked Adora? Her entire stupor didn't take longer than a few seconds, yet, it has distracted her.

Catra closes the passport after switching through the pages of it. Adora has a lot of stamps on them, from many of the illustrious countries happy to host the wars of the 21st century. It's an impressive collection and a showcase of being underway. Just like a war journalist would be.
Or a spy.

Catra sighs. It's a problem. She has what she needs: a few days off duty and Adora's ID. Now she can pack a backpack for her little journey. The logistics aren't the issue, if she disregards Hordak's snooping.
The challenge is: can she trust the woman she only knows for a few days? She has mostly acted on instinct ever since she met Adora, the first as well as this second time. Something draws her towards Adora, that's undeniable. She likes the woman in a way that goes too far, that much is clear as fuck. That she wants to drag her into bed and ravish her, too. Well, not ravish, but rather… entice, seduce, corrupt, tempt or simply fuck her until both of them are sore. Adora may play the clueless, innocent one, but she knows the woman is just pretending.

Is she?

The contradiction to her previous thoughts about Adora's inability to act is not really lost on her. And that's… unsettling, confusing. Something doesn't add up.
Plus, her own little game puts her entire career and possibly her future at risk. Being enticed by Adora, wanting to help her like a decent human, is one thing. But is this non-romance they have worth it? What will she get out of this?
"What are you, Adora?", Catra asks herself, muttering the words, like the woman is a mystery for her to unravel.

"What are you, Adora?"
Catra looks… pissed. That might be the right way to describe her. The frown on her features is unmistakable. Adora was so relieved

to hear Catra's knocking after a rather bumpy night, that she opened the door of her small hotel room with a smile, but the atmosphere has totally changed when she looks into the brunette's face.
"What do you mean?", she asks, a bit uncomfortable now, unexpectedly finding herself at the other end of Catra's sudden hostility. The woman still stands in the little hallway of the room, looking grim, after she closed the door behind her.
Unlike yesterday, she's in her formal military attire, and as always, it looks good on her, letting her emanate confidence and authority. It fits her and fits her not, like it's a skin Catra wears, which is just a tad too tight.

"Here's your passport." Catra holds it out to her, and she knows how her own surprised look changes to relief, then to worry, when she gets it. A small "Oh," escapes her.
"Yeah, Oh!"
"It's not what you think," she hurries to state, but it doesn't fall on fertile ground.
"Oh, please tell me what I think, because I'd love to hear your opinion about that."
"You looked into it, didn't you?" Adora makes a helpless gesture, shrugging her shoulders lightly.
"Of course I did." Catra stands before Adora with crossed arms, and all Adora can think of is how damned cute the woman looks when she's trying to look down on her despite being a tad smaller than her.
"What?", Catra asks.
"Oh, nothing," she mumbles, trying to hide the embarrassed grin that is slowly creeping into her face, failing. This is not a good time for that.
"Why are you grinning? Are you… are you laughing at me?"
"No! It's just that you are… cute when you're angry." She nearly whispers it.
"I'm not cute."
"Beg to differ." She nearly giggles.
"It's not that your opinion counts," Catra hisses. "And it's not what I was talking about. Don't try to distract, and don't play to be

dumber than you are. Tell me what this is about? Have you been lying to me?”

“Okay, okay, I’m sorry, I’m—”
“I don’t need your stupid sorrys, I need explanations.”
Adora sighs and gestures both of them to sit down at the table they used yesterday to plan. The map is still there, because she looked at it again and again, trying to come up with alternatives other than the one they made up.
“I’m not working for the Commission or something, if that's what you mean. The passport was meant to open doors for me in Ukraine, not in Russia. With them requiring EU help, it could've been helpful, you know? To get me through front lines or support when needed. This was aiming at them, not you. I was clearly not counting on being captured by you guys.”
“Who provided you with that?” Catra puts her index finger onto the passport with a loud clack.
Adora ponders whether to tell the truth or not. Catra might see her connection to Brightmoon Org as suspicious. But if she already knows about, and this is a test…
“My adoptive mother, Angella Brightmoon. She has close ties to the Commission and some military ranks of NATO. She did it,” she waves with the passport, “without asking me. It’s just her way of doings things, so to say.
“And I shall believe that?”
“That’s all this is about. It came in handy two or three times to get along with commanders in the field, to be taken seriously and get heard. Nothing more. ” Catra obviously doesn’t believe her, given how she stares at her.
“What?” A small laugh bubbles out of Adora. “You find it more credible that I'm part of an elaborate plot to be bombed in Mariupol, then be taken into your care because we knew each other from a conference nobody knows of from two years ago where I've nearly landed in bed with you, and now I'm here to take advantage of our little escapade to do what exactly? Repeating that to make your little war going awry? You realize how that sounds, do you?”
The blunt admission does something, yet the piercing stare Catra

gives her is tremendously frightening and very hot at the same time. After a few moments of obviously computing, her aggressive pose collapses when saying: “If you put it that way….”
She lets out a relieved blow of air she didn’t know she was holding in. “Yeah, I do. Please, believe me, there’s nothing more to it.”

Catra heaves a deep breath, closing her eyes shortly. Adora feels that, when she opens them again, she’s calmer. Of course, instead of admitting anything, the woman changes the topic. “You better get ready. I have three, four days max, and I don't wanna waste my time babysitting you.”
A small grin creeps onto Adora’s face. “Oh, and I thought you started to like me.”
“This is not because I like you.”
“Whatever you say, Kitty.”
“Say this one more time, and I claw your dumb face.”
Adora can't help grinning. When Catra points at her little belongings on the bed and chair, she’s quick to start packing them, though.

An hour later, they’ve left Rostov and its outskirts far behind and are rushing over the M4 expressway towards the south. For the greatest part, it runs through a landscape mostly characterized by subsistence farming, supporting little towns and cities. The road itself is modern, though, one of the few long ones that Russia actually has, built for the Olympic Winter Games in 2014, which preceded nothing less than the annexation of the Crimea later that year. It was another remarkable sign of the Olympic Games serving another semi-dictatorship, legitimizing itself and covering other horrors they were doing.

Adora tried to keep quiet. Catra is obviously still grumpy from their previous quarrel, and she doesn’t want to upset her. She has mostly looked outside, observed the landscape flowing by, and thought about what to do when she’s back in the west. Being cut off from her usual technological means, she has fallen out of

contact with the current events at the front and how the war has been going, she realized.
The Russian TV channels she was able to watch in the hotel room were not very informative, only talking about how well "the special military operation" goes according to plan, whatever this plan might be, and the usual ridiculous political talk shows, filled with aggressive language by people with little knowledge and much opinion, targeting the bases instincts of an uneducated viewership. It was like watching a reversed version of Fox News, and her entire profession is built around telling people what *actually* happens, not what she thinks what *should* happen, so they can make up an informed opinion. Not just follow wild speculations and nationalistic talking points by the thinking impaired.
While corn fields fly by, she thinks of her friends, too. She needs to contact them as soon as she reaches Georgia and is able to call without any fears of being traced and tapped. She must let them know that she's alive and okay. They must be worried sick – or have already written her off. It's an uneasy train of thought.

Beside her, Catra has continued to be dour.
"Are you planning to do the entire trip today?", she asks in an attempt to break the silence.
"No."
"Okay, so I assume you have a goal?"
"Yes."
Adora tries not to get upset on these curt replies. "Mind to tell me that goal?"
"We're visiting a friend of mine."
"And?"
"We will be sleeping there."
"That's it?"
"That's it."
Okay, this isn't working so well. Another try.
"And whom are we gracing with your grumpy presence?"
Catra groans, but her eyes remain on the road. A few moments pass before she finally answers. "Her name is Emilia Traptova. She's kind of an… inventor, does practical science. I call her

Entrapta."
"You're kidding me," Adora blows out incredulously.
"She was the one calling me Catra first. This was my revenge. It started as a kind of joke between us, that got out of hand. Now both names just stuck."
"Okay," is all Adora replies. She really thought there was more to it, but sometimes, people are just being… people, doing things without meaningful reasons, huh?

They fall into silence again.
The last twenty minutes of their ride go over small country roads, getting shittier by the minute. After they leave the paved road in a tiny village with an unspeakable name, they bump their way over a gravel track, whirling up dust behind them. They drive between crop fields and a small wood now, and a part of Adora quietly starting to fear that Catra might have second-guessed her decision to help her and is now just going to dump her body in a field or a quarry in this rather deserted area. She voices these concerns in an unconvincing attempt to jest.
Catra barks out a dark laugh. "I would have better ways to get rid of you if I wanted to", is the answer she gets, snarky, teasing, and just a minute before they come to a halt before a large, gray gate. Their goal, obviously.
Left and right of it, a red clinker wall rises three meters high, capped with barbwire, obviously surrounding a large mansion and definitely protecting it well. Around them is nothing more than fields of wheat and barley and a few groves in the distance. The air smells of soil, not particularly moist or dry, just fertile and with that certain dustiness that comes from the harvest.

When Catra gets off the car, Adora follows her. She's actually happy to be able to stretch her limbs. But when she looks at the gate, there is no mean to ring a bell. No doorbell plate, too. A camera sits atop the wall. "And how do we get in?", Adora asks.
"Don't worry, I got this," Catra replies, and lays her hand on one of the bricks beside the gate. With a slight crunching sound, the stone moves inward, like a large knob. Something whirs, then, with a soft click and a loud squeak, the gate starts to open.
"Trapta likes her little gimmicks. And nobody who doesn't know

about it visits her," Catra says, and motions Adora to walk through, while she gets back into the car to drive it in. Behind the gate, under a few beech trees, is a small parking place, where a few other vehicles stand, looking unused. Catra parks beside a dusty four-wheeled off-roader, while the gate closes automatically behind them with another loud *click*.

Feeling a little trapped, Adora throws Catra a questioning look, but the brunette just smirks, throws Adora her backpack, and walks towards an open archway leading into a courtyard, bordered by buildings on three sides: a long and huge, mostly wooden stable to the left, a long, two-storey stone building to the right, and the main house up front. All roofs are covered with dark red tiles. In the middle of the yard stands a huge oak, spending shadow.
The property gives the impression of a farm from the century before last, but it looks quite peculiar doing so, though.

Because scattered across the cobbled courtyard, strange apparatuses stand everywhere: lingering around, hanging from the gutter and from hooks on the walls, others lurking out of the open gate of the stable. Mechanical, iron and chromed machines, perhaps waiting to spring into action.
A wooden watchtower, 20 meters high and equipped with an antenna and satellite dishes, suspiciously looking like built to catch lightnings or alien signals, stands in the corner between the stable and the main house. And judging from the cables leading from there, it also looks like that this Entrapta person has apparently tapped into the high-voltage line that runs past her house, mansion, farmhouse, whatever. The wiring looks a little unsafe and highly unlawful, in Adora's eyes.

The main house before them only adds to the strange impression, even strengthening it. The timber framing structure was clearly built more than a hundred years ago, and to her surprise, it is well-preserved, with the wooden parts painted beautifully, and the roof of sunburn-colored tiles is new.
It looks… displaced, though, as if it doesn't belong here, but rather somewhere in Silesia or Thuringia, clearly not being a common type of building in the Stawropol region - or Russia at all.

“Is this where you hide your mad scientists?”, she asks quietly, nearly whispering, not really knowing why, but she has this odd feeling that if she speaks too lout, at least some of this weird engineering stuff will wake up in anger and tear them apart. She feels like an intruder, and, well, somehow they are.

Catra just giggles. “Don’t worry. Entrapta is an independent contractor of the government, working on inventions. They wanted her to work in one of their institutions, but she doesn't fit into regimented environments very well. Now, they leave her alone to blow herself up here. It’s kinda home office for her.”
“I can imagine that,” Adora mumbles, but Catra doesn’t mind any of the strange and dangerous looking machines they see, and drags her forward, into the lair of the mad scientist. At the front door, she knocks loudly on the wooden door wing, calling “Hey, Entrapta. Open!”
It takes two more tries until a weird looking, mid-sized woman with huge, dark glasses on her face opens the door, immediately screaming “CATRA!” Her voice sounds a little rough, like she’s just recovering from a cold.
“Hey Trapta. Long time no see, and— NO!” Catra evades Entrapta’s attempt to vigorously pat her head by ducking and hastily retreating a step.
The woman draws back and grimaces, also putting her glasses up.
“Oh, yes! Boundaries, I forgot, sorry! But how surprising! I haven’t expected you. Is it New Year's Eve already? It doesn’t seem that long ago that we—”
Catra interrupts her by laughing quietly, adding. “No. It’s not. I’m here for—”
“And you brought a visitor! How ex-CITING!” The pigtailed woman throws her hands in the air, making a few of her strands bounce around, and Adora can’t help giggling.
Catra points at her, saying: “This is a friend of mine, Adora. She needs your help. So, how about if I have a challenge for you?”

To Adora’s surprise, the blunt approach doesn't seem to bother Entrapta, because it’s obvious how enticed she is, with her eyes sparkling and her mouth falling agape. She’s actually weirdly

enticed helping someone she doesn't know. "Ooh, this just keeps getting better! But I hope it will be a little more ambitious than last time. That was not very fascinating. Oh, but come in!"
Catra gestures to Adora to follow her with a smirk, while Entrapta has vanished into the depths of her lair, or whatever this building shall resemble. Being the last one, Adora closes the door behind her, then hurries after Catra, who follows Entrapta down a long hallway into a very large workshop. This room apparently stretches into the stone building on the right side of the main house, and it looks like a crossover between the labs of Doc Brown and Tony Stark: the floor is lowered into the basement and the room is at least five or six meters in height, with workbenches inhabiting two sides of the room, while the third one is covered by shelves with tools and materials. Hooks and a hoist on a trolley hang from the ceiling. Analyzers, measuring instruments and machines are all over the place. .
"What was not fascinating?" Adora asks, because she's curious, actually rather pointed at Catra, but Catra just daggers her by eyeing and Adora wonders if she crossed a boundary.
Entrapta gets nothing of it and rattles off already: "I was to divert a shipment of medical supplies to her regiment. That was really easy. Our computer systems are not very hard to get into."
Adora looks incredulously, but her investigative nature kicks in. "Was this some kind of black market deal?"
Catra rolls her eyes and groans. "We needed that stuff, you idiot. My commander at the time was an asshole. He made the orders on paper only and put the expenses into his own pocket. Fucker. I asked Entrapta to *actually* execute the orders via our IT, so he HAD to pay for them."
Now Adora eyes her sharply. "This sounds so reasonable that it can't possibly be true."
"You don't have to believe it, and it's not that anyone has asked for your opinion," Catra retorts with crossed arms. "I don't care."
"I mean, didn't this have any consequences for you, bypassing him?"
Catra cackles. "He had no idea how it happened, and clearly couldn't say a word. These were legitimate orders. Just not given by him. Anyway, we aren't here for warming up old stories or for

sweet chats about my past."
"According to my data, that's true," Entrapta kindly supplies by cutting in and pointing to a tablet she holds up. "In 68% of all your visits, you want something from me, and in 28%, you pass out on my couch, drunken."
"It's not that bad!" Catra complains, and Entrapta immediately waves her tablet to object: "Have proooooof! This data doesn't lie! Oh, I haven't added last New Year's Eve." Sticking out her tongue a bit, she taps around on her tablet, then crows: "It's actually 28.5%!"
"You keep track of such kind of stuff?" Adora asks, aghast, and gets big eyes from Entrapta.
"I keep track of everything. It's the only way to come to accurate conclusions. Social interactions tend to be very confusing otherwise. I need reliable data, if I wanna handle my relationships right."
Upon her questioning look, Catra just shrugs her shoulders. "Underlines what I said. She's good with tech. Not with people."
Adora can't help but to giggle, and her smirk is smug when she half sing-songs: "Birds of a feather flock together, don't they?"
Catra is already on her way to open her mouth to obviously complain – loudly – but Entrapta interrupts her without any care: "What do you want me to do today?"

She obviously decides to it slide, and starts to explain: "There's a search warrant out for Adora. For completely pointless reasons. I want it to fail when she's looked up. We can't fake her passport, but there must be a way to alter the search terms in the FSB's database so that her name doesn't come up when being checked at the border. You can do that?"
Adora glances at Entrapta with an apologetic smile and shrugging, but if she thought Entrapta was above such a breaking of the law, or would at least ask what she did, she is proven wrong. Well, the certainly illegal tapping of the high-voltage line should have given her a hint, but stealing power and breaking into a Federal database are still two different things.
Entrapta waves it off without giving it a thought: "That won't be hard to do. Their security is like fifth grade. Not up to date. We

can look into it and maybe alter the saved search terms. So, her name doesn’t come up when checked.” She lays a finger on her lips, tapping them, thinking, then: “But whoever’s searching for her will notice the change of his request if this person looks into it. Hmm, we’ll have to come up with something better.”
Adora has the impression that the mad scientist knows what she’s speaking about, but: “Can't they trace you back and find out where you accessed it from based on your network address or something like that? I don’t want you to get into trouble because of me.”
“Nah,” Entrapta crows. “I’m not accessing the network via telephone lines. This area isn’t equipped with high speed fiber optics anyway. I’m using the power lines and a few workarounds. I have an—"
“Thank you, Trapta, but this isn’t a lesson in advanced tech-blah,” Catra cuts in, rolling her eyes. “We just believe you know what you are doing, okay?”
“Mostly,” Entrapta states, with an absolutely honest expression on her face.
“Well, that’s a start, isn’t it?”, Adora supplies, not really sure about where all this is going.
Catra nods. “Sure. It’s a good start. We have the evening to figure it out.”

An hour later, Adora is still awkwardly watching Entrapta hacking around on her keyboard from the couch she’s sitting on. Catra is standing at her side, and they mumble things to each other that Adora doesn’t really understand. Both women are looking at the gathering of screens before them. Catra laid a hand on Entrapta’s shoulder several times. They are obviously close, and Adora feels terribly useless and totally third-wheeled while watching them. She’s totally not eyeing Catra, who’s being next to another woman and whom she touched again and again.
Not.
The small seating area she uses for feeling utter useless consists of something that looks suspiciously like an often-used sofa, a

comfortable black leather chair, and a small, round table between them. One of these little party fridges with a glass door stands beside the couch, filled with energy drinks and kefir. And that's pretty much it. Entrapta probably doesn't get many visitors.

Time passes until it is late afternoon, and the women seem to have achieved what they wanted to. Catra stretches her limbs and yawns, and Adora looks quickly away when she's caught watching her.
"Okay, that'll do it," Catra says, satisfied, grinning at Adora like she stole the sweets from under her nose, more than obviously prompting her to ask.
"What did you achieve?"
"Entrapta had a good idea. We're not altering Hordak's search terms, but we're replacing them in the background in the receiving systems. So he still has his womanhunt running for *Adora Grey*, but the name is replaced on the fly with a different one when anyone checks it. That's actually very clever." She snickers, rather to herself, but Adora feels a great relief. If Hordak's search is going to fail in such an elegant way, she's probably off the hook at the border crossing. It sounds way too easy. She doesn't say it, but the look on her face must speak volumes.
"He isn't going to get it, until someone looks directly into the database," Catra adds. "And the best is that Traps' little code deletes itself in two days. There will be no traces left."
"Okay, this sounds clever, but is it really going to work?"
"Probably. I mean, Entrapta really is the most clever person I know. I think it's going to work. We have no other option anyway, so it has to."

Catra shrugs her shoulders, then calls over to the woman still at the working station. "Hey, Trap? Do you have a place for us to sleep this night?"
Entrapta nods enthusiastically. "Sure!" Whirling off her chair, she immediately starts walking to a dark hallway to the right, where lights go on automatically. "Let me show you the guest rooms. I have a lot of space!"
Catra winks at Adora and whispers: "She doesn't have guests that

often. And she really has a lot of space." Turning towards her host, she asks: "Where are your little minions, by the way? You know, this odd trio of saccharine caretakers that used to be so overbearing?"
"Oh Catra, leave them alone. They're just with their parents for a few weeks, because they got COVID, and they wanted to take care of them."
"Ugh. This fucking pandemic sucks so much. Haven't really thought about it since the war started, you know? Never had time for that kind of stuff."
Being the third in line again, Adora follows Catra while they walk down a hallway, turning right, then left, then up a wooden stairway to the upper floor of the main house.
"According to your boss, it's no war, but a *special military operation*, Catra." The teasing is unmistakable, and Catra jumps on it immediately.
"Ugh, cut it. I'm calling it whatever I goddamn like."
Entrapta snickers. Until now, she hadn't seemed to Adora to have much of a sense of irony, but that had obviously been a little too superficial.

On the upper floor, there's another, narrower hallway, from where a few doors to several rooms lead off. Entrapta opens the first one of them to the left, and they enter a large corner room with windows to the courtyard and the side where one can look over the wall surrounding the mansion. A wheat field lies there, with a small forest behind. The sight is beautiful, as is the room itself. Wooden beams hold the alike ceiling, the windows have intricate ornaments on their frames, and the bed is huge, a large playground—
Adora nearly runs into Catra's back, who has suddenly stopped, saying, "Uhm," and pointing to the bed.
The double bed.
"I think you might've misinterpreted the situation, Trap. We need two rooms," Catra says to an absolutely clueless looking Entrapta.
"Don't bother! We're fine with one room," Adora interjects, without really thinking about the implications. Catra turns towards her, one hand on her hip, smirking hard. "Oh, really, Ms. Gray? Are

you that desperate to sleep in one bed with me? Isn’t that a bit needy?”
“That’s not what I meant! I just don’t want her to have more trouble because of us.”
“So noble, so considerate”, Catra laughs into her face. “And yet you seem quick to offer such a sultry solution. It’s a bit transparent.”
“That's… ugh. Why are you like that?” Adora growls. She didn’t mean it like that. Not very much, at least.
“Like what, Adora? A responsible grown-up who doesn’t want to be groped by night?”

Entrapta has watched the back and forth with interest. It looks like she got something, turning to Catra. “Ooohh, of course! That’s no problem. But I thought you’d like to… I mean, given the last time—”
“THANK YOU, EMILIA,” Catra calls loudly with big eyes, putting her hands on Entrapta’s shoulders from behind, starting to shove the woman out of the room. “Why don't we leave Adora here alone for a few minutes, to accommodate herself, and you show me my room?” She pushes the squeaking woman out of the door, and both vanish into the hallway.

Adora is actually grateful for this moment of silence. She didn’t mean to imply she wants to sleep in the same bed with Catra. Not at all!
Well, it wasn't the main reason. Surely not. Putting her backpack down, she lowers herself on the bed and sighs. Catra’s oscillating behavior doesn’t make any sense to her. And having to deal with this incoherence of approach and distancing is confusing.
When she sniffs at herself, it’s clear that it’s probably best to use this opportunity to wash and redress herself.
A little bathroom is connected to this as well as to the next room, but given she hears nothing from over there, Catra has presumably occupied a room on the other side of the floor. After a refreshing shower, she dresses herself into a pair of blue jeans and a grey-whiteish shirt with short sleeves. Because it’s warm, the dark-red leather jacket she produces from her backpack isn’t needed. Catra estimated her size pretty good, the clothes fit well,

Adora judges when looking into the mirror while trying on the jacket. Her facial features have gotten a bit better since the day before yesterday. It's good to see that her condition gets better. And yet, she's not—

Knocking startles her out of her pondering. "You up for some dinner?", Catra asks from outside.
"Hell, yeah," Adora answers immediately. They haven't really eaten since breakfast, because they didn't dare stop besides going to the toilet at a pull-in once, and now her stomach grumbles on the mere thought of something to eat.

Entrapta turns out to be a decent cook. At least, the Solyanka she prepared tastes delicious, a rich and thick red broth with a lot of vegetables and meat in it. Cucumber, onions, cabbage, potatoes are supplemented with parsley and dill and few mushrooms and tasted with a good shot of vinegar. Sour cream and a huge loaf of soft, brown bread accompanies it. Catra and her dig into the meal like there has never been a better one, while Entrapta helps herself with several tiny portions of it in a very small bowl.
"Still sticking to your tiny portions' attitude?", Catra muses mockingly over her own, much larger one.
"Yes!" The pigtailed woman shrugs her shoulders. "It cools faster, and it is more delicious when it's not so hot."
Catra snickers, but Adora interjects simply: "I get that," which earns her a grateful look from Entrapta. "I mean, it makes totally sense. And this is really good." She nods down to the bowl she holds. "I'd like to have one more tiny portion, too."
Entrapta practically beams at her.

Afterwards, Entrapta pulls out several little cupcakes from the oven and puts a glass bottle of a clear liquid as well as three shot glasses on the table. Catra is on it before Adora can even ask what's in it.
"Don't ask, just drink it," Catra recommends with a grin, and downs the first glass. Adora eyes the liquid in her own glass warily, then sniffs on it. Okay, this isn't really Vodka, but

something even harder. “Uagh! What is this?”
“Entrapta’s best. She uses it to disinfect her workbenches and sterilize her tools, but you can drink it, too.”
“That probably doesn’t mean that we should.”
“Ohh, it’s not toxic or anything… at least, not unless you drink it like Catra does,” Entrapta says, laid-back in the sofa, with Catra beside her. Again, Adora can’t help feeling a bit jealous. Weird.
“What? I’m not that bad,” Catra pretends to be offended, but is just laughing it.
“This statement doesn’t correspond to the facts. Last time you drank half a bottle of it and then tried to set my stable on fire because you shot at the power lines. Several times, as I remind you.”
“It was just to prove that I wasn’t that drunk and could still hit it.”
“In which world is shooting a power line considered a good idea to prove anything?” Adora asks, incredulously so, but also a little amused.
“Behaving irrationally is a Russian tradition,” Catra states with grave seriousness. “You wouldn’t understand,” and Entrapta supplies: “That is, actually, according to the facts, as well a Russian trait as it is a Catraesque one.”
“Catraesque? Is that even a word? That is not a word.”
“I just invented it. Now it is!”
“Okay, I think I need one too.” Adora grabs the bottle and pours herself a shot.

All in all, they have a funny evening. Talk flows effortless between them, with Entrapta occasionally rambling about her inventions, Catra pretending not to be proud over some of her war stories, and Adora giving a lively report of how she got out of Kabul when it fell to the Taliban – again – in 2021. The memory isn’t always that easy to be recalled, because it were some freaking days, with embassies being evacuated in haste and the rudimentary governmental structures of Afghanistan breaking down by the minute. Kabul was nothing but chaos, and the last-moment helicopter ride she got by Angella only sounds cool in hindsight.

While at it, it was terrifying.
However, due to her tipsy state and the two giggling listeners, it's not hard to talk about. "The pilot just let the rotor run full speed, while I ran over the roof and threw my backpack in, then me afterwards. On the streets, people ran towards the hotel, trying to catch us too. But the pilot took off the moment I was in."

They don't drink too much, though. Even Catra, much looser and more relaxed, states that they can't overdo it tonight, and so it doesn't get beyond three shots each, and they stick to water and a dark, Russian beer afterwards.
Sometime, standing up, Adora announces she has to go peeing, which she wouldn't proclaim so openly when more sober. But right now, she doesn't give a fuck.
"Oh, you don't have to go all the way to your room. You can use my bathroom, it's right there down this hallway." Entrapta babbles drunkenly, and points head over into a corridor behind her. She's draped herself over the couch, her feet up, hanging overhead, clearly relaxed and nigh passing.
"As drunk as you are, you should probably avoid stairs," adds Catra, snickering into her glass, again sipping on it.
"I'm not that drunk, I just need to pee," Adora says confidently, swaggering down the hallway. Well, she may be a little drunk, but mostly she's just relaxed. Entrapta's weird estate feels unexpectedly safe to let loose. It's the first time since weeks that Adora doesn't feel threatened, chased or under fire, and beside the fact that her two drinking companions are somehow working for the enemy, she's fine. Even her wound hasn't been hurting much anymore, and this evening is really nice.

Was the toilet now on the left or the right side? Left, right, she thinks while staggering down the hall and then opening the wrong door. That is instantly made clear by the interior. Behind a thick, black curtain she pushes aside, is not a dungeon, not really, but… kinda.
Dim red-purple light turns on by itself. The room isn't large, six by six meters, perhaps. It has no windows, instead mirrors cover the walls left and right from ground to the ceiling. There are large mirrors at the ceiling, too, Adora realizes because she sees herself

moving in them. Her mirror images only add to her alcohol-induced nausea. She should leave, perhaps, because this isn't the bathroom, but then again, she's… curious.

The purpose of this room is given away by its furnishings and several mechanical devices standing around. They are way too special to be experimental. At least not in that way a *scientific* experiment would need. Maybe Entrapta does research on *human needs*, too? Or are these just for her personal use?
A metallic frame forming an X with cuffs at the upper and lower legs and a beam between the upper legs with another, larger cuff – a leather collar – where the throat would be is so blatantly speaking of what this is to be used for, that Adora immediately gets it.
A kind of stretching bench also has shackles on all four legs. The reclining surface is made of soft-looking, black leather. Behind the bench, a kind of rotation machine with different fittings lurks, and Adora has little difficulties to imagine what purposes this machine in combination with the bench can possibly serve. A few other apparatuses stand around too, but she doesn't get to figure them out.

Because on a glass table to her right side lay several, well, *toys*, neatly lined up, clean and ready to be used: a riding crop, a whip, several collars of different colors and material, from woven cloth over leather to iron ones, with eyelets to clip one of the leashes hanging down from the wall behind the table into them. And: ropes, handcuffs, blindfolds. A selection of dildos of different sizes and textures completes the picture.

Beside having read about it, she has no experience in this certain kind of inclinations, but she clearly recognizes a veritable BDSM playground when she sees one. She stands before the table, feeling a bit awkward, fumbling with her hands and fingers. She's not really embarrassed, rather… unsure. Her younger self would've been mortified and totally confused when stumbling over such a sexual playground, most probably finding it freakish and a thing only total shameless people do. She would've squeaked and ran away.

Her contemporary version has grown to be more lenient when it comes to human fads.

Compared with the witnessed atrocities humankind is capable of on the battlefields of the world as well as behind closed doors, this here looks like a harmless hobby, with people taking part consenting to it. Why should that be a problem for anyone to care or get uptight about?
Despite her lack of personal experience with this certain… pastime, Adora never understood the commotion made around it. If people like it, so what?

Rather unconsciously, out of curiosity, she picks up one of the leather collars and rolls it around in her hands. Running her fingers over the fabric, it feels soft and unrelenting at the same time. The clasp is an ordinary metal buckle, the same as on a belt. She opens and closes it a few times, not knowing why. What would it feel like around her neck, if she put it on? Her thumb running over the steel leather gives her senses a taste of it, but it may be different around her throat? A gentle desire tells her, urges her to put the collar on, yet, her hesitation is still stronger. This isn't hers.
After laying the collar down again, the flogger she picks up next has many weals, but just a short, curved and grooved glass handle that overtly can be used a dildo. Slowly, she pulls the black leather welts through her hand. They feel nice. So soft. Is being spanked with them something people really want or… get off to? Her head tilts while pondering about it.
She slaps her own hand with it.
It doesn't feel too rude. Rather… ticklish, a little like many fingers running over her skin.
When she puts it back, and lays her hand on the metal cuffs beside, suddenly, her dreamy, dizzy haze ends. She should perhaps go. All of this seems to be very personal, she feels like overstepping, intruding. If Entrapta finds out she's in here—

"Heeyyy, Adoraaa," Catra slurs behind her, leaning at the doorframe with crossed arms and a smirk on her face, wide enough to land big planes on. "Exploring? Yeah, Entrapta has a

few… kinks, so to say."
"I realized," Adora nervously states. She pulls back from the table with the *fucking toys*, is a bit clearer in her head, because her exposure is flushing her with adrenaline. And she feels a little… aroused. It's the alcohol, surely.
"But don't worry, she's not into women," Catra adds with a hint of spite. "Probably not into men either. I think she's perfectly fine with herself and her tools here. You're here to try them out?"
This goes a bit far, and Adora stutters: "I didn't… I haven't…"

Catra pushes herself off the doorframe, approaching her, circling her, then she draws a line over her cheek with her index finger and breathes into her ear. "Of course you haven't, you pretty thing. And you never would, hmm, playing with the big girls?" The brunette's slurring voice has become teasing and sinful at the same time. With the adrenaline shock wearing off, Adora feels how much she's bedazzled from the alcohol. And from the long day. And from Catra's mismatched eyes who look at her so pretty, so alluring, so piercing. The feeling in her stomach is not helpful, too. Adora takes a step back to escape the beguiling proximity of the woman's scent and warmth. But Catra's still blocking Adora's only way out of the room, and the situation.

Hey, why should she be embarrassed? These are not *her* playthings. Adora musters a little wit. "What, Catra? Do you wanna try this stuff out yourself? Be nice for me?"
"The collar wouldn't be for me, Adora."
"Quite presumptuous to just assume that."
The woman only laughs darkly. "I know the likes of you."
Adora is speechless for a moment too long. It lets Catra adding: "Plus, as if you would dare to do something about it. The last time we were ready to go, it was you who chickened out. I remember that."
"Are you ever going to let that go? That was one time! And you ran away!"
"Well, you had your chance." Catra gestures to herself, running her hands down her body in a fluid wave that moves over to encompass the entire room with a spin. "This here is way out of

your league, Adora. Don’t play with the adults, you’re not up for it.”

Adora can’t deny she has a thing for all this back and forth they do, but this drunken Catra-version really is getting on her nerves. “You would be surprised. Last time we checked was two years ago. I maybe learned a few things.”
She has not, but Catra doesn’t know that. Being pierced by this beautiful eyes doesn’t help to slow her heartbeat, until the woman snarls: “Well, I’m not falling for your airs and graces another time, Adora. If you wanna try, and let a little steam off, ask Entrapta if she wants to bestow you with some of her experience. I doubt she’s into you, but maybe she’s up for some research.”
Catra turns on her heels and vanishes into the hallway, leaving Adora behind startled. When she gets back into the salon only two minutes later – after she finally found the bathroom – Entrapta is still draped over the couch, now lightly snoring with an open mouth and sleeping deeply, while Catra is not to be seen.
Of course.
Of course, the woman hadn’t the guts to continue where they left. “Who’s the coward now,” Adora mutters, frustrated.
It’s as much self-assurance as it is a groan.

Adora goes for the staircase, fully intending to head off to her bed when she takes the first steps. Still, there’s this nagging, this feeling that somehow this evening could’ve ended differently, if she just… well, she has no clue what could’ve turned Catra’s whims into another direction. It’s not that she understands the woman.
She turns the corner and stands before her door. Diagonally opposite is Catra’s. Two, three steps, her body make on its own, and she’s standing right in front of it.
Like an idiot.
Raising her hand. To knock.
She can stop herself in the last moment. She feels so stupid, so needy. If Catra wanted something different, she would’ve stayed, not vanished, right before. *I had my chance, two years ago,* Adora parrots Catra’s words from just three minutes ago, in Entrapta’s little playground. She doesn’t want her like that. Not anymore.

Adora winces, squeezes her eyes shut in silent embarrassment. She wants to knock. So much.
And can't.
Ten minutes later, she's in bed, though sleep doesn't come easy to her. She thought that maybe at this last evening it could've ended… different. Perhaps spending it with a woman she… she… she wants to have with her. Right here. The admission is not as hard as she thought it would be.
Instead, there is just this pillow around which she curls. And after tossing around for half an hour, Adora finally falls asleep.

What makes her wake up, is the presence of someone lurking over her.
It's still dark in her room, morning has not yet arrived. She gets that as she blinks her eyes open, and quickly acknowledges the shady, messy mane of Catra hovering over her. Perhaps, Adora should be scared or at least startled, being ambushed like this in the middle of the night, but actually, she isn't.
Is this perhaps a dream?
The woman is kneeling on all fours next to her, on the mattress, looking down on her. With the little light that is, Adora can see that her eyes are dark and wide open, her breath reeks of alcohol, but she's not slurring. Rather… mumbling.
…stupid. So stupid."
"What are you—", Adora breathes, not able to move a limb. She is not threatened, that much is clear. Catra rather makes a confused impression, as if she's not herself.
"Shut up."
Adora shuts up, equally stunned as aroused by Catra's proximity. What's going on with her?
"I hate you." The words are clear, but they don't *sound* clear. Too soft, like there's no weight to them. It's the Catra-typical teasing way of saying things, throwing words around just to fire back, just to have the last word.
"You wake me up in the middle of the night to tell me that?" Adora retorts, aghast, forgetting about the previous order.
"I said, shut up," Catra growls back. "You talk the entire time. It's an endless stream of babbling, as if you want to drown your

thoughts in talking. Now you listen to me."
Despite feeling pretty cornered, Adora can't deny this is pretty hot, too.
She nods, her head sinking back into her pillow.

But whatever great speech Catra might or might not have prepared, it doesn't come.
"I just wanted to— No... Ugh. I had to—" The brunette shakes her head. "I can't believe I'm here. I'm just as stupid as you are."
Catra scrambles back from the bed and staggers to the door.
No, she can't let her go, not another time. Her hand reaches out, and she calls, "Catra, wait!"
All she gets in return is a swift: "I said, shut up. Forget I've been here." Then the woman is out of the door before she can do anything. Ten or twenty seconds pass in silence, as Adora tries to comprehend what just happened. But when she finally musters the wit to stand up and to knock at Catra's door, trying to open it, it is locked.
"Catra? What was the meaning of this?" She gets no answer to her plea. It's dead silent behind the door. Again, she stands like an idiot before the woman's door, biting her lower lip.
It takes her some time to give up.

They don't talk about their encounter from last night.
It's a clear day, with only a few clouds in the south, hanging over the distant silhouette of the mountain range they are to approach today.
While they mutually sip on hot, black coffees Entrapta offered them without asking, Adora glances at Catra over the edge of her mug. The pigtailed woman joined them for like a minute or two, but now she's bouncing around, emanating restless energy like she hasn't passed out on the couch drunken mid night. Her cup still stands on the table, full, steaming.
Catra pretends that nothing has happened.

Upon her question, "Are you alright?", Adora gets a cool, unconcerned "Everything's perfect," in return. It's a bit too curt for

being sincere, and the lithe woman is unusually silent. She guesses Catra at least remembers something of what her drunken version did.
But she doesn’t poke her.
Reluctance isn’t Adora’s normal attitude. She’s rather the punching-through-it-type, barreling through obstacles, not calming them down. And yet, Adora doesn't want to poke her, not now, because today they need their concentration otherwise. If they wasted their last chance this night, then so be it. Whatever devil possessed Catra, this time it is not Adora’s fault.
Half an hour later and after saying goodbye to Entrapta, they are on the road, heading to the south, where this day shall finally mark their farewell, for good.

Despite harboring a populace of around 300.000, Vladikavkaz doesn’t really look like a major city. It lacks the high-rising structures of modern, western ones – whether beautiful or not – and the entire color scheme of the houses just looks *aged*, like from an era 50 or more years ago. Skin colored pink tones alternate with pale green and gray ones, the latter mostly on all these humdrum functional buildings of the 70s and 80s, still built in Soviet times. They mostly aren’t in a good shape, and not particularly well maintained city roads add to the picture. Yet, they are bustling with intensive traffic, making it a lively place before the nice mountain panorama of the rising foothills of the Caucasus in the south. It could be a beautiful place, but all in all, this city still looks… outdated. It’s like this place is stuck in the past for 30 years.
Rostov had at least been a bit more modern, even with the closed shops of all the western brands and companies, but here it’s like the 21st century never actually begun.
With all the money that has flowed into Russia from mostly Central and Western Europe over the last seventy years regarding buying gas and oil, you would think that the cities would’ve somewhat... more arrived in the 21st century.
But they haven't.
And this might be the consequence if wealth and income isn’t

distributed between a large middle class, but into the hands of a few oligarchs only – whom often and immediately have taken their money back to the west, because on what would they spend it in such a backwards nation anyway?
This is what happens when a nation has no strong civil society: a few people take over, loot the shit out of the natural resources and the economy, and leave all of it behind when times get harder, Adora ponders, while Catra weaves through the heavy traffic. She doesn't voice it, not wanting to spark another argument about political stuff.

Adora focuses on their surrounding, and what's noticeable is, that especially on important intersections and central squares, police cars and police officers can be seen again and again.
"They're not just here for traffic control, I guess," Adora says, a little uneasy.
"Eh, no. But it's not uncommon and has nothing to do with you. At least, I think so. Vladikavkaz is a cultural melting pot with many ethnicities. Ossetians, Russians, Armenians, Georgians, Ingushs and so on. There have always been tensions between them, even if the last years were calmer. I'm sure they've just ramped up security because some might take their chances for a little turmoil due to the war and the army being occupied otherwise."
The presence of the police force is unmissable, but as long as it is not directly aimed at her, she has to ignore it. Being extra inconspicuous would only draw attention to them. Didn't they want to plan details regarding the border crossing? Now, they barely even talked this morning.
Catra seems to have a plan anyway, because now she turns off the street, and pulls into a large parking lot between a reddish brick building with many ad signs on its sides, and a warehouse.

"What are we going to do now? What is your plan?"
Catra points at the clock. "It is shortly after nine. In general, the border station is only about an hour's drive away, not counting in any traffic jam. Our plan is to approach it in the late morning, before noon, when it's busiest, but we don't know how long the queue will actually be. It'd be best to have something to eat and drink with us." She points over to a building that hosts a store on

the first floor. “There's a supermarket. We can shop a few supplies, and stretch our legs for a few minutes before continuing. The police isn’t watching supermarkets.”
Adora nods. Despite she’s not keen to walk around in the open so close to her goal, it’s a good idea to fetch some supplies. Not having to leave the car again is a good thing, too.

They buy a few bottles of water and lemonade, some odd looking Russians snacks based on potatoes, but they are not quite chips, and a pair of sunglasses as well as a funny looking hat for Adora, like she’s on holiday. Not that this disguise will help much, when being thoroughly checked, but it can’t hurt either. When leaving the supermarket, Adora notices a little square going off from an alley to its side, where seemingly a local market is behind held. Out of curiosity, she points to it. A few more steps in the morning air will be good, too. Catra shrugs. They still have time.
The square is surrounded by the usual three-storey buildings of this area, with a few cheap restaurants and a café in them. The market completely fills the place, with stands offering fruits and vegetables, meat and other food, as well as local handicraft. As usual, Adora finds herself intrigued by all the goods made by artisan people, and starts to stroll over the place, Catra in tow.

A minute later, she has lost the woman. Dammit! She just looked at these wood carving pieces, and now she lost her friend?
Is Catra a friend? The question comes to her mind, while she starts walking back faster, searching for Catra. The market isn’t that big, is it? She can’t be far away. Her heartbeat fastens.
But the woman is nowhere to be seen.
Best would be to go back to their car, huh? It’s just over at the parking lot. Adora turns into the little alley leading back, when someone puts a hand on her shoulder. Startled, she wheels around.
“Sorry,” Catra spouts, looking a little agitated. “I saw you rushing, but couldn’t call you by your name, you know?”
She’s so relieved. “Where have you been?”
“Just got lost at a stall.” She pulls out a small paper box with a ribbon around, and hands it over to Adora, who takes it only after staring at it for a few seconds. “What—”

“Just a memento. Of our little adventure,” Catra hastily chips in, and looks down to the ground. Why is she so uncomfortable?
Adora gives the little present a searching look. This is… surprising.
“Shall I open it now?”
“No! Don’t! Do it when you’re back, in safety. It’s nothing big anyway.”
Adora puts it into her jacket, determined to look into it as soon as possible. Why did Catra do this, giving her a present? Is this some kind of apology for her behavior from last night, for her weird ambush that led to nowhere?
“Thank you. I will,” she lies.

As they walk back, Catra pulls out her mobile phone, fumbling to turn it on. Quickly, she notices how warily Adora watches. “I’m just going to check if the border is open. There’s a hotline for that. Would be bad to be captured in a traffic jam.”
Adora remembers that she explained to her that she turned the device off since they left Rostov, in order to not be able to be traced. So, this is probably a dumb idea.
And as if to confirm her fears, the moment the phone connects, it starts beeping from incoming messages. Very often. Catra looks a little caught while scrolling through. “Oh. I think I have to make a call,” says, and stops walking.

Assessing their situation in the back alley between the supermarket and the square, Catra illustrates Adora to go back to their car with handing over the keys and shooing her away. The brunette puts the phone to her ear and stays behind, while Adora slowly moves away. She hears Catra starting to talk to someone, but can’t understand it. The conversation is calm at first, but gets quickly heated, Adora can sense it from Catra’s voice.
Then, it’s quiet again. That doesn’t bode well.

She’s reached the car and settles into the passenger seat. When Catra sits down next to her, she makes a rueful face.
“I shouldn’t ve done that.”
Adora looks at her, but says nothing.
“It was Hordak. He asked me what I’m doing and if you’re with me. I denied it, but I’m guessing he knows that I’m helping you.”

“That’s… not good. And now?” Adora asks, uneasily, concern growing in her.
Catra turns on the car and grips the steering wheel. “Flight forward. He’s in Rostov, we’re here. He’s already put out his search, so what can he even do. Plus, the idiots are searching for a blonde woman, and if Entrapta’s little helpers work, they border guards are looking for the wrong name. Nothing about our plan has changed.”
“Good. Let’s not waste time,” Adora adds with a lot more confidence in her voice than she actually feels in her.

On the western outskirts of Vladikavkas, they enter the A301 road which touches the city and leads straight into the broad valley the Terek river formed since long ago. For being the only contemporary road link between Russia and Georgia, it’s not impressive. Just a broad, two-lane street, not even grade separated with the many little junctions they pass, and not particularly in a good shape either.
Quickly, the urban area vanishes behind them, and they enter a forest. Concurrently, left and right, the hills of the valley rise higher. Dense forests cover the slopes, which become increasingly steed. Behind the nearest tops, further in the south, Adora sees mountain summits, stony, woodless, and covered with remnants of the winter snow, stubbornly persisting on the shaded northern slopes still in June. This is surely a fast rising mountain range.

Away from the bottom of the valley, there is no visible human settlement. The slopes are mostly wooded, but the further they drive into the narrowing valley, the more arid and quilted it gets. It’s not like the Alps of Central Europe, which have become a good part of the cultural landscape and heritage of Europe, with century-old villages, alpine pastures, commercially used forests and a bunch of ultramodern ski resorts. This here, just ten kilometers south of the great city guarding the northern edge of a mountain range that used to separate this nation from the Middle East for centuries, it is almost untouched nature. But as the forests haven given way to barren soils, testifying to aridity and

little fertility. Only the road and an occasional little settlement beside the Terek river bear witness to human existence.

What proves humans more than anything, is that traffic is getting heavier, more dense. Alongside a dozen other cars, they are squeezed behind a lumbering in front of them, and another one behind. Sometimes, someone dares to overtake the truck, but when Adora asks Catra why she doesn't pass too, she mentions that she doesn't want to spark any attention and no possible accident. "And before this truck are a dozen more. It's of no use." It sounds reasonably, almost too reasonable for someone whose alcohol-soaked breath Adora had in her face this very night, muttering nonsense she still doesn't understand. Trying to avoid this memory, she tears her gaze away, and lets it linger on the landscape again. But when she follows the curvy road, she sees what Catra meant. Before them, trucks carrying goods, cement, and building materials sprinkle the traffic everywhere. She's right, there's no use to hurry.

Just a few minutes have passed, but the hilly landscape has morphed into steep valley walls, squeezing the river and the road into a narrow gorge now. The rock face of the mountain to her right side has pushed itself closer and closer to the road until it hangs halfway over them. It's a bit unsettling. In the Alps, this rock slope would've been heavily secured, with a lot of steel nets and barricades, or a tunnel would've been built. Here, nothing. Just an almost vertical cliff, where falling boulders could crush them anytime.

Between river and rock, the road squeezes its way south, and so do they.

A few kilometers further, the valley widens again. Alongside the road is a little settlement, maybe just three dozen houses, and a large gas station. Aside from the modern rest stop, everything looks outdated. Broken roofs, dilapidated front yards, dirty walls. Clearly not a thriving place.
"This is Chmi," Catra informs her, "the next town is Nizhnii Lars, and then comes Verkhny Lars, the place with the border station.

Only ten kilometers left.”
Adora’s gut tightens, her heartbeat fastens, and her body is flushing with adrenaline. This is it.
She puts the funny hat Catra bought her deeper into her face. Which is ridiculous, but anyway.
“How do you plan to do this?”
“We stay cool and drive through the checkpoint. They're looking for a blonde with another name, and that won't fit them anywhere. Stepanzminda is just half an hour behind the border. From there, you’ll catch a bus or another ride to Tbilisi. And that’s it. I go back, and we part ways for good.” She sounds so calm and calculated, but there is an edge to her voice, Adora can’t place. It may sound a little wavering, but she surely interprets too much into it.
If there was more, Catra would have acted differently last night. She’s just being an idiot.
“Adora, you can stay cool, can you?” Catra teases her. “Because last time I checked, you were pretty uptight and snapped faster than a switchblade.”
“That’s so unfair, to bring this up again and again. How many times do I have to say I’m sorry?” She knows she sounds complaining, but this little piece of… ugh!
“At least once more, Adora, as always.” [42]

Just right behind Nizhnii Lars, the valley gets narrow again, and a great service station with a parking lot, gas station and restaurant comes into sight, pressed against the mountain slope. Here, sunlight barely reaches the valley ground at this time of the day, with the sun hanging in the southeast. And before they even reach the parking lot, the already slow traffic comes to a halt.

They’ve reached the end of the queue, kilometers before the checkpoint. They are stuck.

Time passes slowly, and when it’s noon, the actual checkpoint comes into sight. For Adora, this is nothing but torture. Her mind supplies her with stupid ideas of getting out, climb the slopes and find hidden paths over to the Georgian side. Being trapped in this

narrow valley, with nothing to do, is unsettling.
“Shit. Shit shit shit.”
“What do you mean?”
Catra points to the checkpoint. This isn't some backwater crossing with some overworked customs officers guarding it. The Russians have heavily upgraded it. Large signs sort out trucks to several special lanes, where they are X-rayed, while the customs officers seem to inspect every few cars more thoroughly in a separate parking lot. People, standing around their cars, while uniformed men pull out every one of their belongings, are looking angrily at them.

And there are construction works underway, too, obviously intending to enlarge the entire border station again, with more lanes and checkpoints. [43] Everything looks like chaos, and yet, this is probably not that sort of chaos Catra was looking for. It is an *organized* chaos. When Adora turns to her, the woman looks baffled. “It wasn’t like this the last time I got here.”
“When has that been?”, Adora asks.
“It was just a few years ago,” she retorts, apologetically.
“Looks like they upgraded this, huh?” Both women screen the place over and over again, searching for information and possible weak points. They are still a hundred meters before the point where the road fans out into half a dozen lanes. But the queue is moving. Slowly, but yet.
“I don’t think this is going to work. This isn’t a backwater border crossing, this is a highly-modernized checkpoint, and they will surely put any documents through digital checks connected with FSB databases. If there is the slightest suspicion, I'm sure they'll pick up on that, Entrapta’s machinations or not. And if Hordak knows you’re helping me, they probably just search for two women in a car and inspect all of them,” Adora reasons.
Catra drums her fingers on the steering wheel. She has to think about it, the faster, the better. They still have time until it’s their turn, but Adora’s right. And thanks to the dozen or so checkpoints, the queue moves steadily. This is not like it was before.

It's chance that her gaze falls into the rearview mirror, where an official looking car has pulled out of the queue behind them, and now drives on the wrong side – of the oncoming traffic one's – overtaking them. There are two people sitting in the front seats. The driver and the passenger, the latter looking vaguely familiar, dark hair, and it's—

"Down!"
Catra reaches over and pushes Adora down and forward, making her squeeze half into the footwell of the passenger seat and half laying on the seat, *immediately*. She doesn't really resist. Adora notices how Catra puts her cap forward and down to hide her face, looking at the fittings on the center console, pretending to do something there, while she tries not to break her ankle. Her side hurts, too, the side where her wound is. The seat presses against it.
"What?", she whispers.
"Hordak", Catra grumbles. "The svoloch's here. In this car that just drove by. He's going for the station."
It's like the gorge gets even narrower, closing in on Adora. The slopes that shoot up left and right of the valley floor, which is just one hundred meters wide here, seem even more constricting. And they are. There is nothing except this one road they're driving, standing, waiting on.
"Shit," Catra adds and Adora says. "He wasn't in Rostov anymore when you talked, was he? He was in Vladikavkaz already, and…," and Catra cuts in "...he used the call to startle us up, the goddam fucker. I fell for it. He knew he would never find us in the city, but here, at the checkpoint, it's easy to pick us out."
"But how did he track me down? I haven't been identified anywhere, and there's nothing on me to track me."

Catra laughs, angrily. "I'm pretty sure he didn't track you, but me."
It needs a moment to sink in.
"Oh. That means… so, he concluded, that you're with me."
"Most certainly. I used my debit card to refuel on our way to Entrapta. And I used the phone in Vladikavkaz, too, like a rookie. That's traceable. Fuck. I didn't think he would go that far."
Looking up at Catra from her position, she sees the woman balling

her fists.
“What do we do? We can't try it here, that's for sure,” Adora states.
“No, we can't. We turn, go back and think. But first, we must leave this feeder immediately, before he picks up on us. We must not approach the customs station.”

Before them, Catra halts, resulting in the opening of a growing slot to the car up front, and she slowly steers them to the right side of the road. It’s already started to fan out, they have little time left before they are trapped in the lines.
Maybe it's luck, but on the opposite side, a slow truck opens a gap for them to turn in. Swiftly, Catra pushes the accelerator down and hurls at the steering wheel as far as it will go. Adora wasn't prepared for the harsh speedup, and bumps her head on the passenger door, letting out a loud “Ow!”
“Don’t be such a crybaby,” Catra snarls
Their vehicle makes a jump forward, picking up speed, and they are on their way to where they came from.

The minute they leave the narrow valley behind and Vladikavkaz appears in front of them again, it’s like a weight is lifted and Adora start to breathe again. She scrambled back into her seat a minute after the border was out of sight, but they stayed silent until then. The weight of their failed attempt to get her out of Russia is unpleasant.
“That was… close,” she finally lets out, and mentally prepares herself that they head into the city to sit down and make another plan.
But Catra has different ideas, which becomes obvious when they reach the same roundabout they used before, and takes the exit to the west, out of the city, and not into the center. Only a minute later, they leave it behind, driving westwards on a road that seems to wind directly along the northern, forested slopes of the mountains. As fast as possible.
When Catra says nothing, Adora raises her hands questioningly, asking: “I assume that means you have a new plan. Shall we go back to Entrapta? It was a good shelter.” For a split second,

images of the woman's elaborate *playground* come into her mind, the toys and tools, colorful and piercing. She shakes it off. That's not what this is about.
"No. I don't want to endanger her. We drive as quickly as possible. We must put some distance between us and him." Catra grips the steering wheel tighter.
"But what do we do now? Where are you going?"
Catra grimaces at her, then inhales deep and points at the northern foothills of the Greater Caucasus. Behind the slopes at the front, the mountains rise higher, showing sparkling, beautiful summits with snow caps. "We now have but one choice. We must face the high passes of the Caucasus. Be on your guard, there are more frightening things than Hordak in the gorges of these mountains. It's a four-day journey to the other side. Let us hope that our presence goes unnoticed." [44]

Chapter End Notes

This is the largest chapter I ever wrote. Could've split it up, sure, but I low-key wanted it like that. I'm happy it's done, because I really ran out of stamina at the end.
So, here we are, up and ready to face the high passes of the Caucasus.
In preparation for the next chapter, "The Roof of the Caucasus", I strongly recommend giving this BBC documentation your precious time. It's funny, and scary to watch: "World's Most Dangerous Roads – Georgia".
Furthermore, there's a good amount of innuendos for the final chapter in this one. You'll get it, I promise.

Footnotes & Sources:
[38] The peninsula of Crimea had been a part of Russia since the 18th century. In 1954, the Politburo of the Communist Party under Chruščëv - actually not the Supreme Soviet of the Soviet Union – ordered that Crimea was to be "donated" to the then Soviet Republic of Ukraine for not really clear reasons. At this point, Crimea was already mainly Russian by

origin and mostly Russian speaking. That didn't change much till today: 60% of the population are still Russian, and only a quarter are Ukrainian.
The Russian annexation of Crimea in 2014 appears to be a direct consequence of the public discussions about a NATO membership of Ukraine since the Euromaidan, and clearly the trigger. The unlawful annexation is therefore countered by the fact that the majority of the population of Crimea has no problem with it, because they see themselves as Russians rather than Ukrainians.↑

[39] How about having a look at this useful information about frightening roads here.↑

[40] Since 1990, the today rather pacifist Germany has reduced its military spending and downsized the army from around 500.000 men to under 200.000 and abandoned mandatory service in favor of a professional army since the zeros. The term "peace dividend" was often used for this reduction, enabling the country to spend federal money otherwise. In the light of the Russian attack on Ukraine, the German government and parliament unanimously and cross-party decided to enlarge the military budget and put a special fund, twice the size of the annual budget, on top, making it the fourth-largest military spender worldwide for several years to come, behind the USA, China and India, topping the UK, Russia and France for the first time since decades. Amongst NATO-ranks, it is widely seen as an overdue move, despite the shadows of the past a more capable German army has always sparked mostly across Eastern Europe. Those concerns have now all but disappeared.↑

[41] The Kuban is a river in Northern Caucasus, and eponym to the region through which he flows. ↑

[42] Yeah, I stole it. And what are you going to do about it?↑

[43] "Russia enhances clearance capacity"↑

[44] Yes, this is a paraphrase. I'll explain it right in the next chapter.↑

The Roof of the Caucasus

Chapter Summary

> As the road takes them high into the mountains, their journey becomes more dangerous by the minute.
> Catra thought she got this.
> But she miscalculated.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Six months prior

Adora stands in the office of the Secretary General of one of these organizations, underpinning the vast network NATO has spun across the European continent. She's heard of the woman, and knows who she is, but of course she never talked to her in private before. This kind of people were and are way above her pay grade.
Yesterday, though, Angella recommended a meeting with "a friend, and she would be pleased to meet you in person, Adora, please consider it", and Adora never disregards Angella's ideas and wishes easily.
So, she went and met with someone nobody in the public has ever heard of beside maybe a mention in a footnote of an annual report of the NATO budget talks or something like that. The military has always been good at hiding the important things right amongst many unimportant ones.
And yet, the unimpressive person sitting very relaxed on the couch opposite of her, with an arm draped over the backrest, is one of the few women amongst NATO ranks powerful enough to command troops *and* budget alike. A rare thing, because NATO command structure has always been a bit messy, regarding representation. Not so much in terms of gender distribution. The military is still mostly men's stuff, after all, even if women slowly make their way through the institutions today. It's rather about

nationalities. Never has the SACEUR[45] not come from the USA and never have Non-Americans held the key positions of command, even if NATO pretends to be a happy little international circus of equals.
They aren't, and yet, here she is, the short Polish woman with the bright blonde undercut and select snarky comments regarding the end of The Long Peace[46], disconcerting Adora like she hasn't been for years.

It's the sixth of January 2022, the weather outside is chill, but it hasn't by far felt as cold as the sentence the woman in front of her just spoke. The words still resound in her ears, and the drink of heavy alcohol she was offered before with the words "You might need it", is still standing on the glass table, untouched, steady. Adora, on the other hand, has difficulty holding herself upright.
"You can't really mean that," she finally voices, disbelieving, putting her hand on the backrest of the couch she still stands behind, because she didn't take the offer to sit down. She now reconsiders and curses herself for being so stubborn.
"I'm afraid I can. The facts are clear. We know he's going to do it, it's just that we don't know exactly when. There's no need to worry the public with things they can't do anything about it, too, so sorry for not running around and screaming like kids. We also don't want to telegraph our own countermeasures too openly. But what's for sure is that in a few weeks from now, we'll be as good as at war with Russia. I mean, NATO AND the European Union. Ukraine certainly will be. Putin has finished his built-up alongside borders, and we estimate his order of attack for the beginning of February, depending on the weather conditions."

Adora is rarely stunned.
She's always been quick to learn and adapt to situations, been lightning-fast in her reactions in combat situations, and she rarely hesitates. But this is different.
"You mean, a real, full-blown war? Russia invading Ukraine? That doesn't make any sense. You can't conquer such a large nation with 150.000 soldiers. That's what you said he has, right? The

Germans tried it with one million in 1942 and didn't succeed. This is complete madness." They both know what they're speaking about. The military calculations aren't exactly rocket science. These matters have been studied extensively a thousand times. The woman shrugs. "I'm stating what's going to happen, not that it's clever. And just to make it clear: we won't call Article Five, though. Ukraine is not a NATO member. But; we will help them as much as we can without making this war global." She shortly pauses, for the accentuation. "And a nuclear one. We're not stupid."

Ooff.
Adora could take a few minutes to process that. She has not, because little Madam So-and-so just goes on with derailing her. "Anyway. I didn't bring you here to talk about that. This was just information up front."
"Oh, goddamn it," Adora blurts out because she *just can't*. A fucking war is going to happen, and this was just the built-up? Really? What else now?
"Easy," the woman says with her raspy voice, "you'll get the good news in short order. I want to commission a project from you."
Adora raises her hands questioningly, seeking for more.
"I want the Russians to see what they're doing to the Ukrainians. The feeds are already full of numbers and political rhetoric, and that's just going to increase. I want them to see the people they're going to hurt."
Adora blinks, then immediately shakes her head. "I don't do propaganda. You have your… minions for that."
"I do, and if I need a public service announcement, about intimate disease or tax evasion, they're fine. But you have a following, and you have style."

Adora has never been good at taking compliments, and certainly not by some shady NATO official she doesn't even know, recommendation or not. She finds it rarely believable that this woman has ever seen her channel. But that's not her problem. "I have credibility that state media doesn't have, and you'd like to exploit it." That's totally true, and they both know it while staring at each other.

"I'm not asking you to lie for me. I'm asking you to tell the truth. To tell, what is. Isn't that your motto? Not just the statistics, but what they mean. The lives lost. The pain suffered. All the things regular Russian newsfeeds will skip."
"Do you think that's gonna change anyone's mind?"
The woman waggles her hand slightly. "It might. A few, on the margins. You can put a human face on the victims. And make it just a little harder for the Russians to feel good about killing Ukrainians." She leans forward and looks down, making a little, artificial pause. When she continues, she pretends lightheartedly and her voice is nearly sweet, uncaring, quiet. "Or don't. And wonder, with every new attack, if that was the one you could've stopped, and you chose not to."
It's silent for a moment. Interesting, that it can be that silent in this huge building, full of people and busy activity.
"Wow," Adora finally says. "You give a really good guilt trip."
Her counterpart nods, still not looking at her, being absolutely serious. "I practice a lot, when I'm alone."
"I'm sorry to be so blunt, but that sounds… messed up."

The eyes of the Secretary General meet hers again as she shrugs her shoulders. "Do you think this is an easy, representational job? It's what it needs to take over a position like this," she says, and gestures at the desk, the couch, the office, the building, encompassing everything under her watch.
"See, this isn't going to be on operation of ours. That's just one of my little eccentric ideas, which is about *not* shooting people. It won't show up in our reports. The expenses with which I'm going to cover for you will barely interest the auditors. This is the military, and no one messes with our small side spending. We pay more for one laser-guided missile than I'm going to throw out on you, meaning no disrespect. And yet, I think you can make a valuable contribution. Talking to people is what I really do the entire day. You do, too, and it's certainly as effective as shooting them. Given my position, you might not believe me, but I actually think that *not shooting* people is *good*."

Adora laughs dryly, because on a weird level, she understands her perfectly. If it wasn't so degrading of having the unvarnished truth

about her irrelevance peppered in her face like that, the woman would be pretty funny.
"I… see," she slowly replies, hardening herself.
"We're not going to help you in the field with anything. That's out of our reach. But we support you with equipment, finance, and tech up front, as well as data connections. Angella will handle it. Out there, you're just on your own, as usual."
Adora nods, already feeling trapped. "As usual. I can't put anyone in danger just because of me. But tell me, are you really trying to win me for this job? Doesn't sound very convincing to me."
"Hah. I know how you are. Angella speaks only highly of you. That means a lot. And you're still here, and still talking. If I don't get the easy way out, neither do you. So? Are you interested?"

Adora stares in the air for half a minute, not saying a word. She hates being tricked into anything, all the more into anything like this. But… if that is really going to happen, then it will be the greatest war the continent has seen since 1945. And where else would she be anyway, telling *what is* to the people who need to know.
"I need that drink now," she finally says instead of an answer and grabs the glass. They both know what she's going to do anyway.

And that was how she got the diplomatic passport, and the military grade satellite phone.[47]

Today

"We now have but one choice," Catra says. "We must face the high passes of the Caucasus. Be on your guard, there are more frightening things than Hordak in the gorges of these mountains. It's a four-day journey to the other side. Let us hope that our presence goes unnoticed."
Despite the situation, she sees Adora narrowing her eyes like she doesn't believe what she just heard. Adora's voice is pretty snarky when she says: "That sounds like you have stolen it from a movie."

Catra grins with the defiance of a kid caught at the cookie-jar, but the laughing noise she makes is not quite laughter; it is too choked for that. Her eyes glisten. “What? Never. Such western garbage is not for us.”
Of course, Adora is way too stubborn to let it go that easy. “You know what? When I’m thinking about it, it sounds really familiar. Wasn’t this what Gandalf said to the fellowship when they entered Moria? You watched Lord of the Rings, admit it.”
“Absolutely not," she retorts with crossed arms.
Adora isn’t swayed. “Judging from how perfectly you mimicked him, you did not just once.”
Catra’s typically not a fan of all the sugarcoated western dramaturgy for retarded adults, and prefers stories with a bit more… bite and strength to it. In every sense. But LoTR is for many reasons still the best movie trilogy ever made, and she will die on that hill. She could talk hours about the movie, but however, Catra wouldn’t be Catra if she admitted anything. “That’s false western propaganda, and I’m not falling for it.”

Adora is delighted. Because *a lot* of things fall into place now. She’s maybe a bit dense when it comes to other people, but this is something she gets. Her hand claps before her mouth, stopping herself from giggling. It doesn’t really work. “Oh my god, I got you wrong the entire time. You’re pretending to be this wicked, bad woman with a grumpy attitude, not caring about anything, but really, you’re just a nerd. I can’t believe that I fell for it.”
A growl makes it out of Catra’s chest, and despite her words, it’s unbelievably sexy. “Use this word one more time, and you can find the way alone. I’m abandoning you somewhere in the mountains. There are a lot of gorges to dump you in. No one will find your body.”
But Adora continues, mouthing: “Awww, Catra, the movie nerd. This is so awesome. And I thought you were scary.”
“Do I have to smack you to get you to shut up?”, she groans, getting more serious. Adora’s clearly getting on her nerves, and she doesn’t like to be mocked. All the more when it’s at least partly true.

Luckily, her stupid passenger gathers herself and looks at her, but she has to keep her eyes on the road. She pretends to be concentrated, but her gaze keeps wandering to the side, to Adora, and she notices how much the formerly blonde smiles. Broadly.
Then, Adora salutes and voices very sweet: "Yes, big baddie, I mean: Yes, ma'am! At your service! Trying to be a good girl from now on!"
Ugh! She hopes that Adora dies from a lightning strike right now!. She also hopes Adora doesn't notice the shiver running over her arms, and how her hairs stand on end. The dead straight road they ride westwards to Alagir is certainly no reason for any excitement, but the woman's voice puts many inappropriate thoughts in her mind.

But maybe Adora picked it up, though, because now she got quiet, still looking at her. A part of her wonders what the sudden change would possibly mean, the innocent, clueless version of herself, the young woman she once was when she hadn't seen so many things she should've rather not. Another part, a more feral, unhinged one, understands it on a deeper level.
Adora, the clever, pretty, naive idiot, has certainly never allowed this part of her to flare to life. Never.

Whatever Adora noticed or not, she asks: "What's your plan now?"
Catra shrugs her shoulders. "As I said, we're going to face the high passes. It's not a joke. We will use the Mamison, that's our plan. We'll take it from there."
"Didn't you say it's something like a horror trip?"
"Yeah. But in case you haven't noticed, there aren't so many options left. It's the only way to get you over this mountain range with traveling by car, and all other options are worse. Do you want to hike over? I just hope that Hordak doesn't come to the same conclusion."
"And what if he does?"
"Surprise me with a better suggestion, Adora." It sounds as soft as it sounds final, and Adora - to her surprise – stays silent afterwards.

Forty minutes and one traffic jam later, several rural villages have rushed by, and they reach the town of Alagir. The small city sits at the entrance of another great valley leading into the greater mountains piling up in the south. Behind the bridge they approach, Catra sees a large roundabout, from where one road leads northwards into the town, and the other exit dives into the valley of the Ardon. The small river is a tributary of the Kuban, and just an innocuous stream in the middle of a large riverbed, filled with boulders and rubble here, testifying to a different character and great floods in the snow melt of spring.

Despite its majesty, neither she nor Adora have an eye for the beauty of the landscape behind. Both fear they are still being followed, and Catra wants to have as much lead as possible. The speedometer needle has always stuck exactly to the 90 km/h mark. Completely against her nature, she has driven so defensively, as to not get into any trouble, but she also knows that Hordak doesn't have to give a shit about the speed limit. If he's following them.
She fears he's following them since they turned at the border. She can't let this get to her, though, not now.

They cross the Ardon on the bridge, and the roundabout behind is encircled by two gas stations. A look at the fuel gauge tells her it's a good idea to refill here. Even if the distance to the Mamison is not so large, just around a hundred kilometers, the point is that she doesn't know about the infrastructure in the valley further south, as she's never been there. What she knows is, that the pass is located at almost 3,000 meters, and Alagir is just at 600. When they leave the Transcaucasian Highway, the road will just be winding up and up at the end of a mostly abandoned and empty valley, and there certainly will be nothing beside a small guard post at the pass itself. Nobody uses this road besides tourists these days. And even these might be rare.
The route to get there is only half the battle anyway, the next 100 kilometers, down into the Rioni valley on the Georgian side, are unpaved and said to be in horrible shape, one of the most dangerous roads of the world. She doesn't mind a little thrill while driving, has often done road trips beside the highways when she

had time, but dying in a car accident because they crash down into a gorge isn't the way she painted her demise.

Despite she doesn't want to waste any time, not even a minute, she decides to make a short stop here, where it's busy. And they need some other stuff, too.
The one station from Gazprom greets her with the typical modern blue-white colors. With a grin, she steers the jeep to the other one, just because she hates Gazprom.
Sometimes, things are simple.

Catra has moved the car to a parking lot beside the station after she finished refueling, and rummages through the trunk, storing two additional petrol cans. Since their little conversation, Adora stayed silent, and now she sits on a small wall at the backside of the parking lot, stretching her legs, and shielded from passers-by on the not-too-busy street and roundabout by their Jeep and the building itself.

She's thinking. Thinking about this sort-of-plan.
All of this isn't working so well, but she sees little other choices, too, and guesses that Catra is right. She doesn't like it, though.
"Adora?"
Catra has obviously finished, slamming the trunk lid shut.
Hearing her own name from Catra so… normal is a bit challenging. Catra has rarely used it in the recent days, often replaced it with epithets like "dummy," "idiot", "fool" or the ever teasing "Heeey Adora." She knows the brunette doesn't mean it spiteful, and Adora doesn't mind the banter they developed. Catra risks much for her, she can cut her a little slack and tag along. Plus, she finds it funny too, in fact she even likes it, and she gratefully pays her back with needling the other woman when she can. She's often not as witty as Catra is, but that doesn't mean she can't try.

She's uneasy, though.

The entire situation is unsettling. Despite she's grown very fond of Catra's companionship, she wants to get out of Russia as quick as possible, too. Travelling with her feels a little like a road trip

amongst friends, and it would be awesome to do that with Catra. But it also feels like the entire Russian nation itself has turned into a hostile environment, even if many of its people are not fond of the war either. It would be interesting to make reports and documentations about what the ordinary citizen thinks is going on with their nation, but talking openly has become outright dangerous today. People are thrown into jail for just calling this war a *war*, and not a 'special military operation'. In western societies, the attempt to control how people *speak* would be regarded ridiculous and ignored.
But it isn't.
In a society as represses as the Russian today is, it's just like in 1984. Controlling the way people *speak about something* is an effective way to control what they can do and what not about the things their government does. And it seems to work.
The early protests against the war have all but vanished – as far as she knows. Educated, liberal Russians have been leaving the country all the time, but now they're surely leaving in droves. And all those not so smart, capable or willing are left behind in a more monolithic, poorer, and slowly degrading culture. And while they'd never made up the majority of it, they'd been a loud voice of an otherwise weak civil society. Some elders, the mothers and fathers mostly, of soldiers pressed and tricked into fighting in Putin's army, have voiced their concerns, but meanwhile they have been silenced, too, by gag orders and intimidation.

And a lot of people are going, because they lost hope that the situation will get better ever again, under Putin. With the only slow-action sanctions, the country is gradually retrograding back into the last century. The Russian economy has been barely on par with Italy during the recent decade, and in a globalized world, where several billions of people work together in terms of specialized labor forces, North Korea gives a good example of what happens to a nation when it's cut off from the world. Russia clearly moves into that direction. It hasn't even felt that bad in Afghanistan, because the Taliban didn't care about what people talked about as long as it didn't touch delicate religious matters and as long as they held power. Here, Putin even wants to

control about what and how people *speak*. And freedom of mind and speech is what Adora's entire profession is about.
She can't stay here.
And she can't put Catra into more danger for her selfish needs.
She has to leave, even if a part wants her to *stay*.

"Don't we need something else?", Adora asks.
"Snow chains," Catra states, and points up to the mountain peaks. They still have a bit of snow way down their northern slopes, in the shadows of crevasses. "I've heard the street conditions are much worse on the Georgian side, and the chains help when it's muddy, too. I'm going to fetch some at the station. But we shouldn't have to worry about the filling, it should last twice the distance we have to make. And we have reserves. I'm buying snacks, too. I'm starving. Shall I bring you something?"

Adora shoots her a gratified look, replies, "I don't mind," and feels a little guilty about all the expenses the woman has to make for her. Catra waved any comment about it off, when she asked her about it yesterday, and Adora believes that it isn't really a problem for her, but nevertheless: Catra spends a lot of money on this.
On her. It feels a little off, too.
While the lithe woman seems to plunder the gas station like a scavenging horde wreaking havoc across a defenseless village, Adora waits on her little wall seat outside, and enjoys being able to stretch her legs. And the not too hardly burning afternoon sun of an otherwise nice day. When her hand unconsciously reaches into her pants pocket, she feels the little present Catra gave her this morning, and remembers her intention about it.
Slowly, she pulls it out.

Curiosity.
As always, she grins wryly to herself. The language of her adoptive nation calls it "Neugier", a portmanteau of the components "new" and "greed", an oh-so-well and fitting word for what the motion really is: the *greed for new things*, for discovering what is yet unknown, for seeing what you haven't. The great motivator of humankind, beside convenience. She's always been a curious explorer, never afraid of finding out what

lies at a place she doesn't know yet, and it has often warred with her other traits. Of being reliable. Of acting responsibly.
She turns the small package in her hand.
Catra asked her not to open it before they parted. But this is *her* present, now. Catra gave it to *her*. She can do what *she* wants with it. It's not really a decision. It's just her doing. Her fingers move quickly to open the little box.

A medallion greets her.
It's made of steel, dark and shiny, polished steel. A thick coin, almost as big as her palm, with a thin leather band through it, to wear it as a necklace. The coin is formed as two hands gripping each other in a firm handshake.
Much like comrades or friends would do. It seems that a piece of cloth is loosely draped around them, to somehow underline or seal whatever these hands agreed on. Just two human hands, joining effort in an attempt to help each other. To look out for each other.
It's beautifully made, a masterpiece of intricate lines, making the hands realistic and a little three-dimensional.
Is this how Catra sees her now? How she sees them? As friends? Probably.
And if she's honest with herself, despite the pretty present, the thought is a little… disappointing.
At first.
She hoped the other woman would see more in them, perhaps. Just… more. Her grip tightens around the jewel.
But then again, to what use would that be? They clearly don't have a future in being more, and her stupid longing for Catra's touches is a whim that has to fade soon. Their ways will part, inevitably, and her egoistic needs do not help here.

The longer she thinks about it, the more beautiful and fitting she finds the coin. In a way, the medallion represents hope. That Catra and her can probably stay friends.
It feels weird, right and wrong at the same time. Their respective nations and entire ways of life are in an undeclared war with each other, and have maybe always been. But Catra has been so helpful to her, and she likes her so much that she wants to kiss

her again, to do more with the pretty body and the mind of the woman behind. She can't—

"Adora, hop in. Time to move!", Catra calls on the backside of the car, and a pack of snow chains rattles down on the ground, while she opens the trunk to put them in.
"Yes, sure." Luckily, the brunette hasn't seen that she unpacked the present. While Catra rounds the Jeep to get in, Adora makes a quick decision.

Not a minute later, Catra takes the roundabouts exit southwards. The road turns into a two-lane express street, leading into the valley. Catra pushes the car to 115 km/h – just a tad over the limit – and they quickly leave the little city behind. Again, forests cover the slopes of the valley that gets narrower the more they drive into it.
Their joy of having a newly built road under their tires comes to an end soon. Just a few kilometers further, and while they are just slowly gaining altitude, the valley turns into a gorge again, and the street is back to one lane.
It makes a gentle bend to the west around a mountain ledge, and suddenly, above them, a monumental rider, carved out of the rock itself, appears before them. The road passes almost directly under it.
The huge figure with a grim expression and a helmet on its head sits on a horse that is jumping forward, out of the rock ledge, and looks like it's about to come down on them any moment. The shapes of the statue are hard and angular.
And it's awesome.
"What is that?", Adora asks, impressed.
"The monument of Nykhas Uastyrdzhi.[48] You know him as Saint George," Catra explains, adding: "He's said to help men who are in need and sorrow."
"Well, we could use that, can't we?", Adora replies light-hearted and points to it.
"Only the men," Catra insists with a flat voice.
"What?" Her arm falls down again.
Catra sounds really snarky when she informs her: "He's a patron

of men only, not the women. For us, it's forbidden to even speak his name. Instead, we must refer to him as 'The Saint of Men'."
Adora raises her hands questioningly. "But you spoke his name just now?"
"Yeah, and? As if I care about such stuff. And if he's really a saint, he won't mind such stupid superstition, made up by *men*." She raises her finger and points at the monument they're rushing by now. "Hey George! Watch out for us!"
Adora can't help but to giggle, and shortly, they do both. They fall back into a now a little more comfortable silence.

But quickly, Catra's mind supplies her with problematic questions. She has known about the existence of this giant sculpture, has seen it on photos, but they can't waste time to admire it.
Not now. Not with the enemy perhaps on their trail.
It is there where her trains of thought derail. She really thinks of Hordak as a threat, trying to detain Adora, which is something she just doesn't want to happen. The problem is, that, in extension, she perceives what he represents as a threat, too. But she doesn't understand why. It seems the right thing to do, to help her, but then again, why? She never cared for the right thing, did she? A very quiet part of her mind tells her, that a good part of this is motivated by something like greed. Adora should be *hers* for the taking. Nobody elses. She shushes the stupid thought. It's ridiculous.
And Adora? She's a kind idiot, a self-proclaimed hero-wannabe perhaps, but the woman certainly doesn't see it that way. Instead, the sweet but stupid dummy seems to wander through her life with an ingrained faith in the good. Catra knows that the world is different. She has never been spoiled, and lost for long or never had this kind of naivety in the first place. It was always hard to stay a kind person in Russia, but in Putin's Russia, the cynics and misanthropists have taken over the society and state, slowly and steadily wiping out the civil society and any sort of resistance who wanted a more amenable and liberal one, replacing it with an atmosphere, where the cruelest and greediest always wins.

And in some way, she just tags along, has done it since her childhood.

She always has, and didn’t really question it. She doesn’t feel beholden to Putin and his henchmen, or the state itself. But she appreciates her rise in the military ranks, and the recognition that comes with it. Being a Major, soon a Colonel to be, comes with a certain standing in this kind of society, and she low-key craves for it. It’s not really vanity driving her. It’s rather… need. She acknowledges that quietly, and also that she hasn’t seen anything wrong with it.

Until now.

The woman on her side makes these certainties starting to slip, just with her presence, and Catra the fuck doesn’t know why that is.
Why does Adora do what she does? And more important, why does she herself do what she does? Helping a fugitive. Wanting Adora physically shouldn’t spill over like that.
Hovering over her last night, and not being able to voice what perhaps slumbers in her, has only fueled her stupid confusion. She wanted to kiss the sleeping woman so badly, and could only hold herself back in the last moment, and then Adora stirred. It broke the spell.
Yet, her physical desire alone to seduce the pretty dummy, to drag her to bed and probably fuck with her until they're both unconscious, just isn't enough of an explanation for what she does now.
It’s not enough.
Why does she do it, though?
What if this is more than just an infatuation over a beautiful stranger?
What if this is more?
Catra’s grip around the steering wheel tightens, because she dreads that she most certainly won’t like the answers to these questions. All she knows is that her ground got pretty muddy.

Unaware of Catra’s ruminations, Adora lets her gaze roam over the landscape again. It’s not different from before, at the Terek river. Forests, very little signs of human presence, and rising mountains. While they slowly gather altitude, the valley makes a

bend westward, only to return southwards a while later. Every now and then, a small, unspectacular settlement presses itself on one side of the riverbed at the valley floor, while above them, sometimes frighteningly steep, the rock faces tower. And again, as before, the deeper and higher they advance into the mountains, the more arid and meager it gets. Trees on the northern slopes shrink, while the southern slopes are covered with dusty meadows that bear no sign of cultivation. Abandoned and mostly half-ruined hill forts made of stone line the way, bearing witness to a time long gone. Half an hour later, the valley widens again, and obviously splits to the east and west, with a large dam sitting at the junction. Above them, snow caps cover the tops of mountains reaching four thousand meters.

Catra sighs relieved. "Okay, we've made the first part. We leave the main road here, and head for the pass road. There comes the fun part. I hope you're free from vertigo." Adora grins at her and gives a thumbs up. "No problem."
"Good. It's going to be slower from now on. I don't know the area, but I bought a map at the gas station."
"Shall I drive for a while?", Adora offers suddenly. "So you can read it and guide us?" Adora doesn't say that she's not used to be driven around. To be *pampered*. But it's coming through. She wants to do something, too. Be of use. If driving is everything she can offer, it's that.
Catra hasn't really thought about handing over the oar, not driving herself, but it would be good to have a pause and to be able to look at the map herself. It's clearly more exhausting here than in the lowlands. And from now on, it's all bumpy side roads, she doesn't know the terrain, she doesn't give a shit about the car, and with Adora pleadingly looking… "Okay then."

Before the dam, on the sides of the valley, sit several buildings, mostly belonging to the power station of the dam and some older structures that must've been a village before the dam construction destroyed it and flooded the rest. They change positions when their road leads over a little bridge onto the western side of the valley ground, while the road moves above them and along the eastern side of the steep slopes, where it vanishes towards

sunrise. They drive through a short tunnel and when they leave, they've gained a little altitude, have passed the dam, and besides it sit numerous buildings. It's not a village, it rather… has been one.
The most prominent structure is a Russian garrison, though.
"Just drive by. Don't stop," says Catra, reading the map, but she sounds tense, too. With her heartbeat quickening, Adora doesn't take her eyes off of the road winding its way along the steep slopes. The garrison lies a little beneath the road, on an artificially formed plateau, and it seems to be recently built. Its roofs are shimmering from the ever same blueish-grey tiles the Russian military always uses for its buildings.

There is nothing happening on the premise, though. Just a few troop carriers stand around, as far as they can see the inside from their heightened position. A short branch leads from their street to the entrance of the garrison, where guards stands. Adora drives carefully, her attention on the road as they pass it. She feels the guards watching them.
Her heart drums.
She's so close to get out of this damned country.
But the guards do nothing.
Once the garrison gets out of sight behind the next ridge, she hears Catra letting out a soft blow, and her heartbeat normalizes. It looks like nothing's going to happen, at least not now.

Has there been little traffic on the so-called Transcaucasian Highway, there's none on this road. They are alone on the street, leading into a broad valley that looks uninhabited. The longer they drive, the more the paved main road transforms into a bumpy gravel track. Still manageable and without big holes, but already clearly different from before. It slows them down, Adora notices, with a bit of tension. She barely makes it above 40 km/h now. Before and at their sides, the mountains of the Great Caucasus rise higher and higher, reaching four thousand meters and more easily now. The northern slopes are covered with forests, where the remnants of snow fields stubbornly resist melting between the trees and in crevasses, while the southern ones are mostly

covered by short, sturdy grass, unused dusty-green willows which have possibly been worked at times long ago, but have been abandoned for decades now. And above them, stony mountain tops, some still snow covered, and untouched by man. Other than a power line and the road, no other infrastructure is visible.
In the European Alps, this would've been turned into a huge ski resort, with ski lifts everywhere, Adora muses. Here, it's just nature. Beautiful in its own way, without human presence. Man might've claimed this valley in former times, but today, it is a quiet place, with even little wildlife, it seems.

Beside her, Catra turns around and looks behind them.
Adora doesn't mind it the first time, and she also doesn't the second one. They pass some ruined buildings, unfinished constructions from Soviet times perhaps, built on the meadows of the broader valley floor.
When Catra turns around a third time, Adora asks."What are you doing?"
"I thought I've seen a familiar car behind us. Wanted to check up on it."
Her grip tightens and her foot presses the accelerator a little more down. "And?"
"Nothing. It's gone, or maybe I was wrong."
Instinctively, Adora looks into the rear mirror. It's of no use, because the winding road allows little sight.
"Do you think Hordak is following us?"
"He already proved to be no idiot. He maybe decided that he did everything possible over at Lars, and now he's checking up here too, making sure the guys here understand what he wants. They surely laid no telephone line up there, and our satellite phones don't always work." She doesn't say that rampant corruption often leaves them without the equipment that was actually paid for.

When the valley splits into a southwestern and a northwestern arm, the gravel track starts winding up the slopes of the mountain ridge in the west. It's manageable, but Adora has to concentrate. Rarely, bushes line the road, and sometimes their branches grow right into it, testifying to how rarely anyone comes along here.

Maintaining this godforsaken road is clearly no priority.
“This would be nice for a documentation,” Adora jests. “World’s most dangerous roads or so.” Catra huffs, but isn’t sure where here displeasure is aimed.
The road takes turn after turn, the panorama becoming ever greater, but Adora is hauling at the wheel the whole time, while they move up the serpentine and ride along the edges of the slopes. As they turn around another edge, the pass comes into view on the other side of the high valley the road now moves into. There's still a lot of snow remnants up there.
Adora wants to speed up, but Catra stops her: “Wait here. Just for a minute.”
Adora obeys. A short pause would be good, and now comes a particular difficult part, so she just stops in the middle of the road. They haven’t seen other traffic since they left the highway, and that was an hour ago.

Catra jumps out and approaches the edge of the road, looking down into the valley with her hand shielding her eyes from the sunlight coming from the southwest. She looks so pretty when she’s standing straight, her attention all focused, Adora can’t help but to think. What if she hugged her right there?
She sighs and grabs two of the water bottles and the bag of snacks and fruits Catra got at the gas stations and puts them onto the car roof. She fetches an apple for herself, and walks a few steps to loosen her limbs.
“Seen anything?”
“Not yet.”
“But you think he’s after us.”
She shrugs. “It’s just a hunch.”

Maybe this would be a good opportunity to ask Catra about the events from last night, when she… Oh goodness, the woman had been so near, just in a tank top and boyshorts, and with her loose, curly mane. Adora didn’t feel ambushed or afraid. Just a little… cornered. Like prey. Happy prey, do be honest, ready to be conquered.
But why did Catra do that, when she’s so clearly not into Adora anymore? Adora hasn’t forgotten the woman’s words when she

caught her in Entrapta's little playroom. But why this weird ambush, then? She should ask again. Here, Catra can't really run away and evade her.

While Adora's still pondering about the pros and cons of elaborating on her confused emotional inner, Catra starts cursing and points down the valley. "Fuckfuckfuck!"
Adora follows her hand.
Not more than a few minutes behind them, a gray Jeep has come into sight, struggling up the serpentine road, and not really slow by doing it.
"I knew it. It's the same car. It's him."
Adora already wipes everything back into the bag and tosses it onto the back seat, practically hurling herself behind the wheel again. Catra jumps into her seat, and a second later, Adora's pushed the accelerator.

Her careful hesitation from before is mostly gone. Now every minute counts and she has no idea what awaits her up there. Adora drives as fast as she can. She hasn't heard a word from Catra since they got back in, but she notices the firm grip the woman has around the handle over the passenger window. The road has not gotten any more lenient, but now they know that time is running out.
Hordak is after them, after Adora, and he's not slow.

They pass the floor of the deserted high valley where the road bends into it. At this altitude, vegetation has become sparse. This is rather a steppe, covered with short and stubborn grass where it's not rocky, and a few struggling and sad spruces and firs here and there. This is way above the tree line, the pastures on this basin have clearly never been cultivated or worked. Here, just nothing is. Even the road seems to dissolve at times.
But Adora has an aim, and pushes for it. Before them, the last ridge they have to pass arises, the lowest point of the Greater Caucasus crest, at 2.900 meters, and she drives the gravel track up with power. Because behind them, their follower is doing the same, and it looks like he's catching up.

It takes them ten minutes and two nearly misses of crashing down the slope to reach the pass. If this was a novel, it would be a bit anticlimactic.

Adora sees the road reaching the ridge top and looks out for anything resembling an outpost, a garrison, anything they have to get past.
But there is just nothing.
The vertex of the road, where it passes the mountain, is just more remnants of snow fields, rocks, and dust. Beside the gravel track itself, it is untouched high alpine landscape. There's clearly no border station or something like that.
What is this?
Catra and her look at each other, obviously having the same fucking question in mind.
When her gaze falls down to the Georgian side, it becomes all clear.

Of course, nobody would be so stupid to built anything up here. Why would you? Instead, the fucking checkpoint obviously lies hundreds of meters downwards on the *fucking other side*, where a tiny outpost sits on a point where the slopes aren't that steep anymore, ogling a road that is probably used no more often than once or twice a month by stupid tourists, but not by anyone sane.
This godforsaken place on earth, Adora groans internally.
"Go!" shouts Catra, shaking her out of her stupor, and Adora pushes the accelerator again, pebbles and dirt splash up behind them as the Jeep jumps forward and leans into the first turn of the fucking serpentine leading down.

The funny thing is, there is *no* Russian outpost guarding the border. Where it apparently lies, just a half-sized and old sign tells everyone that from here on it's Georgia. It stands at the side of the road, which leads alongside a steep hillside, and is maybe a hundred meters away. And the unimpressive small concrete building on the *other side* belongs to the Georgians, which the huge white flag with the red cross makes clear. It's just another two or three-hundred meters further, where there's more space at

the downhill side of the gorge. Freedom and safety are ahead of Adora, they're at the grasp of her hand.

And, though, she can't reach it.
At least not with the Jeep.

Because three large rocks efficiently block the road right in front of them, massive enough to stop a tank. That was surely done on purpose. They can't get around if they don't want to crash down the gorge. Two of the Georgians soldiers standing before their station look their way, obviously having watched their crazy descent for a while. Presumably rather out of curiosity, because, well, this is such an abandoned place. They've clearly seen them —and that they're not alone.

Catra hears Adora breathing heavily, but she realizes that she's panting hard, too. The air is thin up here, and not just in a metaphorical way. Turning around, she looks back at Hordak's Jeep coming closer quickly, already passing the last few turns of the mad serpentine road.
"Get out," Catra says, a moment before Adora can. "Run."
They hurl out of the car, and Adora starts running. Only a moment too late, she realizes there's nobody beside her, that Catra doesn't. Adora stops and turns. The woman still stands beside the Jeep and does nothing. She just looks back.

"What are you doing?" She calls out loud and is yelled back at.
"I stop him, dummy. What did you think I'm going to do?"
"Come on, Catra," Adora begs. She doesn't mind how pleading she sounds. She just wants them to cross that damned border.
"What? Going with you? I'm not doing this because I like you."
Oh.
Of course not.
Adora didn't think. She's so stupid. Of course, Catra wouldn't leave Russia with her. That would be stupid. She's stupid, having assumed that—
"I can't just leave you here like this. Come with me. You don't have to go back there. We can fix this!"

Now Catra turns to Adora, glaring. She can't cross this border. It would be a step too much. She's not prepared for that step, and probably never will be. With the option and the begging dummy right in front of her, something inside her resists against being pushed and shoved.
"Are you kidding? I've known you for what, a couple of days? And now I should throw everything away for what? Ugh!"
"But—"
"Go, you idiot. Your time is running out. I haven't brought you here only to lose at the last moment." She makes a few steps towards Adora and thrusts her back, towards the sign showing that from here on it's not Russia anymore. Adora doesn't resist, but is confused. She doesn't want to leave Catra behind. Fifty meters behind them, Hordak Suchorow's Jeep comes to a halt behind theirs, grinding. The tall, wiry man gets out of the car, and he has a gun in his hand.

This is getting much too real for her taste.

But the border is close. Just a few more steps on this menace of a road, where the drop to their left hand is deep, then Adora is safe.
"Go, move, you idiot."
Adora is apparently not smart enough to distinguish the important from the unimportant things, because she's still not helping, needing to be pushed and shoved by her. How can someone be so stupid?!
Maybe they should've talked before, Catra quietly admits, but now it's too late.

Hordak is not far behind her.
The sign is right ahead.
With a last push, she shoves Adora so far that the woman comes to a halt on the other side of an imaginary line, only existing in her mind. Anyway. It's done.
Probably.
"Stop!"
Hordak is now standing only ten meters away. His weapon raised, and it points right past her.

To her surprise, she isn’t scared. Instead, she’s quite cold, looking back at Hordak Suchorow with a mix between disgust and anger. Quickly, Catra puts herself between him and the seething woman behind her, shielding Adora with her body. She doesn’t even know why she does that. But she won’t let him take this little victory away.
“Take down your weapon. She’s not in Russia anymore.”
His fists are clenched as he approaches another step. Anger furrows his face.
“Unfortunately, that is up for debate, Major Volodova. This is treason. You know that.”
“We’ll see about that. And how you gonna prove that. As far as my superiors know, I’m still on holiday. And we don’t like it when some FSB spooks want to tell on one of ours.”
“You are a fool if you think that is going to work. You won’t get away so easily.” His voice is cold.
“Ha. You can try. My word against yours. And anyway, Adora's not within your grip anymore.” She can literally feel Adora bristle behind her and hopes that the dummy doesn’t do anything stupid. Like crossing that line again.
“You can't do anything to her. She’s safe from you.” It’s maybe a bad idea to tease him. Yet, she strongly doubts he’s going to shoot Adora with the witnessing Georgians.
And maybe she’s right, because he lowers his weapon.

Hordak Suchorow looks at her with nearly the same mixture of disgust and anger, Adora stared at him just before. The weapon in his right hand still points at the ground. Through clenched teeth, he presses out: “You're right, I can't do anything to her.”
He raises his pistol again and aims at Catra, coolly, without any emotion. “But with you, it's something else entirely.” He nods toward the Georgian border guards who are still a hundred meters away, unsure what’s playing out before them. And too far away, Catra realizes, to stop Hordak from doing anything.
“Don’t count on them. They won’t fuzz around about a Russian. And this is how we deal with traitors.”

For a moment, she is dumbstruck.

She miscalculated.

This isn't how this should've played out. Never had she thought that *she* could be the one looking at the end of his gun. Her hands start to shake a little. Behind her, the Georgians start yelling, but she knows that nothing will save her. Not from this distance.
How could she make such a mistake?
"Goodbye, Major," Hordak says, toneless.

A distant part of her brain follows the situation very analytically. It's impressive how slow everything happens when you are able to witness your own death with the highest level of attention, flooded with adrenaline, yet unable to do anything because thoughts are so much faster than nerves. Catra is forced to watch how Hordak triggers the gun, and in the same moment she's pushed aside, as a sharp pain hits her shoulder. She tumbles down ungracefully, lands in the dust and gravel of the so-called road of the fucking Ossetian Military Road, and eats dirt while skidding over the ground.
Her sight is getting a bit fuzzy from the blow that pushed her down. Instinctively, she caught herself on her palms, but now they hurt, scratched and ruptured as they, are smeared with strains of blood.
And her ears still ring so much from Hordak's shot. Behind her, the Georgian's border guards yell something at someone. They must've gotten nearer. Catra turns her head towards the shouts and can make out that they have risen their weapons and come closer. Everything is dimmed.
Her thoughts are not working very well.

What happened?

Her sight clears slowly.
Catra realizes two things: Hordak still stands a few meters before her, still behind the border and looks at her with disgust, the gun is still in his hand. For a few seconds, Catra catches his gaze, still not realizing what happened.
Then, the spook looks to her side and puts his gun back into its

holster. The Georgians still yell, but he just ignores it. With cruel and bright clarity, she hears him mumbling, “Also fine”, then he turns around and retreats to his Jeep with no haste at all. He doesn’t even look back at what he has done or gives a shit about what the Georgians yell.
He’s on the Russian side, and they won’t dare. They learned that lesson back in 2008. [49]

Catra’s eyes fall to her side. Her pupils dilate. Her heartbeat fastens.

Adora lies in the dust and dirt of the road.

She’s on her back, her hair is splayed across her head in a total mess, her limbs are stretched, twisted.
She is far too quiet.
But her eyes are open, looking into the sky.
And yet, her face looks so sunken.

“No,” Catra whispers, propping herself up, ignoring the pain in her hands. Bandages would be good, but she doesn’t give a fuck. Hastily, she scrambles over to Adora.

The once-blonde angel just lies there, and does nothing. Her eyes slowly seem to focus on hers, trying to recognize, but now they are closing. Catra hovers over her and her stupid brain supplies her with thoughts of how beautiful Adora’s hair is, splayed around her head in this wild, pretty pattern, like a halo surrounding the strong yet so kind lines of her face.
A gentle wind blowing plays a little with her hair. In the distance, she hears a car getting quieter, driving away.

It can't be, not after all they went through. The woman can’t die here, not in her hands! Catra grips Adora's shoulder and whispers at her, knowing how useless it is. ”Hey, I’ve got you. Are you okay?”
Adora’s eyes flutter open, but she apparently struggles to keep them like this. “I’m sorry,” she weakly says.
Catra snorts desperately. “For what are you sorry, you idiot? Stay

with me. I’m not letting you go.”
With a sigh, Adora smiles weakly, winces. Then her eyes close, and she gets completely limp in her hands.

It takes her a few moments. Her brain wasn’t fast enough to catch the realization of what Adora just did. Now, it washes over her.

The woman just threw herself in the line of fire for her.
Tears dwell in Catra’s eyes. She can’t breathe good enough.
Her hands find Adora’s cheeks and cup them slowly. It’s starts as calling, but turns over to screaming. “No! No, no, no, no, no! Adora, come back!”
Nothing.
“You can't just leave me like this. Don’t you get it! I need you. Stay!”
She gets no answer from a woman who has gone silent.

Chapter End Notes

The next chapter is called "One last night", and half of it will be smut.
Spoiler!!!

Be assured, that I could never kill Adora.
Back to lighter things: Originally, I planned the girls to cross the border at Verkhny Lars, escaping Hordak at the last second via running or something like that. But during my research… things happened. You probably won’t believe what sparked writing the girl’s flight over the Mamison Pass, but don’t worry, I’m here to have many words about it.
If you haven’t already done, please, let me introduce you to Hugh Bonneville (more commonly known as Robert Crawley, 7th Earl of Grantham or to the elder folks among us as Bernie, the unsuccessful banker) and his colleague Jessica Hynes, who both traveled across Georgia for a ridiculous BCC documentation and have a heartattack-inducing road trip while they cross the Georgian region of Svaneti, which is

where the Mamison Pass lays. They use a different road than our girls have to use, but it's the same region.
Please, give this BBC documentation a gentle look and take the time to watch it, it's just a pleasure to follow both of them and listen to their conversations while actually putting their lives at risk. I really admire their guts to travel these roads. When Bonneville voices "Confront your fear" while chickening around just minutes later, it's just beyond funny, too. They have a great dynamic going, and the landscape and their cultural encounters are beautiful to watch. Some of these regions are cut off from the Georgian heartland for three to six months a year because of winter. Modern roads continue to be built in recent years, and they probably change these circumstances a bit, and yet, the region is going to stay a distant and closed-off part of this great mountain range. When watching the docu, I knew what I had to do.

I also said to explain why the Georgians won't dare to shoot Hordak. Please read the Wikipedia article about the Russian occupation of Georgian territories since the war of 2008 for a broader understanding of that topic, even if it's barely enough to get a good grip of it. But I want to point out that Russia still has artillery in firing range of Tbilisi, the Georgian capital, just around 50 kilometers away.

Footnotes

[45] The SACEUR is the Supreme Allied Command Europe, the commander of all US and European NATO troops and this person has always been a US General, as the USA is the largest troop contributor. SACEUR is always dual-hatted with that of Commander of USEUCOM, United States European Command, which includes almost all US troops in Europe: United States Army Europe, United States Naval Forces Europe/U.S. Sixth Fleet, United States Air Forces in Europe and United States Marine Corps Forces, Europe. This sums up to around 100,000 troops. USEUCOM covers an area of focus of 54,000,000 km² and 51 countries and territories, including entire Europe, Russia, and Greenland. ↑

[46] "The Long Peace", have a look at what this means here for

around two minutes, starting at 14:20. The graphic shown around the 16-minute mark is tremendously impressive. Get the full, interactive version of this at http://www.fallen.io/ww2/, but do this after finishing reading. It's too gripping. ↑

[47] The middle part of this dialogue I have taken from S06E02 of "The Expanse", when Chrisjen Avasarala talks to Monica Stewart on board of the UNN One, persuading her to do exactly the same. I spun up the rest of this paragraph around it, and I like how it turned out.↑

[48] Have a look here, it's awesome. ↑

[49] I explain that in the afterword.↑

One last night

Chapter Summary

> “That’s what you wanted anyway, isn’t it?” she replies without any judgement in her voice. It’s a statement, and maybe an acceptance of defeat.
> “I can sleep on the couch,” Adora offers, restrained, like a little girl.
> With a short laugh, she waves the ridiculous attempt to avoid what’s going to be inevitable off. “It’s fine. Don’t pretend.”

Chapter Notes

> Just a note: a good part of this chapter is smut. I'm sure you're here for that.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“I need you. Stay!”

The scream breaks through her dizzy consciousness like a punch. The desperate voice drags her out of her stupor, and electrifies her like being hit by a defibrillator. She feels a breath bubbling out of her chest, flaring to life, no, it’s rather a cough, more coughs, heavy coughs.
What has happened?
Catra.
Catra has happened.
She needs her.
She has to go back.
Deeply, she sucks the air in.
Adora opens her eyes. Before her is Catra’s face, and her expression is desperate, and puzzled, and caring like she didn’t see it before. The lines in her beautiful face only accentuate it perfectly. Now, it morphs into questioning.
“You need me?”, Adora quietly asks, and gets that she sounds raspy.

Catra can’t believe it. A small laugh escapes her, she can’t help it. A croaking “What?” is all she can manage, while still holding Adora in her arms, her head in her lap. She’s overwhelmed by all the unbridled feelings inside her, now getting unleashed. How come that Adora is not gone?
“I thought you were dead. I thought Hordak shot you.”

Adora slowly nods and weakly grabs at her chest, or rather, around her neck and tugs at a soft leather strap that was hidden under her shirt. Then she takes out the steel amulet Catra gifted her, in Vladikavkaz.
In the steel disc, at the back of one of the hands, is a deep notch.

From where the bullet hit it.

“You unpacked it?” Catra asks, aghast.
“You need me?”, Adora asks again.
She knows herself that her answer is much too high-pitched, but she can’t suppress the half-laugh half-cry pouring out of her.
“You’re such an idiot! You just got shot and that’s what you ask me?”
Slowly, with a smile creeping onto her face, Adora nods. “I need you too. I just didn’t realize it. It’s so… new. But when he aimed at you, all I wanted to do was to save you. It was all I could think about.”
“You could’ve died, you dumb goat!” Catra perhaps knows that she could be a little more lenient with the happy grinning woman in her lap, but this is— Ugh!
She gets a firm answer, without hesitation. “I had to protect you.”
Catra cups Adora’s cheek with a gentle touch. “You are an idiot, aren’t you?”
Adora nods again, still weak, but with a smile growing. “Yeah, I know. But you said you need me too. That’s not very clever of you too, you know?”

“Ah, shut up.” Catra lowers herself and kisses the woman passionately.
For a short moment, Adora stiffens in her arms, perhaps even startles. But now she softens, wraps her arms around Catra’s

waist, and then she feels pressed. And kissed back.
It's wonderful.
Adora is a good kisser.
She might've had some training, Catra very slowly thinks, but disregards the thought because it's so unimportant. Adora is hers. Their tongues mingle, tease lightly, while their lips press against each other with verve. She's perhaps moaning a little, and that would be embarrassing, she doesn't moan, doesn't need other people, but who cares. She needs Adora, needs her, needs to be close to her, needs her everywhere. She will—

On the street, still a few meters away, and clearly not needed, four Georgian border guards stand around and at least three of them scratch their heads at the vision playing out in front of them. There are two women lying on the floor, one of them in a Russian military uniform, the other one seemed to catch a bullet right before, and now the madwomen make out in the middle of the road.
That is a sight they don't get every day. Perhaps no one ever did. They watch the madness before them unfolding for, like, minutes, before they finally decide to actually do something about their job.

Adora is so relieved that Catra isn't harmed, that she finally made it into safety, that she doesn't really care what happens. What's even more important is, that while they are brought to the Georgian border station, she never let go of Catra's hand. When one of the border guards, a younger man, tries to separate her from the brunette, she hisses and holds out her other hand for being cuffed or whatever they want to do to her, as long as they are not separated.
Catra, for once in her life, says nothing. She just grins like she won a great victory or whatever, but her possessive grip around Adora's hand never falters, too. Still, she revels in the softness of Adora's lips, the abundance of Adora's want. If she's a bit dizzy about it, that's fine.

To their luck, one of the guards understands and speaks English very well, and after a quarter of an hour of heated debate, Adora

persuades him to let her make a phone call to bring light to a situation they are clearly uneasy how to handle it. After all, nothing really happened, not on Georgian territory at least, beside a woman dodging a bullet for another one, and then much kissing. Which isn't really a crime. The weird women are still kissing right now, while they are one footstep away from being detained.

When Angella picks up the line, she sounds a little surprised, presumably by the strange number she's called from.
"Hello?"
Adora lets out a small blow before she starts talking. She's already nearly crying just by hearing Angella's gentle voice. She doesn't get far. "It's me. Adora. Hello—"
"OH, THANK GOODNESS. You're alive!" The relief blatantly pouring out of Angella's voice, cutting her short, is nearly too much for her. Adora never really doubted Angella's good-natured affection towards her, but her own traits made it sometimes hard to believe it without the little inner demon asking herself if she really deserved it. If she did enough to warrant it.
"Yeah, I'm not dea—"
"Where are you? How are you? What happened to you, my dear? We were worried sick since our—"
"I know! I know! I'm sorry Angella, really, I'm so sorry that I couldn't reach you earlier." She falls silent because she has a lump in her throat. Guilt is creeping into her, that she didn't try to reach out harder. The last days and weeks have been so wild, exhausting, she barely thought about her friends and the woman who's like a mother for her. Now, all this trembles down on her, and she falls silent.
"Adora. Do not, I beg you!" Angella's voice is suddenly calm and comforting. "There's nothing to apologize for."
A croaking "What?" manages it out of Adora's throat.
"I'm just so happy that you're alive. We nearly lost hope to ever find you again. We couldn't even think about the possibility that you died in Mariupol, and that we would never see your beloved face again. You are alive, and that is what is important, Adora. Do not feel guilty, my child."

Angella calling her that drives her over the edge.
A single sob makes it out of her mouth, before she claps her hand before it, but more follow. Her next words just leave her mouth before thinking. They do crying.
“I’m so sorry, mom.” She has maybe called Angella that three times in her life. She has no hesitation to do it now. “I’m so sorry. I didn’t—"
Angella’s voice is unbelievably soothing, and if the people watching her find her crying immoderately, she doesn’t care. “All is well, my child, you’re alive, and everything else, we can handle. We will.”
Adora cries even more.

After that, Angella handles the tasks at hand, and handling them, she does. Adora gave her an overview of her - their! - situation, then Angella speaks with the officer letting Adora call in the first place, obviously asking him about his chain of command, and afterwards she tells Adora to wait a little. To just sit, and wait patiently, and to keep the line free until she calls back.
It needs another two hours, a lot of phone calls and many promises by Angella towards the Georgian Minister for the Interior so that Adora and Catra are set free again. Some time of nervousness, expectancy, and a few, now shyer kisser between two women never letting go of holding hands like obsessed teenagers later, the phone rings, and whatever Angella did, the guard in charge stands at attention. Not a minute after the call with his superior ends, it rings again, and it’s Angella, demanding to speak with Adora. She sounds calmer now, and like being in control.
And this lets Adora feel at ease like never before.
“Don't worry about it,” Angella says. “You can go. Your... acquaintance too. As far as I understand, she was helping you. I assume you have some means of getting you down to Tbilisi? Organizing something would take a little time.”

Well, she actually doesn’t know about that, but Adora’s sure to figure something out. Their entire plan didn’t think so far as to how to get out of the mountains after she crossed the border. The worst part of this road is probably yet to come. But Adora doesn’t

want Angella to do more, and so she says: “It’s fine! I got this.”
They talk a little more, but not even two minutes after the short call ends, they are free to go, with being practically shoved out of the station and led back to the car by one of the officers.
On the other side of the border is nothing but silence.
The movement back there has – unfortunately – broken the spell tying them together, that had led them holding their hands until now, where they stand beside the car and are alone again.

Somewhat puzzled, they look at each other. A small grin creeps onto Catra’s face while she asks: “What the fuck just happened?”
Adora shrugs, nearly laughing. “I have no idea what she did, but it’s clearly working.”
“Who is ‘she’” What person has that much influence?
“Uhm, Angella. My… adoptive mother.”
“Aah, the woman from this NGO, right.” It’s not a scoff, not really, it’s too short and silent for that. But somehow Catra is envy that Adora has someone who can pull such strings. And that she has probably none. And soon, she has not even Adora. She still has no clue what to do now.

“Yeah,” Adora weakly smiles, then adds with this little kid-grin: “What are you going to do? I think, you’re free to go back. But…”
Catra looks back, over the border, up to the pass they crossed a few hours before. It’s illuminated by a low sun in beautiful, rich colors now. Evening is approaching, and she should probably—
“But?”
“You said you need me. How did you mean that?” Adora’s saying it so open and obviously prying that Catra can’t help but to groan.
“I needed you to live. It would’ve been such a waste of my time if you died right there, waving all my efforts to get you here safely. I couldn’t let that happen.”
The bummer is so visible on Adora’s face, it makes Catra laugh. She takes Adora’s hand again.
“I can't very well let you walk from here. And who knows how long it would take the guys over there to organize something.”
Adora, clearly picking up on what she’s about to imply, starts to shine so bright that it’s outright annoying. When Catra says: “I’ll take you to Tbilisi,” it sounds a bit grumpier than she wanted it to.

Yet, she should've perhaps expected what follows. It's still a surprise when the other woman steps forward, and embraces her into a deep, strong hug.
"Thank you. Thank you. Thank you," Adora murmurs into her neck, and Catra has rarely felt so good in her life. Maybe… maybe she can let it happen for just a little longer. Just a little.

"Come on, dummy, we don't want to be caught in darkness," Catra finally says, and gets behind the steering wheel again. They do, but their relief about the quick release is countered when both women realize that the road is shittier than Catra even described. In fact, this is outright mad, insane to travel on.
Not even two minutes after their departure from the border stations, they have a slope on their left side that drops deep, going down hundreds of meters almost vertically. Catra was never frightened about heights, but this is different.
"I can't believe you roped me into this," she says tense while concentrating on driving, but Adora actually chuckles. It's such a sweet sound, coming from the gorgeous woman. Even in this threatening situation, she can't help but be delighted by the noise of Adora's sweet giggling.
"Hey, that's not fair," Adora says, "you suggested this."
"No, I didn't", Catra retorts deadpan. "I suggested staying in bed."

Again, Adora giggles, but this time, the sight makes her sad. Because she knows she'll lose this soon enough. Because Adora won't stay. And then, the thought of the woman leaving makes her angry.

Catra never gets to have what she wants.

Never. Why didn't she tell Adora what she wanted to say to her last night? Why didn't she pin the woman down into the mattress and kiss her then? Would that have been so hard to do? Given they kissed just now, she wouldn't have been rejected another time, presumably. Too late, as always, Catra scolds herself. She's such an idiot.

Adora has obviously noticed the change of mood, asking: “Hey, what’s up with you? Is something wrong?”
And Catra, despite her better judgement, does what she always does when she doesn’t want to make herself vulnerable: She shakes her head, presses her lips together, and says “It’s okay, dummy. This is just hard to drive”.
Regarding their situation, and the necessity to pay full attention to steer the vehicle, Adora doesn’t pry, and that is another point why Catra doesn’t feel like to talk. If it were important to her, she would ask, wouldn’t she?

In some way, Catra is equally thrilled as she’s scared. Not that she would ever admit the latter. “I have never been a lay-down on the beach person. But this is ridiculous.”
Adora remembers the helipad they saw beside the border outpost, and it suddenly makes a lot of sense now. In any case, a periodic supply flight is likely to be considerably smarter than losing ten percent of your people on these roads every year.
“Perhaps I should’ve asked Angella about a heli evacuation again,” Adora tries to jest, to light the mood, because they desperately need that when Catra nearly slips them off into the gorge the third time. What she gets are big eyes and a hiss in return.
“What? You could’ve done that? I mean, she could do that?”
“I don’t know about here. But she did it, back in Kabul.”
“You were in Kabul” The flat voice says everything about how much Catra beliefs her.
“From June to August 2021, yes. I mean, did you forget that I told the story just about… yesterday, at Entrapta’s?”
“Maybe I was a little drunk?” She wasn’t that drunk. She just didn’t listen well, and the memories of yesterday are shaded by her own embarrassment.
“But, August….”, the pause Catra makes at the end gives away that she puts together the timeline of the events with the fact of a heli evacuation real quick. “And this got you a heli evac when the Taliban stormed the city.”
“I wasn’t exactly making holidays there, you know?”
“Oh, I believe you. What I can’t believe is, that you didn’t ask this angelic woman to bring you down from these fucking mountains

safely. If she can just get us free with a few phone calls, she can surely make the Georgians get us with one of these Black Hawks the Americans gave them. Instead of, you know, letting me chauffeur you down this fucking hell of A MOUNTAIN ROAD? Ugh! That's it. I'm done with you. That's too much. I can handle the fucking FSB, for sure, but not this!"

Adora vacillates between apologizing, defending herself and giggling. Out comes a restrained sound that doesn't make any sense, while she desperately tries not to break out into laughter. "I'm sorry," she says a little later, not exactly sure why. She's halfway certain that Angella doesn't have this kind of influence here.
A little later, when the road got a bit more *unmad*, she says: "It was scary, you know?"
"What do you mean?"
"To watch the Afghan government crumble so fast. Their military units just rolled over to a bunch of quite ill-equipped illiterates, and I'm not meaning it in a mean way. Most of the Taliban warriors were just kids, or our age. But they nearly didn't have to fight to take over town after town when they advanced to Kabul during July and finally August. Those were terrible days."
She falls silent, realizing that she's not really in the mood to pull up the memories of her last hours in the Afghan capital, when thousands of people tried to flee the quickly advancing Taliban troops. She remembers with shame the poor performance her adoptive country made, not really helping all the people who desperately sought shelter because they were in actual danger. As so often, it was the Americans who just acted pragmatically, and filled their planes to the point of insanity. More than 100.000 people were evacuated in 14 days, and Germany accounted of only around 5.000 of them. She remembers the cries and the desperation of people, waiting in the chaos around the airport, while huge C-17 Globemasters roared over them in emergency take-offs, filled with twice their load.
"Why were you there?", Catra suddenly asks after a little silence.
"I wanted to make docus about the life of women under the Taliban's joke. Turned out to be the wrong time. Or the right one,

depending on the point of view.” She makes a weak smile.
“Sounds like a thing of yours, to be in the wrong place, at the right time, huh?” Catra is teasing her, she gets that, but it’s not vicious.
“I’m not a hero. I just do my job.”
“You know, for someone who says she’s no hero, you sure end up being one a lot. Anyway, one day I really want to hear that story. That Kabul story,” Catra says, and sounds nearly… relaxed.

It’s a beautiful wish.

Thinking about both of them, talking about their life stories, the little events, the times when nothing happened. Maybe they would sit aside of each other, looking over a beach, or a lake. Maybe they would be cuddling. Adora could put Catra between her legs, lean back, and brush her messy mane, weaving her fingers through the thick curls, feeling the softness of them, sensing the skin of her neck. Hear her laugh while she tells her a silly story of how she messed something up.
That would be wonderful.
But they won’t have that future.
They probably won’t have any opportunity to actually talk to each other after tomorrow again.
And the thought makes her sad.

As her gaze falls back over Catra’s form, she notices. “It might be a good idea to get you out of your clothes,” Adora suddenly says, and Catra feels her eyes going wide. What did the dummy say?
“Out of my clothes?”, she asks warily.
“Your uniform, Catra! Not what you think. I assume the Georgians are not really fond of it. You said they hate Russia.”
Adora has a point there. “Should be enough if I take my jacket off. The pants are pretty neutral.”
The other woman regards her pants maybe a little too long. “As you say. Should I drive again?”

It’s early evening, and they’ll have an hour of daylight at most. Yet, they need a short pause for Catra to change out of her jacket and rummage through her backpack for something else. The

temperatures up here don't really allow running around in a shirt, and the Jeep isn't exactly isolated, never getting warm in it. While she slips out of her uniform, Adora stands at the edge of the gorge and looks over the beautiful panorama.
"Ooohh! Catra, look, an eagle! Can you see it?" Adora points into the sky and bobs on her feet like a little kid. Her childlike excitement is so sweet that Catra wants to kiss her again. But since they made out and rode on, it looks like that both have fallen back into their previous *attitude of pretending*. She's unsure what to do with that now. So she stands across the car with folded arms and says: "It's just a bird, Adora."
"But oh my god, Catra. It's majestic," Adora breathes reverently. "You're such a sweet nerd, really."
Adora turns towards her and smirks with folded arms. "We had that nerd discussion already." She points at her accusingly. "Movie nerd."
"Ugh, whatever," she replies while putting on the leather jacket, pretending not to be aware of Adora's glances as she does.

Adora has taken over the wheel and long slowed down to walking speed, and Catra has long stopped teasing her for it. In fact, she's happy that Adora drives. She would've perhaps not have the necessary patience to drive that slow, but the road clearly demands it. Sometimes there's a narrow strip of scree next to the drop, that makes the road seem a little safer. Then again, there's nothing at all except a steep slope thirty centimeters beside their car, that goes two hundred meters down. Certainly, cars lie there, and possibly their dead passengers too. Nobody would know if someone slipped off the road.

Like it's fate reminding them what can and will happen if they do, their next discovery is not so sweet as the eagle was. Rounding another of the innumerable rock edges, the road winds around, it then widens a little into the hollowed mountain over it. It just means that two cars could pass each other here, instead of helplessly facing each other with nowhere to go beside backwards.
A little shrine comes into sight, standing in the half-formed cave of the overhanging cliff face. It's just a small gravestone with faded

pictures of three middle-aged men on it.
With walking speed, Adora passes it, because she doesn't dare to waste time, no, not with sunlight fading so fast.

Not five minutes later, they encounter the first living soul since the border, and it's an old man, walking along the inner side of the track into the direction they just came from. He has a walking stick, and given his looks, he's apparently a local. Adora brings the car to a halt and leans out of the window.
"Sir, do you speak English, or Russian?", she asks, repeating it in Russian and English alike.
To their surprise, the man with the gray-whiteish mustache nods and answers in Russian. "Of course, I speak Russian, young lady. The svolochs have forced their language on us long enough."
This makes clear where he stands. "That's quite a frank statement, if you don't mind me saying," she says.
He huffs shortly. "I don't."

Adora continues: "We wondered what happened up there, with the men on the shrine."
"What does it look like, girl. Their car dropped into the gorge, it is such simple." He nods slightly, then adds: "The road is very dangerous and merciless. You can't lose your concentration even for a second."
"Sounds like you know something about it, sir?"
"I helped to build it, but that was a long time ago. Today, I'm just enjoying nature here."
Adora admits that if this was a holiday road trip, hiking here would be beautiful, and perhaps immensely calming. Driving, not so much.
"Can you tell us how long it's to the next village? We kinda… got lost a little."
He laughs. "Tourists. You folks never really care to prepare, do you?"
She shrugs. "It was kind of an accident that we got here. Didn't really plan it."
"That must be quite a story. But don't worry, Shovi is just a few minutes away. I'm from there. Just making a little evening stroll."
"Oh, that is great. Thank you. Ahm, do you think we can find

accommodation for the night there?"
The man frowns. "Our hotels are probably full. It's summer holidays. But a little further down are a few more guest houses, too. You can try it there. Sometimes, they have a place left."
They, or rather, mostly Adora says goodbye and drives on. The old man didn't promise too much. Just after a few minutes, the road broadens with the slopes getting flatter, until it reaches the ground of the high valley.

The – very small – settlement the man called Shovi looks more like an accumulation of three larger hotels with a few surrounding support buildings, sprawling on the meadows of the valley ground and surrounded by mountains with vast coniferous forests. A stream runs through, and the climate is obviously much more humid here, now they've reached the southern part of the Caucasus. It's green, and calm, and just a few people seem to come back from their hikes of today.
One of the hotels is, unfortunately, closed due to renovation and the other ones seem to be fully booked.
"It's because of the summer holidays," a passer-by Adora asks about it tells her. "Everyone is fleeing from the heat of the valley." But he recommends them to a bed and breakfast a little further down the road, where they should be provided with a bed for the night.

The sun has already set, and she drives a bit faster than before, now, that the road got more lenient. When glancing over to Catra, she realizes how tired they both are. Catra has been quiet for a while, leans at the side, and clearly struggles to keep her eyes open. She's half-asleep. No wonder, given what they went through that day. Adora still feels the hit from Hordak's bullet on her chest, where the amulet was pressed deep into her skin. Again, Catra saved her life, even if only unintentional.

Catra is fast asleep when Adora stops in front of a normal living house that has a green sign indicating accommodation hanging on the front of the yard. With the help of hands and smiles and gestures, she and the elderly woman offering it come to an understanding. It probably helps that she looks so exhausted.

She’s shown a small and simple bedroom with two beds and a window looking over the valley.
And afterwards, Adora struggles a little to carry a sleeping Catra bridal-style into her bed, takes off her boots, and covers the cute, slightly snoring woman with a sheet without another word. It would be nice to talk about the events of this day, about what they said and did after their… revelation.
But Catra is clearly out of it. And if she’s honest to herself, she is too. All her usual energy has left, been drained.
When Adora flops back on her bed, it doesn’t even take her two minutes to fall asleep.

Despite the road is still fucking crazy, and scaring every now and then, because hey, who cares to built side posts next to a one hundred meter drop, it’s not the same as yesterday. The further they climb down the southern side of the Caucasus on the Ambrolauri-Tqibuli-road via the Nakerala Pass, the better the road gets. It’s still sometimes not well paved, because it seems to need to adapt to sudden changes of its track due to alike sudden land- and mudslides. Despite it’s much more settled here, with a lot of villages and smaller cities, the landscape up the hills and mountains is still mostly wilderness.
But it’s not the adventure it has been yesterday, and the tops reach barely more than 2.000 meters anymore. The snow caps have vanished behind them, as has the fright of being chased. Adora feels how the tight grip in her gut loosens.

It feels much more like a road trip with a friend, now. Given their mutual revelation from yesterday, that they like each other, that they want to kiss and maybe more, this isn’t so bad, either. Adora’s eyes are firmly focused on the road, but her thoughts are often with the woman next to her. Yesterday evening, she was just tired, not able to do anything beside sleeping, but when she woke up and noticed that her and Catra’s hand joined each other over the little gap between their beds, it sparked a warm and

good feeling in her. She just laid there, looked over at the sleeping woman's form, and allowed herself to bask in the feeling of their touch.
What's going to happen to them today? They will reach Tbilisi, just in a few hours, and then?

Sneaking behind other cars and the occasional tractor ahead of them is boring, but it also allows her to admire the landscape, even when she's driving. 30 km/h *do* allow that. And the landscape is beautiful. As the slopes soften, alpine meadows appear, often with cows, sheep, goats, and other livestock standing on mostly small fenced pastures. It's a greener, more humid landscape here, with a lot of woods aside the valley bottom. They're passing a large lake, and sometimes, everything looks like from a postcard.

"Oh, I love this. This is so much more my thing than scary hill drops," Adora laughs softly, thinking about if she should overtake the tractor or not. The view ahead isn't exactly clear, but it's ridiculous how slow this vehicle is.
"You're such a spoilsport," Catra teases her mercilessly. She doesn't look so unhappy herself, with an arm draped out of her open window, obviously enjoying how warm it got.
"Safety first!" Adora shoots back. "I don't want us to die because of a car accident right before our goal."
"Don't worry, dummy. We won't ever reach any goal with you driving like my grandpa. We'll forever be stuck here, endlessly, behind these lurkers. I would be faster if I walked. Is this your way of torturing me?"
Adora laughs again, brightly so, striking back before she thinks. "I mean, I could think of better ways of torturing you than this."
Suddenly, Catra's voice is like a sharp edge. "Oh, is that so, my pretty idiot? And how would you do that?" And by saying that, she fake yawns and crosses her arms by the wrists before herself, writhing in her seat, pushing her boobs against the tight fabric of the top she wears, and Adora has suddenly a lot of problems with breathing.
"I meant… I… it's…I—", she starts to stutter, because her mind is filling with inappropriate pictures. She blinks, and turns her

concentration back to the street, and not to the laughing woman at her side. But she admits, that Catra's companionship feels just great, even when she loses the banter.

But only this one more day.

As the road flies by, it's all she can think about. That they're gonna part for good. Soon. And when they arrive in Tbilisi by late afternoon, Adora feels all the more torn, and got chattier and chattier, talking about everything and anything.

Catra, on the other hand, got quieter and quieter. She's dressed in inconspicuous civilian clothes, and doesn't look like a Russian military at all. But she feels very conscious in this environment. Georgia isn't on friendly terms with her country. And Adora is safe, obviously doesn't need her anymore. Why is she still here? Why isn't she on her way back to Rostov, trying to prevent Hordak from dragging her name through the mud and ruining her career? Does she even have a career anymore? All of that feels so unreal and distant, after these few days with Adora.

At a gas stop right before Tbilisi, the blonde dummy chats with the owner, for the store is empty, and the man is of the loquacious sort, in his passable English. Catra is able to follow the conversation, but she doesn't want to take part.
"How are things down there?", Adora ask, referring to the capital of Georgia with lies in a basin. "Can you recommend a hotel for us to stay?"
He shrugs his shoulders. "I don't know. All people talk about is that the city is overrun by Russians."
"What?" Catra perks up, and for a moment, Adora seems confused, asking: "Russians?"
He huffs, dryly so. "They're fleeing. At least they say so. From the war, from being drafted, I think. Instead of fighting for the great glory of their homeland or whatever."
Oh, that makes a lot more sense. Adora calms and nods. "Got it. You mean they don't want to fight for Putin?"
"I don't know. There are suddenly all these Russians here, and they're not welcome, that's for sure." His tone isn't exactly

accusing, but he clearly feels something about it.
"But, if they don't want to support what Putin's doing…", Adora leaves the rest of the sentence open, and to Catra it looks like she's not wanting to spark an argument right here.
"I see where this is going. But we don't know anything about them, and if they are good people or not. What if they… what's the word…, uhm, infiltrate us?"
Catra quietly laughs to herself. They wouldn't use such means. The Russian army has a large presence in the South Ossetian territory, which is just about 60 kilometers from Tbilisi. There's artillery in firing range. If they want to occupy the country, they just could.
Adora stays cordially. "Hmm. I doubt that, but I see your point. You surely have many reasons to mistrust Russia, right?"
"For sure, lady," the man grumbles, and they leave him to his own.

The gas station owner didn't lie. Tbilisi is somewhat overrun with Russian refugees, which becomes clear when Adora starts searching for a hotel room. Many of them are full. At least, after calling Angella again from the office of a bank, Adora's money problems all but vanish and Angella promises to organize a flight for her, and to clear her ID problems. Adora has to stop her adoptive mother from making her tell her entire story since March, and stop herself from nearly crying a second time. She never *really* realized how much Angella cares for her. But hearing the relieved voice, soaked with so much love and concern for her, makes it obvious, even for her.

But a little later she's equipped with a lot of Laris and Euros and leaves the building.
First thing she does with the money, is dragging Catra to an ice cream parlor and buying her the largest banana split the world has ever seen. Catra mentioned it somewhere during their ride that she likes that one the most.

Two hours later, they still haven't found a room, but a place in a nice café called 'Daphna'. It has a half-oriental, half-modern, half traditional-Georgian style and if that makes three halves, well,

math never was that important to Catra. Adora persuaded her to enjoy it there, while she makes another walk around a few nearby hotels, asking for a room.
Catra waved her off graciously, because she's in a weird emotional state, and low-key glad to be left alone for a while. It's charming here, and she feels torn between a lot of warring feelings. Losing Adora within the next 24 hours is perhaps the most dominant. She had no time to really think about her feelings since yesterday, well, not since the beginning of their turbulent acquaintance to be honest, but she doesn't want it to end.
Hanging over her first good coffee since days, and just sitting here, alone, without Adora for half an hour makes it clear that she doesn't want to let her go. She wants— she wants… more. More of the woman. More time with her.
But she can't exactly just leave her duties and life behind. There's no question about it.

Beside her, on the long wooden bench against the wall behind, a woman in a dark blue suit skims some newspaper frantically, and murmurs something to herself. In Russian, Catra realizes. A fedora lies on the table, and her dark hair has a noticeable blue shimmer. She's middle-aged and well-equipped, and has the looks of someone who won't be pushed around. Her entire appearance also is a lot too aesthetic for Catra's taste. Not much of her angry mumbling is understandable, though, but what finally sticks out is "The bloody asshole."

She puts the paper down and takes a long sip of her drink.
"What?", she asks aggressively when she becomes aware that Catra is looking at her from the side.
"You seem pretty pissed," Catra finally states, leaning relaxed against the backrest, and with one arm draped over it, halfway turned to the woman. She spoke Russian too, revealing that they both have at least that in common.
"I have every reason to, but that's none of your business."

Catra has never been the type to pry or make people talk. Not like a certain blonde she knows. But she can listen if she's curious. And she likes people that don't budge. With an unobtrusive, curt

gesture, she raises her coffee cup in an unspoken invitation for the woman to talk. It gets her a sigh.
"I'm so fucking done with Russia. This idiot has destroyed everything I've been working for since 15 years."
Okay. Another rant about what she's part of. But she's still curious. "What was that?"
"I had a shipping company, in Taganrog. But the Western sanctions wiped out my business, there's practically nothing left to ship. This idiot president of ours says everything is fine, and that we're doing good without the West. Well, let me tell you that that's bullshit. We had several ships coming in and out daily. Now it's one a week. The 300 employees I had are laid off, and the remaining 10 unwind the rest of the business." She sighs, and a short pause occurs. Catra says nothing, feeling a bit off about the open statement. That's not how Russian's usually are.
"I thought I could set up deals with the Chinese, but even they became reluctant. Did you know that Chinese imports halved since February?" Catra shakes her head. Economy isn't her strength.
"Nobody really wants to give the US and EU the idea of imposing over-the-rail-sanctions on you because you make deals with Russia. Our country is driving against a massive wall, and this warmonger is just too caught up in his own lies that he thinks he can win something out of this."
Catra sees the point, she's no idiot, but the biting attitude the woman speaks with is annoying. "Well, we still hold our ground in Ukraine. It's not that they have the equipment to fight back."
"Not yet," the woman says. "I'm not pretending to be a military expert. But I know something about economy. The US and EU alone can supply Ukraine with enough material twice the budget we can, over years, and they will barely feel it. It will even boost their military suppliers and strengthen them. Do you know what I'm speaking of, regarding the economic difference?"

Catra has to admit that she doesn't really know the numbers and shrugs.
"I see. It's always the same, with the economically uneducated, huh?" She forms a ball the size of a football with her hands.
"Look, the combined US and European GDP is this large, around

30 billion Euros.” Now she indicates a golf ball with her right hand by putting her thumb and index finger against each other. “Russia has that, around 2 billion. And in some way, that’s all one needs to know. They can outmatch our military spending by the factor of ten and barely feel it. The only reason we’re taken seriously, is because we have a nuclear arsenal, gas, and oil. And Europe works very hard to diminish its dependency on the latter two. Soon, our GDP will cripple, because they won’t buy our two biggest exports anymore. We will definitely feel that.”

“But we still have our military strength,” Catra insists. “And nuclear weapons.” She never considered that to be an option, but it’s good just to have them. As a deterrence.
“To attack whom? NATO? Ridiculous. They have too. It would be the last war humankind fights. Or against the loser club with ‘stan at the end? What do we want with such burdens?” The woman groans and gestures with her arms questioningly. “Why do we even want to fight against anybody? The world has changed, girl, and we shouldn’t try to fight against countries who could be our partners in the long run. Anyone should know that. I’m not some ideological pacifist, but nobody imposes any threat on us, not even in the slightest. The EU is not a military power, despite what the idiots in the Kremlin say. The entire EU couldn’t fight a real war without the Americans. And these are just bullshit conflicts about who has the longest dick, and I’m done with it. As long as this asshole is in power, our country will be an outcast, and be left behind in the world. Putin ruined my company, he’s going to ruin the entire country, and I’m never going back.”
The woman got angrier and louder at the end. Now she takes a deep breath, then takes a long sip of her drink in an attempt to calm herself.

“I get that you’re really pissed. What are you going to do?”
Another sip. Another breath.
“”Sometime it’s good to seek for a new beginning and to cut old ties. If you don't know why, you haven't done it before anyway. As for me, I’m flying to Rome tonight. A friend of mine has a little transport company there, and we’re going to talk about it. Maybe I can start over there. No idea, but we’ll see. Maybe I just make a

month of holiday. But I bet I’m just getting bored. Italy is nice. Relaxed. No warmongering attitudes. They have good food, too. I don’t know.” The woman has faltered a little.
“Yeah, who would be frightened by Italians anyway,” Catra tries to break up the mood, but the woman answers dead serious: “Absolutely nobody. And you know what? That’s a good thing.”

Catra answers nothing, and the sentence somehow hangs in the air. She has spent half her life being intimidating in a male-dominated environment by snarkiness and taking no bullshit. It has taken her where she is today. It worked. It’s only that… sometimes… she gets pretty tired of it.
“What’s about you?”, the woman asks.
Catra shouldn’t be as surprised as she is?
“Me?”
“Yeah, why are you here? What’s your deal?”
She has to think about a fitting answer, and doesn't come up with one. Finally, she replies: “Nothing at all. I'm just taking a kind of trip.”
For a few moments, she feels regarded, a bit too much for her own liking. “You look lost,” the woman lastly says, in a short, cruel and cutting assessment of her situation. A few months ago, she would’ve fiercely challenged and argued against such a ridiculous saying from someone who doesn’t know her. The realization, that there’s perhaps nothing waiting for her, back home, is somewhere in the back of her mind.

It makes her shrugging her shoulders, and pulling a corner of her mouth.

The woman nods, stands up and puts her fedora on. “I wish you well.”
Catra nods too, then: “Hey, what’s your name?”
“Merm— Mariam Salinski,” the woman says, tipping her fedora and makes one, two steps away, then stills and turns back to her. “Watch out for you. Hold on to the good things in your life. They are precious, and if you don’t take care of them, they’ll be gone sooner than you think.”

Catra's rolls the words around in her mind until Adora comes back. When the woman with the golden retriever energy appears, it puts a wary smile on her face. Adora looks so relieved now, despite her face has still some lines, bearing witness of the last weeks. But her smile is so genuine.

Adora looks happy.
Or rather, happily concerned. Her voice makes it clear. "I found a room for the night. It's not even far away, just around the corner, and the hotel looks nice. But…" She falls dry.
"But?" Catra asks, and nips on her coffee, which is long cold. Bah! Disgusted, she puts the cup back.
"It's just a double room. The last one they had."
"So what? We slept in a room last night."
"I know. But: it's a double bed."
The guilty face Adora *pretends* to have, is contradicted by some sparkles in her pretty eyes, Catra realizes. She might not be one to give much about the real intentions other people have, but Adora is often like an open book.

Catra could tease her for that.

She knows the woman is flustered easily, and something tells her that she deserves it. But remnants of Mariam's words still linger in her mind, and if this is their last night together, she doesn't want… she doesn't want…
"That's what you wanted anyway, isn't it?" she replies without any judgement in her voice. It's a statement, and maybe an acceptance of defeat.
"I can sleep on the couch," Adora offers, restrained, like a little girl.
With a short laugh, she waves the ridiculous attempt to avoid what's going to be inevitable off. "It's fine. Don't pretend."
And when the other woman cocks her head lightly, looking back at her, it's like an agreement. She just isn't sure about what.

The River Side Hotel is a nice mixture between old exterior and modernized interior. The building is only five stories high, but that's quite common in Tbilisi. There aren't many high-risers, and most of them are still from Soviet times, where residential buildings for cheap living were built extensively.
They had a short quarrel over the payment, which was cut short by Adora by insisting furiously. Now that she has money again, there's no way that she doesn't pay some of Catra's generosity back. She still feels a little heated from it, and honestly, the friendly bickering aroused her.
"Let me treat you tonight, please. You did so much for me, I want to spoil you as much as I can tonight."
As is so often the case when Adora talks about anything personal, the wording is slightly off, as if she's talking very close to what she *should* be saying and mixing it up with some of what she *actually wants* to say. Her words spark a lot of ideas in Catra's mind, about what that might look like, starting with an undressed Adora under her, because she straddles the woman, Adora's hands over her head and tied, and she's moaning in her name in delight —
A little embarrassed, she realizes that she has walked down the wrong aisle, getting how much she got lost in these alluring thoughts when she hears Adora calling her name from the other side of the hallway. "Catra! Here!"

Catra sighs at the pretty sight. The woman is surely going to be the death of her.

Adora opens the antique wooden door with intricate ornaments to their room and is greeted with the sight of a very reddish-orange view. Thick beige curtains hang before semicircular windows, a carpet patterned with a crest-like symbol in red and beige covers the entire floor. The room is L-shaped, and around the corner stands a huge wooden double-bed, wide enough for three people, with small bedside tables left and right, topped with antique bedside lamps already spending a warm, yellow light. The room is totally kitschy, but in a pleasant way, making the atmosphere

herein comfortable and soothing. It's exactly what she needs, and why she immediately said yes when offered.

Adora has lowered herself on the bed, but Catra still stands beside the table in the corner, looking outside, over the river and a good part of the city.
"I need a shower," Catra interrupts her thoughts and states like it's a law. Adora smiles, and nods, amused. "Go ahead," and gestures with her hand to the bathroom with lies in the inner corner of the room. "I'm going to call Angella again, and ask her if she achieved anything regarding my flight."

She did, and afterwards she notices the usual flat screen hanging over a desk on the wall across the bed, and as Catra has closed the door behind her, Adora can't resist switching on the news. She flips through the channels, shortly stopping watching CNN, BBC and Deutsche Welle each for a minute. The war is still a major issue, and many ribbons at the screen bottoms cover it. But it also looks like that it's not as prominent as before. BBC covers a parliamentary debate about the issues of English fishermen who can't sell their goods to the European Union anymore, because of Brexit, and CNN covers the heated debate in the US about the cost of living crisis.
At least Deutsche Welle has three politicians talking about the struggles their country is having with jumping from an institutionalized and even law-based pacifism with long time-relationships to Russia into a nation that has to find a new role in leading the European Union's efforts to support a country many Germans barely know anything about with heavy weapons, while also slipping into a recession due to exploding energy prices.
Ten years ago, the German voters would've overthrown their own government and pressured the successor into a neutral stance if anyone spoke too loud about a heavy upgrade for the Bundeswehr. Only slowly, the country adapts to the harsh reality that Putin is not as reliable as they told themselves he is, and even not to their precious Euros. Cheap gas did the trick on them, and yet, many struggle to realize it.

Adora's stomach grumbles and reminds her that they haven't eaten much today. She considers if they shall use the rooftop restaurant the hotel has, but then she remembers the room service. A menu lies on the desk beneath the TV. She grabs it and just reading it quickly makes her mouth water.
"Shall I order something to eat?", she yells, hoping that Catra can hear her.
"What?", is the muffled reply.
She walks over and opens the door to the bathroom a crack to repeat her question. Steam pours out of the room, making it obvious that Catra likes to shower hot. Like, really hot.
"What do they have?", the woman calls again.
Adora gives the menu another runover. "Pretty much everything. Meat, fish, pasta, salad. They have a restaurant up there, so I think we can order anything."
Catra ponders shortly until she calls: "Pancakes! With strawberry jam!"
It makes Adora laugh. It's such an easy yet delicious meal, she hasn't even thought of that. And while pancakes are not on the menu, they'll surely be able to make them.
"You know what? That's a great idea, I'll take them too." Now that she thinks of it, pancakes sound great. Aside from the blini in Rostov, where the dough is a little different, she hasn't eaten them since… well… a long time.
And pancakes are great.

Rather unconsciously, her look falls onto the mirror over the sink, visible through the crack. In the reflection, she can see the shower and its walls, made of glass. They are fogged, and yet, the slender, lithe figure of Catra in it is quite visible. Adora has seen her in tight wear, but this is different.

Now, she's naked.

The fog blurs the view a bit, but not so much that she can't make out Catra's form. Her breasts look small but firm, perfectly proportional to her figure, and between her legs sits a neatly trimmed, brunette triangle. The woman's legs are slim, trained, as are her arms. Catra has her eyes closed, clearly enjoying the

shower, indulging in the warm water stream, humming softly. Her hands roam over her own body, creaming it with shower gel. Adora clearly knows that it's inappropriate to watch her, and yet, the sight is so beautiful, and so alluring, that she just can't tear herself away from it.

"I know you're watching," Catra suddenly says. Her voice is neither a growl, nor a tease, but it has a dark timbre. Her eyes are still closed. "Come in or get out, but close the door. You're letting my steam out."
Adora nearly falls over her own feet as she stumbles back, feeling so caught. "Sorry! Sorry! I'm gonna…"
Yeah, what is she gonna do? Join Catra in the bathroom? To do what exactly? Is the woman insinuating what she thinks she is? Shall Adora… join her in the bathroom to… discuss the meal they order? With her being naked just a meter away while she showers? Or should Adora join in the… shower? Upon the thought, more arousal rises in her, between her legs, mostly. Rather unconsciously, her hand falls down there. Catra can't mean that, can she? But then again, she agreed to join a bed with her tonight. They kissed, yesterday. She's nearly sure that Catra wants her, too. Adora just isn't so sure about how she can navigate her insecurity, and not mess everything up, like last time.
She knows she wants Catra near her, tonight.
But they will sleep in the same bed. That will have to do it, right? It's maybe the best to just order dinner.
"Uhm, I'm… ordering the pancakes, okay?"
"Just as you like."

Adora doesn't see the disappointed expression on Catra's face, when she closes the door. But it quickly morphs into a little smirk, because the evening is still long, and Adora is so easy to fluster. She'll have the pretty idiot right beside her, later.
She hums a little to herself as she enjoys the warm water.

The TV still runs in the background. Beside the soft shorts, Catra has a tight shirt on that is relatively skimpy, and by the way it presents her body, Adora guesses it's on purpose. They sit at the small table, the pancakes have been delivered, and beside from

the strawberry jam she ordered, there are little bowls with all kinds of different marmalade too.

Catra puts a dark orange one on a piece of her pancake and bites into it, making a delighted sound, while Adora still admires how the shirt compliments the woman's form, dreaming with her head in her hand. She startles out of her thoughts when a piece of pancake is shoved into her face.
"Wanna taste?", Catra asks, and Adora snaps out of it, hits the pancake with her hand in surprise, spinning it onto Catra's chest. Half the strawberry jam squirts over her shirt, and the food lands in her lap.
"Oh no! Sorry, I'm so sorry. I was dreaming—"
Catra has raised her arms to look at the mess Adora created, and stills when the other woman reaches over the small table and starts rubbing the jam off of her shirt. Which means almost the same as petting her stomach up to her breasts, and now the idiot actually rubs her tits. It doesn't feel so bad, but she looks down on the oblivious, clumsy beauty who has bent herself over the table. "What do you think you're doing there?"

Adora looks up to her guiltily, and realizes with big eyes. "Oh." She realizes more. "Ooh… I'm sorry. Sorry! I didn't want to—"
Catra rolls her eyes. "Relax. It's fine. I have one more." Maybe that's not so bad?
"I'm so sorry," Adora insists two more times and slumps on her chair, obviously embarrassed about messing up.
"Relaaax," Catra insists, finds it funny and giggles, and then, using this chance in a bold move to push Adora, she takes off the ruined shirt and has nothing on under it. "We most probably won't see each other again after tomorrow, so, it's not that we have to care what happens tonight."
Adora gawks at her. She does nothing, though, just sits there, frozen.
Catra kinda basks in the blatant admiration, but then she sighs, because Adora still doesn't do anything.
Why can't the woman just pick up a good hint?

Adora literally feels her eyes widening. Catra's tits are just perfect. Tanned skin, firm, looking soft. *Touchable.*
Is Catra insinuating what she thinks she is? Is this her way of telling Adora that this should happen tonight? She's often pretty oblivious when it comes to such things, but even she felt the energy sparkling between them since they entered the room. Pfff, what nonsense, since they met!
And Catra's constant teasing.
Catra's sitting over there with her perfect boobs, and her comment loosens the ties Adora'd left. Heat spreads in her.
The pancakes are totally forgotten.
She wants to touch Catra again.
One of her hands moves forwards, but stops half-way, and she feels how warily Catra pierces her.
It bubbles out of her before she can even think about it. "I need you," she repeats the sentence they said to each other at the Mamison Pass.

This is not enough, she realizes, and says: "I want you."

Catra could do many things now.
She could tease and fluster the hell out of Adora. With such a blunt admission, it would be just too easy. The pretty dummy made herself totally vulnerable right now, and the opportunity for payback from something of two years ago is great.
She doesn't even ponder it.
Quieter than she wanted, she says: "Me too."

The next Adora knows is that she jumps up and drags Catra onto the bed, where she flops down backwards and eagerly pulls the surprised woman on top of her. If Catra doesn't like it, she can just stand up again.
She shouldn't have worried.
Catra growls, and immediately starts to plaster her face with eager kisses, while the TV in the background fills the room with the opening music of "Casablanca".

Minutes later, Adora still pants from the heated makeout. She still feels Catra hands all over her body, her face, her chest, her

stomach, her tits. But she needs a breather. Just to catch her wit and courage before they make another step. She rolls Catra off of her, and they lie side by side, looking at each other. Catra's still just in her shorts. Adora is still clothed in her underwear, shirt and shorts, but she wants to get out of them.
The sooner, the better.

They both know what they want to do.
It's not fear holding them back.
It's expectation.

"Will it be like I always imagined it would be?" The thought lingers at the edge of Adora's mind. She's a little anxious, in a sense that she hopes her inexperience won't ruin the evening. But she can trust Catra, can she? The woman saved her live more than once. She *can* trust her.
And Catra will clearly know what to do. She looks so confident, and if she just let the woman take the initiative, she should be fine?
On the TV screen, Casablanca still runs, and Rick just hides the transit visa in his piano. A small part of Adora's brain muses over the funny resemblance of their own situation, while she looks into Catra's perfect, two-colored eyes. She loves the movie, it's so well-made, with a perfect cast and such simple yet working means of production, compared with modern movies. A perfect storytelling.

When Catra's hand suddenly rests on hers, everything else just vanishes. The touch fires up her body, as it looks like the time of expectation is coming to an end. On Catra's face appears the most predatory grin she ever saw on the woman. It's her signature smirk, but it's also a bit darker.
Adora shivers a little.
"You're probably a German spy," Catra says.
"I'm not," Adora retorts labored, but softly, feeling her hand gripped more firmly immediately. Her heartbeat fastens.
"I should be interrogating you, if you're a threat to the kingdom," Catra playfully presses on, her voice getting deeper, and Adora likes it so much.
"Oh, and how would you do that?"

“I have my methods that will make you talk,” Catra growls. Her hand reaches around Adora’s head and yanks softly at her ponytail, making her bare her throat.
Yet, she laughs quietly. “Come and make me then.”

Catra is onto Adora within a wink, shoving her on her back, pinning her wrists to the bedsheet, straddling her lap, then her teeth grind into her neck. Adora squirms under Catra’s touch, but she doesn’t really make an effort to escape the grip. Instead, she admires the contours of the women’s stomach and her breasts, and she wants to lick at them. She gets bitten on her pulse instead, then Catra reaches over to push her arms behind. Shoving her chest into Adora’s face is just a side effect.
“How about you put your tits out of my face?”, Adora teases her.
“How about I put my tits into your face?”, Catra shoots back.
Adora glances at Catra’s lips, licking her own, then at Catra’s boobs again, back to the woman’s face, and her lips glisten so wet and damp, and, oh, they come nearer and nearer.
Catra lowers herself and kisses her in an angry, excited outbreak. This is probably the angriest kiss Adora’s ever gotten, and it makes her feel absolutely hot. She moans. Loudly. Her chest is about to explode from pure need. From being *wanted*.

At first, the sound surprises Catra so much that she nearly snaps out of it.
“My goodness, she’s perfect,” she thinks, while the woman under her continues moaning, breathing heavily.
For a moment, she feels shame to overwhelm Adora like she just did. But the woman pulled her onto the bed in the first place, so it’s okay. Kissing Adora so possessively didn’t come out of nowhere. It was an impulse, just her angry and needy nature finally, finally acting out. Now she knows they both want it rough and soft alike. She has known it all evening, wanted, hoped for what is happening now.
But when she hears Adora moaning, she knows exactly what the woman needs.

Again, they look into each other’s eyes, with Catra straddling Adora’s lap, their faces just a hand’s breadth apart, and Adora’s

large eyes mirror her own.
Now Adora's wrists slip out of Catra's grip and reach around her waist, drawing her in, then gliding upwards along her side, up to her boobs. Catra breathes heavily, Adora looks at her questioningly, a little shy even, but she manages to press out, "Go ahead."

Despite there's nothing she wants more, she lets it sound like an order. She would beg Adora, even if she hates begging for anything, even if she never begged anyone. Here, it would be easy. Begging Adora would be so easy, but luckily, it's not necessary.
Adora's hands glide over her side, onto her tits, and she fondles them softly. She could surrender to all the tingling, but in return, Catra reaches down for Adora's shirt and pulls it up, making her to let go of her tits, pushing Adora's arms over her head, tossing the shirt aside. Under it, Adora wears only the tight and soft sports bra, and Catra eagerly tugs it upwards too, over Adora's face, where she stops, effectively blinding and binding the woman by her upper arms with it, so Catra can take in the sight of Adora's perfect, naked upper body, and damn, is the woman a sight to behold.

She isn't ripped, but she's clearly working out her entire life. There's no extra gram of fat where it shouldn't be one. Despite she has a few scars, her hills are unscathed, round, and full. She puts both her hands on them, softly rubbing, feeling soft, yet firm flesh. So soft. Sooo soft. Adora twitches, cries. "Ah! Aaaah." Adora's moaning turning deeper is great, Catra thinks.

Still, she uses the tether of Adora's bra to make the woman helpless against more kisses she now presses at the base of Adora's perfect breasts, then moving down onto the hills, around the nipple, circling the little but already hard bud with her tongue. "Ah, Aaaahh," Adora moans loudly, and kicks her legs a little in excitement.
"Looks like you're enjoying this, Adora," Catra teases her friendly, and still holds her by the wrists with one hand, using the bra as a rope to bind the woman. "I enjoy it too," she adds smugly, before

she cups the entire meaty hill of Adora's left boob with her mouth, teasing its hard top with her teeth first, then with her tongue. Adora writhes beneath her, struggles, kicks her legs again, breathes heavily, but she lets it happen. Only a few words escape her mouth under all the moaning: "Aah. No! Uhh, yes! Ah!"
"You're beautiful," Catra murmurs, smirking. "So beautiful for me," and sits up, letting go of her grip while still straddling Adora.

But now she slowly shuffles downwards, focusing on a place she knows is dripping wet by now.
Here, all the beauty has on now are her boyshorts. She still has her arms over her head and doesn't move them. Adora doesn't do anything aside from laying beneath her with heavy breaths, and Catra smiles. She knows where this is heading to.
"I will take care of you, Adora. There's nothing to fear." To contradict her statement, she softly drills her nails into the firm flesh of Adora's thighs. Another moan escapes Adora, then a few rugged words: "I am not afraid. I… uh,.., I trust you. Aah!"
It's too much honesty for her taste, she can't help it. She wanted to hear this, needed to hear this, and yet she needs to tease Adora: "Probably a mistake. You may regret this before the night is over, but I promise, I'm not going to hurt you."

That Adora doesn't answer but moans again may have something to do with the pressure her fingers exert on the inner side of the blonde's long, firm legs. Catra's fingertips glide upwards, until they reach the fabric covering Adora's last privacy, the place where she knows that Adora needs her most.
When she curls her index fingers under their waistband on both sides, she hears how Adora stops breathing, and asks her with a low, "Are you good?"
She already knows the answer, she can smell Adora's spicy arousal even now, and all the woman does is to nod with closed eyes, slowly, but determined, underlining it with a low and needy "Hmmm. Uhhm."
It works as a confirmation.
It works just fine.

“Perfect. Good girl,” Catra praises her, and Adora actually twitches a little. It gives Catra another hint of how all of this will be going. Slowly, she pulls the shorts down and drinks in the beauty of Adora’s womanhood. She has a nice and broad blonde landing strip, beautiful curly hair, obviously freshly shaved at the sides. Her fingers feel the softness, the wonderful, wonderful softness of Adora’s skin while they roam over the goddesses body with growing hunger.

Catra decides to take a risk.

It’s probably a little fast, but… “How about if I make you mine tonight, Adora? Do you hear me? Do you want this? I can do many things with your body,” she lustfully says, and for a moment, Adora gets stiff as a rock, says nothing, but then she smiles… and nods again.
“Say it, Adora. I need you to say it,” Catra insists.
Adora’s voice is a little high-pitched, ragged, when she breathes: “I… I want it.”
“You want what?”
“Make me yours,” her prey whispers, quietly, but with strength.
“Good girl. I will.”

Robust and *enduring* are words coming to Catra's mind while her gaze and hands roam over the naked blonde woman. Adora’s wrists are still bound by the bra, her arms over her head, and she looks back at Catra so open, so genuine, expecting and obviously wanting Catra to take the lead, and Catra is willing to do this. Adora is vulnerable, but not by anything imposed on her. Here, under her touch and care, she *lets* herself be vulnerable.
Just now. Just here. She offers herself, and Catra knows she could destroy the woman just by rejecting her offer. Just by withdrawing. By laughing at her.

She never could.

It would mean nothing else than squeezing out what’s left of her own naivety, kindheartedness, and her ability to… love. She doesn’t want it, but she knows the feeling is there, growing,

planting its roots deeper into her heart with every passing moment. This here isn't just sex. It's terrifying, because Adora will be gone, soon, tomorrow, in a few precious hours, but no, not yet, this isn't a thought for now.
Now, she's here. Under her.
And if there is one person on earth worth to share this feeling with, it might be the blonde idiot, this stupid blonde idiot, laying beneath her with this shy yet wanting look, waiting for Catra to do more to her.

Adora as a person *is* robust and enduring, her skin is warred with scars from her life and the way in which she leads it. But Adora is also kind, and warm, and trusting, softly looking at her with this vulnerable expression on her face, and Catra could never, never, never resist her, never hurt her.
"I'm going to take care of you. But we can do—", she slowly states, giving Adora a last possibility to shy away.
Funnily, she really needn't have racked her brains.
"Now go ahead," says Adora, obviously impatient.
Upon the firm, pressing answer, Catra can't resist chuckling. "Oh, wow, that was eager, huh?" But it's amicable and not taunting. It nearly could've been a giggle, but Catra never giggles. That's for little girls.
"Don't worry. I'm going to play with your body. Just relax and enjoy it."

And it turns out, that insecurity about having sex is nothing they should've been worried about. It's as everything just fits into place, as they were made for each other. They both know what they want, and they know what the other person wants. If she weren't already dripping from the wetness between her legs, Catra would have to make sure she does.

Now, her palm lays between Adora's pussy and her clit, her thumb slowly circling this pert bud between her labia, while she also teases Adora's entrance with two fingers by just probing a little. Her other hand is on Adora's perfect abdomen, circling it. Catra starts rubbing Adora's folds beautifully, with growing force. The woman twitches and pants beneath her. The tension has been

building since Catra started teasing her. Now, a hand falls onto Catra's leg, and Adora fixes her gaze with her beautiful blue eyes. "Catra, please! Come on…, more, I… need…"

"I know, honey, I know. But not so fast. I'm gonna fuck your brains out, baby. Before this night is over, you'll be screaming my name, but we need to work through something. Because…," Catra lowers her face to Adora's and smirks into it: "You wanna earn it, don't you? You wanna be a good girl."
Catra wants to delay and sweet torturing the woman more, much more, so all of this will be Adora's most unleashing experience ever. She wants Adora to have the night of her live, and to memorize it for forever. She lowers her mouth near Adora's ear: "You haven't earned all the things I wanna do to you yet, have you?"

Catra roughly pushes two fingers into Adora pussy while she asks, half in her: "You have been a bad girl, and bad girls need to be punished. Right?"
Be it from Catra's finger in her or from what she says, but Adora eyes nearly pop out, so wide is her look, and Catra feels how Adora's pussy clenches around her digits. The woman screams of lust.
"Tell me what you want me to do to you, Adora. What must I do with such a bad girl?" She underlines her question with very slow pumping.
The words the naked, flushing woman mumble are incomprehensible. But Catra knows what she said. Now she needs the woman to admit it louder.
"Louder."
"Push me," Adora whispers, now flushing even more.
"Louder!"
"Push me."
"Why?"
"Because…"
"Why, Adora? Tell me."
"I've been a bad girl?"
Catra withdraws her fingers from Adora and leans back, pretending to be relaxed at the sight of the panting woman. "Is

that a question or an answer?"
"I've been a bad girl!" Adora calls, desperation shining through her words, and now it's a statement.
"Good girl. You'll get what you need. I'm gonna make you mine tonight, my love."

She realizes what she just said, just said so naturally, so easily. It just slipped out. And judging from the look of the woman panting beneath her, she got it too.
"What did you—"
"Never mind, it's just a part of the play," Catra quickly interrupts.
"But you—" Adora can't finish her sentence. It's probably hard to talk and think when you're suddenly getting fucked by two fingers filling your pussy, while a thumb rubs your clit.
"You don't get to talk while I'm not ready with you, Adora. You be patient. But you can moan for me, if you want. Moaning is okay."
She knows this is just a short reprieve. But the word just tumbled out of her mouth, and she doesn't want to talk about it now. Instead, she leans down, and starts sucking Adora's breast again, while her fingers move in an out of Adora's pussy with growing speed. Quickly, the woman is falling apart, just like Catra intended.
"Don't stop, uhhh, please, don't stop."
It's music in her ears. Catra can do many things. She can clearly give Adora the time of her life.
"You need me?"
Adora fists into the sheets. "I do. I do. I dooouuu….I need you! Please, ah, Catra, please, aah, go—"

Again, she can't finish her sentence, because Catra curls her two fingers in Adora's slick entrance. "You do? That's good, but it's not enough. This isn't the first time you've touched yourself down there, is it? Bad girls do that."
She never stops circling Adora's sweet spot, now she adds a steady rhythm in fingering the panting woman. A few times, she licks her breasts, teasing them with the tip of her tongue, and Adora's moans get louder then. "You look perfect, baby. I love you just like this."
"What?" Adora pants, nearly breathless: "Under you?"

“Yes. You’re beautiful when you get fingered by me. You like it when I fuck you like this?”
Maybe Adora would roll her eyes if she were able to. Maybe not. It’s awesome that the woman can still be a little bratty.
“You really have it with the dirty talk. Why haven’t I uuuhhnnngggg—"

Again, she can’t finish her sentence, can’t think of words anymore, because Catra’s thumb presses hard on her nub and now the woman adds a third finger to Adora’s pussy while smiling down on her so tempting with her mismatched eyes. Her other hand squeezes one of Adora’s boobs not too gently.
“That’s it, baby, that’s it. Moan for me.”
Adora moans. She moans so loudly that Catra needs to put her hand from Adora’s tit over the woman’s mouth, silencing her. Adora’s blue eyes glow in excitement as they fix Catra’s in an angry stare mixed with lust and desire. They glow like on fire, and for a moment Catra thinks she’s about to bite her hand, but then she feels how the woman is just grinning beneath her palm, daggering her with her beautiful eyes.
“Do you like this?”, Catra asks mercilessly, and honestly a little breathless. “Being taken like this, silenced like this?”
With one hand in Adora’s pussy, the other over the woman’s mouth, her side lined along Adora’s body with her right leg draped over Adora’s left one in a way of fixating her, keeping her open, it becomes clear, that Adora wants to be dominated as much as Catra wants to dominate her.
Catra wants to make Adora hers.
Only hers.

And deep inside, Adora needs this, needs Catra, needs Catra to show her what she wants, and Catra knows what the woman wants. She knows it, and they both knew from the start that gentle standard sex wasn’t what they wanted. It’s this way of being taken, overwhelmed, pushed, guided what Adora needed to overcome the little barrier in her head, that kept her all the time from having… sex.

The barrier is clearly gone.

For Catra, it's arousing to feel Adora panting against her hand while she curls her fingers into her dripping cunt, time and again. She feels that Adora's nearing an orgasm, with her inner muscles working around her fingers, the heavy panting, the naughty, lewd noises coming out of Adora's mouth. "Come on, baby. Come for me. I know you want it. Come for me, and if you do well, I'm going to fuck you again."
Adora's voice is muffled by Catra's hand, but yet she cries: "Yes, yes, nngg, yes… mmmmnnggg!"

Adora's first orgasm is hard, and wild, and overwhelming. It collapses over her like a huge wave on the beach, lets her spasm, her legs going limp, sweating. She wants to ride it out, but her high leaves her arms and hands without any strength.

Unfortunately, without any strength to defend herself against Catra's continuing onslaught, too.

"You think you had enough? Oh no," the woman smirks devilishly over her. She looks down into Adora's eyes, pierces them, pins her down onto the mattress with this unrelenting stare. "This was just the first round. You're not done. I promised you to fuck you until you're wrecked. I have you now, and I'm not letting you go. You're mine to play with."
Adora could use a little breather, just a few minutes to recover. Her muscles are still shaking, her body is so feeble, she still feels the aftermath of her orgasm running through her inner. She could cuddle a little.

But that's only until she gets, that Catra's face has vanished, gone down over her stomach and now the brunette has started to lick her clit. Just a few licks, over the little pleasure bud Adora's playthings got to know so well and which is now teased in such a different, better way.
The lithe woman has dived, put her hands around Adora's hip and ass cheeks from below, and uses her shoulders to mercilessly spread her legs. Adora's pussy is completely at Catra's disposal, and the thought alone is so thrilling, flustering, arousing, embarrassing. Shortly, Catra's eyes meets her gaze again, and

damn, the expression the woman is wearing is absolutely smashing, so shameless.

Suddenly, Catra stops licking, and just says: “Beg me.”

Adora’s need for a pause is gone, instead, want and lust flooded her. Catra is teasing her, sure, wanting her to submit. And does Adora want to submit. But not without a fight. She shakes her head. “Fuck you.”
Catra licks her one time, dragging the raspy tongue over her clit firmly, and without breaking eye contact. Adora nearly caves, as arousal floods her again. She knows she’s dripping down there.
“Beg me,” Catra orders, insistent, louder.
“Beg yourself,” Adora replies stubbornly, but not very convincing, as her breath stutters a little.
Again, Catra licks her a few times, with her tongue probing the entrance of Adora’s clit. To be more convincing, she digs her nails into Adora’s ass, underlining her statement.

Adora could pretend, could fight a little more.

But actually, she can’t. Catra’s nails in her buttocks do it.
“Please…”
“Beg me,” is Catra’s unyielding, firm order.
“Oh please, go on, do me, please,” Adora caves, gasps, and she wishes nothing more than to be Catra’s—
“Beg me,” Catra commands again. It sounds final.
“I beg you. Please, Catra, I’m yours.” Adora screams, giving in, obeying.
“As you wish, Princess,” is the perfidious return.

She clutches Adora’s thighs harder from behind, to put more pressure on the clenching pussy before her face. Red stripes mark where her fingernails traces Adora’s lightly bruised skin. The woman’s noises are now outright sinful, nothing more than lewd moaning, panting, gasping for air while Catra licks her relentlessly, lapping her juices, and uses her tongue to fuck the spasming blonde.
Two times Adora nearly reaches her second orgasm, but two

times Catra withdraws at the last moment. She draws it out, gives the woman space to breath and only slowly, very slowly rubs the clit, to keep the tension and her arousal high. “How is this for you?”, she asks, already knowing the answer. When Adora doesn’t reply instantly, she stops doing anything.
Adora has her forearm over her eyes and pants. “Please! It’s good, so good. Please, Catra, I need— uuggggghhh".

Catra’s thumb is back at Adora’s clit, and she ups the speed of the circling. She has two fingers in Adora’s pussy, the thumb on her clit and presses and circles around, pumps her fingers deeper, again and again, then puts her tongue to work, too. She feels how Adora’s walls clench and spasm, with another orgasm approaching.
And the moment it’s nearly there, when Adora is gasping for air, practically dripping from wetness, panting and keening, so in need of just a few more strikes… nothing happens.

Catra pulls out, rises her head and just looks at Adora, licking her own lips.
“What are you—”
“Enjoying the view, Princess.”
It’s a pretty view. Naked Adora, her tits and folds displayed for her, the woman looks hot as fucked. But it seems she has made one step too far.
Adora’s eyes go wide, then they narrow. Something inside the woman flares to life, a force not to be messed with.

Uh-Oh, Catra thinks, nearly crumbling under the steely blue and the power behind them. It’s already too late for her.
“You little brat,” Adora starts, voice deep and grim, and then Catra’s expression turns from smirking to shocked, because Adora uses all the firmness in her arms to shove Catra’s face into her lap again.
“Now lick! Do me! Don’t stop until I come.”
Just this once in the entire evening, Adora’s voice holds firm command, and Catra doesn’t resist.
She *wants* to follow Adora’s order.

"Hmppfff." It's probably a weak return, but who the fucks cares when the object of her desire is panting so loud before her. She complies, because the damp, slick wetness of Adora's pussy is so alluring that she just wants to dive in. She wants the woman before her to beg for her, beg Catra for continuing, to get her undone, and so she starts to relentlessly suck and lick and tease and fuck Adora with her tongue. By gripping Adora's hip from underneath on both sides, she draws her closer, holding her firm, so Adora has no chance to escape her assault.
The woman probably never would. She feels the muscles in Adora's ass and thighs working, spasming, for her. "Oh god, Catra, this is soooo—uunnngg. Please, yes, please… Aah, Aaahh!" Adora screams, gasps, bites her hand to silence herself. All of this is the sweetest music in Catra's ears. She feels how her folds clench, then Adora topples over the edge the second time and Catra could bask in the woman's deep moans, the pleading voice, the trust her prey has in her, and she absolutely plans to use that again.

Adora's breath hasn't even slowed, when Catra says: "This is not over, Adora. I want another one," she says, then licks Adora's folds roughly a few more times, and only minutes later, beneath her, the blonde goddess falls apart another time, screaming "Uuughhh, Catra, yes! Yes! Oh, no… yes, uuughh! Aaaah!"

Laying beside and petting Adora, Catra is merciful enough to let her ride out the third orgasm. And Adora *is* spent. She just lays there, with a forearm over her eyes, breathes heavily and doesn't do anything else, until she mumbles: "Enough, please, let me breathe. I'm… I'm completely finished." She had orgasms before, because masturbation is a well-known concept for her. But getting off on herself is not in the same league as *this.* Her muscles are still twitching a little. Her entire body feels agitated, exhausted, *used*.

Well, three orgasms in a row are good, Catra thinks. She's a little proud of herself.

But it’s not enough. Not for her. Not tonight. “Is that so?”, Catra asks with an amused undertone. She needs more, she needs to pull out one more out of Adora.
When Adora lifts her arm, she sees Catra looming over her in a posture telling her that the brunette isn’t done with her. In despair, the blonde pants: “Please, I need a break!”

Her plead is heard, but not recognized.

“No. You don’t,” Catra grins. “You need to be… tickled.”
Adora squeaks like a little girl when Catra starts tickling her, poking into the sides of the naked, panting woman.
“STOP IT, you foul beast!”
“Never! I said I’m going to play with your body.” While still poking, again, Catra takes the nipple of one of Adora’s beautiful breasts between her teeth, bites it softly until Adora surrenders, then she licks it playfully. She shortly ponders to leave it at that, but then is reminded that this is their only night.

She wants more. More of Adora. All of her. Adora under her. Hers.

Her arms trace Adora’s arms, up to her neck and cheeks, her lips. Again, Adora starts to moan softly.
Catra takes her panties, which she has just worn since the shower, and stuffs them into Adora's mouth, silencing the woman who stares at her with this beautiful angry look in return.
“Do you want to be a bad girl again? You know, bad girls get punished!” Catra smirks into the face of her plaything. Adora keeps staring at her, maybe a little less challenging, but that is not enough. “Not enough, you brat. Turn around,” Catra orders.
Adora doesn’t move, until Catra repeats her command. “Turn. Around.”
Adora obeys, slowly turning onto her stomach, stretched out, and unaware of what’s coming.
Catra puts one of the small pillows under her lap.
“Be prepared,” she murmurs into her prey’s ear, then she slaps Adora’s beautiful ass one, two, three times.

She doesn't even hit hard.
It’s rather friendly slaps. Yet, Adora’s surprised cry and a few muffled gasps are heard, even with Catra’s panties still in her mouth. Catra knows this sound, and it’s exactly what she wanted to hear.
Only louder.
And more of it.
“What, Adora? Is this all you have? I don’t think we’re done here.” Her hand moves over Adora’s ass, slowly traveling along the firm flesh and then down to the wet folds between her legs. She parts the legs a little, and plays at the wet entrance with two of her fingers, and her thumb lies on Adora’s *other* hole, just teasing it. Fucking Adora there would probably a little too fast, but it looks like if just teasing drives the woman crazy.
“More,” Adora whimpers, begging, with a faint voice, “More, please.”
Catra grins, saying. “You get it, good girl. I’ll give you more.” She pushes three fingers into Adora’s warm, wet hole to the knuckles, and lets the woman scream out her pleasure. Then she slaps Adora’s ass another time. The noises coming out of the woman are absolutely sinful, and absolutely pretty.

She really wishes she had a strap with her, to fuck Adora with it until the Blonde would black out. She hasn’t, but she can do her with her fingers pretty well, pulling out lewd moans from Adora that fill the room with Catra’s muffled name and many, many *Yes*.

It's unbelievable that both women have still some lust and strength left to continue, but then again, both know this their only night. As much as pure desire, also the knowledge about their looming separation fills them with enough energy, to do it again, driving them never to falter.
Because aside from her exhaustion, Adora wants to squeeze every tiny bit of experience out of this night. She made that decision when she practically handed over her body to Catra for her to play with, to do what she wanted to do with her, to let herself go this one time.
She can sleep at home.
But not tonight. And it seems that Catra is very eager to do

exactly that.
Another time, she drives Adora to another orgasm, and perhaps a fifth. She doesn't really know, but Adora's body is wax in her hands. As it should be.

Night has advanced. It's not morning yet, but it's way after midnight. Outside, the traffic before the hotel has calmed down to a small trickle, and many lights are out. The city seems to be sleeping, undisturbed, calm, peaceful. Catra stands beside the window and looks over the street, still naked. Behind her, on the bed, she hears Adora's breath calming. She doesn't know how many times she brought the blonde to a high, but it also doesn't matter.
What matters is that this is the best night of her life.

"This is the best night of my life," Adora says from behind, her breath still a bit ragged, but her voice sounds steady, and confident.
Catra is a bit moody, because watching the dark city outside reminds her that the sun will rise in a few hours, ending this night of pure bliss, and ultimately taking Adora with it. But Adora's words also make her smile. If she were a little less gruffy, she would probably tell her about the synchronicity of their thoughts. Yet, she can't resist teasing her: "I'm not surprised. After all, you spend it with me."

Adora groans audibly. "Someone is very full of herself."
Still looking over the street, Catra hasn't turned around. "I know someone who has been full just yet. With my fingers. And my tongue. Remind me, how many times did you come?" Now she looks at Adora, who lies on her stomach, has propped her head into her palms, elbows resting on the bed, and she wiggles her legs. Her smirk is wide. "Oh, did I? I can't remember, must've been sleeping. Did something happen? Have you done anything?"

Catra does nothing. She just leans at the window and looks at Adora with a smile she can't believe she has it in her. She knows

herself that her voice sounds way too kind, and much too warm, when she says warmly: "You little piece of shit."
Adora sways her head left and right, wiggles her feet childishly, and just smiles back. The atmosphere in the room is much too sweet for Catra's taste. Of course, Adora has to top it: "Will you come to me? Cuddling?"

It's probably a bad idea.
Cuddling with the beautiful idiot, this damned girl who will leave her behind tomorrow… no, today, is just stupid. It will be her demise. Sex is something different. They have been driven by lust and want, by the need to right what they did wrong two years ago. But they better not get too—

To her actual demise, Adora holds out a hand, and she looks at her so trusting, so full of… it can't be love, no, not after just a week of acquaintance. That's ridiculous. Only Catra is stupid enough to capture feelings, an attachment to someone leaving her right away. "We shouldn't—"
Adora waves it off, bows forward and grabs her wrist, draws Catra in until she topples ungracefully onto the mattress with a squeak.
"What—"
"You owe me cuddles."
"I do not," she tries, pretends, fakes, and is overheard.
"Oh, but you absolutely do. It's an obligation."
"I don't care what you—"
She can't finish her sentence. Against her protests, Catra is entangled by an octopus. Adora has turned and laid on her own back, and Catra finds herself pressed face-front into Adora's tits with a firm grip and Adora's legs wrapping around her back. An iron embrace from which there's no escape. Usually, she hates being womanhandled and confined, but in this case, it's different.

She feels safe. Wanted. Protected.

Anyway, she puts – she has to put – up a fight, struggling and squirming against the strength of the blonde, but it's mostly for show. She doesn't really want to escape.
"Let me go," she muffles into Adora's chest.

“No,” Adora says, and it’s so audible that she absolutely looked through Catra’s facade, grinning and putting more strength into her embrace until Catra finally surrenders, then saying: “You’re so warm. Soft. I like it. And it’s really cute that you pretend not to want this.”
“I’m not cute,” laments Catra, and is ignored.
“You’re super cute, and you’re enjoying this.”
“And you are insufferable, you smug bitch,” Catra grouses against Adora’s arm. She bites a little into the soft flesh with the hard muscles underneath. Her teeth are far from harming the skin, it’s just to extend her show. That Adora used the exact same phrase Scorpia did, just makes it more necessary.
Adora even tastes so sweet.

“How did you know?”, Adora suddenly asks.
Her smug sound is gone, replaced by an uncertainty that gives away exactly what she’s talking about. Never has Catra been asked such a question after she dominated a partner while also being held in a such firm, assuring, powerful grip.
Usually, it takes longer to do what they just did. Much longer. It needs trust, and relationship-building, and getting-to-know, and many talks. And talking about it is something not everyone has the guts for. But well, if Adora wants to have that conversation right now, they can.

She turns her head a little to be able to look at Adora’s face, but she still has her head on Adora’s pretty tits. “I have a good feel for it. I may not be the brightest when it comes to recognizing the feelings or motives of others, but I'm never wrong about their sexual preferences. It's like a sixth sense.”
No one says anything for a moment, both of them way more comfortable with this conversation than they probably should be. She continues. “Did you know beforehand that you would like it?”

Adora laughs softly. “To be dominated in bed? Honestly, I haven’t really thought about it before.”
Catra huffs.“You seriously want to explain to me that this is the first time you've let someone else taken the reins and fuck you like this?” She feels a small shudder running through Adora as she

speaks. Catra always likes to keep her counterpart off balance with her rude language, but, apparently, Adora is just getting horny from it.
Catra can also feel her own pussy getting wet again. She would love to start sucking Adora's tits again, which are still pressed against her right jaw so firmly.
But, well, this is also fine, cuddling – and a little teasing. She adds: "Holy shit, if I had known before what a horny piece you are, it would have been different, back then at the conference. I could've taken you right at the bar, huh?"

Instead of saying anything, Adora slowly turns her around, so that Catra lays with her back on Adora chest and lap. Then the damned woman hits her on her left boob with a hand. It's playful, somewhere between soft and *not*. Her hand stays, grabs the flesh of Catra's hill and squeezes a little, glides over Catra's side, her stomach, down to this delicate place between her legs.
This is not how this should be going.
But the touch makes her giddy, wax in Adora's fingers, and Adora's hand hovers over Catra's trimmed triangle, then covers it, with the tip of her middle finger laying on her sweet bud. The touch alone is so… phew. Catra starts breathing heavily, and yet she feels firmly embraced.

From behind and under her, Adora wiggles her legs around Catra's thighs, hooks her feet under her ankles and uses the leverage to slowly part Catra's feet and legs with them, spreading her a little, while her other arm and hand still holds her around the stomach.
Catra feels used, handled, but also… excited.
"It comes in handy that I have long legs, huh?", Adora asks, and Catra can feel the smirk in her back. "Shall I show you something about being taken?"

Now, the hand on her stomach slowly glides upwards, between her boobs until she feels how Adora's strong fingers come to rest around her throat, the thumb on one side, the fingers on the other.
Adora doesn't exert the slightest pressure there, she just lets her hand rest on a place where she knows Catra senses the possibility

of being gripped stronger. Catra is too surprised – and horny – to do anything against this insidious onslaught, this violation of their unspoken role distribution.

Her pussy is so wet.

And while she's still getting used to Adora's hand around her throat, the woman's middle finger slides into Catra's entrance. A moan escapes her, she can't suppress it. Adora's hands on her throat and in her pussy make her, then she squirms a little, while panting out, "Ahhh,".
Adora holds her firmly everywhere and pushes her finger deeper into the moist place of need.
"Your body is betraying you. I can feel how wet you are." Adora's voice is rough. "I'm not the only one who's turned on by being dominated. I could do everything to you right now, and you would probably just let me. Is that not so?"
Catra moans again. She can't deny it's true, her cunt is dripping from wetness, she hasn't it in her to stop Adora, but she would never admit it. This is not what they had agreed about. Not—
Her thoughts are derailed when Adora whisper into her ear. "Shall I add another? Just order me. I do whatever you want. Use me, please!"

Pfff, this is not a plea. It's a command! Goddess, Adora is the perfect example of topping from the bottom.

She wants nothing more than another finger, no, two more fingers in her pussy. There's no strength left in her to fight back, she just wants to be pleased by Adora. But this is not how this should've gone. Her body bucks, giving away how much she wants this.
"Ahhh," she moans, then deeper again.
"Shall I?," Adora pressures. The hand around Catra's throat moves a little, just to remember her it's there. "More fingers? Just nod. Command me, Catra, I can't do anything without your command."
Liar, Catra thinks. But she nods.
"Say it, Catra," Adora orders her. "Say. It."
"More fingers, Adora. More! Pleas— AAAH!"
Catra is not quiet.

Later, after she came – after Adora made her cum – the blonde's hands glide back to where they had been before, to Catra's stomach and chest, Adora's legs shuffle back too, and let Catra close her own, so she's not so… open anymore.
She feels rolled, over onto their sides, with Adora's front pressed against her back, and cuddled.
And Catra feels so done. It was just one orgasm, but she never experienced something like this. Adora held her firmly, the entire time, while she was knuckle-deep into her and Catra rode through the most intense orgasm she ever had. When she started to cry out loud, Adora covered her mouth firmly, letting her scream into her hand, even when Catra bit her. She felt in command and used at the same time, knowing that Adora would stop on her order, but didn't find it in her to use the words. Any words. While taken and fucked, she felt safe.
Now, she's still breathing heavily, now, that she can breathe again, after Adora moved her hand away from her mouth, after Catra cried out her lust.
Despite dizziness washes over her, she asks, needs to ask.
"How did *you* know?"

Adora laughs, a delicate shyness in her tone, but yet with much contentment. "I didn't. I just followed your example."
"You're kidding me."
Funny, that the woman sounds a little desperate when answering:
"Really, I didn't know I would like this. I had clues, but— It just felt natural to me. It's perhaps that I trusted you to not hurt me, and I… just repeated it? Maybe it's because you're a doctor, and I know that you won't harm me just out of ignorance. Or maybe it's because you already saved my life twice. I don't really know why exactly, but I trust you. It's just a feeling, that I'm safe with you."
She shrugs her shoulders, and the gesture is so natural, so honest in its lightness, that it pushes easily through Catra's walls, even more when Adora adds: "I felt in good hands. I hope you did, too?"

And Catra gets it, oh yes she does.
Again, it's too much, too much honesty and trust, for her taste. What does Adora expect her to say now? What is she supposed to

repeat? She says nothing, but she doesn't have to, because Adora goes on: "Do you believe it now, that I didn't want to reject you when we first met?"
Catra can allow that much. "I think I'm starting to," she admits. But she already does. It nearly overwhelms her, she feels tears rising in the corners of her eyes, and it's good that the blonde cannot see them. Now she understands that Adora's rejection was made out of being overwhelmed, that it had its cause in *Adora* and her own insecurities, not in *not wanting Catra*. It's weird that this is so important to her, but this is how she is.

Considering that took her a long way to come.

But she walked this way, and it brought her here, finally back into the woman's arms. *Where I belong*, Catra's brain supplies her with, and she sighs, while she feels Adora's boobs pressed against her back and the woman's ridiculous strong jawline nuzzling onto her head from above.
She enjoys this, but a minute later she finds herself being turned around, again amazed by the strength the woman has, her head put on Adora's tits again, her body lined up with each other, and it's even better. There's still some sweat on Adora's skin.

Oh.

Now she's petted so softly.
This is… wonderful. Adora's hand moves over her head, down her neck, further down her back until she reaches her butt, then up again, slowly the entire way, slowly, and gently, with such a warmth that Catra cannot even comprehend it.
And again.
And again.
Adora pets her like a cat, and it's perfect. She would purr if she could.
"I have you. I don't let go," Adora murmurs, and it's not the words alone. It's not her petting of Catra, not the embrace in which she has entangled her, not the color of her voice.

It's everything together.

A small sob escapes Catra which she can't stop. This is too much, too much.
Because Adora *will* let go, tomorrow, no today, when she leaves this hotel, this country, this corner of the world, she will leave her behind and all Catra will have is this one night of blissful memories. One perfect night of her life. She should stand up, now, now, not to let herself be enticed more into this.
This has gone way too far.
Unfortunately, she can't. Her body does nothing.
"All is well," Adora mumbles, and repeats it. "All is well."
Over her ruminating, she is embraced by Adora's firm arms, and the woman practically wraps herself around Catra, arms around her chest and stomach, legs entangled, her front pressed against Adora's breast.
She can't do anything.
Can't.
Won't.

Her entire firmness and dominance when she made love to Adora was a front. A wanted and needed front, a play she greatly enjoys, and doing it with the woman under her was something she craved for so long. She *wanted* to make the beauty *hers*.
But still a front.
And this… being held like this feels just like… home.
A great peace settles feather-light inside her.
And before she knows what to do with this thought and feeling, she falls asleep, embraced by the warmth of the most wonderful woman in the world.

All is truly well.

Waking up, Catra just feels how much her guards are up again, and how the mood that made this night possible has nearly vanished, much like dust from a meadow beside a stream between the willows, under the glare of a swiftly rising morning

sun, set about to march across the sky again.
She already hates this day.
Bleak reality, with all its tiring thoughts she was able to push away for the last twelve hours, rises its ugly head and casts away what's left of the veil of wonderful, delicate kindness they've been able to enjoy.

Adora has already gotten up and sits at the edge of the bed, her beautiful and strong back towards Catra. She's still naked, just a towel around her hip, and probably came right out of the bathroom. Catra picks herself up, leans against the headboard of the bed, and doesn't know what to say. The woman clearly noticed her movement, but looking at her, she doesn't. The silence in the room was okay until now, but now it threatens, very slowly, to tip over into the unpleasant. Catra already feels left behind.

"Thank you." Adora's open, honest statement takes her by surprise, and shakes the feeling off.
She understands the woman better now, but still, how can someone be so blunt and straightforward about her own feelings?
For a moment, Catra isn't able to say anything back, to come up with a proper reply.
But Adora already rambles on: "It was beautiful. You were so beautiful, when you woke up." She stumbles over her words. "Not… not that you haven't been beautiful the whole night. You were! But especially in the morning, while you still slept. You looked so peaceful, so kind, so—"

Just like in the night, it's a bit too much honesty, openness for her.
"Okay, doofus. First of all: creepy, watching someone sleeping, and secondly—"
Adora snaps around and looks appalled. Beautifully appalled. "It's not creepy! What was I supposed to do? Wake you up?"
"And secondly, you were… pretty great yourself," Catra mutters.
A little scoff escapes Adora, sounding disbelieving. "That's nice of you to say. But as far as I remember, you did most of the work."
That's true, but… "Do you call me a liar?"
Adora looks so funnily worried, Catra nearly laughs. "What? No.

But I know that… you know… I'm not— I was mostly acting on instinct. It's not that I—."

Adora's sudden shutdown is making Catra confused about how this conversation goes. And a weird thought rises. Can it be that…? Before she's able to shut her stupid mouth, it already tumbles out: "Is this your weird way of telling me that this has been your first time?"
All she gets in return is a woman looking down into her lap and fiddling with her fingers. It's the least confident impression she gets from Adora since… since ever. Okay, maybe it's also because they are both naked, but after last night, this shouldn't—
"You're kidding me," she presses on, but softer, and still, Adora stays silent, as if all her breath left her.

It would be so easy. So easy to tease the woman, to make fun of her for the fact, that – obviously – the stunning, beautiful, otherworldly enchanting Adora Gray just had her first time.
With Catra.
With stupid, stupid Catra.
She could smack her head about it.
Also, it would be easy to use this to sever their ties for good, now that they are about to part for… forever.
Adora will go anyway, leaving nothing behind than the memory of this one night, and Catra… well, Catra will have to think about what she wants to do now. Cleaning up the mess she left behind won't come easy. When Hordak learns he hasn't killed the woman, he'll probably try to get Catra down instead, at least get her arrested, if he's just stubborn enough.

He found out which part Catra played in getting Adora out of Russia, out of his grip, but he has little proof. It'll most likely mean the end of her career, but if her superiors believe him more than her, and want to make another example, then… well, there's no use in ruminating about that now. It's a problem for future Catra. She'll deal with it, when she comes to it.

"Can you say something? Anything?", Adora asks, while turning around to face her.

Catra startles from her thoughts, realizing she'd been quiet the entire time she thought about what to answer. "Uhm, sure. Sorry. I think I got a bit… overwhelmed." She desperately tries to keep her eyes onto hers, to ignore Adora's perfect boobs in front of her own, ignoring the temptation emanating from her bare, soft skin, ignoring how much she wants to touch them, to kiss them, to cup them with her hands, squeeze and lick on them, to push Adora over and drive into her with her fingers again, until Adora makes these beautiful sounds she made last night again and was moaning so mesmerizing under Catra's touches.

She wants to have the woman again so much.

Deep down, Catra knows she'll never find someone else again, who reacts to her so perfectly. They are made for each other, and she could tell her about that. Catra feels, she could tell Adora about these thoughts without getting anything else than compassion in return.

Inwardly, she curses herself for being such a coward.
But she doesn't say it.

The feeling, and her immediate regret not to act on it, makes everything just more cruel.
"Sorry. I just can't believe it. It never came to my mind that this could've been your first time. You acted like you knew what you were doing, experienced."
Adora shrugs her shoulders. "Well, I did read about it. And it's not that I'm insecure about my body. But I didn't really know what I was going to do before… I just did…, I… I let myself be carried away."
"But this was your first time?", Catra digs.
"In this way… yes. I mean, uhm… technically, I wasn't a virgin, you know?"
"Oohh, so you had good times rubbing your swee—"
"Catra!"
She giggles like a girl. "Hehehe, oh man, this is so perfect. I mean, honestly, I feel honored that I was your first… you know… woman. It explains a lot, too, and— hey, there's no reason to be

ashamed.” She reaches forward and cups Adora’s cheek with a hand, and the blonde immediately leans into it. Oh, god. Adora is going to be the death of her.
“You were absolutely stunning last night. It was the best night I ever experienced, and I wish—”
“You wish what?”
She doesn’t spin the thought further. It’s useless.
She can’t.
She can’t.
She can’t.
“Nothing. Silly babbling. It was great, I assure you. You’re a perfect lay. But it’s time to collect ourselves and bring you to the airport, right?”

The sudden change of atmosphere makes Adora frown. But Catra is right, and they both know it. She ignores the woman’s piercing gaze when she goes to the bathroom.
Twenty minutes later, they are both dressed, have packed their stuff and stand in front of the hotel lobby, about to part. A taxi should be there in a few minutes, and then Adora is away, gone to the airport, gone to a part of the world Catra has no access to, and probably won’t have for a decade. Or more.
This will be it.
They will part, and even if they can call or write each other in this century, their paths certainly won’t cross each other again. Their connection will vanish, and the hole in Catra’s heart will stay there for the rest of her life.

“What are you going to do now?” Adora asks, expression concerned, all caring. Just like she is, Catra thinks.
“Going back home. Dealing with… well, you know.” She doesn’t want to speak about it.
“Is there anything I can do? To help you?”, Adora asks. Her face is an expression of worry, and Catra really hates being pitied.
“No. I don’t need you do to take care of my affairs. I can do it myself,” she grouches, a tad too firm for her liking, but well.
“That’s not what I meant. It’s… I care about you, and I don't like the idea of what consequences await you there.”
“That’s not your cup of tea.”

Adora groans, and rolls her eyes, obviously not able to let it go. "I know that. But I can still try to help you if you want to."
"What can you possibly do? Change Putin's mind? Put an end to this useless war? Make everyone friends again?" It comes out a lot angrier and louder than the target it is aimed at deserves. Adora is not responsible for any of that.
Barely visible, Adora shakes her head two, three times.
"I can't do that. I'm not a magical princess, you know? But if I can help in things a little more… in reach, I will certainly try. You matter to me."

The words do not really register with Catra. She's perhaps just interpreting too much into them, as always. And after that, because she doesn't answer anything, Adora just stands before her and says nothing anymore, too.
The woman's lip quiver a little, but maybe she's just excited because she knows she's back in safety in a few hours, hell, even when the plane has taken off.

While Catra's heart and brain are in uproar.
She doesn't want to let Adora go, but of course she can't do and say anything to hold her back. Last night was a… no, it wasn't a failure, that would do both of them injustice, but it was a one-night-stand, and not the prelude to a relationship. Adora has to go back to safety, and Catra has to face the results of her decisions. Her career maybe over for now, and all she can hope for is to escape a trial for treason. Maybe… if she lets Hordak believe that he killed Adora, he's content and just too busy to take care of her. Whatever. It doesn't matter.
If Adora wanted her to come with her, she would say something. She would've said something in the morning even, but at least now.

But she doesn't.

Instead, she just stays before her, says nothing, and looks at her with her kind, attentive blue eyes.
"So," Adora says.
"So, "Catra replies.

“Uhm, thank you. For helping me.”
“You’re welcome.”
“Seriously. You risked a lot for me, and I don’t think I’ll be ever able to pay it back.”
“You don’t have to. In my opinion, you paid with last night.” Catra stops and restarts: “Uh, that came out wrong. I didn’t mean—"
Adora smiles softly, a little laughing. “It’s okay, don’t worry. I get what you mean. I just wish this was more than just a goodbye. And I wish I could come back to see you again.”
“Yeah. I mean, whatever, huh? It was… nice to get to know you.”
Why the fuck is she so stupid with words? Why can’t she just say what she wants to say? And why is she such a goddamn coward? She is a goddam Lieutenant Colonel of the largest army in Europe, or nearly has been one, now, that her career is presumably over. She isn’t a wimp, though!

Next to them stops the cab in the hotel driveway.

“I guess that's my cue to leave,” Adora says, and hands over the key to the room. Their room. “Can you turn that in? It’s already paid for, but I think a little tip is in order.” She grins her stupid, goofy, smile and Catra wants to kiss her right there.
“Okay,” is everything her stupid brain comes up with and everything coming out of her stupid mouth.
“Good.” After a short pause, Adora steps forward, hugs her, presses a kiss on Catra’s cheek and adds quietly: “Thank you, for everything. I will never forget. Never.”

She lets loose, and Catra already feels abandoned, left behind. And it’s exactly what this is. She’s left behind, while Adora is able to go back to a home not in war with half the world, able to roam the planet in peace, not fighting a war she has no say in.
While she has to.
The door to the taxi closes, and Adora lays her hand on the glass, looking at her. There may be tears in her eyes, but it’s hard to see good through the window. Catra curtly waves, more out of a reflex than a deliberate action.
Their eyes meet one last time.
Adora looks so beautiful. Torn, but beautiful. Again, it’s too much

for Catra. Tears dwell up. She can’t breathe. Her stomach clenches.

She’s saved by the taxi driving off. Saving her from throwing up, or breaking down, or collapsing, or exploding, or all of it simultaneously.

A minute later, Catra has put herself together so much that she’s able to turn back into the hotel to hand over the key. The man at the reception takes it with a nod, but when she’s about to turn, he stops her. “Ahm, Miss, there is a letter for you. The other lady dropped if off for you.” He hands her an envelope.
Catra takes it with a frown, and is puzzled.
She needs a few moments, until she’s able to settle down at the seating group in the lobby, dropping her backpack on the floor. She opens the white envelope with the hotel logo on it, and finds a letter from Adora inside, written on the paper of the notepad on the desk in their room. It’s not long, only a few lines. Catra traces them, and it’s obvious, that Adora has a very precise, beautiful handwriting.
It’s just like her entire personality.

“Dear Catra.
Thank you for saving my life. If it weren’t for you, I never would’ve made it. As I said, I wish I could come back to see you again. I’m not sure if I ever can, given the circumstances, and given your profession, I don’t have a clue how to possibly find you.

But, if you ever decide to come and visit the West, please, call me. I’ll be happy to host you, and maybe to take you to a dimly lit bar in a hotel for letting you seduce me again. This time I will not hesitate. I promise. I will be just yours.
Thank you for last night. I wanted this, and it was wonderful. You were wonderful. Only with you could it be so perfect. I still smell your scent, and I will never forget it. To me, you’re perfect.
Yours, in love, Adora.

P.S. Burn this letter after reading. It's evidence. Just keep my number."

Catra sits at the hotel lobby and reads the message one more time.
Then one more time again.
And again.
Even after the fifth time, she already forgot what Adora wrote beside these two words. These two, carelessly written words. Clearly, Adora doesn't mean it that way. She can't, not after such a short time.

"In love", the woman wrote.

What does that mean? Only Catra is stupid enough to fall in love with a woman she barely knows. Only Catra…
But, is that true?
Does she barely know Adora?
The woman would not use these words without thinking, would she?

But if she's in love, why didn't she say anything before. The words lay on Catra's lips too, but she didn't dare and say them. Adora and her would never see each other again, so what good would it be for if she admitted her feelings to a woman who was on the edge of leaving her today and forever?
But there are these two words, in her note.

"*In love*," Adora wrote.

What did she mean by that? Like "Hey, we had a nice night, and that's just my wording for it, be well?" That would be okay, wouldn't it? It's not like that they have a future, together. Adora knew they would part before Catra read this, so it was easy to write anything!
Or has she meant it more serious? Catra doesn't dare to let the words roll off of her lips.
Maybe she can… think it.

Adora… loves me?

Catra sits in the hotel lobby, her small rucksack at her side, people bustling around her in the busy entrance because it's checkout time, and she has things to do, to clear up, to get the fuck back home, and all she can think of is 'what the fuck does Adora mean with these two words'?
She lays the note down into her lap, looks outside, and thinks.

What is she supposed to do with such a message?

The plane is nearly full. Adora had been told she got one of the last tickets, yesterday, but maybe not everyone got to the airport in time. That wouldn't be surprising, because the traffic was difficult. It's not that Tbilisi International Airport is overrun with passengers. Barely twenty flights leave from here each day. No, it seems that traffic in Tbilisi is just like that in these times, where too many people pour into a country that consists mostly of one large valley with one large city, and many hills and mountains otherwise.
Just around four million citizens live in Georgia, but the infrastructure was made for less, and all of these new people are seeking… whatever.

The airport itself is a modern concrete and glass building, completely confusable with any other contemporary small-to-middlle-sized airport in the world built in the recent twenty years. Adora knows many, and they all look the boring same. Often, they even smell alike, their own odor stemming from the worldwide same machines and aggregates, working to circulate and clear the air, to cool or heat it to the ever same temperature so that, god forbid, the oh-so-important travelers are not exposed too quickly to the adversities of their old or new host country. In Adora's experience, airports are the most boring buildings mankind ever built, and devoid of individuality.

So it’s only good that Adora was prepared and ready and arrived early enough. Now, she settles into the seat of her plane towards Munich, and looks out of the window of the not too modern aircraft. It’s a small Airbus, which has seen better days. It was probably revamped more than once, and now serves for the rest of its lifespan in this backwater airline.
But it’s her way home, and the largest part of Adora is grateful for that.
Her gaze falls onto the peaks of the Great Caucasus, visible far in the distance. Tbilisi is just forty kilometers away from its foothills, and the mountains rise swiftly into the sky behind them.

Just yesterday morning they drove them down from Shovi, and now tears dwell up in her eyes, because it means that now, right now, she’s leaving Catra behind, and this is hard. She silently pondered about not going, about not leaving today. She could, she possibly could have stayed another day, another night.
But they both know that Catra has to go back, the faster the better, back to an uncertain future and probably be sentenced for helping Adora to flee. She can’t jeopardize Catra’s fate anymore, not for her selfish needs and wants.

Still.
Why didn’t she say something?

Why did she just write this stupid letter instead of voicing to Catra what she wanted to say to her? She could’ve said it, directly into her face, that she wants her to come with her.
Another great example of how stupid she is when it comes to feelings. What a coward she is.
No, it’s not upon her to impose her needs upon Catra. They’re good.

Adora rubs her temples. Around her, preparations for take-off are made, the stewardesses proceed with the usual security theater. She knows it in and out, doesn’t really take notice, still looks out of the window. Someone talks to the passenger beside her, but it doesn’t spark her attention. The feeling of loss, of leaving something important behind, is so overwhelming that she can’t

find it in her to tear her thoughts away from thinking about the woman she had her first time with this very night.
She was acting out of her league. Daring, surely, but out of her league.
It was just that something inside her flared to life like never before, a certainty about what to do, how to respond, how to… let herself being used by her partner, and use her in return.
The thought and memory lets her blush faintly. She has still no clue how she got so bold to allow it, to do it. Maybe it was all Catra.
Still, there's this warm feeling inside her.
Unfortunately, it already fades away.

It's only when a so familiar scent tickles her nose that she feels triggered to turn her head towards the other side.
From the next seat, a big smirk greets her, because Catra grins at her broadly, and then she lays her hand on hers.
Adora tries to stutter something, but her throat is dry, and her thoughts are twirling. She can't believe it, and after a few moments, she raises her other hand and pokes Catra at her cheek.
Is the woman real?
It feels like, because it's warm and soft beneath her fingertip, and Catra makes a funny grimace and reaches over, drawing her in for a short kiss on her lips, to which she doesn't hesitate in the slightest. "You can't write shit like that and just vanish, Princess."
Adora is still dumbstruck when Catra adds: "If you don't mind, I'd like to pick up on your invitation from before. So, do you wanna show me the beauties of your city? I mean, it doesn't even need to be the city. I have some ideas."

And Adora finds that she can't stop grinning either. She wants to ask why, and how, and what, and so much more. Their gazes lock, she firmly grips Catra's hand, then nods furiously. She doesn't mind the tears, her tears. The same moment, they are pressed into their seats, still staring at each other, as the engines of the plane speed-up to full thrust. They roar, accelerate them, then the runway disappears beneath them as the plane tilts upward, taking off, gathering height as it turns westwards.

Towards freedom.
And a future uncertain.

Uncertainty, blissful, invigorating and vivid uncertainty, for two women who have no clue what the future holds for them. Yet, it looks brighter and more promising than it ever has before.

While she sinks into Catra's mismatched eyes, grinning broadly, it's probably for the first time in her life that Adora is simply happy. She's perhaps crying, too, but she doesn't mind.
Catra grins back at her so hard.
This woman is going to bring nothing but trouble.

She wouldn't want it any different.

Afterword

I apologize for putting this afterword into the chapter text. Despite my pleas, AO3 still has a tight character limit in its chapter notes for reasons unknown, and I exceed that again and again.

Puh. Finally. I'm glad this is done. Really, really glad.
I do not have many warm words for you, now, that our beloved girls got together finally. I dragged it out as long as I could, in case you didn't notice ;-). Is it cheesy? It sure is. Is it the way I like it. Yep, and I'm proud of it. One thing I really like about SPOP is, that it ends on a perfect note and timing. Do I want to see more? Sure! Would that be a good idea to have? Probably not. That being said, here's an afterword more political than it's for everyone's liking. If you don't want to read about that, skip it. It's not that important, just my opinion about some things. Our journey is over, so thank you for reading this. Have a nice sunday evening.

Writing this piece wasn't easy, but it was educational in many ways. It comes as no surprise when I tell you, that I'm strongly believing that Putin is an idiot. I cannot state this more bluntly. The man has continuously led the country on a downwards slope, and he has for years taken full and unhinged authority of the entire state, so he's the one person responsible for this war and the developments leading to it. But, we also have to take into account, that he has been re-elected several times, and therefore, a good part of his fellow Russians are responsible for this too. "The only thing necessary for the triumph of evil is for good men to do nothing." Whoever said it was right.

The people of Russia may not have wanted to go to this or another of Putin's wars, and they may have – as the West did – underestimated Putin's willingness to spark a large one like this, too. But obliviousness, sloth, and disinterest don't make one innocent, at most pitiable. In a society that votes their leaders, everyone is responsible for what he did not try to prevent what they do. And the general support for Putin in the Russian population has not ceased, as the country now experiences the typical rally-around-the-flag-mentality due to being isolated and surrounded by nations increasingly seen as enemies and reverse. What a surprise, when, as the jokes goes, your main export are spies and your main import are other sovereign states.

If we cut out the scenario of a nuclear war between NATO and Russia – I'm not afraid of this, because in this case, we're all dead and the dead don't have to worry – this can only end one way: with Putin's voluntary or forcibly resignation. One or the other will happen. The man is 70, and dictator's seldom die of old age.

And I know that it's tempting to punish Russia for its deeds, and the Russian populace for their part in it, when the time comes. But I invite you to look up the results of World War One and its consequent aftermath, World War Two. A major reason for the rise of National Socialism and Hitler in Germany was the Treaty of Versailles of 1918, where "peace" was made between the warring nations. It was a bullshit treaty, and a bullshit form of peace, and surely one of the biggest failures of diplomacy.

See, Germany wasn't actually defeated in the field when it surrendered, but it was treated as a defeated enemy, and more important, as the **sole** originator of the entire war. Especially France pushed for a hard treatment, sanctions, and reparations from Germany, which had to take the entire blame for the war and its results, while in reality, every European nation was responsible. All of them eagerly went to war, happy to pick up their new toys and to fight for glory and land and power and bullshit. All of them were stupid idiots, and crying for war, at a time when most of them started to get connected like never before.

Consequently, Hitler fueled his early movement and rise to power by using the resentment in the German populace against the other nations to blame them for the German problems at the end of the twenties. As soon as he came to power, he started to tear the very contract, hated by his subjects, piece by piece apart, and found great support in every social stratum of the country. Many Germans wanted revenge. They longed for it.

It would directly lead into the next, greater war, because victor's justice never sparks anything good. It would lead to a real global war, with over 60 states, over 100 million people taking up arms, and to over 60 million dead, soldiers, and civilians. I know I mentioned it before, but I can't often enough: http://www.fallen.io/ww2/. It is available in many languages.

Thoughts of revenge, and mistrust, and hate contributed much to that result. Humiliating a defeated opponent has never been a good idea in the history of humankind. It has *never* proven to work. The only time it "worked" was when Rome defeated Carthage in the Third Punic War, when it burned the once biggest metropolis of the Mediterranean civilization down to the ground and killed every living citizen, or sold them into slavery. No Carthaginian, once a great power of the early antiquity, survived the Roman victory, the entire culture was wiped out, and I do not think that is a path we should find viable today.

We have to find a better one.

So, when Russia will finally lose this war, and Putin's regime falls, the West should be ready to reincorporate Russia quickly into the international community. Any other action will only lead to more resentment, on both sides, actually. We should also do this because people like this woman still exist in Russia. We have to offer these people and the nation as a whole a perspective. It was and is, after all, still a European country, and it should and must have a perspective of being a close ally of the European Union as well as the NATO in the future.
If we want to prevent this situation from going on forever, of course.

We have more important issues to deal with.

The real challenges of the 21st century are still ahead, and we cannot afford to squander human lives, valuable resources, time, and attention in useless wars little people need for their trivial satisfaction. In a decade, the Russo-Ukrainian war will be a mere sidenote of history. The aftermaths of World War One tell us everything we need to know how not to handle this.
Thank you for reading.

Chapter End Notes

Some sources

I found valuable insight in several sources, most of which I already mentioned and linked throughout the story. Here you have a list of more general ones.

- The Austrian Army has a very good Youtube-Channel, where current tactics of the war are explained in a clear and precise language, with going into details. Many of the videos covering the Russo-Ukrainian war have been made in English as well.

- I skimmed Tsargrad TV for original Russian news content from a conservative view, or rather, from something like a pendant to Fox News. It's not my cup of tea, but you can give the website a try to have a glimpse on how they see the events over there. Use Google Translate for the whole site, it works pretty good.
- War on the Rocks has good in depth-analyses of the military side.
- CNA, The Center for Naval Analyses has that, too.
- And of course, Google Earth, with which I tracked their entire trip, and was able to look into the actual places and cities, often with Street View. That was really helpful, and an inspiring source of information.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!